

TL;DR — Executive Summary

The Question

What does Scripture require, permit, and forbid regarding parent-and-adult-child relations between the end of childhood and marriage? The Bible speaks abundantly to the child under the roof and to the married couple in the new household. It speaks to the unmarried adult son or daughter *between* those seams only obliquely, through a handful of texts and a great deal of pattern. That silence is not indifference; it is also not blanket permission (a hermeneutic §3.2 applies to the Didache's own silence). It is space bounded by what Scripture *does* say, checked by Christ, tested by Antiquity and Reality — inside which faithful households have arranged themselves in more than one way for two thousand years.

The Method

This study uses the **SCAR quadrilateral** — Scripture, Christocentrism, Antiquity, Reality — a discernment tool for questions where explicit biblical command runs out and pattern, tradition, and consequence must be weighed together.¹ The four legs are not co-equal votes. They are ordered: Scripture governs; the Christ of Scripture is the lens through which Scripture is read; Antiquity (with special weight to the pre-Nicene witness — the church before the Council of Nicaea, AD 325) checks whether the reading is one the church has held; Reality tests whether the resulting doctrine survives contact with the lives of actual families. **Where Scripture is clear, the question is settled and the other three legs illuminate application. Where Scripture is open or contested, the convergence or divergence of the remaining legs governs how firmly anything can be said** — the paper *presents* the honest disagreement rather than adjudicating it, and trains the reader to walk his own case through the same four questions before the Lord (Chapter 6).

The Non-Negotiables

Five things no faithful view denies. All five rest on direct scriptural teaching, with one partial exception: the second half of #4 (that *none may compel* marriage) rests on a Scripture-and- tradition convergence the paper treats as settled catholic teaching, as noted at #4 below.

¹SCAR is a Protestant restatement of Dean Taylor's Apostolic Quadrilateral, developed at *A Change of Allegiance* (2009) and RadicalReformation.com, with the ordered-leg discipline and the "discipleship test" emphasis retained.

1. **Honor never expires and has content.** Exodus 20:12 and Ephesians 6:2 are addressed to adults, not only minors. Honor includes material provision (Mark 7:9-13; 1 Tim. 5:4), reverent speech (Exod. 21:17), consultation (Prov. 23:22), and care in the years when the direction of provision reverses (2 Cor. 12:14 → 1 Tim. 5:4).
2. **Marriage is the God-given seam.** Genesis 2:24 — quoted by Christ (Matt. 19:5) and Paul (Eph. 5:31) — attaches the paradigmatic leaving to the marriage covenant, not to a launching age.
3. **Christ relativizes every human bond.** Allegiance to Christ supersedes allegiance to parents (Matt. 10:37); but no tradition, however pious, may nullify the honor commandment (Mark 7:9-13). Both hold.
4. **No tradition may forbid marriage.** 1 Timothy 4:1-3 names forbidding-to-marry as “doctrine of devils.” Scripture is direct on this point, and the pre-Nicene church defended the line: Clement of Alexandria’s *Stromata* III (c. 200) is the paper’s principal early Christian polemic against the encratite party that took bodily renunciation as constitutive of the higher Christian life (§3.6a). On the further claim that *none may compel it*, the paper reads Scripture and catholic tradition as converging: the paradigmatic biblical case of arranged marriage explicitly turns on the adult child’s consent (Gen. 24:57-58, “we will call the damsel, and enquire at her mouth”), and the Western tradition from Roman canon through Trent Sess. 24 through the modern Code of Canon Law (c. 1057 §1) requires consent for validity — a convergence the paper treats as settled catholic teaching rather than as a claim from any one proof-text alone.
5. **The unmarried Christian’s covenant belonging to Christ is not less than the married Christian’s.** Isaiah 54:5, 2 Corinthians 11:2, and Revelation 19:7-9 address the church corporately as Christ’s Bride; the corporate bond is fully and without remainder shared by every member. The Bridegroom-language is not consolation-language for a missing spouse; it is the actual state of the case for every Christian, married or unmarried (§4.3.3). What the corporate texts are *not* claiming is an individual bridal union in a sense that would compete with earthly marriage; what they *are* claiming is a covenant belonging so total that no earthly bond can add to it or diminish it. This is the theological ground on which every faithful arrangement stands.

The Views

Where the non-negotiables run out, faithful households arrange themselves along four patterns of residence and authority — plus a distinct, orthogonal question about how the marriage covenant itself is initiated. All are presented here without adjudication (Chapter 4 gives each its steel-manned best):

View 1a — Household Continuity (Prudential Covering). Unmarried adults ordinarily remain in the parental household until marriage, under paternal formation and (for daughters especially) paternal protection. Framed as biblical pattern and pastoral wisdom, not absolute rule (Deut. 6:6-7; Ps. 78:5-8; Mal. 4:6; Eph. 6:4). Voiced by Voddie Baucham, Scott Brown, and the National Center for Family-Integrated Churches (NCFIC) tradition (§4.1a; on the tradition’s Reformed-Puritan warrant, §B.1.7; on its entanglement with and separation from the Phillips-era movement, §B.1.4). Cases like Elisha, Samuel, and the Zebedee sons — the adult child remaining embedded in a household while directly accountable to Christ for vocation — are treated in Chapter 1 as biblical pattern rather than as a separate view (§1.4.6). Presented at its steel-manned best at §4.1a.

View 1b — Continuous Doctrinal Authority. A stronger, systematic form: the biblical household is understood to place every believer under a continuing, defined human authority (father, then husband; or an equivalent covering) for the whole of unmarried adult life, grounded in exegesis of the New Testament household codes (*Haustafel*, §1.2) that reads the “obey” verb (ὁπακούω) as continuing beyond minority, and in a systematic reading of honor that includes continuing obedience. **Presented by its advocates** as continuous with older streams (Reformed household-covenant theology, Puritan household religion, Catholic teaching on paternal role, Anabaptist family-integrated practice) and articulated in twentieth-century form by, among others, Watchman Nee (*Spiritual Authority*, 1972), Bill Gothard (the “Umbrella of Protection” seminars, §B.1.3), and Doug Phillips (*Tenets of Biblical Patriarchy*, 2007, §B.1.4). This twentieth-century articulation is historically distinct from the older streams on which View 1a draws, and the two views are frequently conflated by critics and proponents alike; the paper treats them separately throughout (§4.1). Appendix B.1 traces the exegetical genealogy, and the continuity claim is examined against the primary sources — Gouge, Baxter, Aquinas, the CCC — at §B.1.6. Presented at its steel-manned best at §4.1b.

View 2a — Prudential Launching (Continuing Honor Without Continuing Directive Authority). At adulthood, directive obedience matures into consultation, honor, and lifelong care; the adult child directs his or her own life under Christ, in continuing relation

to the parents. Widely held across mainstream evangelicalism and articulated by John MacArthur, James Dobson, Wayne Grudem, and others (see §5.3 for the full list of representative published works). Presented at its steel-manned best at §4.2a.

View 2b — Release with Prayer. Outward launch shaped by Luke 15's father: releases the adult child with what is due, does not chase, watches the horizon, keeps the door open, keeps praying. Honor is kept; directive authority is released; petition to the Father continues. Presented at its steel-manned best at §4.2b.

The Arrangement Question. Distinct from — and orthogonal to — Views 1a/1b/2a/2b: how is the marriage covenant itself initiated and mediated? Parental arrangement / betrothal concentrates parental authority at the marriage moment (initiating, mediating, blessing the covenant) rather than diffusing it across daily life. This is not a fifth arrangement of daily life; a household holding any of 1a/1b/2a/2b can answer it in more than one way. Ignatius of Antioch (*To Polycarp* 5:2, c. 107 — among the earliest post-apostolic witnesses) is the pre-Nicene warrant (§3.4). Presented at its steel-manned best at §4.5.

The Twin Idolatries

Every view has a central good — family, launched adulthood, parental mediation — and every view can drift the same way: when the central good ceases to point to Christ and becomes a god in its own right. Two drifts are *paired* twins. The **Clutch** — sometimes a failure mode of 1b's discipline — promises safety through remaining under one's covering. The **Abandonment** — sometimes a failure mode of 2b's release — promises safety through throwing off every covering. Both refuse the Father: one by clutching, one by fleeing (§5.5). The Prodigal parable diagnoses both, and does so without collapsing either doctrine into its idolatry.

The Parent's Three Postures

Scripture models three parental postures toward the released adult child (§5.0): **Release-and-Await** (the Prodigal father; the Samson/Eli contrast — Samson's parents speak the covenantal word and release; Eli neither confronts nor restrains sons still under his priestly jurisdiction — with which View 2b's steel-manned "Release with Prayer" shape is closely kindred); **Intercession-without-Restraint** (Jairus, the widow of Nain, the Syrophoenician mother; and — critically — the parent whose adult child has walked away, §5.0.2); and **Dedication** (Hannah lending Samuel to the LORD, Mary at the cross, the Son's

own submission in Gethsemane). All are faithful; mature parenthood practices them at different times toward the same child.

The Eight-Question Test

Every arrangement must pass a *family* test and a *discipleship* test (§5.7). The four family questions — the questions any warmly affectionate household, Christian or not, might set for itself: does it promote love (John 13:34-35); preserve unity (John 17:20-23); enable lifelong honor with content (Ex. 20:12; Mark 7:9-13; 1 Tim. 5:4); and keep the peace of the household (Rom. 12:18; 1 Pet. 3:8-9)? The four discipleship questions — the questions only a Christian household can honestly ask and answer: does it form disciples, not merely well-adjusted family members (Matt. 28:19-20; Luke 14:26-33); produce visible witness (Matt. 5:14-16; 1 Pet. 3:15); bring the church genuinely into the discernment (Acts 15; Ignatius, *To Polycarp* 5:2); and leave Christ above every human bond, including this household's own — bearing the cost of doing so (Matt. 10:37; Luke 14:27-33)? A warmly affectionate secular family can pass all four family questions. Only a Christian household can pass all eight.

The Summons

To the unmarried daughter: you are not incomplete for lack of a husband. You are already the beloved of the Bridegroom (Isa. 54:5). Whether marriage follows or not, that is your first bond.

To the unmarried son: your task is not to *wait* for a wife; your task is to *become* the man Christ is calling you to be (the missionary author Elisabeth Elliot, *The Mark of a Man*, 1981 — her book-length letter to her nephew Pete). Do the next thing He has given you, today.

To the parent releasing a child: your love outlasts your control. Hannah lent Samuel “as long as he liveth”; Mary stood at the cross. Release your child to Christ, and keep releasing him, in prayer, as long as you draw breath.

To the parent whose child has walked away: Luke 15's father was watching the whole time. Keep praying. Keep the door open. Do not chase; do not relent on the household's confession. Do the next thing the LORD has given you today, and trust the ending to Him.

Chapters 1-6 give the full argument. Chapter 6 trains the reader in SCAR itself — because the paper's final work is not to hand the reader an answer, but to hand the reader the tools to seek the Lord for one.

A Note on What This Is, and What It Is Not

This is a study copy, not a final tome. It is a working document offered to the church for community discernment on a question Scripture treats with more silence than most of us are comfortable with — the question of what parent-and-adult-child life should look like *between* the end of childhood and marriage.

Who this is written for. Christian households and congregations wrestling with this question — parents and adult children who share the confession that Scripture is authoritative, that Christ is Lord, and that the Church’s historic witness on family and marriage is worth listening to before departing from it. The paper is not written to persuade a secular reader; where a “warmly affectionate secular family” appears in Chapter 5, it is a diagnostic thought-experiment, not the intended audience.

What this is:

- **A structured SCAR walk** through Scripture, Christocentrism, Antiquity, and Reality on the question, presenting each faithful Christian view at its steel-manned best, drawn where possible from its own advocates’ published words.
- **A reader-training document.** The final chapter teaches the reader to walk their own case through SCAR before the Lord, in prayer and in community.
- **A shared-ground close.** Where the views agree, they agree on Christ Himself as treasure and goal. That is not view-picking; it is naming the ground beneath the views.

What this is not:

- Not a personal manifesto. The author is named (see the Attribution note below), but no faithful view is commended in the narrator’s voice; the argument stands or falls on its evidence, not the byline.
- Not a settled ecclesial statement. It does not bind any household, congregation, or tradition.
- Not a polemic against any of the views. Every view named as faithful is presented as its best advocates present it. Section 5.5 names two paired *failure modes* — the Clutch and the Abandonment — that can afflict any household drifting toward its view’s idolatry rather than its view’s central good. The failure modes are distinguished from the doctrines they can distort, and the distinction between doctrine and drift is drawn at every point where the modes appear.
- Not neutral about *everything*. Where Scripture speaks clearly on the *what* of the question — that honor the father and the

mother is a lifelong command with content (Ex 20:12; Matt 15:4-6; Eph 6:2-3), that no tradition may forbid marriage (1 Tim 4:1-3), that no tradition may nullify honor (Mark 7:9-13) — the paper is faithful, not neutral. Where Scripture leaves the *how* to household judgment, the paper presents the honest disagreement and trains the reader in the tools rather than adjudicating a winner.

The reader is invited to sit with the material, walk the case through SCAR before the Lord, and bring the fruit into their own household and congregation for prayer and counsel.

On Attribution, Citation, and Correspondence

Attribution. This paper is written by **Tim Uy**. Earlier drafts were issued as a corporate work without a name, on the reasoning that the argument should be weighed on its merits and not on any author's personal reputation. That discipline has done what it was meant to do during drafting; the paper is now offered under the author's own name so that the reader can address the writer directly, and so that credit or blame for what is here lands where it belongs. The argument itself still stands or falls on the evidence — the exegesis, the patristic and Reformation apparatus, the historical record — not on the byline.

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For a specific passage: Tim Uy, *Parents and Adult Children Before Marriage: A SCAR Quadrilateral Analysis*, Draft v2.16.0 (2026-08-04), §1.1.1 (four senses of authority).

Version-and-date convention. Every substantive revision bumps the minor or major version and the date on the title page moves with it (so v2.7.1 dated 2026-07-22 is a distinct citable object from v2.6.2 dated 2026-07-22 even where the day is the same). Version numbers never move backward; a citation to Draft v2.7.1 will always point to the same text.

Correspondence. Criticisms, encouragements, and exhortations are welcome at **torque@gmail.com**. The paper is issued through and to communities capable of weighing it — pastors, elders, seminary readers, and Christian households — who are asked to test its exegesis against Scripture, its historical claims against the primary sources named in Appendix B, and its pastoral claims against their own lived experience of parents and adult children before marriage. Corrections, counter-evidence, and pastoral pushback are welcome;

the version number exists precisely so that such feedback can be received and integrated into a subsequent draft that succeeds this one on the citable record.

Chapter 1 — Scripture

Overview (Scripture)

Scripture addresses parents and children extensively — but almost always at the two ends: minor children under parental roof, and married adults forming a new household. The middle case — the unmarried adult son or daughter — is treated only obliquely. This chapter maps every direct text and identifies what Scripture requires, permits, and forbids, together with what it leaves open.

A note on method. The SCAR framework asks what Scripture, Christocentrism, Antiquity, and Reality actually teach — not what a given cultural moment finds congenial. Readers on every side of this question bring cultural pre-shaping: American Christians tend to assume the isolated household and the bounded self as natural units; proponents of continuous covering can equally pre-shape by treating patriarchal household structure as self-evidently biblical. SCAR aims to test both assumptions against the texts themselves. The paper's own prose is not exempt. Written in English for readers formed largely by North American church culture, it defaults — especially in this chapter and the next — to the register of the individual adult moral agent: “the adult child weighs, decides, stands before God.” That register is itself nearer to the frame of Views 2a/2b than to the covenantal-household frame in which Views 1a/1b readers instinctively work, where the deciding person is embedded in a household and its counsel rather than bounded off from it. The reader is asked to treat the register as a translation medium, not a verdict: where individual-agent phrasing appears, the household-embedded reader may hear “the adult child, within the counsel-fabric of household and church, decides before God,” and nothing in the exegesis turns on the difference unless the text itself is shown to adjudicate it. Where the analysis in this and subsequent chapters lands on any specific question, the reasoning is shown so that readers can trace the argument and disagree at named points rather than at unnamed presuppositions.

1.1 The Foundational Command: Honor

The command to honor father and mother is embedded in the Decalogue and is the only command of the ten explicitly attached to a promise.

Exodus 20:12 — Honour thy father and thy mother: that thy days may be long upon the land which the LORD thy God giveth thee.

Deuteronomy 5:16 — Honour thy father and thy mother,

as the LORD thy God hath commanded thee; that thy days may be prolonged, and that it may go well with thee, in the land which the LORD thy God giveth thee.

Leviticus 19:3 — Ye shall fear every man his mother, and his father, and keep my sabbaths: I am the LORD your God.

Ephesians 6:2-3 — Honour thy father and mother; which is the first commandment with promise; That it may be well with thee, and thou mayest live long on the earth.

Observations. The command is not age-limited. It is issued to Israel as a nation of adults; Ephesians repeats it to the Ephesian congregation, whose members were adults. The promise is not restricted to childhood. Honor therefore is *lifelong* — a settled orientation of respect, gratitude, deference, and care that persists across every stage of the relationship.

1.1.1 Four Senses of “Authority”

The paper distinguishes four things that are often collapsed under a single word and that must be kept separate for the exegesis to work. **(1) Directive authority** is the right to *command* obedience — the pattern the verb ὑπακούω (*hypakouō*; Eph. 6:1; Col. 3:20) governs, with a subordinate morally bound to comply with a specific instruction. **(2) Formative authority** is the shaping office of the parent as teacher, model, and catechist (Deut. 6:6-7; Eph. 6:4) — an office whose *content* is inculcation rather than command, and whose subject is progressively a moral agent rather than an instrument. **(3) Counsel-authority** is the moral weight parental (and elder-Christian) speech continues to bear even after directive authority has ended — the pattern of Prov. 23:22, 1 Tim. 5:1-2, and the parental role in the marriage-arrangement traditions of Chapter 4. It carries no command-right, but the honor obligation (§1.1) requires the adult child to weigh it seriously and not dismiss it. **(4) Priestly office** — the parent’s continuing role in intercession, blessing, and dedication (Job 1:5; 1 Sam. 1:27-28; Luke 15:20; §5.0). This office is *entirely non-coercive* and, on any faithful reading, outlasts every other.

Three of the four senses are common ground. No faithful view — 1a, 1b, 2a, or 2b — denies that the formative office (2) continues in some register after minority, that parental counsel (3) carries the moral weight the honor commandment gives it for the whole of the relationship, or that the priestly office (4) outlasts every other. Whatever else divides the views, a parent’s teaching, counsel, and intercession are lifelong on every reading.

Sense (1) is the crux. Whether directive authority is bounded at the

household-dependent stage or extends through unmarried adult life is the question on which the views divide — cleanly between View 1b, which answers *yes* as doctrine, and Views 2a/2b, which answer *no*; View 1a holds sense (1) as bounded in principle while its commended household pattern sustains covering and consultation until marriage (§4.1a). On the narrow exegetical question — what the verb ὑπακούω itself, in its *Haustafel* setting, can be shown to carry — the paper’s own reading leans toward the status-bounded one, on the balance of the seven considerations set out at §1.2.1; the paper does not conceal that lean behind a pretense of agnosticism, and it also does not present its lean as more decisive than the underlying evidence permits. But View 1b does not rest its case on the verb. Its answer is a cumulative systematic argument — the fifth commandment as permanent office, the *Haustafel*, Numbers 30, household-covenant theology — presented at its steel-manned best at §4.1b. Whether that cumulative argument closes the gap the lexical evidence leaves is the wider crux, and the paper presents it without adjudicating it (§1.9).

The paper declares one other bounded lean, in the same register. On the narrow question of what Genesis 2:24 itself grounds, the paper’s reading (set out with its five considerations at §1.3.1) is that the verse describes the marriage transition; whether pre-marital leaving finds warrant elsewhere — vocational call, providential displacement, ministry — is left open, and the views answer it differently (§1.3.1’s closing paragraphs; §4.2a). Like the lexical lean above, this is a lean on a narrow exegetical question with the reasoning shown, not a settlement of any view question.

When the paper uses “authority” without qualifier, it means directive authority in sense (1); the other three senses are named explicitly where they are meant.

1.2 The Command to Obey (and Its Limits)

Ephesians 6:1 — Children, obey your parents in the Lord: for this is right.

Colossians 3:20 — Children, obey your parents in all things: for this is well pleasing unto the Lord.

Both verses sit within a *Haustafel* — a term borrowed from German scholarship, literally “house-table” or “household code.” A *Haustafel* is a compact literary form in which an apostolic writer addresses the three reciprocal pairs of the ancient household in sequence: wives / husbands, children / fathers, and slaves / masters. Ephesians 5:22-6:9 and Colossians 3:18-4:1 are the two canonical New Testament instances; shorter or partial forms appear at 1 Peter 2:18-3:7, 1 Tim-

othy 2:8-15, 6:1-2, and Titus 2:1-10. The form has a Greco-Roman philosophical parent in Aristotle’s *Politics* Book I on the management of the *oikos*, but the apostles adapt it in two Christologically decisive ways: each addressee receives an “in the Lord” ceiling (so obedience is never absolute), and — inverting Greco-Roman practice — the *subordinate* party is addressed first, as a moral agent responsible directly to Christ, not merely a domestic instrument. Reading Ephesians 6:1 apart from its Haustafel context tempts a proof-text approach; reading it as Haustafel keeps its structural setting in view.

Observations. The Greek verb is ὑπακούω (*hypakouō*, obey, submit to). The addressees are τέκνα (*tekna*) — children in the household. A brief note on the singular τέκνον (*teknon*) is worth pausing over: it is a filiation term (from τίκτω, *tiktō*, “to beget”), not an age- or household-status term. A τέκνον remains a τέκνον after leaving. Paul calls the adult, itinerant Timothy his τέκνον (1 Tim 1:2); the father in Luke 15 still addresses his estranged elder son as τέκνον; Mary calls the twelve-year-old Jesus τέκνον after he has deliberately separated himself (Luke 2:48). The noun, then, is not itself household-bounded. Whether the verb ὑπακούω is — so that the same τέκνα owe obedience while in the household and honor for life (View 1a’s reading), or whether the imperative reaches τέκνα qua τέκνα (View 1b’s reading) — is the disputed question §1.2.1 takes up.

Two questions then arise:

- **Does obedience have an upper age limit?** Scripture fixes no numerical age. Whether its vocabulary, its household-code form, and Paul’s own Pharisaic inheritance supply terminating markers — and how firm those markers are — is the disputed question this chapter takes up at §1.2.1: seven considerations bearing on whether ὑπακούω tracks a household-status transition, each presented with View 1b’s answer, their weights varying. The paper’s own lean on the narrow lexical question, and the limits of that lean, are declared at §1.1.1.
- **Are the two commands (honor and obey) the same command?** No. Ephesians 6:1 uses ὑπακούω; verse 2 shifts to τίμα (*tima*, honor). They are distinguishable duties, and Paul quotes the Decalogue only for the second. What the shift signifies is read differently: View 1a takes it as marking honor (not obedience) as the age-independent requirement; View 1b takes both duties as continuing, the Decalogue citation grounding rather than replacing the obedience imperative (§1.2.1).

Balancing this is the responsibility placed on parents:

Ephesians 6:4 — And, ye fathers, provoke not your children to wrath: but bring them up in the nurture and admonition

of the Lord.

Colossians 3:21 — Fathers, provoke not your children to anger, lest they be discouraged.

The word *μὴ παροργίζετε* (*mē parorgizete*, “do not provoke to wrath”) warns against authority that crushes. Whatever authority Scripture assigns to fathers, it is bounded on the other side by this word.

1.2.1 Whether Eph. 6:1’s ὑπακούω Tracks a Household-Status Transition: Seven Considerations, with 1b’s Answers

The four views in this paper differ on how to read one verb — ὑπακούω at Eph. 6:1 — in relation to the τιμάω (*timaō*) of Eph. 6:2. On View 1a, ὑπακούετε (*hypakouete*, the plural imperative) is Koine vocabulary of *currently-active supervisory relation* — a child under day-to-day parental command — and correlates with the household-minor status that a τέκνον occupies before forming his own household. On this reading τιμάω at Eph. 6:2 is the lifelong companion imperative that carries filial duty forward into adulthood and independence. On View 1b, ὑπακούω is not so restricted; τέκνα in v. 1 is a *relational* term for offspring-of-parents (not an age-marked term for minors); and the imperative reaches τέκνα qua τέκνα, so that a mode of directive-following continues past the household-minor stage — in Nee/Gothard/Phillips-style formulations, until marriage or the parent’s death.

Note the frame: the disputed question is not straightforwardly *chronological* (a birthday at which the ὑπακούετε lifts) but *status-transitional* (whether Eph. 6:1’s ὑπακούετε tracks the household-dependent minor’s status and lifts when that status is exited, or whether it continues by virtue of the τέκνον relation itself). Both formulations are on the text.

This section presents seven considerations that are put forward for reading Eph. 6:1’s ὑπακούετε as status-correlated, along with View 1b’s answer to each. The considerations vary in weight: some cut in 1a’s direction, others turn out to be *null* on the disputed question (compatible with either reading) once carefully examined, and one (the Haustafel father-side qualifier) supports 1a’s reading of *who is being pastored* without by itself supporting 1a’s reading of *who is outside* Eph. 6:1’s addressee. The chapter does not adjudicate the cumulative systematic case, which View 1b answers at §4.1b (see §1.9); the reader is invited to weigh both.

The View 1b counter-reading, steel-manned. Watchman Nee, Bill Gothard, and Doug Phillips — the twentieth-century articulators of View 1b, whose contested relation to the older Reformed, Puritan,

Catholic, and Anabaptist streams is traced at §4.1b and Appendix B.1 — do not typically dispute the lexical distinction between ὑπακούω and τιμᾶω. Their move is theological: the fifth commandment, they argue, establishes a *permanent office* — parent — and Paul’s Haustafel merely applies that office to the household stage without terminating it there. In Nee’s *Spiritual Authority* (English 1972, from 1948 Chinese lectures), the obligation to “delegated authority” is tied to the *office*, not the age of the subordinate, and the promise of long life in Ephesians 6:2-3 is read as covering the entire lifespan of the child. Gothard’s “Umbrella of Protection” teaching (hereafter the umbrella doctrine) extends this into practical counsel: unmarried adult children are expected to remain under parental authority until marriage or the parent’s death, and stepping out from under the umbrella exposes one to spiritual attack. Doug Phillips’ *Tenets of Biblical Patriarchy* (2007) reads Numbers 30 (father’s power over a daughter’s vow) and 1 Corinthians 7:36-38 (father giving a daughter in marriage) as ongoing paternal *authority* rather than as guardianship of specific transactions. Sympathetically summarized: the office is permanent, the biblical text never revokes it, and the Greco-Roman world Paul wrote into normalized lifelong paternal power (*patria potestas*), which Paul does not overturn.

That is the 1b claim in its strongest form. The seven considerations below are those most often put forward against it; each is presented with View 1b’s answer, and their weights vary. This is where the Ephesians-6 exegetical dispute is joined.

1. The semantic range of ὑπακούω. The verb appears twenty-one times in the New Testament. In its authority-relation uses it presupposes a *currently active* authority relationship: children to parents (Eph. 6:1; Col. 3:20), slaves to masters (Eph. 6:5; Col. 3:22), the Christian to Christ or to the gospel (Rom. 6:17; 2 Thess. 1:8; Heb. 5:9), and nature to Christ (Mark 4:41). BDAG 1028 glosses ὑπακούω “to follow instructions, obey, be subject to,” presupposing an ongoing authority under which the subject sits. (Acts 12:13 — Rhoda approaching to “answer” the door [ὑπακούσαι, *hypakousai*] — uses the verb in a distinct sense of *responding to a summons or knock*, and is not part of the authority-relation pattern.)

The one apparent exception — Sarah “obeying” Abraham (1 Pet. 3:6) — is Sarah as *wife* to *living husband*, an ongoing authority relation, not an adult daughter to a living parent. There is *no* New Testament instance of ὑπακούω applied to an adult child of a living parent. The Prodigal Son parable is the most telling silence: Luke uses τέκνον of the resident elder son (Luke 15:31), yet conspicuously does not use ὑπακούω. *The View 1b answer*: silence is not evidence; the New Testament simply does not develop adult-child parental scenarios

extensively (the Prodigal Son is the closest, and its focus is on the father's welcome, not on the son's directional posture), and the verb ὑπακούω is not so narrowly bounded to *active* authority as the warrant claims — its Septuagint background (LXX Gen. 22:18, 26:5 of Abraham obeying God's voice; Gen. 27:13, Rebekah's μόνον ὑπάκουσον τῆς φωνῆς μου [*monon hypakouson tēs phōnēs mou*, “only obey my voice”] to Jacob, arguably an adult son — the parallel imperatives at 27:8 and 27:43 use the simplex ἀκούω, *akouō*, “hear”) admits a somewhat broader range. On the balance, this consideration cuts in 1a's direction — the New Testament usage-pattern is real — but not as absolutely as an unqualified “no instance” phrasing would suggest.

2. The addressee-vocabulary of Eph. 6:1 does not itself resolve the age question. The imperative reads Τὰ τέκνα, ὑπακούετε τοῖς γονεῦσιν ὑμῶν ἐν κυρίῳ, τοῦτο γάρ ἐστιν δίκαιον (*Ta tekna, hypakouete tois goneusin hymōn en kyriō, touto gar estin dikaion* — “Children, obey your parents in the Lord, for this is right”). Three lexical observations, with the direction each cuts noted:

- τέκνα is a relational term for offspring-of-parents (LSJ s.v. τέκνον; BDAG 994); it is not age-marked. Paul had age-marked options — παιδία (*paidia*, little children), νήπιοι (*nēpioi*, infants/minors), παιδάρια (*paidaria*, boys), τὸ βρέφος (*to brephos*, the infant) — and does not use them here or at the parallel Col. 3:20. On its face this observation cuts against a categorical age-restriction. 1a's available counter is that τέκνα in a Haustafel dyad whose father-side is aimed at fathers-of-minors is contextually age-marked even if not lexically so — the same way “children, obey your parents” in a modern children's catechism would not need the word “minors.” Both construals are on the text.
- ὑπακούετε is a Koine present-tense plural imperative addressed to whoever counts as τέκνα in the assembly as it hears the letter read. This observation is *null* on the age question: any Koine present imperative addressed to a plural is compatible with an age-bounded or age-unbounded addressee-set. Claims that the present aspect connotes iterative “keep on obeying” continuously read more than the aspect will bear.
- ἐν κυρίῳ (*en kyriō*, “in the Lord”) is a substantive qualifier (locating the obedience in Christian relation), not a demographic one. Both readings agree that the qualifier marks the obedience as Christian-formed rather than as age-sorted. Null on the age question.

Modern Ephesians and Colossians commentators — Andrew Lincoln (WBC 42, pp. 398-408), Peter O'Brien (Pillar), Harold Hoehner (Baker, pp. 787-800), Ernest Best (ICC, pp. 515, 569-70), Frank Thielman

(BECNT, pp. 373-74, 397-408), Douglas Moo (Pillar on Col.), and James Dunn (NIGTC on Col.) — *foreground* minor children in their exegetical framing: the pastoral situation is the household assembly hearing the letter read. That foregrounding is a real datum. What these commentators do *not* generally do, and what a strong 1a scope-restriction reading would require them to do, is *rule out* adult unmarried τέκνα present at the reading from ὑπακούετε's reach. That further step — from *the minor children are foregrounded* to *adult τέκνα are outside the addressee* — is the paper's move to make (or decline to make) on substantive grounds, not something the commentators have established for it.

On these lexical-and-commentator observations, Eph. 6:1 is compatible with two readings and does not force either. View 1a takes ὑπακούετε as pastorally *foregrounding* the household minor, on grounds developed in Considerations 1 (the ordinary authority-relation range of ὑπακούω), 6 (the father-side παιδεία qualifier at v. 4), and the contextualization reading proposed by Charlie Trimm ("Honor Your Parents: A Command for Adults," *JETS* 60/2 [2017]: 247-63, at 258, one voice among modern evangelical scholarship for a both-and structure on the passage — Trimm himself concedes at p. 262 that the harder question of adult *directive* obedience remains textually open). View 1b takes ὑπακούετε as addressing τέκνα qua τέκνα without age-restriction, on grounds that the term is relational, that the Fifth Commandment Paul quotes at v. 2 is lifelong in its OT and Jewish reception (Prov. 23:22; Sir. 3:12-13; Philo *Spec. Leg.* 2.224-236; *b. Kidd.* 30b-31b's *kibbud/mora* structure), and that Paul does not deploy the age-marking Greek terms otherwise available to him.

Consideration 2 therefore does not adjudicate the age question at the lexical level; it locates it. The substantive weighing is carried by the other considerations, by the wider systematic argument on each side, and by the reader's judgment.

3. Colossians 3:20's κατὰ πάντα (*kata panta*, "in all things") intensifies, it does not extend. No serious commentator — including those sympathetic to strong household authority — reads "in all things" as unlimited in scope. It is qualified implicitly by context (a Christian household, believing parents) and explicitly by the Ephesian parallel's "in the Lord." Were κατὰ πάντα absolute and age-unbounded, the reductio is immediate: no adult child could join the church over parental objection, and none could ever leave a heretical parent — plainly impossible readings. The intensification is comprehensiveness *within* the relationship the imperative addresses, not an independent statement about that relationship's duration. *The View 1b answer* is largely agreement: faithful 1b articulations grant

the substantive ceiling (Acts 5:29) and do not read κατὰ πάντα as absolute. The reductio bounds the *content* of obedience (what may be commanded), not its *duration*; whether the relation κατὰ πάντα intensifies is household-bounded is the question of Considerations 1 and 2, which this consideration does not independently decide. On careful examination, Consideration 3 is close to *null* on the addressee-scope question — it defeats an absolutist reading that no faithful articulation on either side holds.

4. Paul’s own image for exiting childhood: the παιδαγωγός (*paidagōgos*) and the *nēpios*-heir. In Galatians 3:24-25 Paul takes the household παιδαγωγός — the slave who supervised a freeborn boy from about age six through adolescence — as his image for a bounded state that *ends* when its purpose is completed: “we are no longer under a schoolmaster.” Paul continues the picture in the next verses: “the heir, as long as he is a child (νήπιος, *nēpios*), differeth nothing from a servant, though he be lord of all; but is under tutors (ἐπιτρόπους, *epitropous*) and governors (οἰκονόμους, *oikonomous*) until the time appointed of the father” (Gal. 4:1-2). Paul thereby supplies his own age-bounding vocabulary — the household minor is *under* supervision precisely as a minor, and that state has a *terminus* after which the heir enters full status. The transition out of childhood is a real transition; being *under* a παιδαγωγός is not permanent, and on this reading neither is the correlate state of being *under* parents in the obedience-mode. What is permanent is filiation (τέκνον) and its lifelong duty of τιμή (*timē*, honor).

The View 1b counter-move on Gal. 4:1-2 must be recorded. The *terminus* in Paul’s analogy is “the time appointed of the father” (τὴν προθεσμίαν τοῦ πατρὸς, *tēn prothesmian tou patros*). A 1b-sympathetic reading takes this as evidence that even where the paper’s exegesis finds an age-seam, the seam is *father-appointed*, not child-asserted — compatible with paternal discretion over when maturity is recognized (for the umbrella doctrine, typically at marriage). The counter-counter is that Paul’s ordinary human illustration is drawn from Greco-Roman *tutela impuberum* (Gaius, *Institutes* 1.142ff.) with parallels in Hellenistic-Egyptian *epitropoi*-and-*oikonomoi* practice, where the *terminus* was set by age of majority, not by open-ended paternal discretion; and in the immediate theological application Paul’s Father is God, not a human parent (Gal. 4:4-7, ἐν τῷ πληρώματι τοῦ χρόνου, *en tō plērōmati tou chronou*, “in the fullness of time”). The paper does not adjudicate the weight of the analogy on this point. What it records is that Paul chose an analogy in which a *terminus* exists at all — and that the same analogy simultaneously names the *terminus* as *father-set*.

The analogy’s theological completion. Paul does not stop at 4:2. He

continues: “God sent forth his Son, made of a woman, made under the law, to redeem them that were under the law, that we might receive the adoption of sons (τὴν υἰοθεσίαν, *tēn huiiothesian*). And because ye are sons, God hath sent forth the Spirit of his Son into your hearts, crying, Abba, Father. Wherefore thou art no more a servant, but a son; and if a son, then an heir of God through Christ” (Gal. 4:4-7). Paul makes the same move in Rom. 8:15-17 — believers have received the “Spirit of adoption (πνεῦμα υἰοθεσίας, *pneuma huiiothesias*), whereby we cry, Abba, Father... and if children, then heirs; heirs of God, and joint-heirs with Christ” — and again at Eph. 1:5, which places *adoption of children by Jesus Christ* in the pre-temporal predestination. Whatever the ordinary human sense of the Galatians analogy, the theological landing is that every believer stands before the Father as an *adult son and heir* — and the *Abba* which the incarnate Son cries in Gethsemane (Mark 14:36) is placed by the Spirit on the believer’s own lips. Chapter 2 develops this filial standing as the christological ground of the paper’s recurring phrase “directly accountable to Christ” (§2.7 on the Father’s House; §2.8 on Jesus’s Priorities Extracted). The analogy Paul begins with the *nēpios*-heir under guardians ends with every believer as adult son at the Father’s own address.

5. Paul’s own tradition sharply distinguishes minor-child obedience from lifelong honor. Paul identifies as trained “at the feet of Gamaliel” (Acts 22:3) and as a Pharisee (Phil. 3:5-6). Pharisaic-rabbinic tradition — preserved in the Mishnah and Talmud, codifying pre-70 halakhah — draws the precise distinction the paper is arguing for:

- The classic definition of the fifth commandment at *b. Kiddushin* 31b splits the duty into *kibbud* (honor: feeding, clothing, bringing in and out of the house — the picture of an *adult* child caring for an aged parent) and *mora* (reverence: not sitting in the parent’s seat, not contradicting them, not tipping the scales against them — the picture of adult deference). Generic obedience (*shema*) is conspicuously *not* on either list.
- The Sifra on Leviticus 19:3, codified at Rambam, *Hilkhot Mamrim* 6:12 and *Shulchan Arukh Yoreh De’ah* 240:15, rules that if a parent commands a violation of Torah, “he must not listen” — a hard ceiling on paternal command-authority even for minors.
- On adult life-choice: the Rema’s gloss on *Shulchan Arukh Yoreh De’ah* 240:25 (citing Maharik) rules that if a father objects to the woman his son wishes to marry, “the son is not obligated to listen.” Adult decisional authority is presumed.
- The one biblical statute that could execute a son for defying his father — *ben sorer u-moreh*, the rebellious son of Deuteronomy 21:18-21 — is narrowed by the Mishnah (m. Sanh. 8:1; b. Sanh.

68b-72a) to a boy in the very brief window of early adolescence, after he had reached the age of majority for religious obligation (about 13) but before the completion of puberty a few months later. R. Shimon at *b. Sanhedrin* 71a then declares it “never was and never will be — it was written only to be expounded and receive reward for its study” — the rabbinic tradition’s way of saying the death penalty was never actually applied and could never in principle be applied. (R. Yonatan on the same page dissents, claiming he “sat on his grave,” so the tradition is not unanimous, but R. Shimon’s reading is the dominant one.) Rabbinic reception thus defused the strongest paternal-authority text in the Torah at the very threshold of biological adulthood.

- Numbers 30’s paternal vow-veto is bounded by the text’s own qualifier “in her youth, in her father’s house”; the rabbis at *m. Nedarim* 10-11 / *b. Nedarim* 66b-70b limit it further to the *ketanah* and *na’arah* stages, ending at the *bogeret* threshold (the stages and the classic formulation are set out at §1.4.1). Paternal legal authority over a daughter’s vows, in Paul’s own tradition, terminates *before* biological adulthood is complete.

Paul writes into churches where Gentile hearers might import either Roman or Greek assumptions, but Paul himself carries the Pharisaic grammar: the parent-child bond is a formative apprenticeship — compare the father’s-duty list at *b. Kiddushin* 29a, requiring the father to circumcise, redeem, teach Torah, arrange marriage, and teach a trade (“whoever does not teach his son a trade teaches him robbery”) — followed by lifelong honor and service in the opposite direction. Command-obedience belongs to the formative years; *kibbud* to the years after.

The View 1b answer: two replies are standard, and a third and fourth are sometimes added. First, Paul’s Pharisaic formation does not bind his apostolic teaching to rabbinic halakhah — the same Paul sets aside his tradition’s rulings where the gospel requires (Gal. 1:14-16; Phil. 3:7-8) — so the rabbinic bounding of command-authority informs what Paul’s hearers may have assumed without fixing what Paul teaches. Second, the rulings most damaging to 1b are attested in codifications centuries after Paul (Mishnah c. 200; Bavli c. 500-600; the Rema’s 16th-century gloss on YD 240:25 for the son’s marriage choice); their seeds are demonstrably Second-Temple (§3.1.2), but their first-century currency in the specific form cited cannot simply be assumed. Third, some 1b readers observe that the tradition’s own *kibbud* obligation — concrete, costly, lifelong active service — shades in household practice toward the directive register the codes formally withhold; the line between “the son must serve” and “the parent may direct” is cleaner in the codes than in a kitchen. Fourth — and most pointed — some 1b readers turn the tradition’s

record against its testimony: the same halakhah that bounds the vow-veto at *bogeret* also narrowed the rebellious-son statute into admitted inoperability (“never was and never will be,” *b. Sanh.* 71a, above), and Jesus’s one recorded engagement with Pharisaic vow-halakhah — the korban device — indicts it for “making the word of God of none effect through your tradition” (Mark 7:9-13). On this reply the rabbinic bounding is an impeached witness: a tradition with a demonstrated appetite for dead-lettering paternal-authority texts cannot serve as independent evidence that the texts bound themselves, and its net effect on Numbers 30 — a paternal veto operative over roughly eighteen months of a daughter’s life, since a younger girl’s vows lack halakhic validity to begin with (*m. Niddah* 5:6) — approaches in practice what *Sanhedrin* 71a made explicit in principle. The counter-counters to the first three replies run through the sources cited above; the rejoinders to the fourth are set out at §1.4.1, where the bounding is used. The paper records the exchange without adjudicating it.

6. The pastoral qualifier addressed to fathers is sharpened for fathers-of-minors. Ephesians 6:4 and Colossians 3:21 warn fathers not to “provoke to wrath” (μὴ παροργίζετε) their children, and to bring them up in παιδεία (*paideia*) — the technical Greco-Roman vocabulary of the formative training of minors. The father envisioned is one whose commands and discipline are active enough to *provoke*; the child envisioned is one whose being “discouraged” (Col. 3:21, ἀθυμῶσιν, *athymōsin*) is the pastoral concern. This is the household of an active παιδεία relationship, not the settled mutual respect of an adult child and an elderly parent.

Whether the pastoral sharpening on the father-side entails a matched-demographic sharpening on the child-side is a further step the text does not itself require. *The View 1b answer*: Haustafel pairs coordinate roles-in-the-room, and each half-imperative carries its own pastoral foregrounding without automatically scope-restricting the other half — as with husbands/wives (Eph. 5:22-33) or masters/slaves (Eph. 6:5-9), where each side’s qualifier is not treated as scope-restricting its counterpart. On that construal, Consideration 6 is a *father-side foregrounding* datum, not a *child-side scope-restriction* datum.

What Consideration 6 does establish, on either construal, is that Eph. 6:4 / Col. 3:21 do not envision the father-of-adult-child as their primary pastoral addressee. That is a real datum for the paper’s larger reading — Paul’s Haustafel is not the place to look for teaching on adult-child household life — but it is a datum about *who is being pastored*, not about *who is outside the reach of v. 1’s imperative*.

7. Hebrews 12:9-10 as data on παιδεία’s temporal bound, and its bearing on ὑπακούω. The most extended New Testament

treatment of father-son discipline appears not in the Haustafeln but at Hebrews 12:5-11. The apostolic author, addressing believers as adult sons under the Father's ongoing παιδεία, contrasts the two: "we have had fathers of our flesh which corrected us (παιδευτάς, *paideutas*), and we gave them reverence (ἐνετρεπόμεθα, *enetrepometha*): shall we not much rather be in subjection unto the Father of spirits, and live? For they verily *for a few days* (πρὸς ὀλίγας ἡμέρας, *pros oligas hēmeras*) chastened us after their own pleasure; but he for our profit, that we might be partakers of his holiness" (Heb. 12:9-10). Three observations, each noted for what it does and does not establish:

- *An explicit temporal bounding of human paternal παιδεία* — πρὸς ὀλίγας ἡμέρας, "for a few days," treated as *past* for the adult believer whom Hebrews addresses. This is direct textual warrant for the paper's Consideration 6 observation about the father-side παιδεία of Eph. 6:4: on the Hebrews reading, that παιδεία has a season, and the season is completed. Whether the παιδεία-terminus in turn correlates with a terminus in the child-side ὑπακούω of Eph. 6:1 is a further inferential step. *View 1a takes παιδεία and ὑπακούω as the same active supervisory relation seen from the two sides* — to bound one is to bound the other. *View 1b holds that παιδεία (the father's formative work) can be complete while ὑπακούω (the child's ordered posture) continues*, because on 1b's reading ὑπακούω tracks the τέκνον- relation itself rather than the active-formation stage. Heb. 12:9-10 supplies the temporal-bound datum on the παιδεία side; it does not itself close the παιδεία↔ὑπακούω correlation question.
- *The location of continuing "under-authority" sonship as Godward* — toward the Father of spirits, not toward the earthly parent — is the Chapter 2 architecture the paper develops from Jesus's own filial life. This datum is textually direct and does not depend on the παιδεία↔ὑπακούω correlation above.
- *The vocabulary of continuing filial duty toward the earthly parent* — ἐνετρεπόμεθα, "we gave them reverence" — lands in the honor / *mora* register the paper's Pharisaic material established at Consideration 5. This too is textually direct: whatever else Heb. 12:9 says, it names the continuing filial vocabulary of the adult son as *reverence*, not as *command- following*.

Human parental *correction* (παιδεία) is past-tensed in the passage; human parental *reverence* is present-tensed and lifelong; the Father's παιδεία toward the adult believer continues. Whether the passage's past-tensed παιδεία carries with it a past-tensed ὑπακούω is the question this section is attempting to determine — Heb. 12:9-10 supplies real data for the argument on the παιδεία side, and it names *reverence* rather than *obedience* as the adult son's continuing filial mode; it does not by itself close the age question on the ὑπακούω

side.

Historical-cultural qualifications. Two concessions to View 1b's cultural argument are due, and they are real but not decisive.

- *Roman patria potestas was legally lifelong for citizen sons.* Gaius, *Institutes* 1.48-200, esp. 1.55; the *paterfamilias* held *vitae necisque potestas* and owned all property acquired by sons in his *potestas*. In principle a 50-year-old ex-consul with a living father remained legally *alieni iuris*. This is genuine cultural background.
- *But two mitigations reduce its force for Paul's addressees.* First, demographically: Richard Saller's *Patriarchy, Property and Death in the Roman Family* (Cambridge, 1994), applying Coale-Demeny Model West life tables to Roman marriage ages via microsimulation, calculates that a substantial share of Roman males lost their fathers before or during early adulthood — Saller's most-cited figure is a 38% fatherlessness rate for senatorial men by age 20 (p. 64), with the rate rising steeply in the following decades and reaching a large majority by age 40 (Saller ch. 3, tables). The image of the tyrannical living *paterfamilias* commanding grown sons was statistically uncommon; adult Roman men passed *sui iuris* by natural attrition in rising shares with age — a large majority by forty — and even for those whose fathers lived, Saller and Suzanne Dixon (*The Roman Family*, Johns Hopkins, 1992) show that daily practice was governed by *pietas* — mutual obligation — rather than by despotic command. Second and more decisively for Paul: his Ephesian and Colossian addressees were overwhelmingly *peregrini* (non-Roman-citizen provincials) governed by local Hellenistic law, in which the Greek *kyrios* concept did *not* hold adult sons in perpetual subordination. When a legitimate Greek son reached adulthood and received his inheritance portion, he formed his own *oikos* and became *kyrios* in his own right. Paul is not writing to Roman citizens under *patria potestas*; he is writing to Greek-speaking believers whose cultural default was neolocal household formation at adulthood.

The upshot: the strongest cultural precedent for View 1b (*patria potestas*) does not describe Paul's actual audience, does not describe the ordinary lived experience even of most Roman citizens (a large share already fatherless in early adulthood, and a large majority by forty), and in any case is not imported by Paul's text. The cultural background therefore cannot carry a lifelong-subordination doctrine into Eph. 6:1 on its own; whether the verse teaches one must be settled on the lexical and contextual grounds weighed in Considerations 1-7 above, where the addressee- vocabulary itself was found compati-

ble with either reading (Consideration 2) and the weight rests on the usage-pattern (Consideration 1), Paul's own age-bounding imagery (Consideration 4), and the father-side foregrounding (Consideration 6), each with 1b's answer recorded.

Reception history. John Chrysostom (*Homilies on Ephesians* 21) takes the addressees to be young children: he keeps the exhortation short "inasmuch as children cannot follow up a long argument," passes over the kingdom "because it does not belong to the tender age of childhood to understand these subjects," and his applied pastoral counsel is about early formation — "From the very first bring him up in the chastening and admonition of the Lord" (NPNF¹ 13, Hom. 21). Calvin (*Commentary on Ephesians*, 1548) glosses ὑπακούω as the "obedience" that "children owe to their parents" and does not extend it into adulthood; honor is the lifelong duty, obedience its childhood expression. The Ligonier / Reformation Study Bible tradition makes the standard distinction explicit (devotional "Obeying Parents in the Lord," ligonier.org, September 9, 2011): the primary audience is those "who still live under their parents' roofs," while "adult children can certainly draw principles from Ephesians 6:1-3 for their relationship with their parents." Patristic, Reformation, and modern critical exegesis thus converge in *foregrounding* the household minor as the passage's primary addressee. Whether that foregrounding forecloses adult τέκνα from the imperative's reach is the further step Consideration 2 distinguished; the reception history here surveyed speaks to the first question directly and to the second mostly by silence — and the streams that read the Fifth Commandment's obligations as lifelong (the rabbinic *kibbud* / *mora* tradition; the strands 1b claims at §4.1b and §B.1) belong to the same reception history and are treated there.

How the two readings marshal Ephesians 6. The 1a and 1b readings differ not only in their conclusions but in how they marshal the passage.

View 1a reads Eph. 6:1 in the immediate lexical-and-Haustafel frame: the shift from ὑπακούετε (v. 1) to τίμα (v. 2), the father-side παιδεία-vocabulary at v. 4, and Paul's own age-bounding vocabulary at Gal. 3:24–4:7 combine to install the honor/obey status-transition the section has been describing. On this method, evidence that would extend Eph. 6:1's ὑπακούετε into adult scope would come from within the New Testament itself — for example, a New Testament text applying ὑπακούω to an adult child of a living parent, a text extending the household code beyond current household residence, or a text refusing the honor/obey distinction Paul's v. 1→v. 2 shift creates. View 1a reports finding none of these securely.

View 1b advocates read Eph. 6:1 as one node in a wider systematic

case: the Fifth Commandment as lifelong-scope (Prov. 23:22; Sir. 3:12–13; the rabbinic *kibbud/mora* structure); the Haustafel as one applied instance of that scope; Numbers 30 and 1 Cor. 7:36–38 as texts on parental authority in specific transactions; and (in Reformed and Puritan formulations) household-covenant theology framing all of the above. On this method, Eph. 6:1 is not the passage where the doctrine of continuing directive-following stands or falls; it is one text among many, read in light of the whole. View 1b holds that Eph. 6:1’s ὑπακούετε does not overturn the wider systematic case, and finds positive support for continuing directive-following in the wider corpus.

The two methods generate different evidentiary weights for the same passage. The paper does not adjudicate between them here — §4.1a develops 1a’s positive case in full, §4.1b develops 1b’s; the reader is invited to weigh both.

1.2.2 The Content of Honor, and the Middle Mode

Paul’s shift from ὑπακούετε (v.1) to τίμα (v.2) leaves a pastoral question the Haustafel does not itself answer: *what does honor concretely require of the τέκνον who is no longer a household dependent?* If honor is left undefined, the doctrine of lifelong honor is empty at precisely the point where it must do the most work. Two extremes then walk through the gap — one collapsing honor back into lifelong obedience, the other diluting honor into mere politeness. Scripture furnishes substantial content between the two poles.

Honor has content. τιμή is not warmth of feeling but a substantial, load-bearing duty. Scripture loads it with at least five concrete requirements:

- **Concrete material provision.** Mark 7:9-13 and Matthew 15:3-6 are decisive. Jesus rebukes the Pharisees for *dishonoring* their parents by withholding material support through the κορβάν (*korban*) loophole. Withholding provision is by definition dishonor; therefore honor positively requires provision. 1 Timothy 5:4 makes the same move: to “requite their parents” is “good and acceptable before God.”
- **Reverent speech.** Exodus 21:17 and Leviticus 20:9 treat cursing father or mother as a capital matter. Not “disobeying” — cursing. Honor extends into the register of how one *speaks of* one’s parents, including behind their backs.
- **Reverence itself (יָרֵא, *yārē’*).** Leviticus 19:3 pairs honor with a word usually translated “fear” — a weight, not a warmth. The parent is regarded, not merely acknowledged.
- **Consultation and receiving counsel.** Proverbs 1:8, 6:20, and

especially 23:22 (“hearken unto thy father that begat thee, and despise not thy mother when she is old”) load honor with the duty of taking parental input seriously — not obeying it, but weighing it.

- **Burial and remembrance.** Ruth 4:10 and the Second-Temple book of Tobit (cited as background, not as a Scripture-leg witness; see Appendix A) show that honor persists after death, expressed in burial, keeping the name, and remembrance.

A middle mode is inferable between obey and honor. Paul’s lexical distinction between ὑπακούω and τιμάω furnishes two categories; several biblical narratives depict adult children operating in a mode neither category quite captures — *consult, weigh, receive counsel, decide before God*. Naming this pattern “the middle mode” is a synthetic move (an inference from the narratives about how honor works pastorally in the register of consultation), not a lexical or exegetical warrant from a single text. Readers who prefer to keep the honor/obey binary and treat the consultation register as pastoral outworking of honor itself are not thereby out of step with the biblical picture; the description below equally captures what they see. The pattern the inference names is clearly visible:

- Rebekah is *consulted* — “wilt thou go with this man?” — and she decides (Gen 24:57-58).
- Jesus at twelve asserts the higher household (“wist ye not that I must be about my Father’s business?”) *and* immediately “went down with them ... and was subject unto them” — ὑποτασσόμενος αὐτοῖς (*hypotassomenos autois*; Luke 2:49-51). Both moves in one paragraph.
- Timothy is called out by Paul with Eunice and Lois evidently *not resisting* (2 Tim 1:5). The transfer happens with the mother-line’s blessing preserved.
- Jesus at Cana addresses Mary as γυναῖ (gynai, “woman” — a term of respect, not distance, in Koine) and then acts on his own timing (John 2:4).
- Solomon, at the height of his reign, rises to meet his mother Bathsheba, bows to her, and *causes a seat to be set for the king’s mother; and she sat on his right hand* (1 Kings 2:19) — the fullest picture in the Old Testament of an adult son substantively honoring a mother. In the very next verses, he hears her petition on behalf of Adonijah and refuses it (1 Kings 2:20-22). The pattern is not honor *or* refusal; it is honor *and* refusal. The son who rises to seat his mother at his right hand is the same son who denies her request when the request is judged, before God, to be wrong. Adult honor without adult decision-authority is impossible in the passage; adult decision-authority without honor is equally alien to it. The pattern of honor-and-refusal

visible across those four verses is the clearest Old Testament instance of what this section has called the middle mode. (View 1b reads the scene more narrowly: Solomon hears and refuses *qua king* adjudicating a succession petition — Adonijah’s request was a renewed bid for the throne, “ask for him the kingdom also” (1 Kings 2:22) — so the refusal is a royal-office datum, and on this reading the passage attests adult honor without bearing on ordinary household decision-authority either way.)

The middle mode is neither ὑπακοή (*hypakoē*, obedience) nor τιμή by itself — it is τιμή *acting in the register of consultation while decision-authority belongs to the adult child before God*. This is where most of adult life actually operates: not “I must do what you say,” and not “your input is noted.” It is: “I have listened, I have weighed, I have prayed, and here is what I have decided.” (The first-person-singular phrasing is the individual-agent register the chapter’s method note marks; a household-embedded reader will speak the same sentence with the counsel-fabric audible — listened *to parents*, weighed *with the church*, prayed *in the household* — without changing whose decision, on every view except 1b, it finally is.) In the vocabulary of §1.1.1, the middle mode is *sense (3) of authority* — parental counsel carrying the moral weight the honor commandment gives it — operated at adult scale, distinct from sense (1) directive authority and grounded in sense (2) formative office. Every view in this paper recognizes the middle mode as continuous through adult life; the views disagree only on whether *sense (1)* is also continuous.

Two failure modes to avoid. The obey/honor tension bends in opposite directions in different cultures, and SCAR must not baptize either default:

- **Filial-piety compression** (visible in East Asian, some Middle Eastern, and some Anabaptist contexts): honor is pressed so close to obedience that the adult child’s Godward decision-authority disappears. This overshoots the biblical picture, which distinguishes ὑπακούω and τίμα.
- **Individualist dilution** (visible in modern Western contexts, especially American): honor is thinned to polite acknowledgement, with provision, consultation, and reverence quietly dropped. This undershoots the biblical picture, which loads τιμή with substantial, costly content.

On the status-bounded reading of ὑπακούω toward which the paper leans (§1.1.1), lifelong τιμή carries real content — provision, consultation, reverence, non-repudiation, remembrance — while ὑπακοή remains household-bounded. The middle mode of consult-and-decide carries the practical weight on that reading.

A load-bearing Old Testament counterweight: individual moral responsibility. Ezekiel 18 supplies a datum any doctrine of continuing paternal authority over an adult child must reckon with. Against the popular proverb “The fathers have eaten sour grapes, and the children’s teeth are set on edge” (Ezek. 18:2; cf. Jer. 31:29), the prophet insists: *“the soul that sinneth, it shall die. The son shall not bear the iniquity of the father, neither shall the father bear the iniquity of the son: the righteousness of the righteous shall be upon him, and the wickedness of the wicked shall be upon him”* (Ezek. 18:20). The passage is a covenant-lawsuit against the theology that reads the child as morally continuous with the father to the point of shared verdict; over against it, the prophet establishes each soul’s individual answerability before God. The relevance here is narrow but real: whatever *authority* a parent retains over an adult child, the adult child’s *answerability* runs to God directly, not through the parent. This is one root of the New Testament pattern in which each servant stands or falls to his own Master (Rom. 14:4), each must give account of himself to God (Rom. 14:12), and no covering can substitute for personal faith and repentance. Ezekiel 18 does not by itself decide the question of adult ὑπακοή; it does bound the theological space within which any answer must be given. *The View 1b answer, recorded as elsewhere:* delegated authority and direct answerability are compatible on 1b’s account (§4.1b); Ezekiel 18 bounds how any continuing office may be construed — no covering substitutes for personal standing before God — without deciding whether the office continues.

Working through cases. The distinctions above narrow, though they do not always resolve, common pastoral cases. Where a case is genuinely settled by the exegesis, the guidance follows straightforwardly. Where the exegesis leaves real tension, this analysis flags the tension rather than papering over it — the different Views in Chapter 4 will divide precisely at those points.

Cases the exegesis settles.

Situation	Guidance
Parent commands sin	No obedience owed — Acts 5:29; SA YD 240:15. Refuse without cursing them.
Married adult; parent competes with the spouse for time	Genesis 2:24 sets the new bond as primary. Honor persists but does not override the one-flesh bond.

Situation	Guidance
Godly parent offers unwelcome counsel	Not owed as obedience; owed as <i>weight</i> . Wisdom often converges once prayed through.
Aged parent needs support	Positively required as honor, not as obedience — Mark 7:9-13; 1 Tim. 5:4.
After parents' death	Burial, remembrance, keeping the name — Ruth 4:10; Tobit.

Cases the exegesis does not settle.

- *An adult child who has left the parental household; parent commands X.* On the paper's lean (§1.1.1), the Haustafel addressee-set does not follow the child out, and honor is expressed through consultation and decision before God rather than obedience. View 1b reads the imperative as reaching τέκνα qua τέκνα regardless of residence, ordinarily until marriage (§4.1b). The divide of §1.2.1 lands here in its most practical form; the paper's lean is a lean, not a settlement.
- *An adult child still resident in the parental household.* The Haustafel argument (current residence marks the addressee) cuts one way; the §1.2.1 usage-pattern argument (ὑπακούω's authority-relation uses presuppose active supervisory relation, which on 1a's reading tracks household-minor status) cuts the other. An adult child in residence for economic, cultural, or caregiving reasons occupies genuinely mixed territory. Ordinary domestic cooperation is owed as a matter of honor and household participation; whether Haustafel obedience proper re-attaches — and if so, in what scope — is precisely what Views 1a, 1b, 2a, and 2b divide over. This analysis will not close that gap by fiat.
- *An adult child accepting parental support while asserting full independence.* This is a pastoral tension the biblical exegesis cannot resolve on its own. It belongs to the register of virtue (integrity, gratitude, non-pretense) more than of household-code authority, and this analysis does not confuse the two.

Chapter 4 (Reality) will return to both the settled and the contested cases in modern form.

1.3 The Foundational Leaving Text

Genesis 2:24 — Therefore shall a man leave his father and his mother, and shall cleave unto his wife: and they shall be one flesh.

Repeated by Jesus (Matt. 19:5; Mark 10:7-8) and Paul (Eph. 5:31), this is the only leaving-command Scripture explicitly issues.

Observations. Three things stand out:

1. The pattern is *leave, cleave, become one flesh*. Leaving is the first movement; it precedes the marriage bond.
2. The command is given to the man (Hebrew *ya'azov-ish*; Greek ἀνὴρ, *anēr*). It is silent about the daughter's leaving. Ancient Near Eastern practice assumed the bride joined the husband's household; the Bible does not repeat this culturally, but it does not correct it either. The nearest canonical counterpart is the bride-addressed summons of Psalm 45:10 — "forget also thine own people, and thy father's house" — nuptial poetry rather than command, but a daughter-leaving text located at the marriage seam.
3. The leaving is *from* father and mother — plural — and *unto* a spouse. The paradigm is transferential, not autonomous. The son does not leave into solitary independence; he leaves into a new covenant bond.

Scripture nowhere prescribes a leaving-command not attached to marriage. This is not the same as forbidding leaving before marriage; it is silence about a mode Scripture does not directly discuss.

1.3.1 Can "Leave" and "Cleave" Be Separated in Time?

A modern reader will often press a specific question against Gen 2:24:

The verse has two coordinate verbs, leave and cleave. Nothing in the syntax mandates that they happen at the same moment. In an era of extended education, career mobility, and delayed marriage, the natural application is leave for adulthood, cleave when a spouse appears. Scripture doesn't legislate a bright-line simultaneity.

That reading has real linguistic weight and deserves an honest answer. The answer is that the sequential reading does not hold for this text specifically, though nothing here amounts to a wholesale prohibition of pre-marital leaving on other grounds. Five things weigh against the sequential reading of this text.

First, the purpose clause. The verse opens with אֶל־כֶּן (‘*al-kēn*) / ἕνεκεν τούτου (*heneken toutou*) — "therefore." *Therefore* what? The immediate antecedent (Gen 2:21-23) is the making of the woman and Adam's exclamation "this is now bone of my bones." Gen 2:24 is the etiological gloss on *marriage*: the verse is explaining what marriage is, not what adulthood is. To sever leaving from the marriage cause is to sever the verse from its own opening word.

Second, the verb pair is a unit, not a schedule. In Hebrew, יָצַב ... קָבַד (ya‘azov ... ve-davaq; imperfect + waw-consecutive perfect) is a coordinate future-consequential construction. The LXX, Jesus, and Paul all render it καταλείψει ... καὶ προσκολληθήσεται (*kataleipsei ... kai proskollēthēsetai*) — coordinated futures joined by καί (*kai*, “and”). Such constructions describe one transition from two sides — from-what and toward-what. Compare “put off the old man and put on the new” (Eph 4:22-24) or “let the wicked forsake his way and let him return unto the Lord” (Isa 55:7). No one reads these as two events years apart. They are two motions of one event.

Third, the “one flesh” clause seals the sentence as marriage-shaped. The three-part structure — *leave* → *cleave* → *become one flesh* — terminates in the sexual-covenantal union that constitutes marriage. “Become one flesh” is not a description of adulthood; it is the covenant bond. Reading the leaving as decoupled from the rest requires ignoring the destination the verse is aiming at.

Fourth, every biblical citation treats it as a marriage text. This is the weightiest of the five considerations. Jesus quotes Gen 2:24 in Matthew 19:5 / Mark 10:7-8 in the context of *divorce*: “what God hath joined together, let not man put asunder.” Paul quotes it in Ephesians 5:31 in the context of *marriage*: “this is a great mystery ... concerning Christ and the Church.” Not one biblical author ever cites the verse as a text about coming of age, seeking one’s fortune, or leaving to be an independent adult. The Bible’s own use of Gen 2:24 restricts it to the marriage transition.

Fifth, the narrative pattern of Scripture confirms it. If Gen 2:24 authorized a sequenced “leave now, marry later” pattern, we would expect it modelled. Instead, biblical leavings divide into two clean categories: *marital leavings* (Isaac into his own tent with Rebekah, Gen 24:67; Jacob toward Rachel and Leah; Rebekah herself; Ruth into Boaz) and *vocational leavings* (David to Saul, 1 Sam 16; the young men to war, Num 1 and Deut 20; Elisha leaving the plow, 1 Kings 19; the disciples leaving nets and tax booth; Timothy leaving with Paul). No one in Scripture leaves *in order to be an independent unmarried adult as an end in itself*. Every leaving that is not into marriage is into a specific *calling* — war, kingship, ministry, prophetic or gospel service. The “independence as a life stage” pattern has no biblical exemplars.

The precise conclusion. Gen 2:24 does not authorize sequenced leave-then-marry as a norm; its own opening word, its verb structure, its closing clause, its citations by Jesus and Paul, and the narrative pattern of Scripture all converge on the reading that this verse describes *the marriage transition*.

But — this does not forbid pre-marital leaving on other grounds.

That would overshoot the evidence. The paper's reading is more precise:

- Gen 2:24 does not *ground* pre-marital leaving.
- Scripture *permits* pre-marital leaving for specific callings — war (Num 1, Deut 20), vocation (David, Elisha, the disciples), prophetic or gospel service (Timothy), and providential displacement (Ruth, Esther, Lydia, arguably the daughters of Zelophehad).
- Scripture *does not exemplify* pre-marital leaving as an end in itself — “leave to be your own person.”

The exegetical point, then, is narrower than either side sometimes argues. Views that ground pre-marital leaving in Gen 2:24 face this challenge: the verse is about marriage, not about the pre-marital departure of an unmarried adult. On the reading declared at §1.1.1 and set out here, a warrant for pre-marital leaving must come from elsewhere — a vocational call, a providential displacement, a specific ministry — rather than from Gen 2:24. Where such a warrant is present, Scripture permits the leaving and even blesses it (Ruth, Timothy, David). Where it is absent, Gen 2:24 does not fill the gap. Views 2a and 2b handle this in different ways; the point here is only that the exegetical burden falls on the warrant, not on Gen 2:24 itself.

1.4 The Unmarried Adult: Direct Texts

Only a small number of texts directly address unmarried adult children in their parents' households.

1.4.1 Numbers 30 — Vows of Unmarried Daughters

Numbers 30:3-5 — If a woman also vow a vow unto the LORD, and bind herself by a bond, being in her father's house in her youth; And her father hear her vow, and her bond wherewith she hath bound her soul, and her father shall hold his peace at her: then all her vows shall stand, and every bond wherewith she hath bound her soul shall stand. But if her father disallow her in the day that he heareth; not any of her vows, or of her bonds wherewith she hath bound her soul, shall stand: and the LORD shall forgive her, because her father disallowed her.

Observations. This is the strongest text for continuing paternal authority over an unmarried daughter, and it must be reckoned with by every view. Three interpretive questions:

- **What does “in her youth” (Hebrew *bin’ureha*) mean?** The term denotes the years of unmarried immaturity; commentators divide over whether it extends indefinitely for an unmarried daughter or only through a particular life-stage.
- **What is the scope?** The passage governs vows, not the daughter’s every decision. The father’s veto is over religious vows and bonds of self-obligation.
- **Is there a parallel for sons?** No. Numbers 30 does not address unmarried sons at all. This is a case where Scripture treats daughters and sons differently.

Rabbinic bounding of the paternal vow-veto. Paul’s own tradition — Pharisaic halakhah preserved in the Mishnah and Talmud — read Numbers 30 as sharply age-bounded rather than indefinitely extended. The tractates *Nedarim* (chapters 10-11) and *Niddah* work out the maturity thresholds. The paternal right of annulment applies to the *ketanah* (the girl before the appearance of the first signs of physical maturity) and to the *na’arah* (the six-month intermediate stage marked by the first signs); it terminates at the *bogeret* threshold, at approximately twelve and a half years of age, at which point the classic formulation is “*yatz’ah mi-reshut ha-av*” — “she has left the authority of the father” (*b. Nedarim* 66b-70b; systematized at Rambam, *Hilkhhot Nedarim* 11:1-11; codified at *Shulchan Arukh Yoreh De’ah* 234). Paternal legal authority over a daughter’s vows, in the reception tradition of the very text, terminates *before* biological adulthood is complete. This is the rabbinic gloss Paul would have known; it is compatible with the second observation above (the veto’s scope is vows, not every decision) and it cuts against readings that make Numbers 30 the load-bearing text for lifelong paternal authority over unmarried daughters (see also §1.9 on the ambiguity that remains for readers who set aside the rabbinic reception). The modern systematic form of the extending reading is not hypothetical: Watchman Nee’s *Spiritual Authority* treats Numbers 30 as a paradigm of delegated authority — “God would rather have her obey authority than maintain her vow” (CFP 1972 trans., p. 73; see §B.1.1) — which is the reading the twentieth-century covering literature inherited.

An objection the rabbinic bounding must face, and its rejoinders. The fourth 1b reply at §1.2.1 presses that this reception is an impeached witness — the same tradition dead-lettered the rebellious-son statute of Deut. 21:18-21, and Jesus indicts Pharisaic vow-halakhah for “making the word of God of none effect” (Mark 7:9-13) — so that its bounding of Numbers 30 nullifies the paternal veto in practice rather than interpreting it. Three rejoinders are available to readers who credit the bounding. First, the *bogeret* threshold interprets limiting terms the text itself supplies — “in her youth,” “in her father’s house” (Num. 30:3, 16) — where the *Sanhedrin* restrictions on the rebellious

son (both parents alive, of like voice and appearance, exact quantities of meat and wine) invent conditions the text lacks; defining a term the text uses is a different act from constructing conditions against it. Second, the direction of effect differs from *korban*: the *korban* device let a son *evade a duty owed* to his parents, while the *bogeret* threshold *ends a jurisdiction over* a daughter — Mark 7 condemns tradition that nullifies an obligation, not tradition that declines to extend a power. Third, in the marriage-economy of the text's own world, where daughters ordinarily passed to a husband's house at or near maturity, a veto running to *bogeret* covered nearly the whole span in which an unvetoesd vow was possible; the bounded reading looks like nullification only when transplanted into a world of much later marriage — a world about which the chapter legislates in neither direction, which is part of why §1.9 lists its scope among the genuine ambiguities. Whether the reception tradition is discountable as a tendentious witness or probative as the reading community closest to the text, both assessments are available.

Numbers 30:9 — the Torah's own internal bounding. The same chapter that grants the paternal (v. 3-5) and marital (v. 6-8, 10-15) vow-veto also contains v. 9:

Numbers 30:9 — But every vow of a widow, and of her that is divorced, wherewith they have bound their souls, shall stand against her.

The text is explicit: for the widow and the divorced woman, no male authority stands between the vow and its binding force. The New Testament carries the same category forward: the widow "is at liberty to be married to whom she will; only in the Lord" (1 Cor. 7:39). This has two consequences that any use of Numbers 30 must reckon with. First, the Torah itself distinguishes "unmarried woman" from "under paternal (or marital) authority": v. 9 names an entire category of adult unmarried woman for whom no vow-veto applies. Second, the chapter's own internal grammar is that vow-authority attaches to a *specific relational status* (daughter *in her youth*, wife *in her husband's house*) rather than to unmarried status as such. Readers who make Numbers 30 the load-bearing text for continuing paternal authority over unmarried daughters must therefore account for why v. 9's counter-category — where the same Torah, in the same chapter, recognizes an adult woman under no male vow-veto — does not similarly bound the vv. 3-5 case at some threshold. The rabbinic tradition's *bogeret* threshold is one such accounting; readings that extend paternal vow-authority indefinitely over an unmarried daughter must supply another.

A tragic parallel case: Jephthah's daughter (Judges 11:29-40). The one Old Testament narrative in which a father's vow is allowed

to bind an unmarried daughter's whole future — Jephthah's rash pre-battle vow ("whatsoever cometh forth of the doors of my house to meet me ... shall surely be the LORD's, and I will offer it up for a burnt offering," Judg. 11:31) and its horrifying issue in his own daughter's coming out to meet him with timbrels and dances — is a narrative every use of Numbers 30 to authorize paternal control over an unmarried daughter's life-course must reckon with. The daughter's own response ("do to me according to that which hath proceeded out of thy mouth," 11:36) is often cited as filial obedience; the narrative frame has overwhelmingly been read as *tragic* rather than exemplary. The judge who spoke the vow is not named as fulfilling righteousness in doing so; the daughter is memorialized *by the daughters of Israel* who "went yearly to lament the daughter of Jephthah the Gileadite four days in a year" (11:40) — a woman's-liturgical remembrance of a woman's loss, not a father's-house celebration of covenantal fulfillment. Rabbinic and Christian commentators alike have read the passage as a warning against rash vows binding others, particularly one's own children (see the wide-ranging treatment in David Marcus, *Jephthah and His Vow*, Texas Tech UP, 1986; Phyllis Trible, *Texts of Terror*, Fortress, 1984, ch. 4). The Torah's own theological space — the same space that supplies Numbers 30 — supplies also the case in which paternal vow- authority over an unmarried daughter runs to catastrophe when detached from any external check. Numbers 30 grants a *veto* over a daughter's vows; it does not authorize a father to *bind* his daughter by his own vow. Jephthah's daughter marks the boundary that any doctrine of paternal vow-authority must respect.

1.4.2 First Corinthians 7 — The Unmarried and Their Fathers

1 Corinthians 7:8 — I say therefore to the unmarried and widows, It is good for them if they abide even as I.

1 Corinthians 7:32-34 — But I would have you without carefulness. He that is unmarried careth for the things that belong to the Lord, how he may please the Lord ... There is difference also between a wife and a virgin. The unmarried woman careth for the things of the Lord, that she may be holy both in body and in spirit: but she that is married careth for the things of the world, how she may please her husband.

1 Corinthians 7:36-38 — But if any man think that he behaveth himself uncomely toward his virgin, if she pass the flower of her age, and need so require, let him do what he will, he sinneth not: let them marry. Nevertheless he that standeth stedfast in his heart, having no necessity, but hath power over his own will, and hath so decreed in his

heart that he will keep his virgin, doeth well. So then he that giveth her in marriage doeth well; but he that giveth her not in marriage doeth better.

Observations. Two principal interpretive traditions exist for 7:36-38: the “father-of-the-virgin” reading (the man is the daughter’s father, deciding whether to give her in marriage) and the “betrothed-couple” reading (the man is engaged to the virgin and deciding whether to marry her). Both are ancient; a third ancient reading, well-attested in the pre-Nicene period, is treated at §1.9. If the father-reading is correct, it is the closest New Testament parallel to Numbers 30 — a father retains real say in an unmarried daughter’s marriage. If the betrothal-reading is correct, the passage is silent on paternal authority. Either way, Paul assumes and commends *the unmarried state as a positive calling* (v. 7-8, 32-34) — a calling that the New Testament plainly permits.

1.4.3 Acts 21 — Philip’s Daughters

Acts 21:8-9 — And the next day we that were of Paul’s company departed, and came unto Caesarea: and we entered into the house of Philip the evangelist, which was one of the seven; and abode with him. And the same man had four daughters, virgins, which did prophesy.

Observations. Four adult unmarried daughters live in their father’s house *and* exercise a public prophetic ministry. Luke reports it as a matter of course. The text does not tell us the mechanism — whether the daughters are under continuing paternal authority, or whether they are independent adults who happen to live at home. What it does show is that in the New Testament church:

- Unmarried adult daughters could remain in the paternal household as a settled arrangement.
- They could simultaneously exercise a Spirit-given ministry (the prophetic gift) that is not derived from the father.

Both patriocentric and non-patriocentric readings can accommodate this passage, but no reading may ignore it.

1.4.4 The Direction of Provision

2 Corinthians 12:14 — Behold, the third time I am ready to come to you; and I will not be burdensome to you: for I seek not yours, but you: for the children ought not to lay up for the parents, but the parents for the children.

1 Timothy 5:4 — But if any widow have children or nephews, let them learn first to shew piety at home, and to requite their parents: for that is good and acceptable before God.

1 Timothy 5:8 — But if any provide not for his own, and specially for those of his own house, he hath denied the faith, and is worse than an infidel.

Observations. Paul teaches both directions: parents provide for children (2 Cor. 12:14), and adult children requite their parents (1 Tim. 5:4, 8). The two are not contradictory — they describe different life-stages. The unmarried adult period is the pivot between them.

Narrative parallels. The Pauline precepts have two principal Old Testament narrative witnesses.

Genesis 45:9-11 — Haste ye, and go up to my father, and say unto him, Thus saith thy son Joseph, God hath made me lord of all Egypt: come down unto me, tarry not... And there will I nourish thee.

Genesis 47:12 — And Joseph nourished his father, and his brethren, and all his father's household, with bread, according to their families.

1 Samuel 22:3-4 — And David went thence to Mizpeh of Moab: and he said unto the king of Moab, Let my father and my mother, I pray thee, come forth, and be with you, till I know what God will do for me. And he brought them before the king of Moab: and they dwelt with him all the while that David was in the hold.

Joseph's word to Jacob — "come down unto me... there will I nourish thee" — is 1 Tim. 5:4 in narrative form: the son whose place God has enlarged brings the father *into* that place and cares for him and the whole household. David lodges his parents in Moab under a king's protection when his own life is at risk. The narrative places the pivot of §1.4.4's precept — the adult son requiting the father — before the reader as a scripturally- modelled response to God's providence, not merely a moral rule.

1.4.5 The Marriage-Arrangement Cluster

A significant cluster of biblical passages concerns the *transaction* of marriage itself — the moment when the covenant is formed. In these passages parental authority is concentrated at that seam rather than diffused across daily life.

Genesis 24:2-4 — And Abraham said unto his eldest servant of his house, that ruled over all that he had, Put, I pray thee, thy hand under my thigh: And I will make thee swear by the LORD, the God of heaven, and the God of the earth, that thou shalt not take a wife unto my son of the daughters of the Canaanites, among whom I dwell: But thou shalt go unto my country, and to my kindred, and take a wife unto my son Isaac.

Observations. Isaac is roughly forty at his marriage (Gen. 25:20). His father does not merely counsel; he sends an authorized servant under oath to secure Rebekah. The narrative records no consultation with Isaac before the servant departs. This is the strongest single Old Testament text for a paternal marriage-arrangement role toward an adult son.

Genesis 24:57-58 — And they said, We will call the damsel, and enquire at her mouth. And they called Rebekah, and said unto her, Wilt thou go with this man? And she said, I will go.

Observations. The same passage that furnishes the fullest picture of paternal arrangement furnishes also the clearest picture of the bride's consent. Rebekah's brother and mother refuse to close the arrangement without her own answer; her answer — "I will go" — is the operative act. Scripture presents arrangement and consent as compatible, not competing. The Council of Trent (see §4.3.1), canon law's insistence on the consent of the parties (canon 1057), and the historic Christian rejection of coerced marriage all draw on this precedent. Where an arrangement view is scriptural, it carries this text with it — the daughter's consent is not ceremonial but constitutive.

Genesis 21:21 — And he dwelt in the wilderness of Paran: and his mother took him a wife out of the land of Egypt.

Ishmael's mother exercises the same office. The pattern is not restricted to fathers.

Genesis 28:1-2 — And Isaac called Jacob, and blessed him, and charged him, and said unto him, Thou shalt not take a wife of the daughters of Canaan. Arise, go to Padanaram, to the house of Bethuel thy mother's father; and take thee a wife from thence of the daughters of Laban thy mother's brother.

Isaac (now the father) initiates Jacob's marriage journey.

Exodus 22:16-17 — And if a man entice a maid that is not betrothed, and lie with her, he shall surely endow her to be

his wife. If her father utterly refuse to give her unto him, he shall pay money according to the dowry of virgins.

The father's authority to refuse a suitor is legally recognized even after the physical union has occurred.

Deuteronomy 22:16 — And the damsel's father shall say unto the elders, I gave my daughter unto this man to wife, and he hateth her.

The father speaks legally on behalf of his daughter in a marriage dispute *even after the wedding*. The verb is *give* (Hebrew *natan*) — a term of legal transaction.

Judges 14:1-3 — And Samson went down to Timnath, and saw a woman in Timnath of the daughters of the Philistines. And he came up, and told his father and his mother, and said, I have seen a woman in Timnath of the daughters of the Philistines: now therefore get her for me to wife. Then his father and his mother said unto him, Is there never a woman among the daughters of thy brethren, or among all my people, that thou goest to take a wife of the uncircumcised Philistines?

Observations. Samson insists on his own preference against parental judgment; his parents nonetheless accompany him and negotiate on his behalf (14:5-10). The narrative treats his overriding of parental judgment as tragic even where God overrules it for His purposes (14:4). The text shows both the assumed parental role and its limits.

Ruth 3:1-4 — Then Naomi her mother in law said unto her, My daughter, shall I not seek rest for thee, that it may be well with thee? ... Wash thyself therefore, and anoint thee, and put thy raiment upon thee, and get thee down to the floor: but make not thyself known unto the man, until he shall have done eating and drinking. And it shall be, when he lieth down, that thou shalt mark the place where he shall lie, and thou shalt go in, and uncover his feet, and lay thee down; and he will tell thee what thou shalt do.

Ruth 4:9-10 — And Boaz said unto the elders, and unto all the people, Ye are witnesses this day, that I have bought all that was Elimelech's, and all that was Chilion's and Mahlon's, of the hand of Naomi. Moreover Ruth the Moabitess, the wife of Mahlon, have I purchased to be my wife, to raise up the name of the dead upon his inheritance.

Observations. Even for Ruth — an adult widow, not a maiden — the marriage proceeds by mediated arrangement. Naomi guides;

Boaz negotiates through the elders at the city gate. Direct romantic self-initiation without covenant mediation is absent from the text.

In 1 Corinthians 7:37-38 (quoted in full at §1.4.2), on the father-of-the-virgin reading, Paul places the marriage decision within the father's power ("hath power over his own will") — even while restraining the exercise of that authority for the daughter's calling.

Song of Solomon 8:8-9 — We have a little sister, and she hath no breasts: what shall we do for our sister in the day when she shall be spoken for? If she be a wall, we will build upon her a palace of silver: and if she be a door, we will inclose her with boards of cedar.

Observations. The speakers are the *brothers* of the beloved, deliberating what protective office they owe their still-young sister at the seam of her being "spoken for" — that is, the seam of a marriage suit. The passage supplies two data points relevant to this cluster. First, it locates the sister's marriage-formation office in her *natal household* — here specifically the fraternal line rather than the paternal (father is absent from the frame). Second, the office is protective and responsive to the sister's own character: *if she be a wall* (self-guarded), the response is adornment; *if she be a door* (open), the response is protective enclosure. The beloved's own answer in the next verse — "*I am a wall, and my breasts like towers: then was I in his eyes as one that found favor*" (8:10) — completes the picture: the sister speaks for her own maturity, and the household office adjusts accordingly. The Song, canonical love-poetry, presents the household marriage-office as *neither absent nor absolutizing* — present in a caring form, calibrated to the sister's own maturity, and completed by her own voice.

Observations across the cluster. Scripture consistently pictures marriage as a covenant transaction into which parents enter as principals — negotiating, blessing, sometimes commissioning. This is not the same as continuing daily authority; it is authority located at a specific covenant seam. The pattern extends across sons and daughters, patriarchs and judges and Ruth, and into Paul.

1.4.6 Vocational Household Transfer

A distinct pattern in Scripture concerns adult (or nearly adult) children who leave the parental household not for autonomous independence and not for marriage, but *to serve under another authority* — prophet, teacher, king, or the Lord Himself.

1 Kings 19:19-21 — So he departed thence, and found Elisha the son of Shaphat, who was plowing with twelve

yoke of oxen before him, and he with the twelfth: and Elijah passed by him, and cast his mantle upon him. And he left the oxen, and ran after Elijah, and said, Let me, I pray thee, kiss my father and my mother, and then I will follow thee. And he said unto him, Go back again: for what have I done to thee? And he returned back from him, and took a yoke of oxen, and slew them, and boiled their flesh with the instruments of the oxen, and gave unto the people, and they did eat. Then he arose, and went after Elijah, and ministered unto him.

Elisha leaves his father's twelve yoke of oxen — a substantial inheritance — to serve Elijah. He takes formal leave; he sacrifices the equipment; his parents are not portrayed as objecting.

1 Samuel 1:22, 28 — But Hannah went not up; for she said unto her husband, I will not go up until the child be weaned, and then I will bring him, that he may appear before the LORD, and there abide for ever ... Therefore also I have lent him to the LORD; as long as he liveth he shall be lent to the LORD.

Samuel is placed in Eli's household under Eli's authority, and serves before the LORD from boyhood through adulthood. (The dedication itself — vow, journey, sacrifice, and presentation — is treated in full at §5.0.3.)

Compare 1 Samuel 16:19-23 — David is sent by Jesse to serve at Saul's court, entering a royal household while still recognized as Jesse's son.

Matthew 4:18-22 — And Jesus, walking by the sea of Galilee, saw two brethren, Simon called Peter, and Andrew his brother, casting a net into the sea: for they were fishers. And he saith unto them, Follow me, and I will make you fishers of men. And they straightway left their nets, and followed him. And going on from thence, he saw other two brethren, James the son of Zebedee, and John his brother, in a ship with Zebedee their father, mending their nets; and he called them. And they immediately left the ship and their father, and followed him.

The Zebedee scene is especially telling: adult sons leaving their father's fishing business at Christ's call — mid-work, mid-day, mid-life.

Luke 9:59-62 — And he said unto another, Follow me. But he said, Lord, suffer me first to go and bury my father. Jesus said unto him, Let the dead bury their dead: but go thou and

preach the kingdom of God. And another also said, Lord, I will follow thee; but let me first go bid them farewell, which are at home at my house. And Jesus said unto him, No man, having put his hand to the plough, and looking back, is fit for the kingdom of God.

Christ's call trumps even ordinary filial obligation at the seam of vocation.

Observations. Scripture repeatedly witnesses that an adult unmarried son (and, more rarely in the direct text, a daughter) may leave the parental household to serve under another authority. The pattern is not autonomous individualism; it is *transfer* to another sphere of formation. Vocational household transfer is a biblically warranted third path — neither perpetual household residence nor cultural launch into self-directed adulthood.

Modern missionary witness. The vocational-transfer pattern is not frozen in the biblical text; it recurs across Christian history and into the modern missionary movement, and the witness is dense enough to name. Adoniram Judson sailed for Burma in 1812 at twenty-three; Hudson Taylor for Shanghai in 1853 at twenty-one; Amy Carmichael for Japan in 1893 at twenty-five, then India in 1895; Jim Elliot, Nate Saint, Ed McCully, Pete Fleming, and Roger Youderian to Ecuador in the early 1950s, dying at Palm Beach on 8 January 1956 at twenty-eight, thirty-two, twenty-eight, twenty-seven, and thirty-one; Bruce Olson to the Motilone in Colombia in 1961 at nineteen. Elisabeth Elliot, whose *Through Gates of Splendor* (Harper, 1957) and *Shadow of the Almighty* (Harper, 1958) fixed the Palm Beach witness for a generation, herself went to Ecuador at twenty-four (1952) to translate the New Testament for the Colorado Indians; her later return to the Auca (Waadani) after her husband's death made her, in her own account, a woman under vocational household transfer twice — first with her natal family (leaving her parents' home for Ecuador) and later with her marital household (returning to the tribe that killed her husband, with their toddler daughter and Rachel Saint). Each of these instances shows the pattern's shape: adult child leaves the parental household not for autonomy and not for marriage but *under call*, into another authority — a mission society, a sending church, or a direct commission from Christ — with the parental relation continuing across the seam (Judson wrote his father from Serampore; Taylor kept a lifelong correspondence with his mother; Elliot with her parents throughout Ecuador). The pattern is neither novel nor rare in the church; it is one of the central Christian shapes of unmarried adult vocation.

1.4.7 The Nazirite / Set-Apart Exception

Scripture makes room for a set-apart calling that pre-empts ordinary household patterns entirely.

Numbers 6:2 — Speak unto the children of Israel, and say unto them, When either man or woman shall separate themselves to vow a vow of a Nazarite, to separate themselves unto the LORD.

The Nazirite vow² could be undertaken by man or woman. In Samuel's case (1 Sam. 1:11) the vow is made *for* him by his mother before his birth. In John the Baptist's case (Luke 1:15) the vow is prophetically declared before his birth. Whether temporary or lifelong, the Nazirite pattern shows that Scripture recognizes callings that override ordinary household patterns for the sake of the LORD's service. The exception is genuine, though narrow.

1.4.8 The Warrior Departure Pattern

Scripture presents a further pattern by which unmarried adult sons routinely left the paternal household for extended periods and under a different authority structure: enrolment in the fighting force of Israel.

Numbers 1:2-3 — Take ye the sum of all the congregation of the children of Israel, after their families, by the house of their fathers, with the number of their names, every male by their polls; From twenty years old and upward, all that are able to go forth to war in Israel: thou and Aaron shall number them by their armies.

Observations. Age twenty is the settled biblical threshold for male military majority. The census is conducted "by the house of their fathers" — the young man is *counted as belonging* to his father's house, yet is simultaneously enrolled in the army under captains of thousands and hundreds. He remains a son; he is no longer solely under his father's daily direction.

Deuteronomy 20:5-8 — And the officers shall speak unto the people, saying, What man is there that hath built a new house, and hath not dedicated it? let him go and return to his house, lest he die in the battle, and another man dedicate it. And what man is he that hath planted a vineyard, and

²"Nazirite" is the standard modern scholarly spelling (from Hebrew נָזִיר, *nazir*, "consecrated one") used throughout this analysis in narrator's voice. The KJV consistently uses "Nazarite" (Num. 6; Judg. 13, 16; Amos 2); that spelling is preserved when the KJV is quoted.

hath not yet eaten of it? let him also go and return unto his house ... And what man is there that hath betrothed a wife, and hath not taken her? let him go and return unto his house, lest he die in the battle, and another man take her. ... What man is there that is fearful and fainthearted? let him go and return unto his house, lest his brethren's heart faint as well as his heart.

Observations. The exemption structure discloses the assumption: the default expectation for a young man of military age was that he *would* leave for the campaign. Betrothal, the new house, the new vineyard — each functions as a competing settled attachment that takes precedence over war. The passage assumes both that departure was normal and that certain covenantal thresholds relieved him of it.

Deuteronomy 24:5 — When a man hath taken a new wife, he shall not go out to war, neither shall he be charged with any business: but he shall be free at home one year, and shall cheer up his wife which he hath taken.

Observations. A newly married man is legally exempt from military service and from public “business” (Hebrew *davar*) for a full year. The text testifies that Scripture places positive obligation on the household seam of marriage — but the very existence of the exemption confirms that unmarried men of age were expected to be under military, not purely paternal, authority.

1 Samuel 17:17-20 — And Jesse said unto David his son, Take now for thy brethren an ephah of this parched corn, and these ten loaves, and run to the camp to thy brethren; And carry these ten cheeses unto the captain of their thousand, and look how thy brethren fare ... Now Saul, and they, and all the men of Israel, were in the valley of Elah, fighting with the Philistines. And David rose up early in the morning ... and went, as Jesse had commanded him.

Observations. David's three elder brothers are with Saul's army, under the king's captain, while David — still under Jesse's roof — runs errands between household and camp. The narrative preserves both the ongoing paternal relation (Jesse commissions David) and the transferred authority (the brothers serve under Saul, not Jesse).

Broader pattern. The register of fighting men appears again in Numbers 26 (the second census, again from twenty years upward), in the Chronicler's genealogies of the armies of Israel and Judah, and in the recurring formula “all that were able to go forth to war.” The united assumption of the Old Testament legal, historical, and prophetic texts is that at twenty, sons of Israel *left* — not into autonomous adulthood,

but into national and military service under a different authority than the father.

The bearing on the present question:

- **Age twenty** is the earliest settled biblical threshold for adult male responsibility outside the immediate household. This is independent testimony toward a scriptural “coming of age” — one that the New Testament neither contradicts nor formally repeats.
- **Departure into another authority structure** is a recurring scriptural mode. It is not the same as autonomous individualism; the young man passes from paternal to military authority, and the father retains a relational and covenantal claim (David and Jesse).
- **Marriage and departure interweave.** Deut. 20 and 24 place the marriage seam in explicit tension with the war seam. This texture belongs in any doctrine of the unmarried adult son.

1.4.9 Adult Filial Bonds Beyond the Nuclear Frame

Scripture recognizes filial-shaped bonds that are not father-to-son or mother-to-daughter in the biological sense but that carry the same weight of honor, loyalty, and lifelong commitment. Any doctrine of the unmarried adult child that treats the nuclear family as the only frame within which adult filial relation can exist misses the biblical breadth.

Ruth and Naomi. Ruth’s vow to her Moabite mother-in-law is one of the strongest filial declarations in Scripture: “Whither thou goest, I will go; and where thou lodgest, I will lodge: thy people shall be my people, and thy God my God: Where thou diest, will I die, and there will I be buried: the LORD do so to me, and more also, if ought but death part thee and me” (Ruth 1:16-17). This is not a biological bond, not a covenant of marriage (Naomi’s son is dead), not a legal requirement (Naomi has just released her: “Turn again, my daughters, go your way,” 1:12). It is voluntarily taken adult filial loyalty to a widowed elder. Naomi in turn functions as Ruth’s counselor at the marriage seam (Ruth 3:1-4) — a *para-maternal* office in the absence of Ruth’s natural family. The book ends with the women of Bethlehem telling Naomi that Ruth “is better to thee than seven sons” (4:15). The Old Testament here names a category the doctrine of parents and adult children must honor: **the adopted or elected elder**, to whom filial obligation runs though no blood does.

David and Jonathan. Jonathan is the crown prince, David the anointed successor; their covenant (1 Sam. 18:1-4; 20:14-17; 23:18) runs *across* the paternal claim of Saul, without violating it — Jonathan

does not renounce Saul, does not desert Saul, dies beside Saul at Gilboa (1 Sam. 31:2). And within that unbroken filial bond he refuses the unrighteous command: told by Saul to kill David (1 Sam. 19:1), Jonathan instead warns David, speaks good of him to his father, and protests the injustice to Saul's face at the cost of a javelin thrown at him (1 Sam. 19:1-7; 20:32-33) — the Old Testament's most extended narrative instance of an adult child holding filial honor together with refusal of a sinful directive, the ceiling every view grants in principle (Acts 5:29). But he chooses David with covenant force, extends the covenant to David's house, and receives from David a lifelong obligation that David keeps toward Mephibosheth (2 Sam. 9:1-13; 21:7). This is not marriage, not paternal, not merely friendship in the modern sense. It is covenanted adult peer-filial bond that binds the two households across a generation. David's lament — "very pleasant hast thou been unto me: thy love to me was wonderful, passing the love of women" (2 Sam. 1:26) — names the intensity without collapsing the category into either erotic love or ordinary friendship.

Naomi-Ruth and David-Jonathan together establish that Scripture knows adult filial bonds that are not created by biology or marriage. Elizabeth of Zechariah is Mary's "cousin" (Luke 1:36 KJV, συγγενίς, *syngenis* — kinswoman), and yet the three-month stay at Ain Karim (Luke 1:39-56) functions as a maternal-mentor relation at the pivotal moment of Mary's calling. Priscilla and Aquila take Apollos aside and "expound unto him the way of God more perfectly" (Acts 18:26) — a mentor-relation Paul later commends to Timothy (2 Tim. 1:5 and Timothy's discipling by Lois and Eunice; 2 Tim. 2:2, "commit thou to faithful men, who shall be able to teach others also").

Bearing on the present question. For the unmarried adult child whose parents have died, are absent, or are unable to fulfill the counseling office; for the parent whose child has walked away (§5.0.2); for the church considering how to care pastorally for unmarried adults (1 Tim. 5:1-16): Scripture names *elected filial bonds* — adopted mothers, adopted brothers, spiritual fathers and mothers — as real bonds carrying real weight. The doctrine of parents and adult children is not confined to the nuclear frame; where the nuclear frame is broken or partial, Scripture supplies patterns for how the household of faith fills the gap without displacing the natural bond where it endures.

1.4.10 The Mixed Household — Believer Under Unbelieving Parents

The four views set out in Chapter 4 (1a, 1b, 2a, 2b) silently presuppose *two believing parents* whose covering, counsel, or release is Christian. This is the frame of most modern American evangelical writing on

the subject, and it is the frame the paper elsewhere works within. But it is not the frame of the pre-Nicene church, which stands as a load-bearing witness for the Antiquity leg (Chapter 3): for the church of the first three centuries, the *ordinary* case of the adult unmarried believer was the *inverse* — a convert under a pagan paterfamilias, or one believing parent with an unbelieving spouse, or a household divided along the line Jesus explicitly named as one of the marks of His coming. Scripture addresses this case directly and repeatedly, and any framework of parents and adult children that omits it addresses only a subset of the church.

Matthew 10:34-36 — Think not that I am come to send peace on earth: I came not to send peace, but a sword. For I am come to set a man at variance against his father, and the daughter against her mother, and the daughter in law against her mother in law. And a man's foes shall be they of his own household. [Jesus quoting **Micah 7:6**.]

Luke 12:51-53 — Suppose ye that I am come to give peace on earth? I tell you, Nay; but rather division: For from henceforth there shall be five in one house divided, three against two, and two against three. The father shall be divided against the son, and the son against the father; the mother against the daughter, and the daughter against the mother; the mother in law against her daughter in law, and the daughter in law against her mother in law.

Observations on the division sayings. These verses stand *immediately before* Matthew 10:37 (“He that loveth father or mother more than me is not worthy of me”) — the verse the paper cites repeatedly as the Christocentric ordering of loyalties. Read together, the two sayings do a single work: Jesus first names the household division His coming produces (the *cause* of the crisis), then supplies the ordering that resolves it in Him (the *response* to the crisis). Reading v. 37 apart from vv. 34-36 loses the scenario the verse was given for. The scenario is precisely the mixed household.

1 Corinthians 7:12-16 — But to the rest speak I, not the Lord: If any brother hath a wife that believeth not, and she be pleased to dwell with him, let him not put her away... For the unbelieving husband is sanctified by the wife, and the unbelieving wife is sanctified by the husband; else were your children unclean; but now are they holy... For what knowest thou, O wife, whether thou shalt save thy husband? or how knowest thou, O man, whether thou shalt save thy wife?

Observations on 1 Corinthians 7:12-16. Paul writes into churches

where mixed households are the *ordinary* pastoral case. The apostolic counsel is neither withdrawal (do not put away the unbelieving spouse) nor accommodation to unbelief (the believer's own walk is not dictated by the unbelieving partner). The pattern is *witnessing perseverance in place* — remaining in the household as a believer, hoping for the household's salvation, without subordinating the believer's obedience to Christ to the unbelieving partner's authority. The reasoning is straightforwardly transferable to the parent-child case: the adult believer under an unbelieving parent honors the parent, remains in relation where possible, and does not subordinate obedience to Christ to the parent's contrary command.

The Christocentric datum. Jesus's own household was, during His public ministry, a divided one. His brothers did not believe on Him (John 7:5, a verse Chapter 2 will use for the argument on John 19, §2.6); His mother received hard sayings that apparently included the sword prophesied at Simeon's blessing (Luke 2:35); James's trajectory from unbeliever to church pillar (Gal. 1:19; Acts 15) is itself a mixed-household narrative resolving in the Lord's favor. Whatever else the Christocentric leg says, it does not say the Lord's ordering assumes an intact-believing household of origin.

The worked example already in the paper. Timothy is treated at §1.6.5 as the paradigm case of an adult child under spiritual paternity. He is also, and the paper acknowledges this in a single bullet, a mixed-household case: his mother Eunice and grandmother Lois were believers, and Acts 16:1 records that his father was a "Greek" — either dead or, more probably given the phrasing, an unbelieving Gentile still living. Timothy's departure with Paul (Acts 16:3) is therefore not a case of an adult son leaving believing parents; it is a case of an adult son under a mixed-household of origin being received into an apostolic household as spiritual son. The paper's treatment of Timothy is consistent with mixed-household as its actual category, and this subsection makes what §1.6.5 has always tacitly assumed explicit.

The commandment when the parent commands apostasy. The honor commandment (Ex. 20:12; Eph. 6:2) is not conditional on the parent's faith. The Christocentric ordering (Matt. 10:37; Luke 14:26) is also not conditional on it. What Scripture and the apostolic tradition converge on for the mixed-household believer is: *honor the parent absolutely; obey the parent in every command that does not command against Christ; refuse the command that would require apostasy; remain in the household as long as witnessing perseverance is possible; leave, if the parent's demand requires it, without hatred and with the door open to reconciliation.* The pattern is precisely what Peter and John declare at Acts 4:19 and 5:29 — "we ought to

obey God rather than men” — applied at the household level. The rabbinic tradition Paul inherited took the same shape: *Shulchan Arukh Yoreh De’ah* 240:15, previously cited at §1.2.1, rules that if a parent commands a violation of Torah, “he must not listen.” The mixed-household case is where this ceiling becomes the *actual* pastoral situation rather than a theoretical limit.

Bearing on the four views. Every view described in Chapter 4 assumes a parent whose direction is at least ordinarily obedient to Christ. Where that assumption fails, none of the four views’ default counsel — 1a’s remain-under-covering, 1b’s continuous submission, 2a’s launched-independence, 2b’s release-with-prayer — carries in its default form. The mixed-household case reorders the question: the believer’s directive obedience is bounded by Christ even where the parent is present and directing, so senses (2), (3), and (4) of authority (§1.1.1) continue to operate in the ordinary way — the believer still receives the parent’s teaching where it is true, weighs the parent’s counsel, and prays for the parent — but sense (1) is defeated *not* by the child’s adulthood in this case but by the parent’s contrary command. This is the case Chapter 3 takes up under the martyr witness (Perpetua, §3.7.1), and it is the case for which the pre-Nicene church supplied the vocabulary the paper’s Antiquity leg draws on.

1.4.11 The Return Seam — Leaving as Reversible

The Haustafel-and-marriage discussion treats leaving the paternal household as an ordinarily one-directional movement: the child departs, marriage occurs (or in some views ought to occur), and the new household begins. Scripture, however, notices three cases in which an adult woman *returns* to her father’s household, and one in which the “mother’s house” is named as an alternate framing of the household of origin. These texts do not settle any of the disputed questions, but they establish that the leaving-seam is not, in Scripture’s own idiom, an irreversible cut.

Leviticus 22:13 — But if the priest’s daughter be a widow, or divorced, and have no child, and is returned unto her father’s house, as in her youth, she shall eat of her father’s meat: but there shall no stranger eat thereof.

The phrase *as in her youth* (הַיָּוֶעֶנָה, *kin’ureha*) is the ordinary Hebrew idiom for the pre-marriage state, and the Torah here anticipates a priest’s adult daughter — widowed or divorced, without a child of her own to establish a household through — reoccupying the status she held before she left. The provision is not a bare return; it is a return *to standing*: she eats of the priestly portion (the holy things set apart to her father’s house) that had been closed to her during her

marriage into another family. The father-daughter relation is treated as capable of resumption of both material provision and household identification. This has no parallel for sons in the Levitical corpus, but the daughter case is stated without qualification.

Genesis 38:11 — Then said Judah to Tamar his daughter in law, Remain a widow at thy father's house, till Shelah my son be grown.

Tamar returns to her father's house at Judah's direction after Er's death. The return is presented without editorial comment as an ordinary and honorable arrangement; the narrator's later censure falls on Judah's failure to send Shelah, not on the return-to-father itself. Whatever else Genesis 38 teaches, it depicts a young widow resuming residence in her father's household as the default while awaiting a possible remarriage. Ruth 1 assumes the same pattern by implication: Naomi releases both daughters-in-law to "return each to her mother's house" (Ruth 1:8), and Orpah does so.

Ruth 1:8 — And Naomi said unto her two daughters in law, Go, return each to her mother's house: the LORD deal kindly with you, as ye have dealt with the dead, and with me.

The phrasing "mother's house" (בֵּית אִמִּי, *bet 'em*) is unusual — the standard idiom is "father's house" — and the same phrase appears at Song of Solomon 3:4 ("into my mother's house") and 8:2, and at Genesis 24:28 (Rebekah "ran, and told them of her mother's house these things"). In Genesis 24 Rebekah's father Bethuel is demonstrably alive (24:15, 50), so the idiom is not simply a substitute for "father's house" in cases where the father has died. In each occurrence the phrase appears in an explicit marriage-arrangement context: Genesis 24 during the marriage inquiry; Ruth 1 as Naomi dispatches her widowed daughters-in-law *for remarriage* (Ruth 1:9 makes the intent explicit — "the LORD grant you that ye may find rest, each of you in the house of her husband"); Song of Solomon 3-8 as nuptial love-poetry. The idiom seems to be semi-technical for the household in its *nuptial register* — the sphere of marriage arrangement, traditionally the mother's domain even in a father-headed household (Meyers, *Discovering Eve*; Steinberg, *Kinship and Marriage in Genesis*). The mother's counsel-authority (Prov. 1:8, sense (3) of §1.1.1) is materially housed in the same building the father heads, and it becomes idiomatically visible precisely at the marriage seam where her office was most engaged.

Bearing on the disputed questions. View 2 accounts (2a and 2b), in describing launched adulthood as a clean forward-only movement, tend to leave the return case theologically undertreated. View 1

accounts, in describing continuous household life, do not need the return case as an exception but also do not typically highlight it. The Levitical provision suggests that a Scripture-shaped account of adult filial life will treat the leaving-seam as a *typical* rather than an *absolute* boundary — the ordinary movement is outward, but the household of origin remains capable of receiving the adult daughter back into standing where circumstance requires, and the church of Jesus Christ, which reads these texts, has implicitly read them as authorizing the receiving-back rather than prescribing a one-way door.

1.5 The Wisdom Literature

The Proverbs assume a father-and-son teaching context that runs into adulthood:

Proverbs 1:8 — My son, hear the instruction of thy father, and forsake not the law of thy mother.

Proverbs 4:1 — Hear, ye children, the instruction of a father, and attend to know understanding.

Proverbs 22:6 — Train up a child in the way he should go: and when he is old, he will not depart from it.

Proverbs 23:22 — Hearken unto thy father that begat thee, and despise not thy mother when she is old.

Proverbs 31:1-3 — The words of king Lemuel, the prophecy that his mother taught him. What, my son? and what, the son of my womb? and what, the son of my vows? Give not thy strength unto women, nor thy ways to that which destroyeth kings.

A distinct case: an adult king receives maternal instruction. The final chapter of Proverbs opens with a superscription identifying the entire subsequent oracle — including verses 1-9 on kingly self-mastery, care for the mute and the poor, and just judgment, and verses 10-31 on the woman of valor — as *the prophecy that his mother taught him*. Whatever the disputed identity of Lemuel (rabbinic tradition read him as Solomon; others as a Massaite king outside Israel; see Waltke, *Book of Proverbs 15-31*, NICOT, 2005, pp. 500-508), the frame is canonical: an adult crowned king is presented as receiving instruction from his mother, and the instruction is preserved and canonized as *his own* wisdom. The passage is the fullest Old Testament instance of what §1.2.2 calls the honor-as-consultation register: an adult crowned son who receives, *hearkens* to, and internalizes maternal instruction

— and it stands as the direct Wisdom-literature counterpart to Prov. 23:22's directive that the adult son shall not despise his aged mother.

Commandment-vocabulary in Proverbs. Alongside the hearken- and-heed sayings above, Proverbs also applies commandment- vocabulary (מִצְוָה, *mitzvah*) to parental teaching, sometimes in the keep-and-live imperative form characteristic of Deuteronomy:

Proverbs 3:1 — My son, forget not my law; but let thine heart keep my commandments.

Proverbs 4:4 — He taught me also, and said unto me, Let thine heart retain my words: keep my commandments, and live.

Proverbs 6:20-23 — My son, keep thy father's commandment, and forsake not the law of thy mother: Bind them continually upon thine heart, and tie them about thy neck. When thou goest, it shall lead thee; when thou sleepest, it shall keep thee; and when thou awakest, it shall talk with thee. For the commandment is a lamp; and the law is light; and reproofs of instruction are the way of life.

Proverbs 7:1-2 — My son, keep my words, and lay up my commandments with thee. Keep my commandments, and live; and my law as the apple of thine eye.

Proverbs 19:16 — He that keepeth the commandment keepeth his own soul; but he that despiseth his ways shall die.

Prov. 6:20-23 is textually striking: it holds together, in a single passage, parental command (שְׁמַר + הִנָּח, the same verb-pair Deuteronomy uses of covenant commandments) and the sapiential re-framing of "commandment" as *lamp* and *light*. Prov. 4:4 and 7:1-2 attach the imperative to an "and live" outcome-clause. The lexical field of parental instruction in Proverbs is thus double: hearken/heed and keep/commandment, side by side in the same corpus.

Observations. The addressee of Proverbs — the "my son" or "children" of these sayings — is not fixed at a single age. Individual passages presuppose different life-stages: some assume a young boy in whom the rod still has a formative role (Prov. 13:24; 22:15; 23:13-14); others assume a young man of marriageable age warned against the "strange woman" (Prov. 5-7); Prov. 23:22 explicitly presupposes an adult son with an aging mother ("despise not thy mother when she is old"); Prov. 22:6, meanwhile, is spoken *about* a child *to* those who train him, not to the child at all. Scholarship divides on whether "my son" (בֶּן, *beni*) names a biological son (a royal-instruction reading fitting the Solomonic frame) or is a wisdom-teacher's stylized address

to any student in the sapiential tradition (Whybray, McKane, Fox). The two readings are not exclusive: the collection as it stands spans the whole arc of formation, from boyhood through young adulthood into lived-adult sonship.

What is consistent across the age range is that both registers carry through. The hearken-and-heed vocabulary dominates numerically (רָצוּם, *musar*, ~30x in Proverbs; תּוֹרָה, *torah*, ~13x; שָׁמַע, *shama*, “hear/heed,” pervasive); commandment-vocabulary functions alongside it (מִצְוָה, *mitzvah*, ~11x), sometimes paired with שָׁמַר (*shamar*, keep) in the Deuteronomic pattern (Prov. 4:4; 7:1-2; 19:16) and elsewhere metaphorized as *lamp* and *light* (6:23). Prov. 23:22 lies at the crux: an adult son with an aging mother is under the standing duty of “hearkening” to paternal instruction. View 1b will read the composite Wisdom data as parental instruction retaining ongoing command-force through adult life — modulated in 23:22 by the parents’ age, but not vacated (sense (1) of §1.1.1 continuous, with the “and live” outcome-clauses of 4:4 and 7:1-2 hearing covenantal weight). View 1a will hear the same instruction-vocabulary as the formative and counsel offices (senses (2)-(3) of §1.1.1) carried at full weight within the household it commends. Views 2a/2b will read the same data as the middle mode of §1.2.2 — טַמֵּן operating in the register of consultation, senses (2) and (3) of §1.1.1 doing the work of parental instruction while sense (1) has resolved, and the “commandment as lamp” of 6:23 recasting even the mitzvah-vocabulary as sapiential illumination rather than sanction. The wisdom literature is available to each reading; the age-elasticity of the “my son” address and the double lexical field mean the same texts do exegetical work in each frame.

1.6 The Church as Extended Family

The New Testament repeatedly names the church using kinship vocabulary — father, mother, brother, sister, son, daughter — applied in ways that overlap and reshape the biological family without displacing it. This texture is important for the present question because *the transition from paternal household is not into disconnection but into an enlarged kinship of faith*.

The texture is not a New Testament innovation. It is rooted in the character of God as declared by the Psalms and Prophets — the God who Himself places the solitary into households, who is Father of the fatherless, and who assigns to the eunuch and the unmarried a “place and a name better than of sons and of daughters.” On the reading set out here, the scriptural datum is that isolated life is not the biblical design; readers whose intuitions run the other way are invited to

weigh Ps. 68:6, Isa. 56:3-5, and the ecclesial kin-language of 1 Tim. 5:1-2 directly.

1.6.1 God's Own Placement of the Solitary

Psalm 68:5-6 — A father of the fatherless, and a judge of the widows, is God in his holy habitation. God setteth the solitary in families: he bringeth out those which are bound with chains: but the rebellious dwell in a dry land.

Observations. The Psalm predicates of God Himself the office that undergirds all Christian family-and-church practice. God is *already* father of the fatherless and judge of widows; He *already* places the solitary — the isolated, the alone, the one without a household — into families. The verse does not describe sentiment; it describes divine action. The Hebrew *yechidim* ("solitary ones") includes every case the current analysis must address: the orphan, the widow, the unmarried adult without paternal household, the disconnected believer.

Two consequences follow, one strong and one that must be argued rather than assumed. First, and directly from the Psalm: *isolation is not the divinely ordained state of the adult unmarried believer*. God places into families; a Christian anthropology that leaves the solitary solitary reads against the grain of the Psalm. This much Psalm 68 itself supplies.

Second, more tentatively: *the New Testament shows this divine placement running in significant measure through the church*. The Psalm itself names no human agent; it predicates the action of God alone. Whether and how the assembled people of God participate in that action is a further claim requiring further warrant. That warrant is developed below in §1.6.3 from Acts 6:1-6 (the apostles' establishment of a diaconal ministry to widows), from 1 Timothy 5:3-16 (Paul's structured order for enrolling widows without family), and from James 1:27 (the visible marker of authentic religion as the church's care for the fatherless and widow), together with the ecclesial kin-language of 1 Timothy 5:1-2 developed in §1.6.4. Absent those texts, Psalm 68 establishes only what it says: God is the agent, isolation is not the design, and the *yechidim* have a divinely-intended household somewhere. With those texts, the church emerges as a — not necessarily the only — instrument of that placement in the age between resurrection and consummation.

Psalm 27:10 — When my father and my mother forsake me, then the LORD will take me up.

Observations. The text addresses the case where the biological household fails. It does not counsel autonomous self-reliance; it promises

divine reception. In the New Testament economy that reception is instantiated in the household of faith (Ps. 68:6 → Matt. 12:49-50 → 1 Tim. 5:1-2).

1.6.2 The Consecrated Unmarried: The Better Portion

Isaiah 56:3-7 — Neither let the son of the stranger, that hath joined himself to the LORD, speak, saying, The LORD hath utterly separated me from his people: neither let the eunuch say, Behold, I am a dry tree. For thus saith the LORD unto the eunuchs that keep my sabbaths, and choose the things that please me, and take hold of my covenant; Even unto them will I give in mine house and within my walls a place and a name better than of sons and of daughters: I will give them an everlasting name, that shall not be cut off.

Observations. This is the Old Testament root of the New Testament esteem for consecrated singleness. The eunuch — the one who by covenant law was formally excluded from full Israelite worship (Deut. 23:1) — is promised, in the eschatological Israel, *a place and a name better than of sons and of daughters*. The category of persons Jesus commends in Matt. 19:12 (“eunuchs which have made themselves eunuchs for the kingdom of heaven’s sake”) is already prepared by Isaiah’s promise. Consecrated singleness has always had its own portion in the household of God — not a lesser one.

The Ethiopian eunuch of Acts 8:26-39 stands in this line: the first Gentile convert recorded in Acts, whose baptism instantiates Isaiah 56 in Christian practice.

A prophetic Old Testament instance of vocational singleness: Jeremiah. The one direct Old Testament case in which the prophetic call *itself* forbids marriage is Jeremiah’s:

Jeremiah 16:1-2 — The word of the LORD came also unto me, saying, Thou shalt not take thee a wife, neither shalt thou have sons or daughters in this place.

The prohibition is not asceticism nor a general commendation of singleness; it is a *sign-act* — the prophet’s unmarriedness becomes a walking image of the coming judgment on Judah, in which neither weddings nor funerals will run their normal course (Jer. 16:3-9). But the datum for the present question is that Scripture already, in the Old Testament, contains the pattern Christ commends in Matt. 19:11-12 and Paul develops at 1 Cor. 7:32-35: a life ordered so as to render *undivided attention* to the LORD’s assignment, in which the ordinary good of marriage is foregone for the sake of that assignment.

Jeremiah is not a eunuch by nature or by human hand; he is a prophet under specific divine constraint. The category “consecrated single for kingdom purposes” is thus not a New Testament innovation but a theological line already drawn in the Prophets, alongside Isaiah 56’s promise to eunuchs and preparing for Christ’s own unmarriedness and Paul’s own commendation of the same freedom.

1.6.3 The Church’s Concrete Family Practice

The New Testament shows the church acting in this office, not merely theorizing about it.

Acts 6:1-6 — And in those days ... there arose a murmuring of the Grecians against the Hebrews, because their widows were neglected in the daily ministration ... [The apostles’ response establishes an ordered ministry to widows through the deacons.]

The very first structural office the church creates after the apostolate is a *diaconal ministry to widows* — instantiating Ps. 68:5 in the assembly’s daily life.

1 Timothy 5:3, 5, 9-10, 16 — Honour widows that are widows indeed ... Now she that is a widow indeed, and desolate, trusteth in God, and continueth in supplications and prayers night and day ... Let not a widow be taken into the number under threescore years old, having been the wife of one man, well reported of for good works ... If any man or woman that believeth have widows, let them relieve them, and let not the church be charged; that it may relieve them that are widows indeed.

Observations. Paul distinguishes three cases: (a) widows with believing family — the family provides, (b) “widows indeed” — no family — the church enrolls them as a formal order, and (c) younger widows — encouraged to remarry. This is direct evidence of Ps. 68:6 in ecclesial practice: the church constitutes a family for those whom biological family cannot supply.

James 1:27 — Pure religion and undefiled before God and the Father is this, To visit the fatherless and widows in their affliction, and to keep himself unspotted from the world.

Observations. The visible marker of authentic religion — before God and the Father, no less — is the church’s concrete family-action toward those who lack a household.

Household conversion in Acts. Alongside its ministry to those without households, the apostolic church also witnessed the conversion of

whole households around a converting head — a pattern that shows how the new-covenant household of faith and the natural household relate at the moment of coming to Christ.

- **Acts 10:24, 44-48** — Cornelius, the centurion at Caesarea, “had called together his kinsmen and near friends” to hear Peter; the Holy Ghost fell on all his hearers, and Peter “commanded them to be baptized.”
- **Acts 16:14-15** — Lydia of Thyatira, seller of purple, “whose heart the Lord opened ... And when she was baptized, and her household” — the household following her as head.
- **Acts 16:30-34** — the Philippian jailer: “Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ, and thou shalt be saved, and thy house ... and was baptized, he and all his, straightway.”
- **Acts 18:8** — “And Crispus, the chief ruler of the synagogue, believed on the Lord with all his house.”

Observations. Three points bear on the present question. **First**, the direction of authority in these accounts runs *through* the converting head to the household, but the household’s belief and baptism are its own — the text does not portray forced or notional conversion, and in Cornelius’s case the Spirit falls before Peter finishes speaking (Acts 10:44). **Second**, the household as a unit is a real biblical category at the seam of conversion; the New Testament neither reduces conversion to purely individual choice nor eliminates the household frame. **Third**, and critical for the present study: *none of these accounts speaks directly to the case of unmarried adult children of already-Christian parents.* The household conversions of Acts are conversions of the *unbelieving* household when the head believes. The doctrine of parents and adult children *within* a Christian household — the paper’s actual question — is not settled by these texts, though a household frame of some kind clearly persists in apostolic practice. Views 1 and 2 read the continuing household frame differently; both cite the Acts pattern with warrant. What Acts *does* rule out is the reduction of conversion to bare individualism with no household bearing at all.

1.6.4 Kinship Vocabulary in the New Testament

1 Corinthians 4:15 — For though ye have ten thousand instructors in Christ, yet have ye not many fathers: for in Christ Jesus I have begotten you through the gospel.

Paul distinguishes instructors from fathers and claims spiritual paternity of the Corinthian believers — a paternity earned by begetting-through-the-gospel. This is the New Testament root of the Christian tradition’s language of “spiritual father” (the presbyter, the bishop, the elder, the abbot, the spiritual director).

Matthew 23:9 — And call no man your father upon the earth: for one is your Father, which is in heaven.

The counterweight text — and its careful reading. Matthew 23:9 is regularly deployed by two constituencies who otherwise share little: covering-doctrine critics use it against the ecclesial paternity of umbrella teaching, and against Catholic and Orthodox use of “Father” for clergy; autonomy-side readers deploy it against paternal authority as such. The steel-manning discipline of this paper owes the text a hearing, especially because Appendix B.1’s debate turns on exactly this question. Two lines of evidence show that the text is a hyperbolic *relativization* of every earthly paternal title under the one Father in heaven, not an abolition of fatherhood as a creational category or a New Testament vocation:

- Paul writes 1 Corinthians 4:15 — “for in Christ Jesus I have begotten you through the gospel” — claiming exactly the spiritual-paternity relation Matthew 23:9 would prohibit if read as abolition. The apostolic use of the paternal register (1 Thess. 2:11; 1 Tim. 5:1; the vocative “fathers” in Acts 22:1; 1 John 2:13-14) demonstrates that the earliest church did not read Matthew 23:9 as abolishing the paternal category.
- Christ himself uses “father” for Abraham (Luke 16:24, “father Abraham”), preserves the fifth commandment’s paternal category in full (Mark 7:9-13), and speaks of “father or mother” of the disciples’ own earthly parents (Matt. 15:4-6). The immediate literary context of Matthew 23:9 is the woes against the Pharisees — polemic against the acquisition of religious title for status and honor (23:5-7, “the uppermost rooms at feasts... and to be called of men, Rabbi, Rabbi”) — not against fatherhood as such. Matthew 23:8 forbids “Rabbi” and 23:10 forbids “masters” by the same construction; a flat reading would prohibit teaching offices and pedagogical authority as categories, which no Christian tradition (including those that most strictly guard Matthew 23:9) has ever held.

On a contextual reading, Matthew 23:9 forbids the elevation of any earthly paternal figure — biological *or* ecclesial — to a status that competes with the Father in heaven. It does not forbid the paternal office, biological or ecclesial. On this reading the text cuts equally against covering-doctrine elevation of the earthly paternal office to spiritual-covering status *and* against monastic or clerical usage that would compete with the Father’s own claim. What it protects is the standing of the one Father in heaven whose paternal address every believer is invited to make on the incarnate Son’s own lips (Gal. 4:6, Rom. 8:15 — see §1.2.1 Consideration 4 on the theological completion of Paul’s adoption argument).

1 Thessalonians 2:11-12 — As ye know how we exhorted and comforted and charged every one of you, as a father doth his children, that ye would walk worthy of God, who hath called you unto his kingdom and glory.

Apostolic ministry is fatherly ministry. The pastoral office partakes of the paternal office.

2 Timothy 1:2, 5 — To Timothy, my dearly beloved son ... When I call to remembrance the unfeigned faith that is in thee, which dwelt first in thy grandmother Lois, and thy mother Eunice; and I am persuaded that in thee also.

Paul addresses Timothy as *son*; the same passage acknowledges the mother-and-grandmother line of faith transmission through Eunice and Lois. Spiritual paternity in Paul does not compete with the biological maternal line; both flow together. Faith passes through the biological household *and* through the apostolic household — Timothy is a son of both.

1 Timothy 5:1-2 — Rebuke not an elder, but intreat him as a father; and the younger men as brethren; The elder women as mothers; the younger as sisters, with all purity.

The church is to be reckoned as an extended kin network — elders as fathers, elder women as mothers, contemporaries as siblings. The practice is not metaphor only; it is instruction on how to *treat* one another within the church.

Mark 3:34-35 (cf. Matt. 12:49-50) — And he looked round about on them which sat about him, and said, Behold my mother and my brethren! For whosoever shall do the will of God, the same is my brother, and my sister, and mother.

Christ Himself establishes the pattern (treated in Ch. 2 §2.3). The kinship of faith is not a second-tier metaphor; it is the *primary* family with which the biological family is reharmonized.

Observations. Every Christian tradition surveyed in Chapter 4 depends on this texture — the Catholic priest as “Father,” the Orthodox γέρων (*gerōn*, elder) and the spiritual family of the monastic community, the Anabaptist covenanted congregation as the sphere of adult accountability, the Protestant “brother” and “sister” as address in worship, the NCFIC recognition that church oversight of marriage supplements and does not replace family. The New Testament does not teach that the paternal household evaporates at conversion; it teaches that a *larger* kinship structure — the church — receives the adult believer and shapes his or her adult life. The unmarried adult son or daughter belongs to *two* families: the household of birth and

the household of faith. Neither may be forsaken; each serves the other under Christ.

Two additional briefer notes belong here.

Numbers 27:1-4, 6-7 — Then came the daughters of Zelophehad ... And they stood before Moses, and before Eleazar the priest, and before the princes and all the congregation, by the door of the tabernacle of the congregation, saying, Our father died in the wilderness ... and had no sons. Why should the name of our father be done away from among his family, because he hath no son? Give unto us therefore a possession among the brethren of our father ... And the LORD spake unto Moses, saying, The daughters of Zelophehad speak right.

The daughters of Zelophehad are unmarried adult women who exercise legal agency before Moses and receive inheritance rights. Their case becomes precedent (Num. 36; Josh. 17). The passage confirms that Scripture permits unmarried adult daughters public legal standing under theocratic order — a text less often surfaced but relevant to any settled doctrine of continuing paternal authority over adult daughters.

Matthew 18:15-17; Acts 15:6-29 — [Community discernment texts.]

Anabaptist tradition rightly emphasizes these texts as evidence that weighty decisions — including matters that would touch the household — belong to the gathered church in her deliberative office, not to isolated individuals nor to families operating without the church. Where an adult unmarried son or daughter must discern a major life question, the church's discernment (Acts 15's "it seemed good to the Holy Ghost, and to us") is a legitimate — and, for the Anabaptist tradition, primary — sphere for it.

1.6.5 Worked Example: Timothy

Timothy is the most fully documented New Testament case of a young adult unmarried man transferred out of his household of origin into apostolic service. His biography, gathered from Acts and the epistles, tests every claim of the present chapter.

The household of origin.

Acts 16:1-3 — Then came he to Derbe and Lystra: and, behold, a certain disciple was there, named Timotheus, the son of a certain woman, which was a Jewess, and believed; but his father was a Greek: Which was well reported of by

the brethren that were at Lystra and Iconium. Him would Paul have to go forth with him; and took and circumcised him because of the Jews which were in those quarters: for they knew all that his father was a Greek.

Timothy is the son of a believing Jewish mother (Eunice — 2 Tim. 1:5) and a Greek father whose faith is not attested. His maternal grandmother Lois is also a believer. This is a mixed household in the fullest sense: religious asymmetry between the parents, a faithful mother-and-grandmother line, and a Gentile father whose place in the story is conspicuously vacant.

The absent father. Acts 16:1's phrasing — "his father was (ἦν, *ēn*) a Greek" — is grammatically past-tense but does not by itself settle whether the father was still living at the time of Paul's arrival. Commentators divide on the reading. Some take the imperfect as implying the father had already died before the events of Acts 16, which would explain his total absence from the subsequent narrative and Timothy's evidently uncomplicated freedom to depart with Paul. Others take him to be alive but uninvolved with the Lystran assembly, whether because he was non-believing, estranged, or simply detached from the church's life. The text does not decide between these readings. Timothy's uncircumcised state (v.3), explained by reference to the father's ethnicity, is compatible with either — a father who died in Timothy's infancy could as readily have failed to arrange circumcision as a living but Torah-indifferent father.

What this ambiguity does and does not affect. If Timothy's father was already dead, then his departure with Paul is not primarily a case of vocational transfer *over* an active paternal head; it is a case of a fatherless young adult received by apostolic paternity — a form of the church-as-placement pattern of §1.6.1-3 rather than of the vocational-departure pattern of §1.4.6. If the father was living but uninvolved or non-consenting, Timothy supplies the stronger case: a young adult transferring out of the paternal household under the higher household of Christ, with Eunice's blessing and no paternal objection recorded. Either way, Timothy remains the New Testament's most fully documented paradigm of apostolic-paternity reception. Readers should note, however, that the case is somewhat weaker as a specifically vocational-departure- over-paternal-authority example than a confident retelling might suggest.

The transfer. Paul takes Timothy with him from Lystra on the second missionary journey. Timothy is called by the epistles to Ephesus, Corinth, Thessalonica, Berea, Rome — a genuinely itinerant adult life. He is not living under Eunice's roof; he is traveling with Paul.

Philippians 2:22 — But ye know the proof of him, that, as

a son with the father, he hath served with me in the gospel.

1 Corinthians 4:17 — For this cause have I sent unto you Timotheus, who is my beloved son, and faithful in the Lord.

1 Timothy 1:2, 18 — Unto Timothy, my own son in the faith ... This charge I commit unto thee, son Timothy, according to the prophecies which went before on thee.

Paul names Timothy his son repeatedly, without embarrassment and without softening — τέκνον γνήσιον (*teknon gnēsion*), “genuine child” in 1 Tim. 1:2. The apostolic bond is fatherly in more than metaphor.

The maternal line preserved.

2 Timothy 1:2, 5 — To Timothy, my dearly beloved son ... When I call to remembrance the unfeigned faith that is in thee, which dwelt first in thy grandmother Lois, and thy mother Eunice; and I am persuaded that in thee also.

2 Timothy 3:14-15 — But continue thou in the things which thou hast learned and hast been assured of, knowing of whom thou hast learned them; And that from a child thou hast known the holy scriptures.

Paul, addressing his own son in the faith, explicitly names *the household of origin’s faith transmission* as Timothy’s foundation. The apostolic paternity does not displace the maternal-and- grandmaternal line; it stands on it. Timothy learned the scriptures from Eunice and Lois; that learning is his qualification for apostolic service. The two households are ordered, not competitive.

Observations bearing on the present question.

- **Timothy is genuinely independent** from his household of origin during the years of active apostolic service. He is not living under Eunice’s roof. He travels. He carries apostolic responsibilities.
- **Yet he is not autonomous.** He is under Paul’s spiritual paternity (“as a son with the father, he hath served with me”), sent on errands, kept on task, later ordained and charged with the church at Ephesus.
- **The mother-and-grandmother line is not repudiated.** It is publicly honored as the *root* of Timothy’s usefulness. Paul does not have to displace Eunice to father Timothy.
- **The mixed household case is handled with realism.** Nothing in the text suggests Timothy’s Gentile father needed to convert before Timothy could serve, though Timothy’s uncircumcised state at Lystra is treated as needing repair for missional reasons (Acts 16:3). The unbelieving parent does not veto the calling.

- **This is not autonomous departure.** From the outside, Timothy looks independent. From inside the New Testament frame, he is a *transferred son* under Paul, with continuing bonds to Eunice and Lois.

Timothy stands as the paradigm case of vocational household transfer (Ch. 1 §1.4.6) plus spiritual paternity (§1.6.4 above) in one life, with the mother-and-grandmother line preserved as inheritance rather than opposed as competitor. He is not Jesus (who is unique); he is an ordinary young adult unmarried Christian man to whom the analysis directly applies.

1.7 The Difficult Texts

Two Old Testament passages deserve honest attention.

Deuteronomy 21:18-21 — If a man have a stubborn and rebellious son, which will not obey the voice of his father, or the voice of his mother ... they shall say unto the elders of his city, This our son is stubborn and rebellious ... And all the men of his city shall stone him with stones, that he die: so shalt thou put evil away from among you.

This governs a son characterized by settled rebellion, gluttony, and drunkenness. It presupposes a legal community and civil sanctions. The detailed rabbinic reception — the narrowing of the statute in *m. Sanhedrin* 8:1 and *b. Sanhedrin* 68b-72a to a brief window of early adolescence, and R. Shimon's judgment at *b. Sanhedrin* 71a that "it never was and never will be" — is discussed at §1.2.1 as part of the Pharisaic bounding of paternal command-authority and not repeated here. The New Testament nowhere applies the statute. Its bearing on the current question is indirect: it shows that persistent rebellion in a covenant community is a grave matter, and — as read by Paul's own tradition — that even the Torah's strongest paternal-authority text was already bounded to a pre-adult window. Whether that reception is probative for the bounded reading or itself suspect — "never was and never will be" is, after all, a tradition declaring a Torah statute inoperative — is the exchange recorded at §1.2.1 (the fourth 1b reply) and §1.4.1.

Deuteronomy 22:13-21 — If any man take a wife, and go in unto her, and hate her ... and say, I took this woman, and when I came to her, I found her not a maid: Then shall the father of the damsel, and her mother, take and bring forth the tokens of the damsel's virginity unto the elders of the city in the gate ... And the elders of that city shall take that man and chastise him; And they shall amerce him in

an hundred shekels of silver, and give them unto the father of the damsel, because he hath brought up an evil name upon a virgin of Israel ... But if this thing be true, and the tokens of virginity be not found for the damsel: Then they shall bring out the damsel to the door of her father's house, and the men of her city shall stone her with stones that she die ... so shalt thou put evil away from among you.

The passage addresses a bride accused of non-virginity; the tokens of her virginity are produced by her father and mother, and both vindication and penalty run through the father's house — the fine for slander is paid “unto the father of the damsel” (v. 19), and the execution, if the accusation holds, is at “the door of her father's house” (v. 21). It presupposes that the unmarried daughter's sexual purity is a family and covenant matter — not merely a private one.

Both texts are governed by Israel's covenant law and its civil penalties; neither is directly applied in the New Testament. They do establish the seriousness of the household in Old Testament ethics.

1.8 What Scripture Requires, Permits, and Forbids

Bringing the texts together:

Scripture requires:

- Honor of father and mother, at every stage of life (Exod. 20:12; Eph. 6:2-3).
- Provision of parents for minor children (2 Cor. 12:14; Eph. 6:4).
- Provision of adult children for aging parents (1 Tim. 5:4, 8).
- That parents not provoke their children (Eph. 6:4; Col. 3:21).
- That children obey while under parental household (Eph. 6:1; Col. 3:20) — with New Testament silence on the exact upper age.
- That the church function as extended family, with elders as fathers, elder women as mothers, and adult believers as brethren and sisters (1 Tim. 5:1-2).
- That the church concretely instantiate God's own action of setting the solitary in families — through diaconal care of widows and the fatherless, and through household-of-faith reception of the adult believer whom biological family cannot supply (Ps. 68:5-6; Ps. 27:10; Acts 6:1-6; 1 Tim. 5:3-16; James 1:27).

Scripture permits:

- Marriage as the paradigmatic leaving (Gen. 2:24).
- The unmarried state as a positive calling (1 Cor. 7:7-8, 32-34).

- Unmarried adult daughters remaining in the paternal household and exercising ministry (Acts 21:8-9).
- Unmarried adult daughters exercising public legal standing in matters of inheritance and family (Num. 27:1-11; Num. 36; Josh. 17).
- The consecrated (celibate, eunuch, virgin) receiving “a place and a name better than of sons and of daughters” within the household of the LORD (Isa. 56:3-7; cf. Matt. 19:12; Acts 8:26-39).
- Parents (especially fathers) initiating, mediating, or blessing the marriage covenant of adult children, *with the consent of the parties* (Gen. 24, including Rebekah’s “I will go” in 24:57-58; 28:1-2; Ex. 22:16-17; Deut. 22:16; Ruth 3-4; 1 Cor. 7:36-38; cf. Num. 30).
- Adult unmarried children leaving the parental household to serve under another authority — a prophet, teacher, king, or Christ (1 Kings 19:19-21; 1 Sam. 1; Matt. 4:18-22; Luke 9:59-62).
- Set-apart or Nazirite callings that override ordinary household expectations (Num. 6; 1 Sam. 1:11; Luke 1:15).
- Departure of unmarried sons (from age twenty) into national and military service under a different authority than the father, while the paternal relation itself continues (Num. 1:3; Deut. 20:5-8; Deut. 24:5; 1 Sam. 17).
- Adult leaving of father and mother for the sake of Christ’s name, received into an enlarged household of faith (Matt. 19:29; Mark 10:29-30; Luke 18:29-30).
- Spiritual paternity as a legitimate and honored office of the church, complementing biological paternity (1 Cor. 4:15; 1 Thess. 2:11; 2 Tim. 1:2).
- Community discernment of major life questions by the gathered church, alongside or on behalf of families (Matt. 18:15-17; Acts 15).

Scripture forbids:

- Nullifying the honor of father and mother by tradition or by pretext of religious devotion (Mark 7:9-13).
- Rebellion against parents (Rom. 1:30; 2 Tim. 3:2).
- Failure to provide for one’s own household (1 Tim. 5:8).
- Provoking children to wrath (Eph. 6:4; Col. 3:21).

Scripture leaves open:

- The specific age at which obedience matures into honor.
- The specific mechanism by which an adult unmarried child transitions from paternal household to independent household apart from marriage.
- Whether unmarried adult daughters are under a *legal* contin-

uing authority (Num. 30 as a settled category) or a *particular* provision (vows in youth).

- Whether unmarried adult sons and daughters must be treated symmetrically or asymmetrically in these transitions.
- The precise degree to which the marriage-arrangement office of parents is binding versus commended. Genesis 24 pictures it at its fullest; Judges 14 shows a son's override; 1 Corinthians 7:36-38 restrains its exercise. Scripture presents a strong pattern with real elasticity.

1.9 Three Genuine Ambiguities

Chapter 1 has surveyed a body of texts — the honor commandment, the obey/honor lexical distinction, the Christological ceiling on obedience, the substantive content of honor, marriage as the paradigmatic leaving-seam, the church's role in placing the solitary. On some of these Scripture speaks with a clarity that every faithful Chapter 4 view accepts; on others (notably the obey/honor distinction and the scope of paradigmatic-leaving), the views read the same texts differently. Chapter 1 does not itself adjudicate the contested readings. Three points in particular remain where Scripture itself does not close the question, and where faithful readers can and do divide. Naming them here is not equivocation; it is preventing the paper from smuggling a verdict the text has not delivered.

The scope of Numbers 30. Numbers 30 grants a father the power to annul his unmarried daughter's vow while she is "in her youth in her father's house" (Num. 30:3, 16). Does the phrase describe a *permanent legal condition* — any unmarried daughter of any age is "in her father's house" regardless of biological maturity — or a *bounded life-stage* that ends at the maturity threshold (as the rabbinic tradition read it, ending at *bogeret* about age 12½; §1.2.1)? The Hebrew supplies grammatical warrant for either reading. View 1b leans toward the permanent-condition reading; Views 2a and 2b lean toward the life-stage reading; View 1a's counsel does not hang on the choice, since it commends the pattern without requiring the vow-veto as doctrine. Both readings must account for v. 9 of the same chapter (see §1.4.1): the Torah itself recognizes the widow and the divorced woman as adult unmarried women under *no* male vow-veto, so "unmarried" and "under paternal authority" are not coextensive in the very chapter the debate leans on. Whether the widow/divorcee category is an exception that proves the ordinary rule, or a datum showing that vow-authority attaches to specific relational status rather than to unmarried status as such, is itself contested. Numbers 30 is therefore the load-bearing text for either continuous paternal authority over adult unmarried daughters or its termination

— and neither reading can bypass v. 9.

The identity of “the virgin” in 1 Corinthians 7:36-38. Three ancient readings survive. On the older interpretation, preserved in the KJV and the Reformation commentators, Paul addresses a *father* deliberating whether to give his adult daughter in marriage — yielding continuing paternal authority over adult daughters’ marriage decisions. On the majority modern interpretation, Paul addresses a *betrothed couple* deliberating whether to consummate — yielding no paternal authority at all. A third reading, well-attested in the pre-Nicene and early patristic period, holds that Paul addresses a man and woman in a spiritual-marriage arrangement (the practice later called *virgines subintroductae* or *syneisaktism*, a committed co-residence for the sake of ascetic devotion without consummation) — deliberating whether to convert the arrangement into ordinary marriage. Cyprian’s *Epistle 4* to Bishop Pomponius (so numbered in the modern critical editions; *Epistle 61* in the ANF ordering the paper’s translations follow) takes the practice to have been widespread enough to require episcopal correction and counsels, in Paul’s own better-to-marry register (1 Cor. 7:9), that those unwilling or unable to persevere should marry; Chrysostom later treats the practice at length in his two treatises against it. The third reading yields yet a different polity — the church, not the father and not the couple alone, mediates the movement between ascetic and marital states — and is what many modern commentators find least attractive but what the pre-Nicene church was in fact reading. The Greek is famously compressed and does not itself decide among the three. Together with Numbers 30, this is the second text on which the strongest form of View 1b’s daughters-remain-under-authority claim rests; if either text is read either of the other ways, that claim loses substantial ground, and the third reading in particular relocates the discernment from household to church rather than to the couple.

The status of the adult child still resident in the parental household. Two of the chapter’s own findings press against each other on this case, as §1.2.2 already flagged. The Haustafel argument (Eph. 5:22-6:9 addresses whoever is *currently* in the household when the letter is read aloud) suggests that residence itself brings the ordinary code back into force. The lexical argument (ὁπακούω’s New Testament authority-relation uses presuppose a currently active authority relation — §1.2.1 Consideration 1, with the qualifications recorded there) suggests that adult status terminates obedience-mode regardless of residence. The one extended New Testament picture of the case is the elder brother of Luke 15 — an adult son in his father’s house, in an explicit obedience register (“Lo, these many years do I serve thee, neither transgressed I at any time thy commandment,” Luke 15:29), addressed by the father as τέκνον (v. 31). The datum

cuts in more than one direction: his years of resident service are presented as real, and neither the father nor the parable rebukes the arrangement itself; yet his heart is the parable's target, and his own accounting of the relation in service-and-wages terms is what the father's τέκνον answer gently corrects. Readers who find resident adult service commended here and readers who find here a warning about what such service can curdle into are both citing the text. An adult child living at home for economic, cultural, or caregiving reasons occupies genuinely mixed territory that Scripture does not adjudicate directly. This is the practical pressure point on which Views 1a, 1b, 2a, and 2b divide most sharply.

Any view that resolves all three ambiguities in the same direction should be held with appropriate humility. The Views developed in Chapter 4 differ, in part, because faithful readers resolve these three questions differently — not because some readers are careless with Scripture.

Chapter 2 — Christocentrism

Overview (Christocentrism)

What did Jesus teach and demonstrate about the parent-child relation? The evidence falls into four groups: Jesus's own conduct as a son; His teaching that discipleship supersedes family loyalty; His defense of the honor commandment against religious traditions that evaded it; and His care for His mother from the cross.

2.1 Jesus at Twelve — Subject to Parents, Yet Not Only to Them

Luke 2:49-52 — And he said unto them, How is it that ye sought me? wist ye not that I must be about my Father's business? And they understood not the saying which he spake unto them. And he went down with them, and came to Nazareth, and was subject unto them: but his mother kept all these sayings in her heart. And Jesus increased in wisdom and stature, and in favour with God and man.

Observations. At twelve — the age of bar-mitzvah threshold in later Judaism — Jesus asserts a higher allegiance ("my Father's business") without denying His parents' authority ("was subject unto them"). The sequence matters: the higher allegiance is not deployed to break the lower one; it is affirmed *and* the ordinary subjection is preserved. For a boy still at home, both hold.

The passage carries a further weight not always noticed. When Jesus speaks of "*my Father's business*" (τοῖς τοῦ πατρὸς μου, *tois tou patros mou*), he is not speaking of Joseph. He is asserting, in Joseph's very hearing, that his ultimate belonging is to *another* Father's household. Joseph is not slighted; Joseph is not repudiated; Jesus goes down with them, and is subject. But at twelve, the boy is already testifying that the paternal household of formation and the paternal household of ultimate belonging are not the same. This double-household frame — a boy's earthly household of formation and a Son's heavenly household of belonging — will govern everything Jesus says about family for the rest of the Gospel record.

2.2 Jesus's Departure for Ministry

Jesus is called "the carpenter" (Mark 6:3) and "the carpenter's son" (Matt. 13:55). His formation for eighteen years between Luke 2:52 and Luke 3:23 is the formation of Joseph's household — carpentry, Torah, synagogue, obedience to father and mother. Joseph is not

mentioned during the public ministry and is presumed to have died before it began. Jesus, as eldest son, inherited responsibility for Mary and his siblings until his departure for public ministry.

By approximately age thirty (Luke 3:23), Jesus has left Nazareth to itinerate publicly. The Gospels report no ceremony, no announcement, no explicit release by Mary. He simply goes. He does not return to live at home. His mother sometimes travels to meet him; he does not return to be a son under her roof.

Observations. Whatever the biblical pattern is for a son's leaving, Jesus's own conduct exemplifies leaving before marriage for the sake of the Father's business. This does not itself construct a doctrine of pre-marital independence — Jesus is unique — but it demonstrates that leaving before marriage for kingdom cause is not sinful, not rebellious, and not dishonoring. And it shows one further thing: the Son who left the carpenter's household did not leave it into autonomy. He left it *into another Father's household* — the same Father he had confessed at twelve. Every subsequent word Jesus speaks about houses, families, and leaving is spoken *from within* that other household.

2.2.1 But the Independence Was Real

It would be dishonest to smooth over the shape of those three years. By every ordinary daily-life metric, Jesus during his public ministry looked *independent*.

Matthew 8:20 / Luke 9:58 — And Jesus saith unto him,
The foxes have holes, and the birds of the air have nests;
but the Son of man hath not where to lay his head.

He had no fixed home. No wife. No settled income (he was supported by the women of Luke 8:1-3). His mother sometimes had to travel to find him. He did not return to be a son under Mary's roof.

Mark 3:20-21 — And the multitude cometh together again,
so that they could not so much as eat bread. And when his
friends heard of it, they went out to lay hold on him: for
they said, He is beside himself.

His own family — οἱ παρ' αὐτοῦ (*hoi par' autou*), "his own" — thought he had lost his mind and set out to physically bring him home. This is the reality in which Mark 3:31-35 ("Who is my mother?") should be read. The redefinition of family in that passage is not a serene theological observation. It is spoken in the very moment his family is trying to retrieve him from what they took to be a breakdown.

John 7:5 — For neither did his brethren believe in him.

Through the ministry years, Jesus's own brothers did not believe him. Only after the resurrection do we find them among the disciples (Acts 1:14; James emerges as leader of the Jerusalem church; Jude writes an epistle). The hinge of that turn is a particular resurrection appearance: "after that, he was seen of James" (1 Cor. 15:7). Paul preserves the record of a risen appearance to Jesus's own brother — the middle term between the unbelief of John 7:5 and the leadership of Acts 15 — and locates the reconciliation of the natural household with the household of faith in the risen Christ's specific initiative toward his own brother.

Observations. The daily-life independence was real. Jesus's family relationship during ministry was strained — misunderstood by his brothers, worried over by his mother, retrieved-for at one point as a mad relative. The subsequent theological confession (that he was leaving *into* the Father's household) is retrospective and Christocentric; it is not what a Galilean neighbor watching the carpenter's son wander off would have said in real time.

Three things must therefore be held together:

- **Yes** — by daily metrics, Jesus's ministry years show a son living genuinely apart from his father's household, with real family strain that was not resolved until after the resurrection.
- **Yes** — theologically and finally, he was under the Father, in a household of disciples and supporting women (Luke 8:1-3), and the strain was healed at the cross (John 19:26-27) and the upper room (Acts 1:14).
- **Also yes** — the transition itself was not a clean break. At the wedding at Cana (John 2:1-11) — the only Gospel scene of the adult Jesus responding to a maternal request before the cross — he honors his mother without command-obedience, timing governed by the Father ("mine hour is not yet come"). Immediately after, "he went down to Capernaum, he, and his mother, and his brethren, and his disciples: and they continued there not many days" (John 2:12). The natural household still travels with him at the very beginning of the ministry. Departure into the Father's household proved compatible, in Jesus's own life, with the natural household still moving alongside him during the transition.

For the present question, this yields a cautious observation. When a young adult leaves the paternal household for a genuine calling, the appearance of independence — and even real family strain — may not by itself be evidence of rebellion or of individualist drift. The Father's-house pattern (§2.7 below) can look, from the outside, much like autonomous departure. Discernment is required.

The distinguishing marks are visible over time, not in the moment:
- Continued honor of parents even when apart (John 19:26-27). -
Concrete provision when the seam is reached (John 19:27b, “and
from that hour that disciple took her unto his own home”). - No
repudiation of the biological family. Reconciliation and incorporation
follow (Acts 1:14). - The departure is *into* discernible discipleship,
not merely away from home.

Where these marks are present, apparent independence can be faithful even when it looks — to observers, and sometimes to the parents themselves — indistinguishable from ordinary leaving.

2.3 “Who Is My Mother?” — The Reordering of Kinship

Mark 3:31-35 — There came then his brethren and his mother, and, standing without, sent unto him, calling him. And the multitude sat about him, and they said unto him, Behold, thy mother and thy brethren without seek for thee. And he answered them, saying, Who is my mother, or my brethren? And he looked round about on them which sat about him, and said, Behold my mother and my brethren! For whosoever shall do the will of God, the same is my brother, and my sister, and mother.

Observations. Jesus does not deny His mother; He redefines the primary family. The doer of the will of God is *more truly* His brother, sister, mother than the biological relation. This is a seismic reordering: the household of faith is prior to the household of blood. Every subsequent Christocentric text must be read with this reordering in mind.

Luke 11:27-28 — And it came to pass, as he spake these things, a certain woman of the company lifted up her voice, and said unto him, Blessed is the womb that bare thee, and the paps which thou hast sucked. But he said, Yea rather, blessed are they that hear the word of God, and keep it.

A second, independent attestation of the same reordering. Luke supplies a distinct pericope with the same shape as Mark 3:31-35: the biological relation is not denied — the woman’s blessing of Mary’s womb is not contradicted — but the obedience-relation is ranked above it. The doer of the word is *more blessed* than the womb that bore Christ. That the same move appears in two independent settings, once framed by biological family members outside and once by a stranger in the crowd, doubles the attestation and confirms that the reordering is not a one-time saying but a settled feature of Christ’s

teaching on kinship.

2.4 The Hard Sayings

Matthew 10:37 — He that loveth father or mother more than me is not worthy of me; and he that loveth son or daughter more than me is not worthy of me.

Luke 14:26 — If any man come to me, and hate not his father, and mother, and wife, and children, and brethren, and sisters, yea, and his own life also, he cannot be my disciple.

Observations. Semitic idiom uses “hate” in the sense of decisively prefer-less. The point is comparative and total: no earthly loyalty may compete with Christ. This is a boundary condition on every family arrangement. A household ordered so that filial devotion (or paternal control) rivals devotion to Christ has failed the Christocentric test.

Matthew 19:29 — And every one that hath forsaken houses, or brethren, or sisters, or father, or mother, or wife, or children, or lands, for my name’s sake, shall receive an hundredfold, and shall inherit everlasting life.

Mark 10:29-30 — Verily I say unto you, There is no man that hath left house, or brethren, or sisters, or father, or mother, or wife, or children, or lands, for my sake, and the gospel’s, But he shall receive an hundredfold now in this time, houses, and brethren, and sisters, and mothers, and children, and lands, with persecutions; and in the world to come eternal life.

Luke 18:29-30 — Verily I say unto you, There is no man that hath left house, or parents, or brethren, or wife, or children, for the kingdom of God’s sake, Who shall not receive manifold more in this present time, and in the world to come life everlasting.

Observations. Christ’s teaching is explicit: leaving father and mother for the sake of His name is licit, is honored, and is promised recompense. The recompense in Mark’s version is emphatically communal — “houses, and brethren, and sisters, and mothers, and children” — restored *in this present time* within the household of faith. This is the textual foundation on which the pre-Nicene consecrated life (Ch. 3), Catholic and Orthodox monasticism, the Anabaptist voluntary-service tradition (Ch. 4 §4.4.1), and every form of vocational household transfer (Ch. 4 §4.6) rest. The promise does not annul the honor commandment; it establishes that adult leaving for Christ’s sake is

not merely permitted but blessed, and that the church becomes the extended family in the receiving.

The accusation Jesus bore. One further datum belongs with the hard sayings. When Jesus's opponents wished to discredit him, the vocabulary they reached for was the rebellious-son statute's own charge-list: "a man gluttonous, and a winebibber" (Matt. 11:19; Luke 7:34; cf. "a glutton, and a drunkard," אֲבִסֵן לֵלֶז, *zolel ve-sove*, Deut. 21:20). The Son whose sayings relativize every household bond was himself smeared as the covenant household's worst case — the son who deserves stoning — and the curse-text that immediately follows the statute, on the man hanged on a tree (Deut. 21:22-23), is the text Paul applies to his crucifixion (Gal. 3:13). The full typology — the prophets' application of "stubborn and rebellious" to national Israel, and the statute's trajectory from the city gate to the cross — is set out at §3.1.2 (point 6). Its bearing here is narrow but real: the hard sayings were spoken by one who was paying, in reputation and then in death, the rebellious son's price — while being, on the data of this chapter (§2.1, §2.6), the one son who perfectly honored both his earthly household and his Father.

2.5 The Defense of the Honor Commandment

Mark 7:9-13 — And he said unto them, Full well ye reject the commandment of God, that ye may keep your own tradition. For Moses said, Honour thy father and thy mother; and, Whoso curseth father or mother, let him die the death: But ye say, If a man shall say to his father or mother, It is Corban, that is to say, a gift, by whatsoever thou mightest be profited by me; he shall be free. And ye suffer him no more to do ought for his father or his mother; Making the word of God of none effect through your tradition which ye have delivered.

Observations. Jesus explicitly forbids any religious device that uses appeal to God to evade material care of parents. This is directly relevant. An adult child cannot deploy "the Lord's call" to abandon responsibility for aging parents. The vertical devotion (Matt. 10:37) does not annul the horizontal duty; it re-motivates it. (See also §1.2.2 on honor's content of material provision.)

Second-Temple background — *Sirach 3:1-16*. The most extended ancient Jewish exposition of the fifth commandment applied to adult children is Sirach 3, the likely background of Jesus's own critique of the *korban* device. Ben Sira presses honor into concrete adult obligation and — uniquely in surviving Second-Temple literature — extends it explicitly into the parent's decline:

Sirach 3:12-16 (KJV Apocrypha) — My son, help thy father in his age, and grieve him not as long as he liveth. And if his understanding fail, have patience with him; and despise him not when thou art in thy full strength ... He that forsaketh his father is as a blasphemer; and he that angereth his mother is cursed of God.

The passage supplies three points relevant to the paper. First, it establishes that the fifth commandment was understood in Ben Sira's generation as governing *adult* care of the *aged* parent — the picture in view is not the minor obeying but the strong son helping the failing father. Second, it names the parent's cognitive decline as the specific pastoral case where the son's honor is most tested — “if his understanding fail, have patience with him” — a qualification the Torah does not draw but which is deeply congenial to Jesus's own Mark 7 sharpening of the commandment. Third, the *korban* dispute in Mark 7 becomes intelligible against Sirach's background: Jesus is defending not a novel expansion but the standing Second-Temple reading of the commandment against a legal device that had grown up around it. Sirach is a deuterocanonical book — accepted as Scripture by Roman Catholic and Eastern Orthodox communions, held as good and useful reading but not canonical Scripture by most Protestants (Article 6 of the Thirty-Nine Articles, Westminster Confession 1.3, and the traditional Reformation position). This paper cites it as Second-Temple background for the honor commandment, and reserves *Scripture-leg* appeal to the Old and New Testament canon.

2.6 Care for Mary from the Cross

John 19:26-27 — When Jesus therefore saw his mother, and the disciple standing by, whom he loved, he saith unto his mother, Woman, behold thy son! Then saith he to the disciple, Behold thy mother! And from that hour that disciple took her unto his own home.

Observations. Jesus's last act toward his family is provisional care for his mother. He arranges her ongoing care through the household of faith (the beloved disciple), not through the ἀδελφοί (*adelphoi*, “brothers”) named in Matt. 13:55 and John 7:5³ (who at that point were not yet believers, John 7:5). This is Christocentric practice

³Whether these ἀδελφοί are Mary's biological sons by Joseph (the Helvidian reading held by most Protestants), Joseph's sons by a prior marriage (the Epiphonian reading held by Eastern Orthodoxy), or cousins in the extended household (the Hieronymian reading held by Roman Catholicism) is a long-contested question that this study does not attempt to settle. The point pressing here is independent of the identification: the persons in view were not at that point believers, and Jesus therefore did not arrange his mother's care through them.

of Mark 7 and 1 Timothy 5 in a single gesture: honor of mother, exercised through the church.

2.7 The Father's House — Where All Household Questions Lead

The double-household frame introduced at Luke 2:49 is completed at John 14. Every question about earthly household in this analysis finds its final horizon here.

John 14:1-3 — Let not your heart be troubled: ye believe in God, believe also in me. In my Father's house are many mansions: if it were not so, I would have told you. I go to prepare a place for you. And if I go and prepare a place for you, I will come again, and receive you unto myself; that where I am, there ye may be also.

Observations. Jesus, on the night of his betrayal, gathers his disciples' attention around a single image — *the Father's house* — in which there are *many mansions*, into which He is preparing to receive them. The Greek is worth registering: μοναί (*monai*, "dwelling places" or "rooms" — a noun the New Testament uses only here and at John 14:23, of the Father and Son making their *abode* with the believer) pictures not primarily many separate mansions on distinct properties, but *many rooms in one house* — the observation carried in the title of McCaffrey's monograph on the passage, cited below. The Father's household in the age to come is a *shared dwelling* in which each of the redeemed has a place.

A reading many readers will bring: the bridegroom preparing a place. A widely circulated teaching hears John 14:2-3 through Jewish marriage custom: the betrothed bridegroom returns to his father's compound to prepare a dwelling for his bride, then comes to fetch her. The teaching bundles two things of very different evidential standing, and they should be separated. The *attested* half is the patrilocal household pattern: in the multi-generation *bet 'av*, a marrying son ordinarily brought his bride into his father's compound, where rooms were added as the family grew (Gen. 24:67 — Isaac brings Rebekah "into his mother Sarah's tent"; on the compound archaeology, Lawrence Stager, "The Archaeology of the Family in Ancient Israel," *BASOR* 260, 1985), and marriage proceeded in two stages — binding betrothal, an interval in which both parties prepared (*m. Ketubot* 5:2 allots the betrothed virgin twelve months "to prepare herself," and the same to the man), then the fetching of the bride to the groom's home. The verb of John 14:3 — παραλήμψομαι (*paralēmpsomai*, "I will receive [you] unto myself") — is the verb used of taking home a wife (Matt. 1:20, 24), and John's Gospel elsewhere carries a deliberate bridegroom motif

(John 3:29; see Jocelyn McWhirter, *The Bridegroom Messiah and the People of God*, SNTSMS 138, Cambridge, 2006). The *unattested* half is the sermon's load-bearing detail — that the groom's father alone inspected the prepared chamber and set the wedding day (commonly linked to Matt. 24:36) — which has no primary-source attestation in the Mishnah, Talmud, or Second Temple literature and appears to be a twentieth-century homiletic reconstruction (popularized by Zola Levitt, *A Christian Love Story*, 1978), apparently derived from Matt. 24:36 rather than from attested custom. Johannine scholarship divides three ways on the primary background of the passage: the temple ("my Father's house" at John 2:16; James McCaffrey, *The House With Many Rooms: The Temple Theme of Jn 14,2-3*, *Analecta Biblica* 114, 1988), permanent family belonging (John 8:35 — "the servant abideth not in the house for ever: but the Son abideth ever" — with the *μοναί* of 14:2 echoed at 14:23, where Father and Son make their *μονή* with the believer), and the bridal resonance just described. On any of the three, the argument of this section stands unchanged; on the bridal reading, the Genesis 2:24 seam gains a further resonance — in the patrilocal world the "leaving" of marriage was never departure into the bounded self but transfer into another father's house, which is the meta-household point below.

Every household question of the present analysis — where the adult unmarried child lives, under whose authority, when he leaves, when he stays, whether the church becomes his family — is answered proleptically in this eschatological household. The direction of all earthly household ordering is toward *the Father's house*, and the church in this age is the beginning of that household, not a competing one.

The New Testament makes this connection explicit.

Ephesians 2:19 — Now therefore ye are no more strangers and foreigners, but fellowcitizens with the saints, and of the household of God (οἰκεῖοι τοῦ Θεοῦ, *oikeioi tou Theou*).

Hebrews 3:6 — But Christ as a son over his own house; whose house are we, if we hold fast the confidence and the rejoicing of the hope firm unto the end.

1 Peter 4:17 — For the time is come that judgment must begin at the house of God.

Observations. The church is not merely *like* a household; she is called ὁ οἶκος τοῦ Θεοῦ (*ho oikos tou Theou*) — *the* household of God, Christ as Son over that house, ourselves as the house. The kinship texture of Chapter 1 §1.6 is not sentimental; it is ontological. The believer who leaves his father's carpenter shop for Christ leaves *into* this house,

not out of a house into an open field.

Bearing on the present question. Jesus's teaching brings three things together that no single earthly view of adult children and parents can hold apart.

- **Formation.** The earthly household (Joseph's carpenter shop, the father's or mother's roof, the parental instruction of Proverbs) is the ordained sphere of formation until the son or daughter is ready to leave.
- **Belonging.** The Father's house is the ultimate belonging of the believer, present already in the household of God (the church), consummated in "In my Father's house are many mansions."
- **Transition.** Whether the departure is into marriage (Gen. 2:24), into consecrated singleness (Matt. 19:12), into vocational household transfer (Ch. 1 §1.4.6), into military service (Ch. 1 §1.4.8), or into service of the covenanted community (Ch. 1 §1.6.3) — the transition is ordinarily *out of* one household *into* another, not into isolation — even the wilderness callings (John the Baptist, "in the deserts till the day of his shewing," Luke 1:80; the desert tradition, §5.0.3) are received as into the Father's own household rather than into the bounded self. The Father's house is the meta-household, and the earthly seams (parental → military, parental → marriage, parental → church-family) are subordinate to it. (The household-embedded readings press this pattern hardest; View 2a records the dissent — launched adulthood under Christ, on its account, requires no earthly receiving household to be faithful, §4.2a. The paper does not adjudicate between them.)

This frame is not supplied by secular developmental accounts of the transition, which treat departure as a movement from the parental household into the bounded self. On the pattern the biblical exemplars trace (§1.3.1, §1.4.6-1.4.8), the young adult leaves one household for another — military, apprenticeship, vocation, marriage, or the ecclesial family — at an appointed seam, on the way home to the Father's house.

2.8 Jesus's Priorities Extracted

Assembling the evidence:

1. **The Father's house is the horizon.** Every household question is finally answered in "In my Father's house are many mansions" (John 14:2; Eph. 2:19; Heb. 3:6; 1 Pet. 4:17). The church in this age is the beginning of that house.
2. **The kingdom is first.** No earthly bond, including the deepest

filial bond, may rival allegiance to Christ (Matt. 10:37; Luke 14:26).

3. **The kinship of faith is primary.** The household of God re-orders, without destroying, the household of blood (Mark 3:31-35).
4. **Honor of parents is inviolable.** No devotion or tradition may nullify it (Mark 7:9-13).
5. **Care for parents is concrete.** It is arranged, materially, even at the moment of dying (John 19:26-27).
6. **Adult leaving for kingdom cause is licit — and is ordinarily *into* another household, not into isolation.** Jesus's own life demonstrates it (Luke 2:49; Luke 3:23; Mark 3:31-35; Matt. 19:29).
7. **Sonship subject to parents is preserved as long as the child is under their roof.** Luke 2:51.
8. **The adult Son's obedience is formed Godward through suffering, not through household subordination.** "Though he were a Son, yet learned he obedience by the things which he suffered" (Heb. 5:8). The New Testament's clearest apostolic depiction of an adult Son *learning obedience* locates that learning in the Son's suffering relation to the Father, not in continuing subordination to a human parent. Whatever cases the four views make for the unmarried adult child, the christological datum is that Christ's own mature ὑπακοή was filial submission to the Father, formed through suffering.

These eight data points together sketch the Christocentric material. Each of the four Chapter 4 views reads them differently — Views 1a/1b weighting #7 (subject-to-parents-while-under-roof), 1b as the ordinary directive mode and 1a as the commended household pattern for the unmarried adult; Views 2a and 2b weighting #6 (adult leaving for kingdom cause) and #8 (mature obedience formed Godward) as the ordinary pattern for the disciple. Chapter 2 sets the data out; Chapter 4 develops the differing readings.

2.9 What the Christocentric Data Does Not Settle

- Jesus was celibate and never faced the specific question of the unmarried adult daughter under the father's roof.
- Jesus did not explicitly teach on Numbers 30.
- Jesus did not draw an explicit line between obedience (proper to minors) and honor (proper to adults). Views 2a and 2b read His own life and His use of the honor commandment as together implying the distinction; View 1a reads the same materials as compatible with the honor-and-consultation structure its commended household sustains, and View 1b as compatible with

a directive-following mode continuing to marriage. Chapter 2 does not adjudicate.

These silences are important; they keep the door open for multiple faithful applications.

Chapter 3 — Antiquity

Overview (Antiquity)

The pre-Nicene church (roughly AD 30 to 325) inherited a strong household-piety culture from both Judaism and the Greco-Roman world, but reshaped it around Christ. The apostolic and ante-Nicene writers teach parents to raise children in the fear of God, teach children to honor and obey their parents, and simultaneously honor consecrated unmarried adults (both men and women) as a distinct Christian calling. There is no single early-church template for the unmarried adult child's household arrangement.

A note on how Antiquity functions in SCAR. Antiquity is not a magisterium and does not overrule Scripture. It functions as a check against novelty — a witness to what the church, reading the same Scriptures in continuity with the apostles, has understood the Scriptures to permit and forbid. This is the historic Protestant posture stated by the Westminster Confession of Faith 1:6: “The whole counsel of God, concerning all things necessary for his own glory, man's salvation, faith and life, is either expressly set down in Scripture, or by good and necessary consequence may be deduced from Scripture.” Antiquity's role in SCAR is to help the reader see what the church has held to be “expressly set down” and what has been faithfully “deduced by good and necessary consequence” — and to flag when a modern claim departs from both.

3.1 The Context — Greco-Roman *Patria Potestas* and Jewish Household

Roman law recognized *patria potestas* — the father's legal power over his descendants, including adult sons, potentially for life. Sons under this power could not own property in their own name; the father's death dissolved the power. Roman practice was more flexible than Roman law: adult sons commonly conducted independent lives with paternal consent. Daughters passed from *patria potestas* into the *manus* of the husband at marriage (in older forms) or remained in the father's household legally while living with the husband (in later forms).

First-century Judaism did not have a legal equivalent of *patria potestas*. Sons ordinarily learned their father's trade and married young (mid-to-late teens). Daughters ordinarily married very young by modern standards. Betrothal was consequential; the father's role in arranging a daughter's marriage was substantial.

The early Christian writers navigate both settings. They do not adopt

patria potestas as their model. Nor do they retreat from strong household ethics.

3.1.1 The Qumran Community and the Dead Sea Scrolls

Independent Second Temple Jewish testimony survives in the Dead Sea Scrolls. The Qumran sectarians provide a first-century witness that neither the New Testament nor the Roman law codes provide directly: how one strict Jewish community actually structured the transition from paternal household to adult community life.

Three texts bear on the present question.

The Rule of the Congregation (1QSa 1:6-11). The scroll prescribes the community's staged formation of male members:

"From his youth they shall educate him in the Book of Meditation, and according to his age instruct him in the statutes of the covenant ... at twenty years of age he shall pass among those who are numbered, to enter the lot in the midst of his family and be joined to the holy congregation. He shall not approach a woman to know her by lying with her before he is fully twenty years old, when he knows good and evil." (1QSa 1:6-11; the paper's composite rendering from the Hebrew — no public-domain English exists; cf. Vermes, *The Complete Dead Sea Scrolls in English*, and García Martínez)

Observations. Independent Second Temple Jewish evidence for age twenty as the threshold of adult status — precisely the biblical military age (Num. 1:3). Marriage, likewise, is barred until that threshold — on the construal of 1QSa 1:9-11 reflected in the standard translations; what exactly attaches at twenty has been discussed in the scrolls literature since Yadin, "A Crucial Passage in the Dead Sea Scrolls," *JBL* 78 (1959): 238-41. The passage combines paternal formation ("from his youth they shall educate him") with a community-mediated adult transition ("he shall pass among those who are numbered"). The son is passed *from* paternal instruction *into* the congregation's structured life — a Jewish sectarian analogue of the vocational household transfer pattern.

The Damascus Document (CD 7:6-7 and parallels). The Damascus Document treats those who "walk in the perfection of holiness ... according to the covenant of God" — some celibate, some marrying and begetting children in the camps. Both are recognized as faithful.

Josephus on the Essenes (*Jewish War* 2.8.2-2.8.13; *Antiquities* 18.1.5). Josephus reports two orders: one wholly celibate, one

marrying “for the propagation of the race.” The celibate order does not beget children but *adopts other men’s children* while still young and teaches them:

“They neglect wedlock, but choose out other persons’ children, while they are pliable, and fit for learning; and esteem them to be of their kindred, and form them according to their own manners.” (*War* 2.8.2)

Observations. Josephus’s testimony independently corroborates the scroll evidence: Second Temple Judaism outside the Pharisaic mainstream already recognized (a) a legitimate celibate calling for both men and women, and (b) transfer of children out of the paternal household into another formative community for teaching. Neither is a Christian innovation.

Bearing on the present question. The Qumran and Josephus material provide first-century Jewish evidence — *before* the pre-Nicene Christian writers — that:

- **Age twenty** functioned as the operative threshold for adult male responsibility, including marriage (1QSa 1:9-11). This aligns with the biblical military threshold (Num. 1:3).
- **The unmarried celibate life** was a publicly recognized honorable calling in Second Temple Judaism, both for men and women (Josephus on the Essenes). Christian celibacy did not arise in a Jewish vacuum.
- **Community-structured adult transitions** — formal enrollment and a community-set marriage threshold — have a Second Temple Jewish precedent. Ignatius’s later requirement of episcopal approval for marriage (*To Polycarp* 5:2) is not without Jewish precursors in community-structured transition.
- **Formation of the young by a community other than the paternal household** is not a Christian invention; Josephus attests the Essene practice explicitly.

The Dead Sea Scrolls thus support both the *marriage-arrangement* theme (community-mediated marriage) and the *vocational household transfer* theme (formation in another sphere) — providing Second Temple Jewish testimony to patterns that later appear in both Christian antiquity and modern practice.

3.1.2 Rabbinic Judaism (Mishnah, Talmud, Traditional Halakhah)

Rabbinic Judaism is the tradition that has, over two millennia, thought hardest about the parent-adult-child relationship on the basis of the same Old Testament texts the present analysis engages. Though the

Mishnah (redacted c. 200 AD) and the Talmuds (Yerushalmi c. 400 AD; Bavli c. 500-600 AD) postdate the pre-Nicene sources of §3.2-3.10 below, they preserve halakhic reasoning whose seeds are demonstrably Second Temple — visible already in Ben Sira, Philo, and Josephus, and in the Qumran material of §3.1.1. Their inclusion here provides independent, non-Christian corroboration of much of the pattern Scripture establishes.

The rabbinic contribution to our question comes down to nine points.

1. Honor (כבוד, *kibbud*) and Reverence (אֲדָרָה, *mora*) as distinguishable duties. Kiddushin 31b splits the Fifth Commandment into two lifelong obligations — precisely the move the New Testament makes in Ephesians 6:1-2 with ὑπακούω / τιμάω. *Kibbud* is positive material service (“to feed, to give drink, to clothe, to cover, to bring in and out”). *Mora* is respectful posture (“not to stand in his place, not to sit in his place, not to contradict him, not to decide against him”). The two-duty framework is not a Christian innovation — it is the rabbinic reading of the same Torah.

2. Provision as concrete, non-optional duty. Kiddushin 31b-32a asks from whose funds the honor-costs are borne (מִשֵּׁל מִי, *mishel mi*) — that is, when the adult son must provide from his own funds versus the father’s. The ruling: provision from the father’s own means where possible; personal service from the son; and where the father cannot provide, the son must (as later codified at *Shulchan Arukh Yoreh De’ah* 240:5) — the direct halakhic anchoring of the principle Jesus presses against the *korban* loophole in Mark 7:9-13.

The tradition preserves a paradoxical pair of cases (the aphorism at b. Kiddushin 31a-b, in the name of Avimi son of R. Abbahu; the fuller wording and both stories in y. Peah 1:1, retold by Rashi ad loc.): “There is one who feeds his father fatted pheasants and inherits Gehenna, and there is one who puts his father to grind at the mill and inherits the world to come.” The stories behind the paradox are the point. In the first, the son provided luxury food but answered his father with contempt when the father asked where it came from (“Old man, eat and be quiet, as dogs eat and are quiet”). In the second, the king’s officers had come to conscript a member of the household for the royal mill-service — dangerous, potentially fatal, corvée labor — and the son said to the father, “You grind at the mill here in my place; I will go do the king’s work.” He took the danger onto himself and left the father the safer task. The rabbinic point is *not* that a son should extract labor from his father, but that the attitude and self-cost of provision matter as much as the substance: a rich provision given with contempt dishonors, while a hard provision given with respect and self-sacrifice honors.

3. Honor at the top of the ranked commandments. Mishnah Peah 1:1 — recited daily in the morning liturgy — lists the acts whose “fruits a man enjoys in this world while the principal remains for him in the world to come.” Honor of father and mother heads the list, alongside acts of loving-kindness and Torah study. Kiddushin 30b compares the honor of parents to the honor of God, invoking the parallel language of Exodus 20:12 and Proverbs 3:9.

4. Age of majority does *not* trigger household exit. Mishnah Niddah 5:6-6:11 fixes religious majority at thirteen for boys and twelve for girls. But majority in this sense is *religious responsibility*, not household independence. Pirkei Avot 5:21 gives the classical life-stages: five for Scripture, ten for Mishnah, thirteen for the commandments (bar mitzvah), fifteen for Talmud, **eighteen for marriage** (חֲפָזָה, *chup-pah*), **twenty for pursuit of livelihood**, thirty for strength, forty for understanding.⁴ The household transition is *marriage*, not majority — the rabbinic embodiment of the Gen 2:24 pattern §1.3.1 sets out.

5. Consent required — the daughter’s marital autonomy from majority. Kiddushin 41a: “It is forbidden for a man to betroth his daughter when she is a minor, until she grows up and says, ‘I want so-and-so.’” Rabbinic law positively forbids the father from marrying off a maturing daughter without her consent. Ketubot 39a and 46b-48a develop the transition through the *naarah* (12 to 12½, a transitional six-month window) and *bogeret* (mature, from 12 years, 6 months, and 1 day onward — about 12½) stages: paternal control of the daughter’s earnings and marriage-arrangement ends at *bogeret* (the threshold as at §1.4.1). **From maturity she is her own agent for marriage** — parental blessing is normal but not legally required. This is distinctively mainstream rabbinic halakhah: Qumran (§3.1.1) by contrast retained paternal authority over the unmarried daughter indefinitely and had almost no framework for female legal independence. The rabbinic picture is a much softer one than the popular caricature of Jewish “arranged marriage” and closely matches the Rebekah pattern of Genesis 24:57-58 (§1.4.5). It sits in apparent tension with 1 Corinthians 7:36-38 (§1.4.2) — but only under the

⁴This schematic age-staged life-course has a striking generic parallel in the *Analects* of Confucius (2:4, c. 5th century BCE): “At fifteen I set my heart on learning; at thirty I stood firm; at forty I had no doubts; at fifty I knew the decrees of Heaven; at sixty my ear was attuned; at seventy I could follow what my heart desired without transgressing what was right.” The genre — a named sage’s decade-milestone progression, shared 15/30/40 markers, adulthood organized around fixed ritual and vocational transitions — is substantially the same. Direct literary dependence is implausible: no plausible channel runs from 5th-c. BCE China to 2nd-c. CE Palestine, and Yehuda ben Tema’s saying draws on independent biblical and Second Temple antecedents. The far more probable explanation is independent development of a common genre in traditional agrarian societies that organized adult life around fixed stages. It is a striking cross-cultural parallel: two unrelated traditions independently framed the arc of adult maturity in decade milestones.

“father-of-the-virgin” reading of that passage; under the “betrothed-couple” reading the passage is not about paternal authority at all. Even under the father-reading, Paul’s language concerns *permission* to marry an older unmarried daughter, not compulsion against her will, and no specific age is in view. The consent-of-the-daughter principle running from Genesis 24 through mainstream rabbinic halakhah is not overturned by Paul on either reading.

6. The rebellious son as dead letter. The rabbis piled restrictions on Deuteronomy 21:18-21 until it became functionally inoperative (Sanhedrin 68b-71a). The son must be between exactly thirteen and thirteen-and-a-half years old (a three-month window); both parents must be alive, agree, and (in some views) have similar voices and appearances; specific quantities of meat and wine must have been consumed in a specific setting.

Sanhedrin 71a issues the tradition’s own verdict: **“It never was and never will be”** (תוֹיָהָל דִּיתַעַץ אֵלָיו הָיָה אֵל, *lo hayah ve-lo ‘atid lihyot*). **Why then was it written? “Interpret it and receive reward.”** The rabbinic reading: Deut 21 is *moral warning*, not legal procedure. Persistent rebellion is grave, but no actual civil execution is contemplated. The New Testament nowhere applies it. Neither did the rabbis.

Two further notes belong to this datum. *First*, the dead-lettering itself is contested evidence: readers inclined toward continuing paternal authority press that a tradition declaring a Torah statute inoperative is not interpreting the text but nullifying it — the “making the word of God of none effect” objection, recorded with its rejoinders at §1.2.1 (the fourth 1b reply) and §1.4.1. *Second*, the statute has a canonical afterlife that neither the civil-procedure reading nor the dead-letter reading exhausts. The prophets take up its exact phrase — הָרֹמֵז רָרוֹס (*sorer u-moreh*, “stubborn and rebellious”) — and apply it to Israel nationally: “a stubborn and rebellious generation” (Ps. 78:8), “this people hath a revolting and a rebellious heart” (Jer. 5:23; cf. Isa. 30:1; 1:2). On the prophetic use, the rebellious son of Deut. 21 became the mirror in which the nation was to see itself, and the judgment the statute prescribes fell at national scale in the exile. The New Testament then completes the figure in a direction commentators have long noted (e.g., Davies and Allison, *Matthew*, ICC, vol. 2, on 11:19): the one figure in the New Testament described by his opponents in the statute’s own charge-list vocabulary — “a man gluttonous, and a winebibber” (Matt. 11:19; Luke 7:34; cf. “a glutton, and a drunkard,” Deut. 21:20; §2.4) — is Jesus; and the verses immediately following the statute, the curse on the man hanged on a tree (Deut. 21:22-23), are the verses Paul applies to the crucified Christ (Gal. 3:13). Read together — a typological reading available to every view

in this paper — the statute’s canonical trajectory runs not to the city gate but to the cross: the true Son, described by his accusers as the rebellious son, bears the curse of the statute’s own context for the genuinely rebellious child, Israel and every reader. Whether the rabbinic restriction of the civil procedure was wisdom about the statute’s real function or evasion of a discipline whose absence the nation paid for — Eli’s unrestrained sons and the judgment that followed at Shiloh (1 Sam. 2-4; §5.0) is the canonical case for the cost — the paper records both assessments without adjudicating them.

7. The father’s obligations toward the son — including finding him a wife. Kiddushin 29a-b lists the father’s duties: to circumcise the son, redeem him if firstborn, teach him Torah, **find him a wife, teach him a craft (*ummanut*)**, and (some add) teach him to swim. Notice the marriage duty: *the father’s obligation includes actively facilitating the son’s marriage.*

The rabbinic model does not eject the son at majority. It sets him up in his own household around marriage-age, with the father providing vocational grounding first and marital initiation second. Sotah 44a, invoking Deuteronomy 20:5-7, gives the sequence: “Build a house, plant a vineyard, then marry.” This matches almost exactly the sequence the NCFIC pastoral counsel (§4.1a) arrives at through Reformed reasoning — two independent traditions reading the same Torah toward the same practical order.

8. Genesis 2:24 in rabbinic reading — always marriage-etiological, never independence-authorizing. Genesis Rabbah 17-18 treats the verse as the definition of marital union. Sanhedrin 58a uses it to define forbidden unions in Noahide law. The rabbis read the “leaving” as making the marriage bond *primary over the birth family in matters of the new couple’s decisions and priorities* — a reading that materially supports the conclusion of §1.3.1. **No rabbinic source reads Genesis 2:24 as authorizing pre-marital independence.** The individualist reading of the verse has no ancient warrant in the tradition closest to the text.

9. One real divergence — celibacy. Rabbinic Judaism has essentially no place for lifelong celibacy as an honorable calling. Yevamot 63b records Ben Azzai defending his own unmarried state on the ground that “my soul yearns for the Torah; the world can be maintained by others” — but he is the exception, and even he acknowledges the pressure of the norm. Yevamot 62b: “He who has no wife lives without joy, without blessing, without goodness...” — the drift is uniformly toward marriage.

This is a real divergence from the New Testament (1 Cor 7:7-8; Matthew 19:12; Isaiah 56:3-7 as read in Acts 8:26-39 and by the

pre-Nicene church of §3.2-3.10). The Qumran material of §3.1.1 shows that Second Temple Judaism was not uniform on this point; the Essenes recognized celibate vocation. But post-70 rabbinic Judaism consolidated around marriage-normativity in a way Christianity did not. On celibacy the New Testament and early church open a space (§1.6.2; §3.4-3.9) that post-70 rabbinic normativity closes.

Bearing on the present question. Rabbinic Judaism supplies an independent Second-Temple-continuous witness to the meaning of shared Old Testament texts. Independently, from the same Old Testament:

- **Honor is lifelong and substantive** — matching §1.2.2.
- **Provision is concrete duty** — matching the Mark 7 gloss.
- **Reverence is distinct from obedience** — matching the obey/honor distinction of §1.2.
- **Marriage is the household-transition, not majority-at-thirteen** — matching §1.3.1.
- **The daughter's consent is required from maturity** — matching the Rebekah pattern (§1.4.5).
- **Deut 21 is not a lever for authoritarian parenting** — matching §1.7.
- **The father sets the son up toward marriage rather than pushing him out** — matching the warrior-departure pattern (§1.4.8) and the vocational-then-marital sequence.

The single real divergence — celibacy — is precisely the point where the New Testament, the pre-Nicene church, and the Qumran material of §3.1.1 open a space the mainstream rabbinic tradition does not. On the parent-adult-child dynamic itself, the several parallels noted above hold across an independent Second-Temple-continuous tradition reading the same Old Testament — evidence that the shared findings above are not projections of modern categories back onto Scripture, but readings that faithful hearers of the same text have arrived at across radically different centuries and settings. Points where the Chapter 4 views disagree are not adjudicated by rabbinic parallel; the parallels bear only on points already common across the faithful views.

3.2 The Didache (late 1st or early 2nd century)

The *Didache*, one of the earliest post-apostolic works, gives household instructions in a section paralleling the “Two Ways”:

Didache 4:9 (Lightfoot trans.) — Thou shalt not withhold thy hand from thy son or from thy daughter, but from their youth thou shalt teach them the fear of God.

Didache 4:10-11 (Lightfoot trans.) — Thou shalt not

command thy bondservant or thine handmaid in thy bitterness, who trust in the same God as thyself, lest haply they should cease to fear the God who is over both of you; for He cometh, not to call men with respect of persons, but He cometh to those whom the Spirit hath prepared. But ye, servants, shall be subject unto your masters, as to a type of God, in shame and fear.

Observations. The Didache preserves what looks like a truncated household code: parents-to-children (4:9) and masters-to-slaves (4:10-11) are treated in the paired form familiar from Ephesians 5-6 and Colossians 3-4. But two elements of the New Testament *Haustafeln* are conspicuously absent:

- No *child-to-parent* address is given. The Didache tells the parent to teach and not withdraw the hand, but does not repeat the Ephesians 6:1-3 / Colossians 3:20 command “children, obey your parents.” A slave-to-master command is included at 4:11. The corresponding child-to-parent command is not.
- Nothing addresses adult unmarried offspring — no equivalent of 1 Corinthians 7 or Numbers 30, no direction on marriage arrangement, no direction on adult children in the parental household.

What “from their youth” means. The Greek is ἀπὸ νεότητος (*apo neotētos*) — the same construction Paul uses to Timothy in 1 Timothy 4:12 (where Timothy is likely in his 30s) and the rich young ruler uses in Luke 18:21 (“from my youth up”). In patristic Greek νεότης covers roughly the whole formative span from childhood through young adulthood; it does not narrowly mean “small children.” Even so, the Didache’s context is unambiguously *catechetical* formation — the parallel construction in Barnabas 19:5 (§3.3), the “Two Ways” instructional frame, and the phrase “teach them the fear of God” all indicate training up the not-yet-formed, not governance of the already-formed adult. Compare Proverbs 22:6.

Sons and daughters are addressed together and equally. Parents are commanded not to *withdraw* their hand — implying that the temptation the Didache guards against is under-discipline, not over-control. The formation aim is the fear of God.

What the Didache does not settle. Because the text speaks only to the formative period and drops the child-side of the code, it supplies no direct evidence for either View 1 (continuing household authority into adulthood) or View 2 (launched at adulthood). The Didache’s silence on adult unmarried offspring is data, but it is data of the argument-from-silence kind: it cannot carry weight either way on its own.

3.3 The Epistle of Barnabas (early 2nd century)

Barnabas repeats the Didache formula almost verbatim:

Barnabas 19:5 (Lightfoot trans.) — Thou shalt love thy neighbour more than thine own soul. Thou shalt not murder a child by abortion, nor again shalt thou kill it when it is born. Thou shalt not withhold thy hand from thy son or daughter, but from their youth thou shalt teach them the fear of God.

Observations. The two texts together indicate a fixed early-church catechetical pattern about *raising* children. Neither text addresses what happens after the child becomes an adult.

3.4 Ignatius of Antioch and Polycarp of Smyrna (c. 107-155)

Ignatius, bishop of Antioch, and Polycarp, bishop of Smyrna, are the two great post-apostolic witnesses — both of the generation that stood within living memory of the apostles, both martyred. Their assumption that marriage in the church proceeds by church oversight (Ignatius, *To Polycarp* 5:2) carries the weight §4.5 places on it precisely because of who they were and how close they stood to the apostolic generation.

Polycarp, To the Philippians 4:2 (Lightfoot trans.) — ... our wives also, to walk in the faith that hath been given unto them and in love and purity, cherishing their own husbands in all truth and loving all men equally in all chastity, and to train their children in the training of the fear of God.

Ignatius, To Polycarp 5:1-2 (Lightfoot trans.) — Tell my sisters to love the Lord and to be content with their husbands in flesh and in spirit. In like manner also charge my brothers in the name of Jesus Christ to love their wives, as the Lord loved the Church. If any one is able to abide in chastity to the honour of the flesh of the Lord, let him so abide without boasting. If he boast, he is lost.

Observations. Marriage and celibacy stand side by side as honorable callings — with celibacy honored provided it is unboastful. The household is the ordinary sphere; unmarried adults have a recognized place.

Ignatius also treats marriage as an ecclesial event, not a private one:

Ignatius, To Polycarp 5:2 (ANF trans.) — But it becomes both men and women who marry, to form their union with the approval of the bishop, that their marriage may be

according to God, and not after their own lust. Let all things be done to the honour of God.

This is early evidence that the marriage decision was not treated as a private matter between the couple alone. Church oversight of the marriage-arrangement moment is assumed by the beginning of the second century.

3.4a Shepherd of Hermas (mid-2nd century)

Vision 1.3 (ANF trans.) — But God is not angry with you on account of this, but that you may convert your house, which have committed iniquity against the Lord, and against you, their parents. And although you love your sons, yet did you not warn your house, but permitted them to be terribly corrupted. On this account is the Lord angry with you, but He will heal all the evils which have been done in your house... For as a smith hammers out his work, and accomplishes whatever he wishes, so shall righteous daily speech overcome all iniquity. Cease not therefore to admonish your sons; for I know that, if they will repent with all their heart, they will be enrolled in the Books of Life with the saints.

Vision 2.2-2.3 (ANF trans.) — Your seed, O Hermas, has sinned against God, and they have blasphemed against the Lord, and in their great wickedness they have betrayed their parents. And they passed as traitors of their parents, and by their treachery did they not reap profit... But make known these words to all your children, and to your wife, who is to be your sister... But as for you, Hermas, remember not the wrongs done to you by your children... For they will be instructed with righteous instruction, if you remember not the wrongs they have done you. For the remembrance of wrongs works death. And you, Hermas, have endured great personal tribulations on account of the transgressions of your house, because you did not attend to them, but were careless and engaged in your wicked transactions.

Observations. The *Shepherd of Hermas* was the most widely-read Christian text of the second century outside the New Testament and was read publicly in some churches into the fourth (attested at Athanasius, *Ep. Fest.* 39). The opening visions are directly on the paper's territory: a father is held accountable by the Lord for the sins of the grown members of his household. (That the children are grown is an inference — the text gives no ages — but their capacity to “betray their parents,” which Osiek reads as “renunciation, blasphemy,

betrayal — all terms that could be related to political persecution but need not be,” possibly apostasy under persecution driven by material interests (Carolyn Osiek, *Shepherd of Hermas*, Hermeneia, Fortress, 1999, on Vis. 2.2, p. 80), presupposes agents acting in the public world.) What the text states is a culpable omission and its remedy. The omission: “you did not warn your house, but permitted them to be terribly corrupted”; “you did not attend to them, but were careless” — the verb of the failure in the Greek of Vis. 1.3 is νουθετέω (*noutheteō*, admonish). The remedy: “convert your house,” “make known these words,” “cease not to admonish your sons,” daily “righteous speech,” and the refusal of grudge-keeping so that the children “will be instructed with righteous instruction” — with the children’s restoration running through their own repentance (“if they will repent with all their heart”). Both wings of the paper’s question can claim this text, and each should be allowed its reading. Readers of Views 1a/1b will hear a paterfamilias answerable before God for the ongoing government of his house — the Lord addresses the father, not the children; blames him for permitting what he should have prevented; and expects him to “convert” them — pre-Nicene evidence for the continuing-office reading. Readers of Views 2a/2b will observe that every instrument the text prescribes is a speech-instrument — admonition, instruction, making-known, and the intercession and repentance the visions enact — and that no directive command over the grown children appears anywhere in the remedy; on this hearing the office the text enforces operates in senses (2)-(4) of §1.1.1. The text itself does not adjudicate between these readings: on the 2a/2b hearing the directive-authority question never arises in it; on the 1a/1b hearing the father’s answerability itself implies the office. What the text enforces on either construal is the father’s answerability and the word he owes his house. A minor companion witness in the same generation is *1 Clement* 21:6-8, addressed to the Corinthian church: “Let us reverence our rulers; let us honour our elders; let us instruct our young men in the lesson of the fear of God; let us guide our women toward that which is good... Let your children be partakers of the discipline that is in Christ.”

3.5 Justin Martyr (mid-2nd century)

First Apology 15 — And many, both men and women, who have been Christ’s disciples from childhood, remain pure at the age of sixty or seventy years; and I boast that I could produce such from every race of men.

Observations. Justin’s public defense of the church cites the existence of lifelong celibates — men and women — as evidence of Christian virtue. He does not describe their household arrangements. Some

evidently lived at home; some in ecclesial community. The point is that unmarried adulthood as a settled state was public and honored.

3.6 Athenagoras (late 2nd century)

Legatio 33 — You would find many among us, both men and women, growing old unmarried, in hope of living in closer communion with God.

Observations. Same pattern as Justin — the honored existence of lifelong unmarried adults, both sexes, in the Christian communities.

3.6a Clement of Alexandria (c. 150-215)

Clement is the most household-focused pre-Nicene writer. His *Paedagogus* (*The Instructor*) is a systematic treatment of the Christian household under the tutelage of Christ; his *Stromata* III is the most substantial pre-Nicene defense of marriage against the encratite party that took bodily renunciation as constitutive of the higher Christian life.

Paedagogus III.11 (the paper's summary — not a quotation).

The Christian household, from the master and mistress to the children and servants, is drawn under a single Instructor; the household's ordinary conduct — food, dress, speech, gesture, hospitality — is the field on which Christ trains the whole family into virtue. The chapter's own image is the Instructor as charioteer, "who, pulling back the reins from far, leads and drives to salvation the human horse — that is, the irrational part of the soul" (ANF 2, Wilson trans.); the whole of Books II-III applies that office to the household's daily practice, item by item.

Stromata III.12.79-90 (the paper's summary — not a quotation; the ANF renders Book III only in Latin, a Victorian propriety measure, so no public-domain English of the passage exists to quote). Marriage is a work of the Creator and is not for Christians a lower state than celibacy. Those who reject marriage as such reject the God who made it. Both marriage and celibacy are honorable callings; celibacy is not superior in principle, and marriage is not a concession to weakness. The apostles married. The condemnation of the encratite refusal of marriage rests on the goodness of creation and the apostolic pattern. (English: Ferguson, FOC 85, or Chadwick's Library of Christian Classics *Alexandrian Christianity*, 1954.)

Observations. Clement matters for the paper on two axes. First, *Paedagogus* treats the Christian household as a single object of formation under Christ — the language of *paideia* now Christianized.

This is straightforwardly the pre-Nicene picture of the household-as-formative-community that Views 1a and 1b both draw on, and Clement is unusual in the pre-Nicene corpus for sustaining that picture at book length. Second, and more consequentially for the paper's Non-Negotiable #4 (TL;DR, Non-Negotiables), *Stromata* III supplies *pre-Nicene* support for the position that marriage and celibacy are both honorable callings — the position the paper elsewhere anchors in 1 Timothy 4:1-5 and in the later canonical settlement. The paper's distinction from encratite bodily-renunciation readings does not rest on 1 Timothy alone: Clement shows that the pre-Nicene church was already prepared to fight this fight and win it, in the second and third centuries, on the ground of creation-goodness and apostolic pattern. Non-Negotiable #4 is not a late-canon settlement imposed on an earlier ambiguity; it is the pre-Nicene majority position, articulated most fully by Clement, against a minority encratite pressure that the church rejected. Editions: *Paedagogus* and *Stromata* in ANF vol. 2 (Wilson, 1885); more recent critical Greek text in Sources chrétiennes 70, 108, 158 (Mondésert, Marrou, Matray, Van den Hoek); English of *Stromata* III with commentary in John Ferguson, *Clement of Alexandria: Stromateis Books One to Three*, FOC 85, CUA Press, 1991.

3.7 Tertullian (late 2nd to early 3rd century)

Tertullian addresses many household questions. Two are pertinent:

On the Veiling of Virgins 1 (ANF, Thelwall trans.) —
 ... it behooves our virgins to be veiled from the time that they have passed the turning-point of their age: that this observance is exacted by truth, on which no one can impose prescription — no space of times, no influence of persons, no privilege of regions.

Tertullian's rule engages precisely at maturity: chapter 11 of the same treatise denies that the veil is worn from infancy — it begins "from the time when she begins to be self-conscious, and to awake to the sense of her own nature." The treatise thus presupposes adult virgins as a standing, publicly visible class in the congregation, with the church's discipline for that class engaging at the threshold of womanhood — not a fringe category.

Ad Uxorem I.5-8 (the paper's summary — not a quotation).
 Discussion of the widow's freedom, including her freedom to remarry or to remain single. Not directly on unmarried children under paternal authority, but establishing that the state of unmarried adulthood is publicly recognized.

Observations. Tertullian's writings are polemical and sometimes extreme, but they consistently treat unmarried adult women as full members of the church, not as permanent extensions of paternal authority.

3.7.1 The *Passio Perpetuae* (c. 203)

Within a few years of Tertullian's writing, and in the same North African church he served — some scholars have argued Tertullian himself was the editor of the surviving text — the *Passio Sanctarum Perpetuae et Felicitatis* records the martyrdom of Vibia Perpetua, a twenty-two-year-old catechumen of noble birth, nursing an infant son, whose pagan father made four documented attempts to force her recantation. The *Passio* preserves what purports to be Perpetua's own diary — one of the earliest first-person texts by a Christian woman — and it turns on the exact question this paper puts to Antiquity: what does honor of a father look like when the father commands the daughter away from Christ?

The *Passio* records three distinct encounters between Perpetua and her father, in ascending intensity across the arc of her imprisonment and trial. In the first (ch. 3), her father comes to the prison seeking to argue her out of her confession; it is here that Perpetua offers the vessel-and-its-name dialogue, and here that her father — enraged — physically threatens her:

Passio Perpetuae 3 — "Father," said I, "do you see this vessel lying, a pitcher or whatsoever it may be? ... Can it be called by any other name than what it is?" And he said, "No." "So neither can I call myself anything other than what I am, a Christian." Then my father, provoked by this word, threw himself upon me as though he would pluck out my eyes; but he only vexed me, and he departed vanquished, he and the arguments of the devil.

(English rendering after W. H. Shewring, *The Passion of SS. Perpetua and Felicity*, MM., Sheed & Ward, 1931; Latin/Greek critical text in Thomas J. Heffernan, *The Passion of Perpetua and Felicity*, Oxford, 2012.)

In the second encounter (ch. 5), the father returns, this time not to argue but to plead. He kisses her hands, throws himself at her feet, invokes his grey hairs, and cries out on behalf of her mother, her aunt, her brothers, and her nursing son. In the third (ch. 6), at the tribunal itself, the father appears carrying the infant and begs her before the procurator to have pity on her child; when he interrupts the proceedings, the procurator has him beaten with a rod and driven off. Perpetua's grief is explicit — "I was grieved for his grey hairs,

that he alone of all my kindred would not rejoice at my passion" — and she does not deny her father's fatherhood, curse him, or renounce him. What she denies is that his directive authority reaches to the confession of Christ. She then goes willingly to the arena and dies.

Two features are decisive for the paper's purposes. The first is what the pre-Nicene church chose to *do* with this account. The *Passio* was read liturgically on Perpetua's feast day, was cited by Augustine in three surviving sermons (Sermons 280, 281, and 282, with the augmented recension of 282 sometimes counted as a fourth), and was preserved and copied through the mediaeval period as one of the church's canonical martyr narratives. The church did not read Perpetua's refusal as a defect in filial piety to be regretted or explained away; it read it as exemplary Christian constancy under paternal pressure, precisely the case Chapter 1's mixed-household treatment (§1.4.10) generalizes from the New Testament witness.

The second feature is what the account does *not* claim. Perpetua does not renounce her father, does not curse him, and does not deny that he retains the offices of teaching, counsel, and intercession that §1.1.1 names as senses (2), (3), and (4) of authority. She refuses him on one point: the point on which his command runs directly against the command of Christ. Sense (1) — directive authority in the specific act of confession — is defeated by the higher command; the other senses of authority are not addressed by the narrative one way or the other. This is the same shape the paper's exegesis of Acts 4:19 / 5:29 and Matthew 10:34-36 already found in the apostolic period. Perpetua is the pre-Nicene church's most vivid narrative embodiment of it, and Tertullian's contemporary or near-contemporary hand in transmitting it places it inside the same North African stream that produced the *Ad Uxorem* passages cited above.

It is worth being precise about how the mixed-household case maps to the four senses of authority named in §1.1.1. Perpetua's father is a pagan; by definition he cannot exercise sense (2) *formative authority* in Christian catechesis (he is trying to *undo* it) and he cannot exercise sense (4) *priestly authority* as intercession to Christ (he does not confess Christ). Those two senses are not so much *defeated* in his case as they are spiritually *moot* from his side — they never had subject-matter to operate on. Sense (1) *directive authority* is defeated at the exact point where his command runs against Christ's command (the confession). What remains active for Perpetua toward her father is the fifth-commandment duty of *honor* — respect for his person, grief at his grief, and the kind of deference that continues to recognize him as father even while refusing his one demand — and the operation of sense (4) in the reverse direction: the believing child interceding for the unbelieving parent, which is the shape §1.4.10 draws from

the Timothy pattern and 1 Corinthians 7:12-16. Perpetua's grief at her father's grey hairs is not sentiment against the confession; it is the fifth commandment operating exactly where sense (1) has been overruled.

Observations. The *Passio Perpetuae* does not settle the question between the four views on the ordinary case of a believing daughter in a believing household. It is silent on that question. What it settles — and what the pre-Nicene church took it as settling — is the limit case: when paternal command runs against Christ's command, the adult daughter's refusal is not disobedience to the fifth commandment but obedience to the higher command that Christ himself named in Matthew 10. All four views recognize this limit. The *Passio* is the narrative on which the pre-Nicene consensus about that limit rests.

3.7.2 The Acts of Paul and Thecla — a Popular Witness the Church Itself Policed

One more second-century narrative belongs in the inventory precisely because of how the church handled it. The apocryphal *Acts of Paul and Thecla* (2nd c., Asia Minor) narrates a virgin of Iconium, betrothed to Thamyris, who on hearing Paul's preaching of continence refuses the marriage. Her own mother Theocleia demands of the governor, "Burn the wicked wretch; burn in the midst of the theatre her that will not marry, in order that all the women ... may be afraid"; Thecla, delivered, resolves to follow Paul — "I shall cut my hair, and follow you wherever you may go" (*Acts of Paul and Thecla*, ANF vol. 8). The narrative thus celebrates an adult daughter's refusal of both betrothal and maternal authority for consecrated celibacy, and it circulated widely enough that Tertullian had to address appeals to it within a generation.

Its evidential standing is exactly what the paper's method requires be stated. The work is apocryphal, colored by the encratite tendency the church resisted (§3.6a), and the church's own discipline policed appeals to it: Tertullian records that "the presbyter who composed that writing ... after being convicted, and confessing that he had done it from love of Paul, was removed from his office" (*De baptismo* 17, rejecting appeals to Thecla's example as warrant for women teaching and baptizing). What the text and its reception attest is therefore not a normative answer but the live pre-Nicene *negotiation* of the very tension this chapter maps: a popular narrative celebrated the daughter's refusal, and the church both honored the consecrated calling (§3.5-3.8) and refused to let the popular narrative function as doctrine. Readers of Views 1a/1b will note that the church's check ran against the celebrated autonomy-narrative; readers of Views 2a/2b will note that the check concerned the work's authorship and its use

for women's church office, and that the church nowhere reasserted the mother's or the betrothed's authority as the counter-principle. The datum cuts both ways, which is why it belongs in the inventory.

3.7a Origen (c. 184-253, via Eusebius *Historia Ecclesiastica* 6.2)

Origen's biography preserved by Eusebius supplies two pre-Nicene data points that fall directly on the paper's seams. Both are in *HE* 6.2, in Eusebius's narrative of Origen's youth.

Eusebius, *HE* 6.2.3-6 (the paper's summary, with quotation from the NPNF² trans.). When Origen's father Leonides was imprisoned under Septimius Severus, Origen — then not quite seventeen — burned with such zeal for martyrdom that he attempted to leave the house and follow his father. His mother, unable to restrain him with words, hid all his clothing so that he could not go out. Being thus prevented, and driven by his zeal, he wrote to his father in prison, urging him not to flinch on his family's account: "Take heed not to change your mind on our account."

Eusebius, *HE* 6.2.12-15 and 6.3.3 (the paper's summary). After his father's martyrdom and the confiscation of the estate by the imperial treasury, Origen — not quite seventeen — supported his widowed mother and six younger brothers through teaching, first as a grammarian and then, in his eighteenth year, as head of the catechetical school of Alexandria.

Observations. Both incidents sit exactly on the paper's material. *First:* the mother's clothes-hiding is a case of parental restraint exercised at the very Christ-allegiance boundary the paper has worked (§1.4.10, §3.7.1). The mother is not commanding him to deny Christ — she is preventing an adolescent's zeal for martyrdom from carrying him past what he was ready to bear, at a moment when his family also needed his life. Eusebius reports the incident with approval, and Origen's own subsequent life bears out the mother's judgment. This qualifies the "no restraint at the confession seam" picture with a specific pastoral exception: a parent may act to *preserve life* even where the child is prepared to lose it, without violating the confession seam itself (Leonides is the one called to die; Origen's later confession comes in a different form, as teacher and, eventually, under Decius, as confessor). *Second:* the seventeen-year-old provider case is a pre-Nicene instance of the reversed provision the paper treats at §1.4.4 — the adult child requiting the parent. Origen's provision for his widowed mother and six brothers, taken up when the paternal estate was confiscated, is 1 Tim. 5:4 lived as biography. Both incidents are settled parts of the pre-Nicene record. Text: Eusebius, *Historia*

Ecclesiastica 6.2, in Kirsopp Lake, LCL 265 (Harvard, 1932) or NPNF² vol. 1 (Schaff, 1890).

3.8 Cyprian (mid-3rd century)

Cyprian's *De Habitu Virginum* (c. 249) is a bishop's disciplinary treatise regulating the dress and conduct of the consecrated virgins of his church.

De Habitu Virginum 3 (ANF, Wallis trans.) — My address is now to virgins, whose glory, as it is more eminent, excites the greater interest. This is the flower of the ecclesiastical seed, the grace and ornament of spiritual endowment ... the more illustrious portion of Christ's flock.

De Habitu Virginum 22 (ANF, Wallis trans.) — That which we shall be, you have already begun to be. You possess already in this world the glory of the resurrection ... in that you continue chaste and virgins, you are equal to the angels of God.

Observations. What the treatise evidences is carried less by any single sentence than by its form: a bishop addresses the consecrated virgins of his flock directly, praises their calling, and issues sustained regulation of their conduct — and Cyprian's *Epistle 4* (the *virgines subintroductae* case, §1.9) shows the same episcopal discipline operating with sanctions. By the mid-3rd century, then, consecrated virgins were a distinct order under the church's direct pastoral care. The treatise says nothing about fathers, in either direction; the inference that such virgins stood under episcopal care *rather than exclusively under paternal authority* is the paper's inference from the jurisdiction the treatise exercises, not a statement Cyprian makes.

3.9 Methodius (late 3rd to early 4th century)

Methodius's *Symposium* (a dialogue among ten virgins celebrating virginity) portrays consecrated women living in community, discoursing together, and pursuing a shared spiritual life. Whatever else it teaches, it shows that by the end of the pre-Nicene period, at least some unmarried adult women lived in ecclesial community rather than in their fathers' households.

3.10 Patterns Across the Pre-Nicene Church

Assembling the sources:

- **Formation of children** — sons and daughters, in the fear of the Lord, from youth (Didache, Barnabas, Polycarp).
- **Marriage** — normal, honored, treated as the ordinary path.
- **Consecrated unmarried adulthood** — honored, public, both sexes (Ignatius, Justin, Athenagoras, Tertullian, Cyprian, Methodius).
- **Household arrangements for unmarried adults** — variable. Some lived at home; some in ecclesial community; the church exercised pastoral care in either case.
- **Continuing paternal authority over unmarried adult daughters** — not codified as a doctrine. The New Testament texts (Num. 30 by reflection; 1 Cor. 7 by direct citation) are used by later Fathers in exhortations to obedience and reverence, but no ante-Nicene writer builds a theological framework of continuing legal authority parallel to *patria potestas*.

The View 1b answer to the absence-finding, recorded here as the other chapters record each view's answer to the data that press on it: in the marriage-economy of the pre-Nicene world, where daughters ordinarily passed to a husband's house at or near maturity (§1.4.1), the window of unmarried adult daughterhood was short for most households, so a doctrine governing that case had little occasion to be codified. On this reply, the silence is weak evidence about a question that rarely presented itself, and the authority 1b finds already established in Scripture (Num. 30 and the Haustafel, on its reading) did not need a patristic framework to survive the period. Whether that reply carries the weight is for the reader; the data of §3.2-3.9 stand either way.

3.11 What Antiquity Requires, Permits, and Forbids

The early church:

- **Requires** — parental teaching of children in the fear of God; filial honor at every age; provision for parents; marital purity; and, for those consecrated to virginity, sincerity without boasting.
- **Permits** — marriage as ordinary; unmarried adulthood as consecrated calling for both men and women; unmarried adults either in the paternal household or in ecclesial community.
- **Forbids** — abandonment of parents; boastful celibacy; and (increasingly, by the 3rd century) private marriages arranged without pastoral involvement.

3.12 What Antiquity Leaves Open

- Whether the unmarried adult daughter's continuing residence at home entails continuing paternal *authority* or continuing paternal *care*.
- Whether the unmarried adult son and daughter are treated symmetrically in the household. The evidence points to some asymmetry (daughters are addressed as veiled virgins in the assembly; sons more often as itinerant apprentices, catechumens, or clergy) but no systematic doctrine.

Chapter 4 — Reality

Overview (Reality)

Faithful believers today live out four distinct doctrinal arrangements for unmarried adult sons and daughters — Views 1a, 1b, 2a, and 2b (§§4.1a, 4.1b, 4.2a, 4.2b). The chapter also treats the multigenerational household as cultural inheritance (§4.4), consecrated singleness as cross-cutting vocation (§4.3), vocational household transfer as cross-cutting biblical mode (§4.6), and the orthogonal Arrangement Question (§4.5) that any of the four doctrinal arrangements may answer in more than one way. The full steel-manned presentations of the four views appear here because Reality is the leg on which the arrangements are tested in the lives of actual households; their scriptural and antiquarian warrants were already set out in Chapters 1 and 3. Each doctrinal arrangement claims some biblical warrant; each has adherents whose lives commend the arrangement. Given the earlier decision to treat sons and daughters differently where the biblical text differs, this chapter also considers sons and daughters in separate subsections where the practice diverges.

4.1 Household Continuity — Two Sub-Positions

Views 4.1a and 4.1b share the outward practice of the adult child remaining in the paternal household until marriage, with a particular protective concern for daughters. They diverge in the theological account they give of *why*. 4.1a treats household continuity as *wisdom and pattern* — a prudential arrangement that best forms adult children and best protects daughters — while leaving room for principled departure with parental blessing. 4.1b treats it as a *systematic doctrine of continuous authority* — every believer must at every moment be under a defined human authority, and stepping outside that structure exposes the person to spiritual harm. Proponents of 4.1a often insist they do not hold 4.1b's stronger claim; critics of 4.1b sometimes conflate the two. The two are treated separately so each can be assessed on its own claims.

4.1a Household Continuity (Prudential Covering)

Description. Remaining in the parental home until marriage is presented as the ideal biblical pattern. Departure before marriage is a principled exception, undertaken with parental blessing rather than as a cultural rite of passage at eighteen. For daughters especially, the household provides an *unbroken protective covering* that passes to the husband at marriage; if widowed, the covering passes to the

church. Adult children in the paternal household are treated as adults — consulted, counseled, and released into responsibility — not as perpetual minors. The claim is *prudential and formative* — this is the counsel that best forms the adult and best protects the daughter — not a systematic doctrine that continuous submission to a defined human authority is required for spiritual protection. That stronger claim is treated separately in §4.1b.

Representative modern voices. Scott Brown, Jason Dohm, and Steve Walker have articulated this position across sermons and podcasts associated with Church and Family Life and the National Center for Family-Integrated Churches (NCFIC). Their podcast episode “Should Children Stay Home till They’re Married?” (2023) is a concise recent statement. The older “stay at home daughters” tradition (Vision Forum, the Botkin sisters’ *So Much More*) argued from the same texts but as systematic doctrine; it belongs to View 1b and is treated at §4.1b and B.1.4, not as a representative of the prudential position described here, though its authors have in some cases revised their earlier claims. The NCFIC articulation is deliberately more moderate — ideal rather than mandate, protection rather than control.

Central positive warrant (steel-man). In its strongest published form, the household-continuity position is not chiefly about the adult child’s residence at all; it is about the biblical office of the father as *discipler*. Voddie Baucham articulates this most directly in *Family Driven Faith: Doing What It Takes to Raise Sons and Daughters Who Walk with God* (Crossway, 2007) and *What He Must Be... If He Wants to Marry My Daughter* (Crossway, 2009), grounding the household pattern in Deuteronomy 6:6-7 (the *shema*’s intergenerational transmission), Psalm 78:5-8 (each generation teaching the next), Malachi 4:6 (the turning of the fathers’ hearts to the children), and Ephesians 6:4 (bringing up children in the *nurture and admonition* of the Lord). On this reading, the father is not primarily an *authority* over the adult child but a *discipler* whose office of formation continues in an advisory register after the child’s minority ends. The multigenerational household is a recoverable *biblical pattern*, not merely a nostalgic preference or an Old-Testament civil provision. For the Reformed and Puritan warrant this position draws on — Matthew Henry, Cotton Mather, William Gouge, Richard Baxter — see §B.1.7.

Biblical arguments cited.

- **Genesis 2:24** as leaving-into-cleaving, not leaving-into-solitary-independence.
- **Ephesians 6:1-4** and **Colossians 3:20-21** without an imposed upper age limit — coupled with the warning against provoking to wrath.

- **Titus 2** — older women teaching younger to be “keepers at home,” read as a settled household piety.
- **Proverbs 31** — the woman contributing substantively to family and household enterprise.
- **1 Timothy 5:10** — the widow’s works include the domestic piety formed in the household.
- **John 19:26-27** — Jesus placing His mother under the beloved disciple’s care is read as a picture of protective continuity: Christ, at the last, arranges ongoing household care for His mother rather than leaving her alone.
- **Numbers 30** — paternal veto over the unmarried daughter’s vow.
- **1 Corinthians 7:36-38** — on the father-of-the-virgin reading, a father’s real role in giving his daughter in marriage.
- The multi-generational household pattern of the biblical narrative — Abraham and Isaac; Jesse and David; Boaz and Ruth (as she enters Naomi’s household then Boaz’s).

Biblical figures who lived outside the paternal home — Ruth, Naomi, Lydia, Esther, the daughters of Zelophehad — are acknowledged as faithful exceptions in which the underlying principles still applied.

Central lines of argument.

- *Against automatic departure at eighteen.* The expectation that children must leave by a fixed age reflects the surrounding culture’s story of autonomy and self-fulfillment, not the biblical household pattern. In this view, “failure to launch” is often misdiagnosed: the deeper failure is treating independence as an intrinsic good.
- *Financial.* Early careers consume most income; a son remaining home five years could accumulate substantial savings, meaningfully advancing his preparation for marriage.
- *Spiritual and relational.* Living under a wise household provides accountability and gentle constraint on behavior. Living alone can create emotional and moral liabilities, especially for women in their twenties.
- *Protection of daughters.* An unbroken *protective* continuity — the father’s household, then the marital household — is the strongest distinctive argument of this view, held as pattern and wisdom rather than as the systematic chain-of-covering doctrine of §4.1b. It is illustrated from John 19:26-27, where Christ arranges Mary’s continuing care with the beloved disciple.
- *Multi-generational household as biblical norm.* Adult children, sometimes with their own families, in the father’s household — the shared-dwelling shape §2.7 draws from John 14:2 and Ephesians 2:19 (the Father’s house as many rooms, not many

separate mansions).

- *Recovering the home*. The home is not a depressing minimalist place; biblically it is “the cradle of civilization.”

Sons. Sons are held to household piety but launched into vocation. They are expected to prepare for the responsibility of a wife — “preparing his field” — before pursuing courtship. A son without “consistent, reliable” work has no business seeking marriage (Walker, *Courtship for the Glory of God*). Where a son leaves before marriage, the reasons are examined against the same criteria as a daughter’s leaving.

Daughters. Daughters remain in the household as the paradigm. Courtship is initiated with the father’s involvement and pursued under his blessing. Yet, following Walker’s “principle-based courtship,” parents *counsel and guide* rather than dictate; the courting couple ultimately discern God’s will together. The father’s role is protective and pastoral, not autocratic.

Practical counsel (as articulated by NCFIC voices).

For an adult child considering leaving:

- Examine motives honestly. Is this rebellion, or a genuine godly reason?
- Ask whether the move promotes holiness, spiritual growth, and soul flourishing.
- Approach parents conversationally. Do not issue ultimatums or simply announce departures.

For parents:

- Do not push children out reflexively at a set age.
- Do not provoke or exasperate — first examine whether the home environment itself is a problem.
- Treat adult children as adults, not as perpetual minors.
- Do not issue ultimatums either.

Brown’s own illustration is a son who approached the question: “*Dad, I’m thinking about it — how are you thinking about it?*” — not an announcement, not a demand — leading to a mutually acceptable outcome with both parents’ blessing.

Strengths (self-described). Preserves purity; forms sons for provision and daughters for household piety; enables meaningful family and ministry work through the young-adult years; resists the fragmentation of modern life; treats leaving as principled and covenantal rather than reflexive; provides ongoing accountability at an age when formation is not yet complete.

Challenges (some acknowledged by proponents, some pressed by the paper’s own analysis).

Requires wise, humble parents. In less-than-ideal households the prudential-covering arrangement can drift toward control rather than covering, and the honest 1a proponent has less external check than a 1b account (which posits a defined authority structure) provides against that drift. Depends on a supportive church culture. Leaves adult daughters exposed when a father is unfit, and 1a’s prudential framing offers only informal remedy for that case. Correlated in some circles with delayed marriage and frustration among adult unmarried women, particularly daughters, when household-piety expectations do not match the household’s actual marriage-pipeline realities. Requires an account of what constitutes a “principled exception” to the household-continuity pattern (vocational call, ministry opportunity, family need) that is disciplined enough to be distinguishable from mere preference; the more moderate NCFIC voices (Brown, Dohm, Walker) develop this carefully, but the distinction is easier to state than to apply. Brown and Dohm concede that their podcast has “only opened the door” on the hardest cases — parents recovering from earlier mistakes, adult children already living independently. First-person testimony from women who describe the *harder* form of the teaching (the 1b / Umbrella pattern of the IBLP and Vision Forum orbits) is substantial and important, but properly belongs to §4.1b’s Reality-leg discussion of the systematic form, not here; readers should not collapse the two, and testimony against the harder form is not by itself testimony against the moderate 1a prudential-pattern position (see §4.1b Challenges and §B.1 for the harder-form material). These Challenges are also only one half of the Reality leg: the affirmative half — Old Order Anabaptist adult-retention findings, the mixed-but-real Cardus homeschool-formation data, and the Catholic household-catechesis correlations, together with a note on why critical memoirs structurally outnumber affirmative ones — is collected at §B.3.5, and a fair reading of this view weighs both halves.

4.1b Continuous Doctrinal Authority

Description. A distinct, systematic form of the continuing authority intuition, articulated as a doctrine rather than as a prudential counsel: *the adult unmarried believer stands under a defined and continuing human authority as a matter of theological necessity, not merely of wisdom.* For the unmarried adult, that authority is ordinarily the biological father; where the father is absent, unbelieving, or the adult child is called out, the authority is understood to transfer to a church elder, a spiritual overseer, or an ecclesial superior (abbot, spiritual director). The doctrine addresses both sons and daughters, though its most visible applications concern daughters because of

the marriage-transfer element.

The claim is *systematic* in that it does not merely commend the household as the wisest arrangement (that is §4.1a) but reads the Haustafel passages — Eph. 6:1-3, Col. 3:20, Ex. 20:12, Matt. 15:4-6 — as ordering a *continuing* relation of parental authority and filial obedience that does not terminate at legal majority or household departure alone. That additional theological claim is what distinguishes View 1b from View 1a.

The crux, stated in the paper’s vocabulary. In the four-sense framework of §1.1.1, senses (2), (3), and (4) — formative office, parental counsel, and priestly intercession — are common ground across all four views. The precise point on which View 1b divides from Views 1a, 2a, and 2b is whether *sense (1) — directive authority in the moment* — extends through the whole of unmarried adult life or is bounded to the years of household formation. View 1b answers *yes*: sense (1) continues, in the ordinary case, as long as the unmarried state continues and only its holder shifts (from father to husband) at marriage. Views 1a, 2a, and 2b answer *no*: sense (1) is bounded to the pre-adult years, and the honor that remains after that boundary is carried by senses (2), (3), and (4), not by sense (1). Everything below in §4.1b is the strongest form of the affirmative answer.

Theological genealogy. Continuous-authority readings of the Haustafel and the fifth commandment are older than any modern movement and were not first devised in the twentieth century. Readers arrive at the view by several distinct routes:

- *Puritan household religion — the worship-continuation stream.*
Matthew Henry’s *A Church in the House* (1704) and Cotton Mather’s *Cares about the Nurseries* (1702) treat the Christian family as a “little church” ordered around daily worship, catechesis, and Scripture reading led by the head of household — the pattern this position inherits at the level of *household worship* rather than of continuing directive authority (Henry and Mather do not themselves extend directive authority past adulthood). The authority-continuation reading requires the further step of William Gouge’s *Of Domesticall Duties* (1622) and its under-government / freed-from-it distinction; whether Gouge’s continuing “honour” and marriage-consent duty for the freed child amounts to a continuing directive authority in the sense Views 1a and 1b divide over is exactly the question §1.2.1 presses. The primary-source examination of all four witnesses — Henry, Mather, Gouge, Baxter — with the passages quoted in full, is §B.1.6-B.1.7.

- *Reformed household-covenant theology.* The Westminster tradition's reading of the fifth commandment (Larger Catechism Q. 123-133) treats the parent-child duties as ongoing categories, not as age-terminated ones, and reads the whole Haustafel through federal-covenant categories in which the household head bears ongoing responsibility for those *within* his household. Readers in this stream can hold a continuous-authority position without any reference to Nee, Gothard, or twentieth-century American patriarchy movements.
- *Catholic teaching on the paternal role.* The Roman Catholic tradition — from the *Rituale Romanum* through the twentieth-century papal encyclicals on the family (Leo XIII *Arcanum* 1880; Pius XI *Casti Connubii* 1930; John Paul II *Familiaris Consortio* 1981) — articulates a continuing paternal responsibility for the formation of adult unmarried children and for weighty counsel at the threshold of marriage: *Casti Connubii* §115 directs children about to marry to “ask the prudent advice of their parents with regard to the partner,” and to “regard this advice in no light manner.” These documents also make free consent constitutive of valid marriage — so the Catholic tradition here overlaps with the continuous-authority reading at the level of counsel and formation, not at the level of parental arrangement of adult children's marriages.
- *Anabaptist family-integrated practice.* Old-Order Amish and conservative Mennonite communities embed the adult unmarried child in the paternal household and community-of-formation as the ordinary shape of Christian life, grounded in the Haustafel and the fifth commandment rather than in any modern doctrinal formulation. (The doctrinal locus is the *practice* itself as documented ethnographically at §B.3.5, not a specific magisterial text: Menno Simons's 1539 *Foundation Book* is scoped to baptism, the Supper, and separation from the world rather than to household order; the tract *How Pious Parents Should Train Their Children*, added to the 1558 enlarged edition, addresses pre-adult training.)
- *Independent exegesis of the Haustafel.* Some readers reach the continuous-authority reading simply by refusing the age-bounding argument developed at §1.2.1 — reading *tekna* in Eph. 6:1 as extending to any child of the household, and reading the present imperative *hypakouete* as commanding continuing obedience within that scope, without commitment to any of the historical streams above.

Twentieth-century movements — Watchman Nee's *Spiritual Authority* (1948/1972), the Shepherding Movement (Fort Lauderdale, 1966-1989), Bill Gothard's “Umbrella of Protection” teaching at the Insti-

tute in Basic Life Principles (1961-present), and Doug Phillips’s Vision Forum with its *Tenets of Biblical Patriarchy* (1998-2014) — are *some* of the modern advocates of continuous-authority readings; they are neither the origin of the position nor its defining shape. The umbrella / covering vocabulary is a distinctive twentieth-century articulation of the older intuition, and it carries theological commitments (delegated authority, spiritual protection through structural coverage) that are separable from the underlying continuous-authority reading of the Haustafel. Appendix B.1 treats the historical genealogy in detail, including primary-source quotations, the twentieth-century movements as one branch, and the documented Reality-leg data bearing on those movements’ applications.

A note on the current systematic carriers. In preparing this chapter the author searched, in print and online, for currently active systematic defenses of the covering doctrine in the same register as Nee, Gothard, or Phillips. The finding — four current carriers of different types (Einwechter’s exegetical essay on the daughters-form, Living Stream Ministry’s continuation of Nee, Gothard *Life Notebook* material in IBLP-attender networks, and Wilson’s daughters-component argument inside a covering-doctrine-refusing frame), together with the boundary-case practitioners and the notes a reader is entitled to — is set out in full at **§B.1.8 (Current Carriers and Adjacent Voices)**, so that this section’s steel-man can proceed uninterrupted.

Biblical arguments cited (by proponents).

- **Hebrews 13:17** — “Obey them that have the rule over you, and submit yourselves: for they watch for your souls, as they that must give account, that they may do it with joy, and not with grief: for that is unprofitable for you.” Read as establishing a general duty of submission to ordained human authority whose breach is spiritually “unprofitable.”
- **1 Peter 5:5** — “Likewise, ye younger, submit yourselves unto the elder. Yea, all of you be subject one to another, and be clothed with humility.” Read as extending the elder/younger submission structure across the whole life of the church.
- **1 Corinthians 11:3** — “But I would have you know, that the head of every man is Christ; and the head of the woman is the man; and the head of Christ is God.” Read as establishing a metaphysical chain of headship into which every believer is incorporated.
- **Numbers 30:3-5** — the paternal veto over an unmarried daughter’s vow, read as a *settled ongoing category* rather than as youth-in-the-father’s-house alone. This is the strongest text for continuing paternal authority over adult daughters, and is treated at length in Chapter 1.

- **Genesis 27:43-28:7** — Rebekah’s directive to grown Jacob, “my son, obey my voice; arise, flee thou to Laban my brother” (27:43), followed by Isaac’s marriage-charge (28:1-2), with the narrator’s summary “Jacob obeyed his father and his mother” (28:7). Read as a narrative picture of directive parental authority over an adult son operating at the marriage seam. (On the Greek of 27:43 see the note at §1.2.1 Consideration 1: the LXX imperative there is the simplex ἀκούω, with ὑπάκουσον at 27:13.)
- **Romans 13:1-7** — “the powers that be are ordained of God” — read as the general principle behind all human authority, including paternal and ecclesial.
- **Ephesians 5:22-24** — extended from the wife-husband relation to a general principle of layered submission.
- **Matthew 8:5-13** — the Roman centurion’s “chain of command,” used by Gothard as an analogy for the divine ordering of human authority.
- **1 Samuel 15:23** — “rebellion is as the sin of witchcraft” — read as identifying the *spiritual* seriousness of breaking covering.
- **Jeremiah 35 — the Rechabites.** Adult descendants of Jonadab son of Rechab keep their forefather’s multigenerational commandment (abstain from wine, from house-building, from settled agriculture) across the generations, and Yahweh commends them in explicit contrast to faithless Judah: “the words of Jonadab the son of Rechab, that he commanded his sons not to drink wine, are performed... but this people hath not hearkened unto me” (Jer. 35:14, 16). Read as proof-text for the principle that a father’s binding commands run down the generations into adult descendants and receive divine approval when kept — a standing 1b/umbrella citation, particularly in Gothard’s Institute in Basic Life Principles material.

Central lines of argument.

- *The systematic authority claim.* Every believer stands under some human authority by divine appointment. Being *uncovered* is not a neutral condition but a spiritually dangerous one. This is presented as the strongest distinctive claim of the view: it offers the unmarried adult a clear answer to the question “under whose authority are you?” that neither 1a, 2a, nor 2b fully supply.
- *Protection of daughters as the paradigm case.* The unbroken chain — father, then husband, then church — is presented as God’s design for female flourishing, illustrated from John 19:26-27 where Christ arranges Mary’s continuing covering with the beloved disciple.
- *Convergent witness across traditions.* Proponents note that the same “always under authority” pattern surfaces in Catholic religious obedience, Orthodox eldership, charismatic shepherding,

and Reformed household government — arguing that this convergence itself indicates a real biblical shape, even if the particular modern articulations have failed.

- *Obedience to imperfect authority*. Drawing on Nee, proponents argue that the disciple is responsible only for his obedience, not for the delegated authority's judgment; God will hold the authority accountable for erroneous commands. This is the view's strongest pastoral offer to the anxious conscience.

Sons. A son remains under his father's authority as the ordinary case, with transfer to another authority (military, apprenticeship, seminary, church eldership) as the accepted alternative. Direct autonomous departure — leaving to "be his own man" — is understood as breaking covering.

Daughters. A daughter remains under her father's authority until her father transfers her to a husband. In the absence of an eligible father or a marriage, the church elder assumes the covering role. Daughters are not envisioned as living independently or under only their own conscience.

Strengths (self-described). Offers a clear, systematic answer to the question of adult authority that neither §4.1a, §4.2a, nor §4.2b explicitly supply. Takes seriously the New Testament texts on submission (Heb. 13:17; 1 Pet. 5:5; Rom. 13; Eph. 5) as *structural* rather than merely occasional. Protects daughters through a defined chain of covering. Provides the anxious conscience with a settled locus of authority. Converges with elements of Catholic, Orthodox, Reformed, and charismatic tradition on the reality of ordained human authority.

Challenges (widely observed, some acknowledged by proponents).

- *Exegetical*. View 1a's exegetical challenges to 1b (§1.2.1) are the primary counter-case: the age-scope of *tekna*, the semantic range of *hypakouete* vs. *timaō*, and the residence-bounded reading of the Haustafel. 1b readers reply that the age-bounding case is cumulative, not decisive, and that the New Testament's silence about a specific age of release should not be read as release itself (see §1.2.1 for the exchange). Beyond the Haustafel, additional texts sometimes cited — Heb. 13:17, 1 Pet. 5:5, 1 Cor. 11:3 — do more work in one systematic articulation (the umbrella / covering doctrine) than in the older streams, which rest the case principally on the fifth commandment and the Haustafel themselves. The Rechabites (Jer. 35) receive an analogous treatment on the counter-side: the ordinary Hebrew-Bible scholarship on the passage — Holladay (*Jeremiah 2*, Hermeneia, pp. 246-52), Lundbom (*Jeremiah 21-36*, AB 21B, pp. 571-90), and McKane

(*Jeremiah II*, ICC, pp. 878-92) — reads Yahweh’s commendation as a *contrast device*: the point is not that Jonadab’s rule is a template for perpetual paternal command, but that a clan-vow (nazirite-adjacent, ascetic, community-of- origin identity) kept faithfully by descendants shames Judah’s breach of covenant with the living God. On this reading the Rechabites function as Jer. 35’s Judah does in the Jonah-of- Nineveh function — Gentile or marginal fidelity exposing Israel’s infidelity — and the text is silent on whether Jonadab’s standing to bind his descendants was ordinary paternal command or the founder-authority of a distinctive clan-vow (Fretheim, *Jeremiah*, SHBC, pp. 494-99). Both readings sit in the literature; the paper does not adjudicate between them.

- *Historical*. The strongest historical version of the position rests on the older streams (Puritan household religion, Reformed household covenant, Catholic paternal role, Anabaptist family-integrated practice) rather than on twentieth-century reconstructions. Where a modern articulation claims to *recover* the older streams while introducing distinctive vocabulary (umbrella, covering, delegated authority) not found in the primary sources, the recovery framing is contested; the underlying continuous-authority reading is not thereby weakened (see §B.1.7 for the primary-source treatment). Separately, where the historical case rests on a claim that pre-industrial Christian households routinely kept adult unmarried children under continuous paternal authority until marriage, the empirical picture is more textured than that summary suggests: under the Northwest European Marriage Pattern documented by Hajnal, Kussmaul, and Morgan, a large fraction of adolescents and young adults spent the years between roughly fourteen and marriage in *another* household as servants-in-husbandry, apprentices, or live-in students, under the authority of that household’s head rather than their biological father (see §B.2.1). This does not refute the continuous-authority reading of the Haustafel; it does refute the specific historical claim that the pre-industrial norm was uninterrupted residence under the biological father until marriage.
- *Pastoral*. Where the delegated authority is unwise, unbelieving, or abusive, a pastoral counsel to “obey the authority; God will judge him” can produce grave harm. Proponents in every stream accept this in principle (obey God rather than men, Acts 5:29), and the older streams tend to develop the criteria for departure more fully than the twentieth-century movements did.
- *Structural*. Where the position names a defined transferring authority (father → husband, or father → church elder), the practical mechanics of the transfer to elder — is she under a specific elder? the whole session? the pastor personally? —

are articulated with varying degrees of specificity across the streams.

- *Reality-leg data on one modern application.* Documented failures of authority in the twentieth-century umbrella-doctrine movements are part of the Reality leg of the SCAR quadrilateral and cannot be silently omitted, but they enter the argument as *data checked against one modern application*, not as a refutation of the underlying continuous-authority reading. The Shepherd Movement leaders publicly repented of authoritarian abuses (see §B.1.2); Bill Gothard resigned in 2014 amid allegations from 34 women; Doug Phillips resigned in 2013 with a subsequent civil suit alleging predatory grooming; R.C. Sproul Jr., then an influential family-integrated-church voice (§B.1.5), was deposed in 2006 for “abuse of authority in an inexcusable manner.” First-person testimony from women raised inside the pattern is also part of this Reality-leg data: an anonymized contributor at Recovering Grace, writing under the initials L.J., describes obeying her parents’ preference against her own judgment at nineteen (“I thought if I didn’t marry him, I’d end up an old maid”; the parent-approved marriage subsequently ended in divorce — “Sorry, Mom and Dad. We DO Have Regrets,” *recoveringgrace.org*, January 2015); Cait West, raised as a stay-at-home daughter, treats the same pattern from the inside in *Rift: A Memoir of Breaking Away from Christian Patriarchy* (Eerdmans, 2024). Faithful 1b readers distinguish *the doctrine* from *the idolatry the doctrine can drift into* — what §5.5 names as the Clutch, in which continuing authority becomes control that refuses release even where release is scripturally warranted. Naming the failure mode is not naming the doctrine; the older streams themselves developed pastoral checks against precisely this drift, and the twentieth-century scandals and first-person accounts bear more heavily on the applications that did not carry those checks than on the underlying reading of the Haustafel. The Reality leg is also not exhausted by the failure data: the positive-outcome evidence for household-continuity communities, and the note on why affirmative first-person testimony is structurally under-produced relative to critical memoir, are collected at §B.3.5 and belong in the same weighing.

Comparison with §4.1a. Views 1a and 1b share the same practical outputs — the adult child remains in the household, the daughter especially is protected, the transition to marriage is covenantal. They diverge on the theological *reason*: 1a offers a prudential and formative account (this is the wisest arrangement); 1b offers a systematic doctrinal account (this is required for spiritual safety). A family may live 1a’s practical shape without holding 1b’s doctrinal claim, and

this is in fact the position of the more moderate NCFIC voices (Brown, Dohm, Walker) even where they sound similar rhetorically. The distinction matters most in edge cases — an unfit father, a genuine vocational call outside the household, a daughter’s independent conversion — where 1a can release the child and 1b cannot, without abandoning its distinctive claim.

Note on Plymouth Brethren and dispensationalist writers. These communities and voices are sometimes assumed to share 4.1b, but the picture is more complex — the Exclusive Brethren practice a community-separation discipline that is its own category, while the American dispensational commentators, where they engaged Ephesians 6:1 at all, tended toward the age-limited reading. The full note is at **§B.1.8**.

4.2 Launched at Adulthood — Two Sub-Positions

Views 4.2a and 4.2b share the outward practice of launching the adult child from the paternal household at or near legal adulthood, but they differ in the theological account they give of what “launched” means. 4.2a treats launching as a *prudential shift of mode* — from directive parenting to advisory-and-honoring relationship — with adult children remaining bound by honor, by counsel-seeking, and by the moral law. 4.2b treats launching as a *covenantal release under continuing intercession* — the adult child is answerable directly to Christ, the parent’s continuing office is priestly rather than directive, and the released child is watched-for in prayer on the Prodigal-Father model (Luke 15). Both positions distinguish themselves sharply from a third option sometimes conflated with them: the “*whatever you want*” posture that treats adult autonomy as absolute and parental honor as optional. That third option is not a faithful view; it is the *Abandonment* failure mode into which either 2a or 2b can drift, and it is treated at **§5.5**. The two faithful sub-positions are treated separately so each can be assessed on its own claims.

4.2a Prudential Launching (Continuing Honor Without Continuing Directive Authority)

Description. At or near legal adulthood (in the US, age 18), the adult child is launched — typically to college, a job, and independent housing. Parents remain advisors and providers as needed, and the honor commandment continues to bind the adult child; formal directive authority ends, but relational obligation does not. Sons and daughters are treated identically or nearly so.

The age-18 threshold in this pattern is not merely inherited from the

parachurch counsel surveyed below; it tracks a concrete legal cliff. Every US state imposes on parents an enforceable duty to provide food, shelter, clothing, medical care, and education for a minor child, with failure punishable under state child-neglect and non-support statutes. The age at which this duty ends is 18 in most states, 19 in Alabama and Nebraska, and up to 21 for support purposes in a handful of others (Mississippi historically; New York, Massachusetts, Illinois, Iowa, and New Jersey allow courts to order continued support through college in divorce cases). “Launched at 18,” therefore, is at minimum the position where the state’s mandatory-provision floor drops out — a point around which any pastoral counsel about launching or continuing has to be constructed, whichever view is held.

Major modern voices (not the only voices, but influential ones).

Focus on the Family (James Dobson, *Bringing Up Boys*, *Bringing Up Girls*; ongoing Focus on the Family counsel on adult children and “letting them go”); Gary Chapman on launching adult children; the counsel typical of many American parachurch youth ministries and the “college transition” genre. These voices do not teach that authority ends abruptly at 18 — Dobson’s own writings warn against the extremes of hovering and abandonment alike — but that the *mode* shifts decisively from directive parenting to advisory-and-honoring relationship, with the adult child ordinarily launching into independent housing, college, or vocation. This counsel is one significant strand of American evangelical practice; it is not the only strand, and Reformed, Presbyterian, Baptist, and charismatic communities each articulate their own accents on the same general pattern. The historical origins of this pattern — pre-industrial household norms, the GI Bill (1944), postwar suburbanization, Erikson’s identity-formation psychology (1950), Focus on the Family (1977), and Arnett’s “emerging adulthood” (2000) — are traced in **Appendix B.2**.

Biblical arguments cited. Genesis 2:24 as establishing that leaving is proper to the marriage seam, with pre-marital leaving warranted by calling — a warrant proponents hold is ordinarily present in vocation itself (cf. §1.3.1’s closing paragraphs); the shift from ὑπακούω to τιμάω in Ephesians 6; the New Testament silence on continuing paternal legal authority; the pattern of Acts (adult believers making independent vocational decisions); 1 Corinthians 7:32-34 (the unmarried are directly concerned with the Lord’s things); and the Thessalonian work-commands — “to do your own business, and to work with your own hands ... that ye may have lack of nothing” (1 Thess. 4:11-12) and “if any would not work, neither should he eat” (2 Thess. 3:10, with the busybody correction of vv. 11-12) — read by proponents as addressing each adult believer’s own economic responsibility before the Lord.

Sons. Launched to college, military, work, or gap year. Ordinary American cultural pattern.

Daughters. Same. Distinction between sons and daughters is either minimal or absent.

Strengths (self-described). Consistent with New Testament silence on continuing legal paternal authority; respects the maturity and Spirit-gifting of adult believers; enables adult children to obey Christ directly; supports vocational calling; leaves room for the adult child to marry, take a vocation, or move geographically without requiring parental veto.

Challenges (raised by critics, several from within the pattern itself). In practice can slide toward the *Abandonment* failure mode (§5.5) — that is, from a prudential shift of mode into a de facto claim of autonomy — with attendant disintegration of household piety, exposure of young adults to spiritual and moral shipwreck at ages when their formation is incomplete, and the loss of parents as ongoing shapers of adult life. Delayed marriage in this pattern is often paired with extended sexual and spiritual struggle. The secular career-track literature (Hewlett 2002, Gottlieb 2008/2010, Bolick 2015, Traister 2016, and US Census median-age-at-first-marriage data) documents the same delayed- marriage-and-frustration cohort arriving by the opposite route from the one §4.1a Challenges records; the pattern is treated comparatively in **Appendix B.2.7**. Critics also cite Proverbs 18:1 (“He that separateth himself seeketh his own desire, and intermeddleth with all wisdom”), Proverbs 27:8 (“As a bird that wandereth from her nest, so is a man that wandereth from his place”), and the refrain of Judges (“every man did that which was right in his own eyes,” Judg. 21:25; cf. 17:6) as texts that describe the drift 4.2a is alleged to enable, even where 4.2a itself does not sanction the drift.

4.2b Release with Prayer — the Prodigal-Father Posture

Description. The adult child is released from directive parental authority into direct answerability to Christ, but the release is *with* prayer, not *from* prayer. The parent’s continuing office is not directive but *priestly* — to bring the adult child to Christ in intercession, to speak the covenantal word clearly at the seam, to watch for return, and to withhold the false comfort of pretending that departure has cost nothing. In the vocabulary of §1.1.1, this view foregrounds *sense (4) of authority* — the priestly office of the parent, which every faithful view affirms as lifelong — as the mode in which the parent-child relation is chiefly carried after sense (1) has released. Sense (2) formative office and sense (3) counsel continue; sense (1) directive authority is released; sense (4) intercession is intensified. What §5.0

develops as the biblical pattern of the *parent's* posture is at core an anatomy of sense (4). In practical shape this converges with §4.2a (launching), but its theological account is different: where 2a offers a prudential mode-shift, 2b offers a covenantal release modeled on the Father of the parable (Luke 15:11-32) and on God's own posture toward His adult-son people in Hosea 11.

Biblical arguments cited.

- *The Prodigal Father* (Luke 15:11-32). The father grants the younger son's premature request for his share, does not restrain the departure, watches the road, and receives him back running. The parable is read as revealing the Father's own posture toward the adult child who insists on his way — release, wait, and restore. (On the parable's *prescriptive* weight see the note at §5.0.1 and §5.3 on the difference between what the parable *describes* and what it *commends*.)
- *Hosea 11*. God's self-description as the Father who releases His adult-son people to their Baal-worship and aches to restore is the Old Testament ground on which Jesus builds Luke 15.
- *Peter's restoration* (Luke 22:31-32; John 21). Jesus foretells Peter's denial, does not restrain it, prays for restoration on the far side, and receives Peter back through the threefold "feed my sheep." The Son practices Prodigal-Father posture toward His disciple.
- *Samson's parents* (Judg. 14). The narrator identifies the compliance-under-covenantal-objection of Samson's parents as the setting for God's providential work: "it was of the LORD" (Judg. 14:4). Release does not obstruct providence; it is one of the means through which providence works.
- *Priority of Christ* (Matt. 10:37; Luke 14:26). Adult believers answer directly to God; every human tie is subordinated to allegiance to Christ. The parent's role at the seam is to make space for that direct answerability, not to mediate it.

Sons. Released into direct answerability to Christ under continuing parental intercession and covenantal counsel; free to receive or decline that counsel.

Daughters. Same, with the additional pastoral concern that release does not become abandonment in a fallen world (see §5.5).

Strengths (self-described). Preserves adult agency under Christ and the parent's continuing intercessory office. Speaks the covenantal word clearly, releases the adult child to their decision, does not withdraw love, watches for return. Consistent with the New Testament's direct address of adult believers; consistent with the freedom of conscience that Reformation traditions defend. Refuses both au-

thoritarian control and pretending-nothing-happened; models the Father's posture in the parable rather than the elder brother's resentment or the younger brother's autonomy-as-absolute.

Challenges.

- *The prescriptive-vs-descriptive question about the parable.* Luke 15 depicts a father who releases; whether it *commends* release in every case or only *describes* one father's posture toward one son's departure is a real question (see §5.0.1).
- *The drift into the Abandonment.* The release-with-prayer posture drifts, where prayer weakens and covenantal speech goes unspoken, into the *Abandonment* failure mode treated at §5.5 — release without intercession, launched-and-ignored, “whatever you want” as the whole of the parental office. Faithful 2b names this drift as the failure mode it is; it is not the doctrine.
- *The classical restrain-texts, cited against the drift.* Scripture itself warns the parent whose posture becomes indistinguishable from Abandonment (1 Sam. 3:13, quoted in full at §5.0.1): “his sons made themselves vile, and he restrained them not” (1 Sam. 3:13, of Eli — the LORD's specific charge against a priest-father who watched his adult sons dishonor Him and did not intervene); “the rod and reproof give wisdom: but a child left to himself bringeth his mother to shame” (Prov. 29:15). These texts sit uneasily with any release posture that collapses into non-engagement. Faithful 2b — release *with* prayer and *with* clear covenantal speech — is not what Eli did; Eli released *without* covenantal confrontation, and the text names that as failure. The restrain-texts therefore bear on the Abandonment drift rather than on 2b itself; but the point stands that Scripture does record a category of parental non-restraint as sin, and any account of 2b that does not distinguish itself from that category is under-specified. Even where 2b itself does not sanction the drift, these texts train the reader in the discernment.
- *Empirical concerns bearing more heavily on the drift than on the view.* Christian Smith's NSYR studies (*Souls in Transition*, 2009; *Lost in Transition*, 2011) describe most American emerging adults as functionally shaped by “moralistic therapeutic deism” and by the priority of self-determination over inherited authority — a picture that bears on households drifting into the Abandonment. Even secular developmental psychology documents costs of the Arnett-defined “emerging adulthood” pattern (delayed marriage, delayed household formation, deferred vocational consolidation, increased mental-health morbidity; see Twenge, *iGen*, 2017). Faithful 2b, released *with* prayer and covenantal counsel, is not the pattern those studies describe; the drift is. The empirical literature is treated in **Appendix B.3**; the Abandonment

drift itself at §5.5.

Representative published works. The closest thing to a book-length first-person embodiment of the posture is Ruth Bell Graham, *Prodigals and Those Who Love Them* (Focus on the Family, 1991) — a mother of prodigal sons assembling her own poems and diary entries with anthologized prodigal accounts. Her summary of the parent’s bounded office is the posture in miniature: “We mothers must take care of the possible and trust God for the impossible... We cannot convict of sin, create hunger and thirst after God, or convert” (p. 101; the fuller passage is quoted at §5.4). The Prodigal-Father posture is developed pastorally in Timothy Keller, *The Prodigal God: Recovering the Heart of the Christian Faith* (2008), which recovers the parable’s double critique of both younger-brother rebellion and elder-brother resentment; and in Keller, *Counterfeit Gods* (2009), which treats “good things become gods” as the pathology that afflicts even household piety. John Piper, *Desiring God: Meditations of a Christian Hedonist* (1986, rev. ed. 2011), grounds the intercessory-and-releasing posture in the pursuit of joy in Christ that no household arrangement can guarantee. Elisabeth Elliot, *Let Me Be a Woman* (1976) and *The Mark of a Man* (1981), articulates the lived posture of adult submission-to-God-first from the perspective of the released adult child (the daughter- and son- facing books, respectively). The Release-with-Prayer posture as this paper articulates it is assembled from these works’ pastoral theology — Graham on the parent’s possible-and-impossible division, Keller on the Prodigal Father, Piper on Christ as the soul’s chief joy, Elliot on the released adult child before God — rather than derived from any single book-length systematic advocacy of 2b as a discrete arrangement. That the systematic form lives partly in the paper’s own synthesis is a limitation the reader should hold in view; the pastoral literature carrying the posture is real and cited, but a work titled *A Theology of Release with Prayer* is not part of the current evangelical catalogue.

4.3 Consecrated Singleness in Community

Description. The unmarried adult child joins a formal or informal consecrated community — a Catholic or Orthodox religious order, a Protestant intentional community, a mission society, a monastic tradition, or a lay covenanted household. The community, not the paternal household, becomes the primary sphere of daily life. Parental honor and care continue.

Biblical arguments cited. 1 Corinthians 7:32-34 (the unmarried care for the Lord’s things); Matthew 19:12 (eunuchs for the kingdom); Acts 21:8-9 (Philip’s daughters); the Christocentric texts on kingdom

priority (Matt. 10:37; Luke 14:26); the antique pattern of consecrated virginity (Justin, Athenagoras, Cyprian, Methodius).

Sons. Enter religious life, mission, or a formal celibate calling. Common in Catholic and Orthodox traditions; less common but present in Protestantism.

Daughters. Enter religious life or consecrated single service. Same broad pattern.

4.3.1 The Catholic Formulation

The Roman Catholic tradition articulates a coherent theology of the parent-adult-child relation in which two categories interlock: **filial piety** and **vocational discernment**.

Filial piety. The Catechism of the Catholic Church (2212-2220) teaches that “the fourth commandment illuminates other relationships in society” and that “as long as a child lives at home with his parents, the child should obey his parents in all that they ask of him when it is for his good or that of the family. However, if a child is convinced in conscience that it would be morally wrong to obey a particular order, he must not do so” (CCC 2217). Regarding adult children:

“As they grow up, children should continue to respect their parents. They should anticipate their wishes, willingly seek their advice, and accept their just admonitions. Obedience toward parents ceases with the emancipation of the children; not so respect, which is always owed to them.” (CCC 2217)

The distinction between obedience (which ends at emancipation) and respect / honor (which continues lifelong) directly parallels the Ephesians 6 shift from ὑπακούω to τιμᾶω identified in Chapter 1.

Vocational discernment. Catholic teaching frames the young adult’s transition primarily as *discernment of state of life* — marriage, priesthood, consecrated life, or single life in the world (CCC 1533-1535; *Vocations to the Priesthood and Religious Life*, various magisterial documents). Parents’ role at this seam is to form the conscience, pray, counsel, and consent — never to coerce the choice of state. The Council of Trent (Session 24, *Tametsi* decree, Ch. I) explicitly condemned any doctrine that a marriage contracted by children without parental consent is thereby invalid; canon law today (canon 1058) states simply that “all persons who are not prohibited by law can contract marriage.”

Marriage form. The Catholic canonical form (canon 1108) requires

that marriage be contracted before the local ordinary or parish priest and two witnesses — an ecclesial requirement that parallels Ignatius's *To Polycarp* 5:2. Parental consent is *strongly urged* but is not canonically required for validity in adulthood, since Trent.

Bearing. The Catholic tradition holds together, in a way that few Protestant expressions do, both the *ongoing honor* of parents and the *primacy of vocation to Christ*. The son or daughter entering a seminary or religious novitiate literally leaves the paternal household under ecclesial authority — a direct modern instantiation of vocational household transfer.

4.3.2 The Orthodox Formulation

The Eastern Orthodox tradition emphasizes similar themes with different accents.

Spiritual fatherhood. Orthodox pastoral care assumes that the young adult, particularly at major life-transitions, will place himself or herself under the direction of a spiritual father (γέρον) — often a monastic elder. This is understood not as replacing paternal honor but as *complementing* it. The natural father and the spiritual father exercise different offices; both are honored.

The monastic paradigm. Monastic departure (to Mt. Athos, to a convent) is treated as a costly but blessed calling. The rites of tonsure (from Latin *tonsura*, “a shearing” — the ritual cutting or shaving of hair marking entry into religious life, in Orthodox practice conferred in three grades: Rassaphore, Stavrophore, and the Great Schema) themselves reference the leaving of father and mother for Christ (echoing Matt. 19:29). Parental blessing is sought; parental consent is expected; but a genuine calling is not to be denied. The practice preserves the tension that Christ's own sayings hold (Matt. 10:37; Luke 14:26).

Marriage as sacrament. Orthodox marriage is celebrated in the church with the blessing of both families in view — the crowning ceremony assumes familial and ecclesial witness. The pre-marital process (in most jurisdictions) includes both the priest and the families. Marriage is neither a private contract nor a purely familial arrangement; it is an ecclesial-sacramental act with familial context.

Bearing. The Orthodox tradition provides a living witness — with continuous practice from the pre-Nicene era — that consecrated singleness in community and household-blessed marriage can coexist as honored paths, both mediated by the church.

A note on the ordinary lay unmarried Catholic or Orthodox adult. The consecrated-singleness paradigm treated in §4.3.1 and §4.3.2 is the

paradigmatic Catholic and Orthodox answer to the unmarried life, but it does not describe the ordinary case. Most unmarried lay Catholics and Orthodox are neither monastic nor formally consecrated (as a virgin under Canon 604, a member of a secular institute, a professed third-order, or an oblate). What does the tradition say about *them*?

The honest answer is: neither Catholic nor Orthodox teaching treats lay singleness as a distinct vocational state parallel to marriage or consecrated life. The Catechism addresses lay singles only briefly, at CCC 1658, and frames the condition as a *circumstance* deserving pastoral solicitude rather than a state of life: “We must also remember the great number of single persons who, because of the particular circumstances in which they have to live — often not of their own choosing — are especially close to Jesus’ heart and therefore deserve the special affection and active solicitude of the Church, particularly of pastors.” John Paul II’s *Christifideles Laici* (1988) affirms the universal call to holiness (§16) and treats the lay secular character as realized “in marriage or the celibate life, in a family, in a profession” (§15) — again without carving out lay singleness as a discrete third state. The Code of Canon Law’s treatment of consecrated life (canons 573-606) contains no canon addressing non-consecrated lay unmarried persons; canon 604 reserves the “consecrated virgin in the world” for those formally consecrated by the diocesan bishop through the approved liturgical rite. Contemporary Catholic writers acknowledge the result frankly: lay singles are often “in a vocational limbo of sorts” because the tradition has not carved out a distinct name for their state (*Catholic World Report*, “Is the Single Life a Vocation? Maybe We’re Asking the Wrong Question,” 20 July 2017).

The Orthodox picture is similar. Fr. Thomas Hopko, in the OCA *Resource Handbook for Lay Ministries* (“Finding One’s Calling in Life”), frames singleness as one *mode* of the single universal vocation to sanctification, not a distinct third state: “Some will sanctify their lives being married; others will be single. Some will do it in clerical orders; others as lay people. Some will be monastic; most will live in the everyday secular world.” The ordinary lay unmarried Orthodox adult is treated under the general framework of parish life, spiritual direction, and vocational discernment, without a separate canonical category.

How this maps onto the SCAR views. The ordinary lay unmarried Catholic or Orthodox young adult does not constitute an additional View. In practice, they default into an existing pattern with a *sacramental and vocational overlay* that Protestant formulations of the same patterns typically lack:

- **In traditional Catholic and Orthodox cultures** (Italy, Spain, Greece, Poland, Ireland, Russia, Latin America, and their di-

aspora), the pattern is §4.4 — multigenerational household as cultural norm — under an ecclesial overlay of parish life, active vocational discernment, regular confession and Eucharist, and (in Orthodox practice especially) direction by a spiritual father. Eurostat’s 2024 data records the empirical shape starkly: the average age of leaving the parental home is 30.7 in Greece, 30.1 in Italy, and 30.0 in Spain, against an EU average of 26.2; the share of 25-34-year-olds still living with parents is roughly 54 percent in Greece, 50 percent in Italy, and 48 percent in Spain, against about 30 percent EU average (“When do young people in the EU leave home?”, Eurostat news ddn-20250923-1, September 2025).

- **In modernizing / Anglo Catholic and Orthodox-diaspora contexts** (American Catholic, urban European, Orthodox diaspora), the pattern approximates §4.2a — prudential launching with parents in an advisory role — but again with the same sacramental and vocational overlay: the parish priest and spiritual director provide ongoing structure that the Protestant §4.2a does not supply, and vocational discernment remains an active category even in the launched adult’s life.

Neither pattern makes lay singleness a distinct View. The *ecclesial-and-sacramental overlay* is the distinctively Catholic and Orthodox contribution; the underlying household pattern is one of the ones already treated in this chapter. Naming this explicitly avoids overtaxonomizing what is already handled elsewhere, and it names the real reason a practicing Catholic or Orthodox family in Rome or Athens looks very different from one in Michigan even where the theology is substantially the same.

Strengths (self-described, both Catholic and Orthodox). Honors the New Testament and patristic recognition of consecrated singleness; provides community for the unmarried; preserves both the honor of parents and the freedom to serve Christ; historically produces significant Christian service; supplies pastoral structure (spiritual direction, vocational discernment) that helps prevent premature or presumptuous choice.

Challenges (widely acknowledged). Requires an ecclesial or communal structure that many Protestants lack; can be entered prematurely or without discernment; not for those called to marriage; tension with parental expectation of grandchildren; historically has sometimes tolerated the coercion of vocation by parents (especially of daughters into convents) that later reformers rightly resisted.

4.3.3 Christ as Bridegroom of the Unmarried

The consecrated life is not first a *renunciation* of marriage but a *claim to a prior marriage*. Scripture insists that the covenant God is Himself the husband of His people: “For your Maker is your husband, the LORD of hosts is his name” (Isa. 54:5); Paul writes that he has “betrothed you to one husband, to present you as a pure virgin to Christ” (2 Cor. 11:2); the culminating vision of Revelation is the marriage supper of the Lamb and the new Jerusalem descending “prepared as a bride adorned for her husband” (Rev. 19:7-9; 21:2). Every Christian, married or not, belongs first to this Bridegroom.

For the unmarried Christian this is not consolation-language for a missing spouse. It is the actual state of the case. The unmarried woman is not *waiting* for a husband as if she has none; she is *already* the beloved of the Bridegroom. The unmarried man is not *incomplete* for lack of a wife; he is a son of the household whose first bond is already formed. Elisabeth Elliot — twice widowed, and single or widowed for long seasons of her adult life, who wrote *Let Me Be a Woman* (1976) out of that experience — presses the same point throughout that book: the unmarried woman’s identity and completeness are settled in God’s idea of her, not in her marital status, and acceptance of that identity is the ground on which either marriage or singleness is received as a gift. She states the gift-logic directly in *Let Me Be a Woman*: “Single life may be only a stage of a life’s journey, but even a stage is a gift. God may replace it with another gift, but the receiver accepts His gifts with thanksgiving. This gift for this day” (*Let Me Be a Woman*, Tyndale, 1976, p. 40). She restates the same logic in the companion volume for men: “Singleness is a gift, not given to everyone for the whole of life, but given to all for a time” (*The Mark of a Man*, Revell, 1981, p. 126).

The consecrated forms treated in §4.3.1 and §4.3.2 name this publicly by vow; the Bridegroom-language of Scripture applies to every unmarried Christian whether or not that public form is taken. It is the theological ground on which every Christian singleness stands — the *positive content* the Protestant traditions must not lose when they set aside the vowed forms.

4.3.4 The Pauline Caveat: 1 Timothy 4:1-3

The New Testament that honors consecrated singleness also names its counterfeit. Paul warns Timothy of teachers who “depart from the faith, giving heed to seducing spirits, and doctrines of devils ... forbidding to marry, and commanding to abstain from meats, which God hath created to be received with thanksgiving” (1 Tim. 4:1-3 KJV). The compulsory imposition of celibacy on those not called to it —

whether by ecclesial requirement, by familial pressure, or by a piety that treats marriage as a lower state — is not honored in Scripture; it is warned against in the strongest possible terms.

Consecrated singleness in Scripture is always *charismatic* in the Pauline sense: a gift, freely given and freely received. “I would that all men were even as I myself. But every man hath his proper gift of God, one after this manner, and another after that” (1 Cor. 7:7). The Reformation objection to mandatory clerical celibacy — Luther’s, Calvin’s, the English reformers’ — was not an objection to consecrated singleness as such; it was an objection to *mandating* on all what Scripture treats as a particular calling to some. The Catholic and Orthodox traditions themselves acknowledge this distinction in principle (celibacy for the Latin secular clergy is a discipline, not a doctrine; Eastern Orthodox parish priests may marry before ordination); the reformers argued the discipline had, in practice, drifted into the very forbidding-to-marry Paul warned of. On the specific question of the unmarried adult child, 1 Tim. 4:1-3 sets a hard boundary in both directions: no one may be forbidden to marry (against certain rigorist Protestant and some Catholic patterns), and no one may be *required* to marry (against pressure to treat singleness as a failure or a delay). Either coercion falls under the same apostolic warning.

4.3.5 Missional Singleness as Affirmative Calling

Protestant tradition, having largely set aside the vowed forms of §4.3.1 and §4.3.2, has recovered consecrated singleness under a different name: *missional* singleness. John Piper argues that “God promises those who remain single in Christ blessings that are better than the blessings of marriage and children, and he calls you to display, by the Christ-exalting devotion of your singleness, the truths about Christ and his kingdom that shine more clearly through singleness than through marriage and child-rearing” (*This Momentary Marriage*, Crossway, 2009, p. 108; the fuller chapter is ch. 9, “Single in Christ: A Name Better Than Sons and Daughters”). Marriage bears witness to Christ and the church; singleness bears witness that the Christian’s ultimate belonging is not to any earthly family but to Christ Himself and to the family of God that outlasts every marriage (Matt. 22:30).

The historical Protestant record is stronger here than the tradition often remembers. Elisabeth Elliot went to Ecuador at twenty-four (1952), single, for translation work among the Colorado (Tsáchila) people (her departure, and the vocational-transfer shape of the whole Palm Beach circle, is told at §1.4.6). Jim Elliot and the four with him at Palm Beach on 8 January 1956 died between twenty-seven and thirty-two; all five were husbands and four were fathers, but the five had gone as a *mission* whose logic was: “*He is no fool who gives what he*

cannot keep to gain what he cannot lose" (Jim Elliot's journal, October 28, 1949; in Elliot, *Shadow of the Almighty*, p. 108 in the Zondervan edition) — a logic in which a wife and children are not the highest good and not required to authorize the mission. Amy Carmichael in India, Lottie Moon in China, Gladys Aylward in Yangchen, Helen Roseveare in the Congo, and countless less-remembered women went single, stayed single, and gave a life. The witness is dense enough that the Protestant collapse of vocational singleness into a *waiting-room for marriage* is a departure from Protestantism's own missionary history, not a return to it.

For the unmarried adult daughter or son considering this leg of §4.3, the pastoral point is affirmative: singleness may be the destination, not the delay. Elliot's counsel to a generation of young women ran the same direction. To the lonely and longing she writes: "The loneliness itself is material for sacrifice. The very longings themselves can be offered to Him who understands perfectly. The transformation into something He can use for the good of others takes place only when the offering is put into His hands" (*Passion and Purity*, Revell, 1984, p. 65). This is not a consolation for those who fail to marry; it is a re-description of the whole enterprise. The unmarried years are not the antechamber to a real life; they *are* the life, whether marriage follows or not.

The same claim runs through Elliot's teaching on manhood and womanhood (*Let Me Be a Woman*, 1976; *The Mark of a Man*, 1981; her essay "The Essence of Femininity" in *Recovering Biblical Manhood and Womanhood*, Crossway, 1991), which frames both maleness and femaleness as *gifts to be received and offered back to God* rather than roles to be performed for social approval — "we human beings haven't got a thing to offer up to God, except what we've been given; and your manhood is a gift that you offer back to Him" (*The Mark of a Man*, p. 118). Whatever the reader concludes about the wider complementarian question, Elliot's central theological move here is one every view in this paper must reckon with: *identity is received from the Father before it is expressed in a household*. The unmarried daughter and the unmarried son are not incomplete versions of the married; they are already the persons Christ died for, already the persons the Father has named, already possessed of the identity out of which any subsequent household will be built.

4.4 Multigenerational Household as Cultural Norm

Taxonomy note: this is View 1a as cultural inheritance rather than as a doctrine — the daily-life shape is the same as 1a, but the warrant is cultural default rather than theological argument. It is treated

in its own section here because the cultural pattern carries its own strengths and stresses distinct from the theological version, and its bearing on the Reality leg (§5.5, §B.3.5) is substantial. It is not counted as a fifth arrangement.

Description. Unmarried adult sons and daughters continue to live in the parental home not as a matter of doctrinal authority but as cultural default. This is the settled pattern in Amish and Old Order Mennonite communities, in Orthodox Judaism, and across much of the global South and East Asia (Filipino, Chinese, Indian, and many African cultures).

Biblical arguments cited. The general pattern of biblical households; the honor commandment; the failure of the atomized modern household to preserve piety; 1 Timothy 5 on family provision.

Sons. Live at home, work in family enterprise or nearby, marry into the household or bring a bride in.

Daughters. Live at home, work in the home and household economy, marry out.

Strengths (self-described). Preserves piety, transmits vocation, supports elderly parents naturally, provides accountability for unmarried adult children without formalized doctrines of authority, demonstrates that the American atomized household is culturally recent, not biblically mandated.

Challenges (widely acknowledged). Can perpetuate enmeshment; can delay individuation and vocational clarity; portable across cultures only with difficulty; is a cultural practice more than a defined ecclesial arrangement, so it can inherit both the strengths and the faults of the ambient culture.

4.4.1 The Anabaptist / Mennonite Pattern

The Anabaptist tradition — Amish, Old Order Mennonite, mainstream Mennonite (Mennonite Church USA, Mennonite Brethren), Brethren in Christ, Hutterite, Bruderhof — combines a strong household ethic with a distinctive theology of the *believer's church* that reshapes how the young adult transitions out from under paternal authority. Because Anabaptist practice varies substantially between “Old Order” and “mainstream” wings, both are described.

The common Anabaptist premises.

- *Believer's church.* Baptism is deferred to conscious adult profession — historically ages 15 to 25, in most streams around age 18. The rite marks the young adult's own covenant with

Christ and church, distinct from any paternal covenant. Ecclesial accountability *begins* at baptism.

- *Community discernment*. Major life decisions — vocation, marriage, service — are discerned with the counsel of the gathered congregation, not the paternal household alone. This is a distinctive corrective to both purely paternal and purely autonomous models.
- *Peace witness*. Nonresistance (Matt. 5:39; Rom. 12:19-21) has been a defining commitment. Anabaptists have historically refused military service and, from Civilian Public Service in World War II through 1-W and 2-W programs in the Korean and Vietnam eras to present-day Mennonite Voluntary Service, have practiced *alternative service* as the young-adult departure pattern in place of the military departure Scripture assumes for national Israel. The Anabaptist answer to the warrior-departure pattern is not suppression of the pattern but its transposition into service of peace.

Old Order Amish and Mennonite practice.

- Unmarried adult children ordinarily remain in the parental household until marriage; farm and household work are shared.
- *Rumspringa* (“running around”), primarily an Amish practice, is a bounded period in the mid- to late-teens during which the young adult tastes something of the outside world before choosing baptism and church membership. It is often misread outside the community as license; within the community it is a *discernment* season culminating in a decisive covenant.
- Marriage is community-mediated, with the church, the parents, and the couple together. Fall weddings following the harvest are traditional.
- Sons and daughters are treated with distinct roles but comparable weight in the covenant community.

Mainstream Mennonite and Brethren in Christ practice.

- Believer’s baptism at conscious profession is preserved; the young adult’s covenant is with Christ and the local congregation.
- **Voluntary service programs** are a distinctive institutional form. Mennonite Voluntary Service (MVS), Mennonite Central Committee (MCC) service assignments, SALT and IVEP terms, Brethren Volunteer Service, and similar programs place many young adults in a *service term* (typically one to three years) between the end of minor obedience and marriage. The young adult leaves the parental household not into autonomous individualism but into a discipling service community — a modern instantiation of vocational household transfer, informed by the peace witness.

- Marriage is honored as ecclesial covenant with congregational witness; parental blessing is sought and normative but not legally binding.
- The Bruderhof (a Hutterite-derived intentional community) and similar communities practice something closer to the Old Order pattern of shared property and household piety, alongside the believer's-church emphasis.

Biblical arguments cited. Matt. 3:11 and Acts 2:38 on believer's baptism; Matt. 18:15-20 and Acts 15 on community discernment; Matt. 5:38-48 and Rom. 12:17-21 on the peace ethic; Rom. 13:1-7 read (with characteristic Anabaptist tension) as consistent with civil obedience short of taking up the sword.

Bearing on the present question. The Anabaptist pattern shows that Scripture's *departure into another authority* motif (the warrior pattern in Israel, discipleship in the Gospels) can be honored without national military service. Voluntary service, MCC, and intentional community together instantiate the vocational household transfer pattern for a tradition whose peace witness precludes the ordinary military form. The believer's church tradition also frames the *end* of paternal authority differently than both the launch model and the household-continuity model: authority passes not primarily to the individual conscience nor primarily to continuing paternal covering, but to the covenanted congregation.

Strengths (self-described). Believer's baptism gives the young adult a decisive spiritual identity independent of the paternal household; congregational discernment provides accountability without paternalism; voluntary service supplies structured vocational departure; the peace witness gives coherent theological form to the young adult's public responsibility.

Challenges (acknowledged by Mennonite writers themselves). Old Order communities face out-migration and the pastoral care of those who leave. Mainstream Mennonite practice — particularly since the 1960s — has drifted, in some congregations, toward the mainstream launch pattern with weaker distinctives. The peace witness itself is contested among heirs of the tradition. Marriage counsel varies substantially between congregations.

4.5 The Arrangement Question — Parental Mediation of the Marriage Covenant

The question, not a fifth arrangement. The Arrangement Question is a *distinct and orthogonal* question about who initiates and mediates the marriage covenant itself. It is not a fifth arrangement of

daily household life; a household holding any of 1a, 1b, 2a, or 2b may answer the Arrangement Question by parental mediation, by pastoral / ecclesial mediation, or by leaving the initiation entirely to the couple with parental blessing. This section presents parental mediation / betrothal at its steel-manned best, together with the ecclesial-mediation third mode.

Description. The parents' most consequential office toward the unmarried adult child is *at the marriage moment* — initiating, mediating, or blessing the marriage covenant. Between the end of minor obedience and the marriage transition, parental authority is concentrated at that covenant seam rather than diffused across daily life. The daily-life question (where the adult child lives, works, travels) is left comparatively open; the marriage-arrangement question is answered decisively.

This arrangement is compatible with the adult child living at home (overlap with 4.1), launched into vocation (overlap with 4.2a), transferred to another household in service (see 4.6 below), or in a consecrated calling (overlap with 4.3). Its distinguishing mark is not the residence question but the parental role at the marriage moment itself.

Biblical arguments cited. The most extensive of any view.

- **Genesis 24** — Abraham commissioning the servant to secure a bride for adult Isaac (roughly age forty).
- **Genesis 21:21** — Hagar taking a wife for Ishmael from Egypt.
- **Genesis 28:1-2** — Isaac charging Jacob and directing him to Padanaram for a wife.
- **Exodus 22:16-17** — the father's legally recognized authority to refuse a suitor even after the physical union.
- **Deuteronomy 22:16** — the father speaking legally on behalf of a daughter in a marriage dispute *after* the wedding.
- **Judges 14:1-10** — Samson's parents attempting to arrange, and accompanying and negotiating on his behalf even when overridden.
- **Ruth 3-4** — Naomi's guidance and Boaz's negotiation through the elders; an adult widow's remarriage proceeding by mediated arrangement.
- **1 Corinthians 7:36-38** — on the father-of-the-virgin reading, Paul places the marriage decision within the father's power while restraining its exercise for the daughter's calling.
- **Numbers 30** — the father's veto over vows, historically often including vows around marriage.

Second-Temple witness — Tobit. The richest Second-Temple *narrative* of arrangement — outside the Genesis material treated above — is the

book of Tobit (deuterocanonical: accepted as Scripture by Catholic and Orthodox communions, held as edifying non-canonical reading by most Protestants; cited here as Second-Temple background for the arrangement pattern rather than under *Scripture-leg* proof). In Tobit 6-8, the young Tobias is directed by his father Tobit and by the angel Raphael to Sarah, daughter of Raguel, who has been widowed seven times by demonic attack on her wedding nights. The arrangement runs through: (i) paternal instruction and journey-commissioning (Tobit 4-5); (ii) kinship-based selection (“she pertains to thee by right of inheritance,” Tobit 6:11-13); (iii) the marriage-contract negotiated between the two fathers Raguel and Tobias’s father-by-delegation Raphael (Tobit 7:11-14); (iv) the couple’s own prayer together on the wedding night, invoking Adam and Eve as the covenantal precedent for marriage: “thou madest Adam, and gavest him Eve his wife for an helper and stay: of them came mankind: thou hast said, It is not good that man should be alone; let us make unto him an aid like unto himself” (Tobit 8:6, DRA); and (v) mutual parental blessing on the return to Nineveh (Tobit 10-11). The narrative gives the arrangement pattern all three of its constitutive elements — parental initiative, kinship discernment, and the couple’s own consent-through-prayer — in one continuous story, and it is the pattern behind the marriage-liturgy tradition of both the Roman and Byzantine rites, both of which appeal to Tobit 8:6 in the wedding prayers.

Antiquity. Ignatius (early 2nd c.) requires that marriages be formed “with the approval of the bishop, that their marriage may be according to God, and not after their own lust” (*To Polycarp* 5:2, as quoted at §3.4). Tertullian critiques secret (private) marriages. By Cyprian’s era, marriages formed apart from familial and ecclesial mediation are treated as irregular. Ecclesial and familial mediation of the marriage moment is the pre-Nicene norm.

Sons. Sons may reside independently, in vocational service, or at home during the pre-marriage period. What is distinctive is the parental office at the marriage moment — initiating consideration, examining the prospective bride’s family, and mediating the covenant. Isaac at forty, Jacob sent to Padanaram, and the Zebedee sons remain in their father’s boat until Christ calls them: Scripture’s picture is not one of pre-marriage independence from parents in the marriage-arrangement dimension.

Daughters. Daughters are more often pictured within the paternal household during the pre-marriage period, but the distinguishing mark of this view is not the residence question. Deuteronomy 22:16 pictures the father speaking legally *for* his daughter in a marriage dispute even after the wedding. Ruth 3-4 shows the mother-in-law and the elders together mediating an adult widow’s remarriage. The

parental office at the marriage moment is genuinely present for both sexes, with the mother's role especially visible in Genesis 21:21 and Ruth.

Modern examples.

- **Orthodox Jewish shidduch.** Parents and a professional match-maker (shadchan) initiate; the couple meet under structured circumstances; families negotiate; the couple decide together with familial and rabbinic involvement.
- **Indian Christian traditions.** Syro-Malabar, Mar Thoma, and some evangelical Indian traditions maintain semi-arranged marriage: parents identify candidates, families meet, the couple has real veto but not initiation.
- **Many African Christian traditions.** Bride-price and family-negotiated marriage remain normal.
- **Traditional Christian courtship in the West** before the mid-20th century routinely involved parental (especially paternal) initiation and mediation of the marriage moment. The modern courtship movement recovered fragments of this pattern, though its emphasis was often protective (Views 1a/1b) rather than mediating (the Arrangement Question).

Strengths (self-described). Preserves the covenant character of marriage. Reduces the burden on young people to identify a lifelong mate by their own limited experience. Draws two families into meaningful covenant. Honors Genesis 2:24 as covenant transaction, not personal preference alone. Corresponds most closely to the actual biblical narrative pattern.

Challenges (widely acknowledged). Requires wise, prayerful, unselfish parents; can slide into coercion or family-alliance politics; can fail when parents overreach the child's genuine consent (Judg. 14 shows the tension); can be difficult where extended family or a supportive church culture is absent; can produce marriages in which the parents' investment outweighs the couple's, with damaging consequences after the wedding.

Dwight Cover's threefold biblical pattern. In *Marrying, Giving in Marriage, and the Will of God* (Equip08 NW Conference, 2008), Dwight Cover argues that Scripture consistently describes marriage formation in three phases rather than one: (1) *Seek and find a wife* — the initiating and searching phase, driven by the man's side of the covenant with paternal counsel and household involvement (Gen. 24:1-9, Judg. 14:1-3, Prov. 18:22); (2) *Betroth a wife* — the covenantal binding phase, publicly witnessed, financially costly, and treated as marriage-in-inception (Deut. 20:7; 22:23-24; Matt. 1:18-20); and (3) *Take a wife* — the consummation and household-forming phase (Deut.

24:5; John 14:2-3 typologically). Cover reads Western dating not as a modern version of biblical courtship but as a *replacement* for the first two phases with an open-ended, non-covenantal, no-parental-mediation practice — a practice Scripture does not describe.

Cover's supra-cultural argument. Against the common dismissal ("betrothal was just ANE culture"), Cover offers five convergent evidences that parental mediation and covenantal betrothal are supra-cultural rather than merely cultural: (i) the *pre-culture creation model* (Gen. 2:22 — the Father presents the bride to the man); (ii) the *written on the heart of mankind* argument (parallel practices attested across non-Israelite cultures, suggesting a common creational grammar); (iii) the *OT and NT witness in continuity* (Isaac, Jacob, Samson, Ruth, Mary and Joseph — the same shape across covenants); (iv) *taught to Gentile Christians* (1 Cor. 7:36-38 on one reading); and (v) *used typologically to acquire the Bride of Christ* (the Father sends the Son to seek, the Son pays the bride price, the wedding is a future consummation — Eph. 5:25-27; Rev. 19:7-9). Cover treats the typological evidence as the load-bearing one in his case: on his reading, if the pattern were merely cultural, it would be surprising that the New Testament writers reach for it to describe redemption itself.

The bride-price grammar. Cover develops the Hebrew triad of *mohar* (the bride price paid by the groom's family to the bride's family), *mattan* (the groom's personal gift to the bride), and *shilluchim* (the father's dowry from the bride's side) — arguing that each element carries theological weight beyond mere commerce. Christ's blood is read as the ultimate *mohar*, the Spirit as the *mattan* (Eph. 1:13-14 as pledge), and the church's gifts and callings as the *shilluchim* the Father sends with the Bride. Whether or not the reader adopts betrothal practice, the theology of the bride price is Christologically load-bearing: the Bridegroom paid for His Bride, and He paid through the Father's initiative.

The fathers-give-daughters pattern. Cover counts thirty-five biblical instances of a father giving or refusing to give his daughter in marriage (Gen. 29:19; 34:8-12; Exod. 22:16-17; Judg. 1:12-13; 1 Sam. 17:25; 18:17-27; 25:44; 1 Kgs. 2:21; and following). The pattern is dense enough that its absence from a modern practice must be argued for rather than assumed.

The male-initiate / female-respond principle. Cover reads Jeremiah 29:6 ("Take wives and beget sons and daughters; and take wives for your sons, and give your daughters to husbands") together with the roughly two hundred narrative instances he counts of men initiating and women responding in the biblical marriage material, arguing that the pattern is normative rather than incidental. Whether the reader adopts this principle or not, it belongs in the steel-man.

The 1 Corinthians 7:36-38 father-of-the-virgin reading. Cover follows the older NAS/NASB rendering of *τῆς παρθένου αὐτοῦ* (*tēs parthenou autou*) as “his [i.e., the father’s] virgin daughter” rather than the betrothed-couple reading or the further minority “his [own sexuality]” reading. On the father-reading, Paul explicitly addresses fathers deliberating whether to give their daughters in marriage and treats the choice as *the father’s* to make “if he thinks he is acting improperly toward his virgin daughter, if she is past her youth, and if it must be so, let him do what he wishes, he does not sin; let her marry” (v. 36 NASB). On the father-reading, this is the most direct apostolic-era attestation of paternal marriage mediation in the New Testament; on the alternative betrothed-couple reading it is not. (§1.9 develops the two dominant readings together with a third ancient reading — the spiritual-marriage / *syneisaktos* case attested in Cyprian and Chrysostom — and does not adjudicate among them; the self-control reading noted above is a further modern minority option.)

The redemptive-history flow. Cover ends by mapping the paternal-mediation pattern along a redemptive-historical arc: Adam’s marriage in Genesis 2 (the Father presents the bride); Abraham arranging for Isaac (Gen. 24); Jacob receiving from Laban (Gen. 29); Boaz and Ruth mediated through Naomi and the elders (Ruth 3-4); Israel wedded to the LORD at Sinai (Jer. 2:2; Ezek. 16); Christ purchasing the Bride at the cross; and the wedding supper of the Lamb still future (Rev. 19). On this reading, every believer’s own marriage is a small enactment of a story the Father has been telling from the first two chapters of Genesis to the last two of Revelation.

There is also a typological caution proper to this view. Dwight Cover’s typological reading (developed above) reads the biblical marriage narratives — paternal arrangement, bride-price, the male-initiate / female-respond grammar — through the redemptive-historical arc in which the Father gives the Bride to the Son (Gen. 2:22; John 3:29; Rev. 19:7-9). (Cover’s larger corpus — see his 2025 Christian Heritage Conference talk “Dads, Prepare and Launch Sons as Men of God” with the Cop → Coach → Consultant developmental chart discussed at §5.0.5 — sorts him on the *daily-life axis* as 1a-with-launched-well orientation, not 1b; his answer on the Arrangement Question here is orthogonal to that daily-life sorting, and the paper’s four-view-plus-orthogonal- Arrangement-Question structure makes the combination visible.) Read as a witness to that arc, the typology is genuinely biblical. Read as a warrant for the human father to occupy the typological role of God the Father *himself*, it drifts into the same territory §5.5 names as the *Clutch*: the human father can begin to treat the daughter as his to give rather than as the Lord’s to give through him, and the arrangement office (which is real and biblical) can quietly harden into arrangement *ownership* (which is neither).

The correction is not to discard the typology but to keep the human father in the position that the type actually assigns him — that of the household through which the Father works, not that of the Father Himself. The ecclesial-mediation mode discussed immediately below is one historic way the church has held that distinction concretely.

Ecclesial mediation as a third arrangement mode. The Arrangement Question, as it has run in the American conversation, has ordinarily divided into two answers: *the couple decides alone* (the modern individual-consent default, congruent with 2a and often 2b) or *the parents mediate* (the classical arrangement, congruent with the biblical narratives above). A third answer has a substantial pre-Nicene, medieval, Reformation, and modern witness: *the church mediates*. Ignatius (c. 107) already places the mediation in episcopal hands (*To Polycarp* 5:2, as quoted at §3.4 and in the Antiquity paragraph above). The medieval Western practice of *banns* — the public reading of an intended marriage in the parish for three consecutive Sundays so that any impediment could be raised — placed the *veto* office in the congregation's hands even when the initiation lay with the couple or their families; the Council of Trent (Tametsi, 1563) codified that a marriage contracted without the parish priest and two witnesses was invalid. The Reformers retained banns and added premarital pastoral examination. Two Christian communities illustrate the third-answer polity in especially concentrated form: the historic Moravians employed the *marriage lot*, in which a proposed match was submitted to prayer and to the drawing of a *ja* or *nein* lot understood as Christ's judgment through His church (the practice was normative at Herrnhut from 1730 and across the Moravian provinces until it was progressively discontinued through the nineteenth century, lingering longest for missionary marriages until 1889); the modern Bruderhof requires that a proposed marriage be brought to the community's *Servants of the Word* for discernment, with the community's ratification a necessary precondition of the marriage. Both practices treat the couple's consent as necessary but not sufficient and the *ekklesia* as the covenanted body within which marriage is discerned. In the vocabulary of §1.1.1, the third mode locates the marriage-moment office in sense (4) authority (priestly office) exercised by the gathered church rather than in sense (1) authority exercised by the father alone. It is a genuine alternative to *both* the modern individualist default and the paternal-arrangement default, and it has earlier and broader historical attestation than either. Where the American conversation forces a choice between "the couple alone" and "the parents alone," the historic answer is that neither is alone: the church is present, and its office at the marriage moment is not a rubber stamp on a private decision but a genuine act of covenant discernment. This connects directly to §4.4.1's account of church counsel and to the Bruderhof

discussion at Appendix B.

Representative published works. The pre-Nicene ecclesial-marriage warrant is set in Ignatius, *To Polycarp* 5:1-2 (c. 107 AD; as quoted at §3.4). The courtship-and-parental-mediation revival in modern conservative Protestantism runs through Doug Wilson, *Her Hand in Marriage: Biblical Courtship in the Modern World* (1997); the earlier work of Joshua Harris, *I Kissed Dating Goodbye* (1997), which the author formally retracted in October 2018 (statement at joshharris.com), disowning the book's central "avoid dating" thesis and identifying its emphases on avoiding dating and kissing as "things that are not found in the Bible"; and Vision Forum's betrothal materials (1998-2014, now defunct as an organization). Anna Sofia and Elizabeth Botkin, *So Much More* (2005), addressed the daughter-facing question; the sisters have publicly resisted being labeled the "stay-at-home daughter movement" and have acknowledged the book's youthful limitations, but have not formally retracted it, and botkinsisters.com continues in substantially the same theological register. The Orthodox Jewish *shidduch* literature — halakhic works on matchmaking and family responsibility in Jewish marriage formation — represents the mature form of arrangement within Second Temple and rabbinic continuity. Historic Roman Catholic canon law on marriage formation (Trent, Session 24; 1983 Code of Canon Law, canons 1058-1071) documents the church's insistence that marriage be publicly witnessed and ecclesially mediated while requiring the freedom of the spouses. Dwight Cover, *Marrying, Giving in Marriage, and the Will of God* (Equip08 NW Conference, 2008; expanded lecture notes, 2010s), develops the threefold biblical pattern (Seek → Betroth → Take), the supra-cultural argument for parental mediation, the bride-price grammar, and the redemptive-history typology summarized above. His companion paper *Reflections on Birth Control and the Will of God* extends the same hermeneutic (Precept → Principle → Person of Truth) into the fertility question and models the "leaky bucket" cumulative method of argumentation from Steve Wagner and the "assumptive language" audit from Del Tackett — both of which are picked up in Chapter 6 below.

4.6 Vocational Household Transfer as a Cross-Cutting Pattern

A brief note on a biblical mode that operates *within* any of the arrangements above rather than as its own view.

Elisha's departure from his father's twelve yoke of oxen to serve Elijah (1 Kings 19:19-21), Samuel's residence in Eli's household (1

Sam. 1:22-28), David's service at Saul's court (1 Sam. 16:19-23), Timothy's transfer under Paul (Acts 16:1-3, with the caveat at §1.6.5 that Timothy's biological father may already have died — which weakens the case as an example of transfer *over* an active paternal head while strengthening it as an example of apostolic paternity received into an already-fatherless situation), and the Zebedee sons' departure from the family fishing enterprise at Christ's call (Matt. 4:22) all instance a distinct pattern: leaving the parental household to serve *under another authority* rather than into autonomous individual life.

Modern analogues include military service, seminary or ministerial training, missionary apprenticeship, Catholic and Orthodox novitiate, and (in agricultural cultures) family-farm placement with another farming household. Family-integrated proponents (Views 1a/1b) can and do recognize vocational household transfer as a legitimate leaving. Consecrated-singleness communities formalize it. Households that answer the Arrangement Question by parental initiation may commission a son into such service until marriage. Even the launched-at-adulthood pattern (Views 2a and 2b) is strengthened when the launch is *to* something — a mentor, an institution, a discipling household — rather than to sheer independence; where a 2b release drifts into sheer independence (§5.5 Abandonment), vocational transfer is precisely the alternative it lacks.

Military and national service as a distinct sub-mode. Scripture gives explicit warrant for the military departure of unmarried adult sons under a different authority than the father (Num. 1:3; Deut. 20; Deut. 24:5; 1 Sam. 17). Modern national military service, and compulsory or voluntary civil service (as practiced in Israel, Switzerland, South Korea, and many other nations), is the closest contemporary analogue. It preserves the pattern Scripture presents: adult son remains his father's son; adult son is nevertheless enrolled and directed by a captain not his father; adult son is formed for public responsibility in a sphere the household could not supply. The New Testament nowhere reverses the pattern; John the Baptist counsels soldiers within their calling (Luke 3:14); Christ commends the centurion's faith without questioning his office (Matt. 8:5-13). Where a young man's departure from home is *into* this kind of ordered service — military, ministry, apprenticeship — Scripture, antiquity, and the ordinary experience of many faithful families all commend it.

The Nazirite / set-apart calling (Num. 6; 1 Sam. 1:11; Luke 1:15) is a rarer but genuinely biblical pre-emption of ordinary household patterns for the LORD's service. Scripture makes room for it without prescribing it.

4.7 Patterns Across Faithful Communities

The Views at a Glance

View	Daily-life shape	Theological ground	Failure mode
1a Household Continuity (Prudential Covering)	Adult child ordinarily remains in the parental household until marriage; father protects, mother forms; daughters especially covered.	Household as biblical pattern and pastoral wisdom, not doctrine. Deut. 6:6-7; Ps. 78:5-8; Mal. 4:6; Eph. 6:4.	Household becomes the treasure; covering hardens into control; marriage delayed indefinitely (§5.5).
1b Continuous Doctrinal Authority	Same outward practice as 1a, but held as <i>systematic requirement</i> : every believer under a defined continuing authority.	Haustafel read as ordering continuing parent-child relation; fifth commandment as permanent office; Num. 30; Jer. 35. Nee, <i>Spiritual Authority</i> ; Gothard; Phillips. Continuity with older streams examined at §B.1.	The Clutch — covering itself becomes the idol; safety-under-authority displaces trust in Christ (§5.5).

View	Daily-life shape	Theological ground	Failure mode
2a Prudential Launching	At adulthood the child is launched; directive authority ends, honor and consultation continue.	Genesis 2:24 as principle; Eph. 6:1-2 read as age-bounded; New Testament address of adult believers as morally responsible. MacArthur, Dobson, Grudem, McGee; Campbell & Chapman, <i>Parenting Your Adult Child</i> .	Independence becomes the treasure; honor thins to courtesy; household piety disintegrates (§5.5).
2b Release with Prayer (Prodigal-Father Posture)	Same outward launch as 2a, but held as <i>covenantal release under continuing intercession</i> ; parent's office becomes priestly.	Luke 15:11-32; Hosea 11; Luke 22:31-32; Judg. 14:4. Graham, <i>Prodigals</i> ; Keller, <i>The Prodigal God</i> ; Piper; Elliot.	The Abandonment — release without prayer; launched-and-ignored; “whatever you want” as the whole of the parental office (§5.5).

<i>The Arrangement Question</i> (orthogonal)	<i>Who initiates and mediates the marriage covenant?</i> Applies to any of 1a/1b/2a/2b as a distinct question about the marriage moment, not a fifth arrangement of daily life.	Ignatius, <i>To Polycarp</i> 5:2; Gen. 24; 1 Cor. 7:36-38 (on the father-reading); Trent Sess. 24 (parental consent not required for validity; canonical form required).	Arrangement becomes the treasure; consent bypassed; parents extend arrangement office into ongoing management of the marriage (§5.5).
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Vocational household transfer (§4.6) — Elisha, Samuel, David, Timothy, Zebedee sons — is not a view but a *cross-cutting mode* compatible with every arrangement above.

Consecrated singleness (§4.3) is a *cross-cutting vocation*, not a fifth arrangement.

Comparing the arrangements (1a, 1b, 2a, 2b) and the orthogonal Arrangement Question:

- **All are practiced by believers who love Christ and read the same Bible.**
- **All cite the honor commandment as foundational.**
- **All provide, in principle, for the care of aging parents.**
- **All recognize marriage as the paradigmatic leaving.**
- **They divide on distinct questions.** Views 1a, 1b, 2a, and 2b divide on where the adult child lives and under what authority during daily life. The Arrangement Question orthogonally addresses *who initiates and mediates the marriage covenant*. Vocational household transfer (§4.6) crosses all of them as a mode. Real families often combine one arrangement from 1a/1b/2a/2b with a particular answer to the Arrangement Question.

4.8 What Reality Requires, Permits, and Forbids

Requires (in every faithful arrangement):

- Parents who love, provide, and pray.
- Adult children who honor and, at appropriate age, provide.
- A local church or community context that supports the arrangement.
- Concrete provision for aging parents when the time comes.

Permits (based on the range of faithful practice):

- Continuing household continuity and covering within a wise and loving household.
- Launched adulthood with continuing honor.
- Consecrated singleness in community.
- Multigenerational household as cultural pattern.
- Parental initiation, mediation, or blessing of the marriage covenant.
- Vocational household transfer — leaving to serve under another authority.
- Asymmetric or symmetric treatment of sons and daughters, depending on the family's reading of Scripture.
- A range of economic structures when an unmarried adult child remains in the parental household, including:
 - *Transitional rent-charging* — parents charge room-and-board so the young person builds savings and disciplines toward independent life; the arrangement is scaffolded toward launch.
 - *Retention without charge* — parents forgo rent because they desire the young person to remain in the household for discipline, protection, and continued formation; the arrangement is not scaffolded toward launch.
 - *No-rent with contribution expected* — the pre-industrial pattern: no cash rent, but chores, care-work, agricultural labor, or participation in the family business is assumed as the young adult's share of the household economy. Each structure signals a different underlying view (§4.1a/4.1b, §4.2a, or §4.4 respectively), but Scripture and antiquity leave the choice to the family.

Forbids (in every faithful arrangement):

- Nullifying honor by tradition or by pretext of Christian devotion (Mark 7:9-13).
- Provoking children to wrath or crushing their spirits (Eph. 6:4; Col. 3:21).
- Adult children abandoning aging parents (1 Tim. 5:8).
- Any arrangement that renders devotion to Christ a competing loyalty rather than the animating center (Matt. 10:37).

4.9 What Reality Leaves Open

- Whether any single arrangement is *the* biblical one, or whether Scripture leaves genuine room for multiple faithful patterns depending on culture, family, and calling.

- Whether the church's teaching office should prescribe a particular arrangement or equip families to choose faithfully among several.

Chapter 5 — Synthesis

Overview (Synthesis)

This chapter brings the four SCAR components together. Where do they agree? Where do they leave tension? What remains for the reader — the parent, the adult child, the pastor — to weigh?

Before the four-component summary and the presentation of views, one biblical pattern deserves to be surfaced on its own. It cuts across every view the chapter will subsequently present, and it emerges from Scripture more consistently than any single view. It is the pattern of *what shape the parent's love takes* when the adult child chooses.

5.0 The Biblical Pattern of the Parent's Posture

Scripture is remarkably consistent about one thing that the governance-focused debates often miss. Where Scripture describes God's own parenthood, or narrates human parents relating to adult offspring, three distinct postures recur. They are not competitors; each fits different circumstances, and mature parenthood in Scripture practices all three at different times toward the same child.

The three postures are:

1. **Release-and-await** — the parent honors the adult child's autonomous choice, even a ruinous one, without withdrawing love.
2. **Intercession-without-restraint** — the parent brings the adult child to Christ when the parent cannot restrain, heal, or reach.
3. **Dedication** — the parent releases the child *to God* rather than to the world, in vocation, calling, or self-offering.

Each is grounded in a distinct scriptural pattern. None of the four views presented in §5.3 (nor any answer to the orthogonal Arrangement Question) makes any of these postures impossible, but some views tend to emphasize one over the others. Naming the three directly gives the reader a scriptural vocabulary for what mature Christian parenthood actually looks like across the arc of an adult child's life.

All three postures below are exercises of *sense (4) authority* in the vocabulary of §1.1.1 — the priestly office of the parent, which every faithful view (1a, 1b, 2a, 2b) affirms as lifelong. Release-and-await, intercession-without-restraint, and dedication are three modes in which the priestly office is discharged, none of them requiring sense (1) directive authority to be exercised at the moment, and none of them foreclosed by the disagreements over sense (1) that occupy Chapter 4. This is why the chapter is placed at §5.0 as common

ground rather than at §5.3 as a view among views: it describes what all faithful parenthood of adult children shares, not what any particular view uniquely commends.

5.0.1 Release-and-Await

The first posture is the most difficult and the most extensively witnessed. The parent — divine or human — releases the adult child to choices the parent would not have made, sometimes to certain ruin, and maintains love and hope without exercising restraint. This is not abandonment. It is release-in-continuing-love, with grief and watchful awaiting for return.

Samson and his parents (Judges 14; the passage is block-quoted at §1.4.5). Samson, an adult under the Nazirite vow, demands a Philistine wife: “I have seen a woman in Timnath of the daughters of the Philistines: now therefore get her for me to wife” (Judg. 14:2). His parents object on covenantal grounds: “Is there never a woman among the daughters of thy brethren, or among all my people, that thou goest to take a wife of the uncircumcised Philistines?” (v. 3). Samson insists: “Get her for me; for she pleaseth me well.” And his parents *comply* against their own judgment. The narrator immediately supplies the theological key:

But his father and his mother knew not that it was of the LORD, that he sought an occasion against the Philistines (Judg. 14:4).

The parents’ compliance is not portrayed as their failure. They spoke the right word. They were overruled by their adult son. God worked through the son’s ruinous autonomous choice to accomplish His own purpose. Judges 14:4 is one of the Old Testament’s clearest providence-and-freedom hinges, and it sits directly on the parent-and-adult-child question.

The Prodigal Son (Luke 15:11-32). Jesus’s own parable is the paradigmatic statement of this posture. The younger son demands his inheritance — culturally tantamount to wishing his father dead. The father grants it and *funds the departure* (“he divided unto them his living,” v. 12). He does not restrain the son’s journey “into a far country.” He does not intervene during the ruin. He watches for return without fetching. When the son “came to himself” (v. 17) and returned, the father ran, embraced, and restored.

The parable is Jesus’s revelation of God the Father’s own posture toward the autonomous adult child who chooses ruinous freedom. It is told to the Pharisees — elder-brother analogs — as a rebuke of their resentment that Jesus receives sinners. Two distinct claims

about the parable are commonly conflated and are worth separating: (a) *descriptively*, the parable reveals the Father's posture toward the ruinous adult child, and (b) *prescriptively*, human parents may imitate that posture. Claim (a) is direct — the father in the parable is a Christological/theological figure for God the Father. Claim (b) is an inference by analogy — from what God does to what human parents may do — and while the analogy is warranted (Christians are elsewhere told to imitate the Father, Eph. 5:1), the parable does not itself issue the imperative "parents, do likewise." Faithful readers who take the parable prescriptively for human parenting are making a defensible move; they should recognize they are making one.

An objection worth naming, and the reading that answers it. A specific objection to any 2b-shaped use of Luke 15 as a paradigm deserves an answer. The parable's rhetorical shape assumes that the son's leaving is not honorable — the inheritance demand was culturally tantamount to wishing the father dead, the departure is into a "far country" and dissolute waste, and the return is only what a starving man does. If the Prodigal is the paradigm, does the paradigm quietly assume that adult-child departures generally *are* or *will be* dishonorable? And how does that square with the many scriptural cases (Elisha, Timothy, Rebekah, the Zebedee sons at Christ's call) in which the departure is called-out, obedient, and honorable in every register? The reading 2b's advocates press is that Jesus chose *this* parable — a maximally dishonorable leaving — precisely because its argumentative shape is *a fortiori*: if the Father's love holds where the son has effectively wished him dead, it holds *a fortiori* for every ordinary and honorable departure that a faithful family will actually experience. Luke 15 is not the ordinary case 2b describes; it is the test case that certifies the posture at its hardest, so that the honorable departures cited above can be held under the same fundamental stance without residual anxiety. Two observations reinforce this reading. The parable is told to Pharisees, not to prodigals — its rhetorical target is elder-brother resentment against grace given to sinners, which requires the son's dishonor as the setup that makes the Father's love stunning enough to expose it. And the parable comes third in a series of three (lost sheep, lost coin, lost son) in which the shepherd and the woman *seek* what is lost; the human father alone waits, precisely because the human son alone has agency to leave and to return. The three parables together depict a range of loss-and-recovery relations; only the third requires the released party's own volition. The parable is therefore doing exactly what 2b needs: showing that even in the case where the parental posture is most tested — release into what looks like sheer waste — the Father's love does not fail. The ordinary case is easier, and the parable secures it.

Absalom (2 Samuel 13-18). The tragic version. David does not

effectively restrain his adult son's rebellion. Absalom mounts a coup, sleeps publicly with David's concubines to seal the break, and dies in battle. David's cry — "O my son Absalom, my son, my son Absalom! would God I had died for thee, O Absalom, my son, my son!" (2 Sam. 18:33) — is the Old Testament's most devastating parent-loses-child lament. Same posture as the Prodigal Father, but without the return. Release-in-love does not guarantee outcome.

Esau (Genesis 26:34-35). "And Esau was forty years old when he took to wife Judith the daughter of Beeri the Hittite, and Bashemath the daughter of Elon the Hittite: which were a grief of mind unto Isaac and to Rebekah." Isaac and Rebekah did not restrain the covenantally-improper marriages of their adult son, though they grieved them. The blessing passes to Jacob; Esau is not restored to covenantal centrality, though he does later reconcile with Jacob personally.

Rehoboam (1 Kings 12). Solomon's careful preparation of the kingdom cannot restrain his adult son's rash choice. Ten tribes are lost. Even the wisest father in Israel's history cannot prevent an adult son from a ruinous decision.

Hosea 11 — the pattern stated as divine self-revelation. "When Israel was a child, then I loved him, and called my son out of Egypt. As they called them, so they went from them: they sacrificed unto Baalim, and burned incense to graven images.... How shall I give thee up, Ephraim? how shall I deliver thee, Israel?... mine heart is turned within me, my repentings are kindled together." (Hos. 11:1-2, 8). The prophetic corpus's most explicit statement of God-as-Father releasing an adult-son people to Baal-worship and aching to restore. This is the Old Testament theological ground on which Jesus builds Luke 15.

Peter's denial and restoration (Luke 22:31-32; John 21:15-19). The pattern is practiced by the Son toward His disciple. Jesus foretells the denial — "Satan hath desired to have you, that he may sift you as wheat" — and does not restrain it. He prays for the restoration on the far side: "but I have prayed for thee, that thy faith fail not: and when thou art converted, strengthen thy brethren" (Luke 22:31-32). On the beach after the resurrection, the threefold restoration mirrors the threefold denial (John 21:15-17). The Son practices Prodigal-Father posture toward His disciple: release-in- prayer, receive-in-love, restore-in-commission.

The Featured Contrast — Samson's Parents and Eli The Release posture is often mistaken for its failure mode: *permissive parenting through weakness*. The clearest way to see the difference is to place Samson's parents alongside Eli.

Samson's parents (Judg. 14, as told above). They *speaks the right word*. They raise their covenantal objection clearly and to their son's face: "Is there never a woman among the daughters of thy brethren, or among all my people, that thou goest to take a wife of the uncircumcised Philistines?" They are then overruled by their adult son and comply with his choice. The narrator immediately identifies the providential frame — "it was of the LORD" (Judg. 14:4). Their compliance is release, not abdication.

Eli (1 Sam. 2-4). Eli *knows* his adult sons Hophni and Phinehas are wicked. He hears the reports: "Why do ye such things? for I hear of your evil dealings by all this people. Nay, my sons; for it is no good report that I hear" (1 Sam. 2:23-24). But his rebuke is weak, and, critically, Eli fails to exercise the priestly-household jurisdiction that was still his when the sons served under him at Shiloh. Samuel receives the word of judgment: "For I have told him that I will judge his house for ever for the iniquity which he knoweth; because his sons made themselves vile, and he restrained them not" (1 Sam. 3:13). Hophni and Phinehas die; the ark is captured; Eli falls backward and dies; his daughter-in-law names her newborn Ichabod — "the glory is departed from Israel" (1 Sam. 4:21).

The two cases look superficially similar (parents whose sons make ruinous choices) but are theologically opposite. The difference is not compliance-vs-restraint; it is *timing, jurisdiction, and the presence of grieving parental voice*.

- **Timing** — Samson's parents speak *before* the marriage. Eli tolerates ongoing wickedness his sons had been committing for years.
- **Jurisdiction** — Samson is an adult and his marriage decision is his own to make. Hophni and Phinehas are under Eli's priestly authority in the ongoing conduct of the tabernacle service.
- **Grieving parental voice** — Samson's parents raise a clear covenantal objection and lament the choice. Eli's rebuke is weak ("Why do ye such things?") and issued too late to be pastoral correction.

Canonical echo — Adonijah (1 Kings 1:6). The narrator's editorial verdict on David's parenting of Adonijah is compact and severe: "And his father had not displeased him at any time in saying, Why hast thou done so?" The construction is not a report of Adonijah's psychological experience but Scripture's own diagnosis of paternal failure toward an *adult* son. David never called Adonijah to account, and the omission stands as the narrative background to Adonijah's fatal attempt on the throne. The parallel to Eli is close — failure to confront wickedness in an adult son — and it sharpens the middle-mode point: Scripture commends the *confrontation of an adult child* by the parent

without collapsing that confrontation into directive authority. What David owed Adonijah, and Eli owed Hophni and Phinehas, was not a command he could enforce but a covenantal word he could name; the failure was not that they could not enforce, but that they never named.

The Samson-Eli contrast should discipline the Release-and-await reading. It is not a warrant for silence, weakness, or permissiveness. It is a warrant for *speaking the covenantal word and then honoring the adult child's freedom* — and for exercising active jurisdiction where jurisdiction is still yours.

Summary of Release-and-Await Scripture's testimony is that mature parenthood toward an autonomous adult child looks like this: speak the covenantal word plainly, then release; grieve when the child chooses ruin; do not withdraw love; watch for return; run when return comes. This is God's own posture toward His people, and it is the posture Jesus taught in the parable and practiced with Peter.

5.0.2 Intercession-Without-Restraint

The second posture appears throughout the Gospels. The parent — or parental figure — cannot restrain, cannot heal, cannot reach the adult (or adult-ish) child. What the parent *can* do is bring the child to Christ.

Jairus and his daughter (Mark 5:21-43; Luke 8:41-56). Jairus's twelve-year-old daughter is dying. He cannot heal her. He falls at Jesus's feet: "My little daughter lieth at the point of death: I pray thee, come and lay thy hands on her, that she may be healed; and she shall live" (Mark 5:23). Word comes that she has died. Jesus says: "Be not afraid, only believe." He goes to the house, takes her by the hand, says "Talitha cumi," and she rises.

The father of the demon-possessed boy (Mark 9:14-29). The disciples have failed to cast out the spirit. The father brings the boy to Jesus. Jesus asks how long. "Of a child.... but if thou canst do any thing, have compassion on us, and help us." Jesus replies: "If thou canst believe, all things are possible to him that believeth." The father's cry — "Lord, I believe; help thou mine unbelief" (Mark 9:24) — is the paradigmatic prayer of the intercessory parent who cannot restrain and cannot heal.

The widow of Nain (Luke 7:11-17). The son is already dead in the funeral procession. The widow has not brought him; she has *carried him toward the grave*. Jesus intervenes uninvited. "And he came and touched the bier: and they that bare him stood still. And he said,

Young man, I say unto thee, Arise.” Christ acts where the parent no longer can. This is intercession-in-extremis where the intercession is Christ’s own.

The Syrophoenician woman (Mark 7:24-30; Matt. 15:21-28).

A Gentile mother whose daughter is possessed. She cannot reach the daughter’s affliction. She reaches Christ instead, and persists through apparent refusal: “Yes, Lord: yet the dogs under the table eat of the children’s crumbs” (Mark 7:28). Jesus commends her faith and heals the daughter at a distance.

The parent whose adult child has walked away. The Gospel cases above are illness and demonization; the church’s classic case is the child’s own departure from the faith. Its exemplar is Monica of Thagaste, whose years of prayer for Augustine the paper treats at §5.4 and in the Conclusion — intercession-without-restraint sustained across decades, joined to the release of §5.0.1: no chasing, no relenting in prayer, and the door kept open.

Summary of Intercession-Without-Restraint The pattern is consistent. The parent’s competence has run out. The child is beyond the parent’s reach — through illness, demonization, distance, death, or the child’s own hardened choice. The Christian parental response Scripture models is *not* the resumption of restraint; it is intercession. The parent brings the unreachable child to Christ. Faith persists through delay and apparent refusal.

Every view presented in §5.3 must answer: when your view of parental authority runs out — because the child is adult, or beyond reach, or in ruin — what do you do? Scripture’s answer is not another mode of control. It is intercession.

5.0.3 Dedication

The third posture is the reverse of release-to-the-world. Instead of the adult child leaving the parent’s covering for autonomous choice (as in the Prodigal), the parent voluntarily releases the child *to God* for vocation, calling, or self-offering. In its purest form, the parent’s release is offered before the child ever independently chooses.

Hannah dedicating Samuel (1 Sam. 1-2). Hannah vows before Samuel is born: “then I will give him unto the LORD all the days of his life, and there shall no razor come upon his head” (1 Sam. 1:11). When Samuel is weaned, she takes him to Shiloh and gives him to Eli: “For this child I prayed; and the LORD hath given me my petition which I asked of him: therefore also I have lent him to the LORD; as long as he liveth he shall be lent to the LORD” (1 Sam. 1:27-28). Her

song of dedication (1 Sam. 2:1-10) becomes a template for Christian dedication and is directly echoed in the Magnificat.

Hannah as initiator of vocational household transfer. Hannah's case is not only the paradigm of parental dedication in the abstract; it is the paradigm of the parent as *initiator* of the vocational household transfer treated in §1.4.6. Samuel does not choose Shiloh; Hannah chooses it for him, before he can. She brings him to the house of the LORD at Shiloh — where Eli's household, the very household whose sons are corrupt (1 Sam. 2:12-17), keeps the sanctuary; Hannah gives Samuel into the priestly office at the very time its corruption stands on the narrative record. She transfers him formally with sacrifice ("with three bullocks, and one ephah of flour, and a bottle of wine," 1:24). Elisha's case (§1.4.6) is child-initiated: Elijah calls, Elisha follows, the parents are informed post-decision. Hannah's case is parent-initiated: the parent identifies the call before the child can, and enacts the transfer while the child is still young enough that dedication precedes independent consent. Both are honored in Scripture; the Hannah shape is the one that reaches most directly into Christian traditions of infant baptism, child dedication, and early formal consecration. It also names, for the present question, that a parent's Dedication posture is not passive — Hannah does not merely *release* Samuel from the household; she *transfers* him into the house of the LORD, enacting the vow with travel, sacrifice, and formal presentation. But the text records no assessment of the receiving authority: the vow is made to the LORD (1:11), and her own words name the recipient — "I have lent him to the LORD" (1:28). Eli receives the child only as the keeper of the LORD's house, and his household's corruption is already on the narrative record (2:12-17), with its judgment to follow (2:27-36; 3:11-14). In Hannah's case the dedicating act is addressed to God; the human hands that receive the child — even unworthy ones — are, in the narrative's frame, entrusted to Him.

Mary at the foot of the cross (John 19:26-27). Mary has released her adult Son to His mission — a mission that ends in the crucifixion she is now witnessing. Jesus from the cross provides for her care through John: "Woman, behold thy son!... Behold thy mother!" Mary's release is not release-to-the-world (as in the Prodigal). It is release-to-the-Father's-will. The Son's mission included His mother's lifelong grief. She does not resist it; she stands at the foot of the cross.

Gethsemane — the Son's own submission (Matt. 26:39; Mark 14:36; Luke 22:42). The perfect parallel case, inverted. The Son requests release from the cup: "Father, if thou be willing, remove this cup from me: nevertheless not my will, but thine, be done." The Father does not grant the release. The Son submits. This is the perfect Son-toward-Father analog of the Dedication posture: the

beloved child does not go into a far country; the beloved child accepts the cup the Father does not remove. It is the vocation of Christ Himself.

Second Samuel 7:14 — the covenantal formula. Speaking to David about Solomon: “I will be his father, and he shall be my son. If he commit iniquity, I will chasten him with the rod of men, and with the stripes of the children of men. But my mercy shall not depart away from him.” This is chastisement without withdrawal of mercy — the covenantal principle underneath Dedication. The dedicated child is disciplined but not disowned.

The Wider Christian Tradition of Dedication Christian tradition has recognized Dedication as a distinct parental and personal vocation from the earliest centuries. The desert tradition (Anthony and after), the Third Orders of the mendicant movements (Franciscan, Dominican, Carmelite tertiaries), the Beguines of the medieval Low Countries, Ignatian dedication, the Orthodox practice of monastic tonsure, Anglican religious communities, and the modern Catholic Order of Consecrated Virgins all give institutional form to Dedication.

For present purposes, three things about the tradition matter:

- Dedication has always been recognized as *distinct from marriage and distinct from ordinary single life*, not a lesser or higher version of either.
- Dedication may be initiated by the child (most commonly) or offered by the parents (as with Hannah), and the church has practiced both.
- Dedication in every tradition preserves *continuing kinship* — the dedicated child does not cease to be son, daughter, brother, sister. The Order-of-Virgins liturgy, monastic clothing, and Third Order formation all continue to name and honor the natural family.

The relevance for this paper: whatever view a reader adopts about household authority in the ordinary case, Dedication remains a live Christian option that has been practiced continuously since the early church, and it changes the parent-and-adult-child question when the adult child is being called to it.

5.0.4 How the Three Postures Relate

The three biblical postures are not competing views. They are different modes of the same underlying reality: *the parent’s love outlasts the parent’s control*. Mature Christian parenthood practices all three at different times toward the same child.

- **Release-and-await** is the posture when the adult child chooses. The parent has spoken the covenantal word; the child has decided; the parent releases without withdrawing love.
- **Intercession-without-restraint** is the posture when the adult child is beyond the parent's reach. The parent's competence is exhausted; the parent brings the child to Christ.
- **Dedication** is the posture when the adult child is called to a vocation the parent must not obstruct. The parent releases the child *to God's use*, not to the world's choices.

The views presented in §5.3 (Views 1a, 1b, 2a, 2b, and the orthogonal Arrangement Question) differ over the *structure* of household authority and, in the Arrangement Question's case, over the mediation of the marriage covenant itself. They do not, if faithful, differ over these three postures. Any view that cannot practice Release will collapse into control that Scripture forbids. Any view that cannot practice Intercession will run out of faith at the point where the parent's competence runs out. Any view that cannot practice Dedication will foreclose vocations that Scripture and Christian tradition uniformly honor.

The reader is invited to hold the three postures in view as the four SCAR components are summarized and the views presented.

5.0.5 A Practitioner's Operational Frame — Cop → Coach → Consultant

One of the useful practitioner-level frames the paper's readers may already know, and which maps closely onto the four-senses vocabulary of §1.1.1, is Dwight Cover's Cop → Coach → Consultant developmental chart (Christian Heritage Conference 2025 talk, "Dads, Prepare and Launch Sons as Men of God"; chart PDF in the author's possession, shared by Cover; Cover credits Gregg Harris as an influence and extends the material). Cover diagrams the parent's role across the child's development on two crossing axes: *parental discipline* (100% at infancy, declining to 0% at adult), and *the child's self-discipline* (0% at infancy, rising to 100% at adult). The young-adult zone in which the two curves cross is labeled "Battle of the Wills" — the turbulence Cover treats as a predictable feature of the release, not a failure of formation. The parent's role across the developmental arc moves through three named stages:

- **COP** — the control mode of the earliest years. Parental discipline is at maximum; the child's self-discipline is under formation. Directive authority carries the whole weight.
- **COACH** — the influence mode of the transition years. Parental discipline is declining, self-discipline is rising, and the parent's

contribution has shifted from *directing what happens* to *shaping how the young adult decides*.

- **CONSULTANT** — the counsel mode of the adult years. Parental discipline is at or near zero as the parent-facing intervention. The relationship is characterized as “shoulder-to-shoulder, man-to-man respect” — the adult child as, in Cover’s phrase, “fellow-heir of the grace of life.”

This developmental picture maps onto the paper’s four-senses vocabulary as follows:

Cover’s stage	Paper’s senses in operation (§1.1.1)
COP (control)	Sense (1) directive authority in the formation years, with senses (2) formative office and (3) counsel operating implicitly through it.
COACH (influence)	Sense (2) formative office and sense (3) counsel come to the front; sense (1) directive authority is winding down through the release seam; sense (4) intercession is intensifying.
CONSULTANT (counsel)	Sense (3) counsel and sense (4) intercession as the modes in which the parent-child relation continues; sense (2) formative office continues through modeling; sense (1) directive authority is released.

Two things are worth noting. First, this is a *practitioner-articulated* picture — a father of eight (six sons, two daughters), articulating what he tried to do across the actual developmental arc — that arrives at the same distinction the paper draws lexically at §1.1.1. That such a picture is available to practitioners in the field who take household piety seriously is evidence that the four-senses distinction is not an academic imposition on the material; it is the shape the material actually has when a thoughtful practitioner tries to describe how the parent’s role changes. Second, the picture explicitly *targets* release. Cover’s stated goal at adulthood is “shoulder-to-shoulder, man-to-man respect” and the son as “fellow-heir of the grace of life” — a launched-well outcome, not a continuously-covered outcome. The chart is a working practitioner’s statement of the status-bounded

reading toward which the paper's own lexical lean runs (§1.1.1, on the balance of §1.2.1's considerations): sense (1) directive authority bounded to the formation years, with what continues after that carried by senses (2), (3), and (4).

The paper offers Cop → Coach → Consultant to readers as one practitioner-tested picture of how the four-senses transition looks in a household that is trying to run it well; it is not the only such picture, and other faithful households will hold it differently. It is not offered as a doctrine but as a working frame — the sort of thing a parent might helpfully post above a desk in the season when the “Battle of the Wills” is live. A fairness note: Cover articulated his chart as practical fatherly counsel, not as a systematic argument in the doctrinal contest this chapter conducts. The paper's use of the chart as corroborating evidence for the §1.1.1 four-senses reading is the paper's use, not Cover's stated aim, and the sorting-note at §4.5 records his own daily-life register (1a-with-launched-well) so that his voice is not enlisted for the doctrinal contest without that sorting being visible.

5.1 Where All Four Components Agree

Five convergences are clear:

1. **Honor is lifelong.** Scripture (Exod. 20:12; Eph. 6:2-3), Christocentrism (John 19:26-27; Mark 7:9-13), Antiquity (universal patristic teaching), and Reality (every faithful arrangement) agree without exception.
2. **Marriage is the paradigmatic leaving.** Scripture (Gen. 2:24), Christocentrism (Matt. 19:5), Antiquity (uncontested), and Reality (every arrangement) agree.
3. **Parents provide for children; adult children provide for aging parents.** Scripture (2 Cor. 12:14; 1 Tim. 5:4, 8), Christocentrism (John 19:26-27), Antiquity (repeated exhortations), and Reality (every arrangement) agree.
4. **Christ is the first allegiance.** Scripture (Matt. 10:37; Luke 14:26), Christocentrism (the entire pattern), Antiquity (consecrated singleness for the kingdom), Reality (every arrangement disclaims itself if it displaces Christ).
5. **Unmarried adulthood is an honorable state.** Scripture (1 Cor. 7:7-8, 32-34), Christocentrism (Jesus's own life), Antiquity (Justin, Athenagoras, Cyprian, Methodius), Reality (every arrangement acknowledges it, though they order it differently).

5.2 Where the Components Create Tension

Four tensions remain:

Tension A — Obey or Honor? Scripture uses ὑπακούω (obey) for children and τίμα (honor) for the lifelong duty; but Scripture does not fix the age of transition. Christocentrism suggests the transition is real (Jesus at twelve is subject; Jesus at thirty is itinerant). Antiquity does not codify a transition. Reality varies widely — from age 18 launch to lifelong household residence. The tension is real and Scripture leaves it open.

Tension B — Sons and Daughters, Same or Different? Scripture treats them the same in general commands (Eph. 6:1-4; Col. 3:20-21) and different in some particulars (Num. 30; 1 Cor. 7:36-38). Christocentrism is largely silent on the distinction. Antiquity honors both consecrated sons and consecrated daughters, with some asymmetry in ecclesial roles. Reality shows a full spectrum: strict asymmetry in some faithful households, full symmetry in others. Scripture does not compel a single answer.

Tension C — Household Authority After Adulthood? Scripture's direct texts on continuing paternal authority over unmarried adults are few and interpretively contested (Num. 30, 1 Cor. 7:36-38). Christocentrism sets a boundary (no tradition may nullify honor; no earthly bond may rival Christ) but does not dictate a mechanism. Antiquity practices variability. Reality shows four viable arrangements in the daily-life dimension. This is the tension most productive of the modern debates about *daily household life* and least resolvable from Scripture alone.

Tension D — Where Does Parental Authority Most Naturally Sit? Scripture places parental authority heavily at *the marriage moment* — Genesis 24, 28, Exodus 22:16-17, Deuteronomy 22:16, Judges 14, Ruth 3-4, 1 Corinthians 7:36-38. Scripture also assumes household piety across the young-adult years (Prov. 1-7; Titus 2). Christocentrism is comparatively silent on the marriage-arrangement question because Jesus was unmarried. Antiquity assumes parental and pastoral involvement in marriages (Ignatius, *To Polycarp* 5:2) while showing variable household arrangements. Reality shows some cultures concentrating parental office at the marriage moment (Orthodox Jewish, Indian Christian, historic Christian courtship) and others diffusing it (mainstream evangelical). Scripture does not compel a single answer, but the *marriage-arrangement dimension* is textually witnessed more extensively than the daily-life-authority dimension.

5.3 The Views, Presented Neutrally

The tensions do not dissolve; they yield distinct, defensible views. Each view is held by believers who love Scripture, honor Christ, and seek the good of parents and children.

This section presents the arrangements at their steel-manned best, together with the orthogonal *Arrangement Question* that any of them may answer in more than one way. All four views are presented here in short form; **View 1b's full presentation lives at §4.1b** — its exegetical case (Haustafel as ordering continuing parent-child relation), its historical positioning (as its advocates present it, continuous with Puritan household religion, Reformed household covenant, Catholic paternal role, and Anabaptist family-integrated practice — a continuity Appendix B.1 examines), its representative works, and its contemporary carriers are all concentrated there so the exegetical, historical, and Catholic/Reformed threads can be traced together in one place. §5.3 does not repeat that full presentation here and instead directs readers to §4.1b for it. §5.5 names two failure modes — the Clutch and the Abandonment — that any of these views can drift into when its central good is treated as the god rather than as pointing to God; naming a failure mode is not the same as naming the view it can drift from.

View 1a — Household Continuity (Prudential Covering)

The view. Remaining in the parental household until marriage is the ideal biblical pattern. Departure before marriage is a principled exception, undertaken with parental blessing rather than as a cultural rite of passage. For daughters especially, the household provides an unbroken protective covering that passes to the husband at marriage.

The argument from Genesis 2:24. The paradigmatic leaving is leaving *into* cleaving — leaving one covenant household for the formation of a new one. Scripture nowhere prescribes a distinct leaving apart from marriage.

The argument from the honor commandment and Ephesians 6:1-4. The household piety these texts envision does not evaporate at eighteen: honor, teachability, and the ordered home continue as pattern for the resident adult — though 1a reads the obedience-imperative itself as tracking the household-dependent stage (§1.2.1); the no-upper-age-limit reading of the imperative is §4.1b's claim.

The argument from Titus 2 and Proverbs 31. The formation of women as “keepers at home” and as substantive contributors to the household economy assumes a settled household in which unmarried daughters have meaningful and formative work.

The argument from Numbers 30. The father's veto of an unmarried daughter's vow witnesses the protective household pattern; the abiding-category reading of "in her father's house in her youth" is 1b's stronger claim (§1.9, §4.1b), on which 1a's counsel does not depend.

The argument from 1 Corinthians 7:36-38. On the father-of-the-virgin reading, Paul assumes and endorses paternal decision-making about a daughter's marriage.

The argument from John 19:26-27. Christ arranges Mary's ongoing care through the beloved disciple — protective continuity as the Lord's own practice at the cross. (The systematic always-under-some-head paradigm built on this text is §4.1b's argument, not 1a's.)

The argument from the biblical narrative. The multi-generational household — Abraham and Isaac, Jesse and David, Boaz and Ruth in Naomi's line — is the presumed setting of biblical ethics.

The view, at its best. Preserves purity, cultivates family ministry, resists the atomization of modern life, honors Genesis 2:24 as the paradigmatic transition, and — as articulated by more moderate proponents such as Scott Brown, Jason Dohm, and Steve Walker — treats adult children as adults, counseling rather than commanding, and refusing ultimatums from either side.

Representative published works. The Puritan household-worship warrant (Matthew Henry, Cotton Mather, William Gouge, Richard Baxter) is examined against its primary sources at §B.1.6-B.1.7. The contemporary family-integrated case is developed in Voddie Baucham, *Family Driven Faith* (2007), *What He Must Be If He Wants to Marry My Daughter* (2009), and *Family Shepherds: Calling and Equipping Men to Lead Their Homes* (Crossway, 2011); Doug Wilson, *Reforming Marriage* (1995) and *Standing on the Promises* (1997); and the teaching of the National Center for Family-Integrated Churches (NCFIC) under Scott Brown and Jason Dohm. For the harder daughters-at-home case, sorted to View 1b, see §4.1b and §B.1.4.

View 1b — Continuous Doctrinal Authority (Systematic Covering)

The view. The outward practice of View 1a — remaining in the parental household until marriage, under a father's protective covering — is here held not as prudential pattern but as a *systematic requirement* of Scripture: every believer stands under a defined continuing authority, and for the unmarried adult child that authority is the parent. The daughter's covering passes to the husband at

marriage; the son's covering ordinarily transitions into the eldership of a local church.

The argument from the fifth commandment as permanent office. Honor of parents is nowhere age-bounded in Scripture. The commandment does not become "honor your parents until you are eighteen." Honor is read as including, for the unmarried, a continuing submission to parental direction — not merely counsel.

The argument from Numbers 30. The father's veto of an unmarried daughter's vow is read not merely as an ancient legal provision but as a standing pattern: the unmarried daughter's spiritual and moral commitments remain under her father's covering until they pass to a husband. The vow-veto category continues.

The argument from the Haustafel without age terminus. Ephesians 6:1-3 and Colossians 3:20 address "children" without imposing an age limit at which the address expires. The New Testament nowhere marks the transition-point that a launching paradigm would require.

The view, at its best. Preserves an unbroken structure of authority through the vulnerable pre-marriage years; refuses the modern atomization of the adult child into a self-directing individual before he or she is embedded in the next covenantal household; takes the Haustafel and the honor commandment at their uninterrupted word.

Representative published works. Watchman Nee, *Spiritual Authority* (1972; continued in Witness Lee's Living Stream Ministry as *Authority and Submission* — see §B.1.1); Bill Gothard, *Institute in Basic Life Principles* seminar teaching (1961-), including the *Life Notebook* "Friends" section on *Chain of Counsel* and *Eight Qualities Essential for Marriage* (§B.1.3); Doug Phillips (Vision Forum), *The Tenets of Biblical Patriarchy* (2007). Scholarly-register exegetical work supporting components of the position — including William Einwechter on the daughters-component from Numbers 30 and 1 Cor. 7:36-38, and Douglas Wilson on courtship (*Her Hand in Marriage*, Canon Press, 1997) — is treated at §B.1.8, which also sorts these as partial-component carriers rather than as systematic advocates of the whole doctrine and notes attendant biographical or public-record caveats a reader is entitled to know about (see §B.1.4). The systematic form of the position is treated in full at §4.1b; on the contested question of continuity with older streams — Puritan household religion, Reformed covenant, Catholic paternal role, Anabaptist family-integrated practice — see Appendix §B.1.

View 2a — Prudential Launching (Continuing Honor Without Continuing Directive Authority)

The view. Obedience is proper to minor children under the parental roof; honor is lifelong and inviolable. The unmarried adult exists as an adult under Christ, owing honor and consultation to parents but not obedience as if still a child. Directive authority ends; relational obligation and moral honor continue.

The argument from Ephesians 6. Paul deliberately distinguishes ὑπακούω (v. 1) from τίμα (v. 2). Honor is quoted from the Decalogue because it is universal; obedience is not because it is age-bounded.

The argument from Christocentric silence. Jesus does not inaugurate a continuing legal category of paternal authority over adult unmarried offspring. His own leaving for the Father's business, without ceremony or explicit release, becomes a pattern.

The argument from 1 Corinthians 7. Paul addresses "the unmarried" directly as agents — commending, exhorting, and instructing them without routing his exhortations through their fathers.

The view, at its best. Preserves adult agency under Christ, matches the New Testament pattern of direct address to adult believers, and prevents authority-arrangements that outlive their purpose — without releasing the adult child from the honor commandment or from ongoing counsel-seeking.

Representative published works. The mainstream evangelical case is developed across John MacArthur's expository commentaries on Ephesians (*The MacArthur New Testament Commentary: Ephesians*, 1986) and 1 Corinthians (1984), and in his pastoral counseling materials; James Dobson, *Bringing Up Boys* (2001), *Bringing Up Girls* (2010), and *Parenting Isn't for Cowards* (1987); Wayne Grudem, *Systematic Theology* (1994) on the household commandments; and the general teaching of Focus on the Family through denominational family-life curricula. J. Vernon McGee's *Thru the Bible* commentary on Ephesians 6 takes the honor-continues, obedience-ends reading as the plain-sense biblical position. The adult-child-specific pastoral treatment is Ross Campbell with Gary Chapman, *Parenting Your Adult Child: How You Can Help Them Achieve Their Full Potential* (Northfield, 1999), whose statement of the transition is direct: "We can no longer operate with the attitude that 'Father — or mother — knows best.' Young adults are not convinced. We must join them as fellow pilgrims rather than speak down to them from a position of superiority" (p. 32) — and whose account of the parent's remaining office is relational: "Your most important job just now is to maintain and attempt to improve your relationship with your child" (p. 28). The "fel-

low pilgrims” framing converges, from the mainstream-evangelical side, with the “shoulder-to-shoulder, man-to-man respect” language of the household-continuity boundary-case practitioners at §B.1.8 — the two views describing the same adult-to-adult terminus from opposite starting points.

View 2b — Release with Prayer

The view. At the point where directive authority has ended (as in View 2a), the parent honors the adult child as one who now stands directly before Christ. When the adult child chooses in ways the parent would not have chosen — including ruinous ways — the parent speaks the covenantal word (as Samson’s parents did), releases the adult child to their decision, grieves what deserves grief, intercedes without ceasing (Mark 9:24), and stands watchful for return. Love and prayer do not end because control has. This is a distinct shape from 2a’s launched-into-adulthood pattern: 2b is release-with-continuing-priestly-office, articulated most explicitly through the parable of the prodigal father.

The arguments, in brief (full presentation at §4.2b): Christ’s own parable (Luke 15:11-32 — the Father’s release-wait-restore posture, with the prescriptive-vs-descriptive question recorded at §5.0.1); Samson’s parents (Judg. 14 — “it was of the LORD,” as quoted at §4.2b); Hosea 11 (God’s own Father-posture toward His adult-son people, the ground on which Luke 15 builds); the priority of Christ (Matt. 10:37; Luke 14:26 — the parent’s continuing office priestly, not directive); and Peter’s restoration (Luke 22:31-32; John 21). At its best the view preserves adult agency under Christ and the parent’s continuing intercessory office, and refuses the drift into release-in-indifference that §5.5 names as the *Abandonment* failure mode — faithful 2b is release *with* prayer, not release *from* prayer.

Representative published works. See §4.2b — Ruth Bell Graham’s *Prodigals and Those Who Love Them* (1991) at their head, with Keller, Piper, and Elliot; the candid limitation note (no book-length systematic advocacy of 2b exists in the current evangelical catalogue) is recorded there.

Note on the “Household-Formed but Kingdom-Directed” Pattern

Earlier drafts of this study distinguished a View 3 to name households in which the adult unmarried child remains materially and relationally embedded in a household of formation — the parental household or another’s — while directly answerable to Christ for vocational and spiritual choices — Elisha under Elijah, Samuel under Eli, the Zebedee

sons under Christ. On further reflection the arrangement is not a separate view but a theological accent within View 1a (household continuity described in kingdom-directed rather than covering-forward terms), together with the biblical pattern of **vocational household transfer** treated in full at §1.4.6.

The Reality-leg witness of household-continuity communities — Amish, conservative Mennonite, Hutterite, Beachy Amish, Orthodox Jewish, East Asian Christian, and much of the Global South — is folded into View 1a's Reality-leg documentation below, §5.5's Reality-Leg Notes, and §B.3.5. The gospel-shaped household literature of Timothy Keller (*Center Church*, 2012; *The Prodigal God*, 2008; *Counterfeit Gods*, 2009) and the Anabaptist household literature of Dean Taylor (*A Change of Allegiance*, 2009; *Marriage, Divorce & Remarriage*), John Howard Yoder (*The Politics of Jesus*, 1972), and Menno Simons are cited in Appendix A alongside the other View 1a and Vocational-Transfer sources.

The Arrangement Question — Parental Mediation of the Marriage Covenant

The question, not a fifth arrangement (as §4.5 opens): who initiates and mediates the marriage covenant itself is a distinct, orthogonal question that a household holding any of 1a, 1b, 2a, or 2b may answer by parental mediation, by pastoral / ecclesial mediation, or by leaving the initiation to the couple with parental blessing. The full steel-manned presentation — Dwight Cover's threefold biblical pattern, the supra-cultural argument, the bride-price grammar, the redemptive-history typology, the ecclesial-mediation third mode, and the representative works — lives at §4.5; what follows is the short form.

The parental-mediation view, in brief. Parental authority is concentrated at the marriage-covenant seam — initiating, mediating, or blessing — while the daily-life question (residence, work, travel) is left comparatively open (§4.5, Description).

The argument from the biblical narrative. Scripture's most extensive treatment of parents and adult unmarried children is not about daily household management but about marriage arrangement: Genesis 24 (Abraham for adult Isaac at forty), Genesis 28:1-2 (Isaac for Jacob), Exodus 22:16-17 (father's veto), Deuteronomy 22:16 (father's legal voice), Judges 14 (Samson's parents), Ruth 3-4 (Naomi guiding and Boaz negotiating through the elders), and 1 Corinthians 7:36-38 (Paul's virgin passage on the father-of-the- virgin reading).

The argument from covenant. Marriage is a covenant, and every biblical covenant is publicly witnessed and mediated. Parental

participation is one of the primary mediations Scripture assumes.

The argument from Antiquity. Ignatius (*To Polycarp* 5:2) requires marriages formed “with the approval of the bishop ... not after their own lust” (as quoted at §3.4). Tertullian critiques secret marriages. The pre-Nicene church treats marriage as ecclesial and familial, not private.

The argument from realism. Young adults are often ill-positioned to evaluate a mate on their own limited experience. Marriage is a lifelong covenant transaction, not a romantic self-discovery.

The view, at its best. Recovers the covenant character of marriage. Reduces the burden on young people to serve as their own matchmakers. Draws families and the church into the formation of new covenants. Allows the daily household to breathe — the adult child may live at home, in vocational service, or launched — while concentrating parental office at the seam where the biblical text most consistently places it.

5.4 Practical Guidelines Applicable to All Faithful Views

Regardless of which view a family holds, these apply — each grounded in Scripture, in the pre-Nicene witness, or in the pattern common across the faithful Realities of Chapter 4:

For parents:

- Provide for the child through minority and into adulthood as required; teach the fear of the LORD; pray (Eph. 6:4; Prov. 22:6; 2 Cor. 12:14).
- Do not provoke to wrath (Eph. 6:4; Col. 3:21).
- Command is proper to the minor, counsel to the adult; the shift is presupposed by Genesis 2:24 (§1.3) and by the pre-Nicene expectation of adult household formation (§3.1.2, §3.10). View 1b reads the shift as delayed until marriage; Views 2a and 2b as accompanying the transition from minority; View 1a holds the command-to-counsel shift as proper to adulthood while its commended pattern keeps the household’s covering and consultation in place until marriage.
- Do not confuse the child’s honor with the child’s agreement. Honor is the child’s duty (Exod. 20:12; Eph. 6:2), and the parent’s task is to receive honor as the child renders it, not to withhold relationship until the child agrees. Where parent and adult child disagree, honor persists through the disagreement and is not thereby forfeit; a parent who treats continued relationship as revocable on the child’s agreement has confused honor

with compliance.

- Prepare the child for the paradigmatic leaving of Genesis 2:24, whether into marriage or into a consecrated calling honored across the pre-Nicene church (§3.4-3.9; 1 Cor. 7:32-35).
- Lay up for the child, not the child for the parent, in the years of provision (2 Cor. 12:14); the direction reverses when the years turn (1 Tim. 5:4, 8, 16; Matt. 15:4-6).

For unmarried adult children:

- Honor is not optional; it is not qualified by the parent's honorableness, nor retired at adulthood (Exod. 20:12; Mark 7:9-13). Honor does not require agreement (§1.1).
- Give priority to Christ, and use that priority as fuel for love of parents, not as a pretext to neglect them (Matt. 10:37; Mark 7:9-13).
- If a parent's counsel is unwise, dissent within honor; if a parent commands sin, obey God rather than men (Acts 5:29).
- Seek counsel (Prov. 11:14, 15:22), including from parents where they are living and willing (Gen. 24; Judg. 14:3).
- Prepare for the paradigmatic leaving of Genesis 2:24, in either marriage or a settled consecrated calling (§3.4-3.9).
- When the years turn, provide for parents as Scripture requires (1 Tim. 5:4, 8, 16; Matt. 15:4-6; John 19:26-27).

For churches:

- Care pastorally for unmarried adults, married adults, and elderly parents as members of the household of faith (1 Tim. 5:1-16; §1.6).
- Bring the marriages of your young under pastoral counsel and blessing — the practice Ignatius describes (*To Polycarp* 5:2; §3.4); how far counsel extends toward mediation is part of the Arrangement Question (§4.5), which faithful churches answer differently.
- Do not require of families a household template that Scripture does not require, and do not permit a template that Scripture forbids (§1.8; §3.11).

For parents whose adult child has walked away. This is its own category and needs its own counsel. The son or daughter has left the faith, left the church, taken a partner outside covenant, or set their face against the household's confession. What does Scripture give you?

- The parable of Luke 15:11-32 is Christ's own answer, and it is precisely calibrated to this situation. The father *lets the son go* with his portion; he does not follow, does not badger, does not compel. He also does not stop watching the horizon. When

the son is “yet a great way off” the father runs. The father’s task is not to *fetch* the son. It is to *release, watch, pray, and be ready*. This is §5.0.1’s release joined to §5.0.2’s “intercession-without-restraint,” applied to the exact case: unrelenting prayer, no relenting on the household’s confession, no cutting off, and no chasing.

- The Old Testament gives you a companion figure: Samuel, who mourned for Saul until the LORD said, “How long wilt thou mourn for Saul, seeing I have rejected him ...?” (1 Sam. 16:1). Grief is right; but grief can become its own idol. Samuel is sent to Bethlehem to anoint the next king while Saul is still on the throne. The parent whose son has walked away is not thereby retired from every other calling. There is still a Bethlehem to go to.
- The specifically maternal witness is Monica of Thagaste, mother of Augustine, who prayed for Augustine’s conversion through his Manichean years and beyond — seventeen years by the traditional reckoning — following him from Thagaste to Carthage to Rome to Milan, until Ambrose received him. Augustine credits her tears explicitly (*Confessions* 3.11-12, 9.10-11). This is not a promise that every walked-away child will return; it is a witness that the calling to pray is real, is long, and is honored in ways not always seen in this life.
- The modern evangelical companion to Monica is Ruth Bell Graham, who waited through the prodigal years of two of her sons and wrote the waiting down. Her division of labor is exact: “We mothers must take care of the possible and trust God for the impossible... We are to love, affirm, encourage, teach, listen and care for. We cannot convict of sin, create hunger and thirst after God, or convert” — and her list under “My Part (the possible)” runs: “love — love expressed; to pray intelligently, logically, urgently, without ceasing, in faith; enjoy being a mother; provide a warm, happy home; minister to their physical and emotional needs as I am able” (*Prodigals and Those Who Love Them*, Focus on the Family, 1991, p. 101). The same book closes an anthologized prodigal story with a mother’s letter that is the whole posture in one sentence: “if ever your heart should turn homeward, remember the door stands widely open, and there is nothing but joy that you will bring to us all” (p. 154).
- Practically: do not make honor conditional on the child’s return (Exod. 20:12 is not qualified by the child’s obedience either; the same principle runs both directions); do not let the walked-away child define the household’s worship or witness (the household continues its confession); do not sever contact unless Scripture requires it (which it rarely does at the seam of parental relation, cf. Matt. 15:4-6); *do pray, do keep the door open, do watch*

the horizon, *do* the next thing the LORD has given you today. Elisabeth Elliot's phrase — "do the next thing" — was originally counsel to those grieving. It applies here.

- A note on hope: the parable ends in restoration; the parent has no guarantee that this particular story will. The parent's faithfulness is not conditioned on the outcome. Hannah's Magnificat, Mary's Magnificat, and the widow of Nain's silence (Luke 7:11-15 — she did not even ask; Christ raised her son unbidden) together stake out the range: from confident intercession to silent grief that Christ meets. All three are honored postures.

The Marriage-Arrangement Dimension

The marriage moment is treated directly by all four SCAR components; guidelines here rest on their combined witness.

For parents at the marriage moment:

- Ensure the child's genuine consent, freely given (Gen. 24:57-58; Ketubot 39a-b, §3.1.2). Consent is presupposed in the Genesis pattern, required in rabbinic practice, and from the fifth century entrenched in canon law (§4.3.1).
- Do not let alliance, provision, or your own vision of the child's future *override* the child's consent or the child's calling before Christ (Matt. 10:37). Alliance and provision are proper concerns of the parent's office — Genesis 24 involves both — but coercion and the bypassing of consent are not.
- When the marriage is entered, withdraw; the child now leaves and cleaves (Gen. 2:24; Mark 10:7-8).

For adult children at the marriage moment:

- Welcome parental counsel and mediation even where the decision is yours (Prov. 11:14, 15:22; Judg. 14:1-3).
- Discern the covenant partner by the biblical marks: shared faith (2 Cor. 6:14; 1 Cor. 7:39), godly character (Prov. 31; Ruth), and calling (1 Cor. 7:17, 20).

For churches at the marriage moment:

- Bring the marriage under pastoral counsel and blessing, as Ignatius describes (*To Polycarp* 5:2; §3.4), in whatever form the household's answer to the Arrangement Question takes.
- Support families where parents are absent, unfit, or unbelieving, as the church did for widows and orphans (1 Tim. 5; Acts 6:1-6).

Commonly Offered Counsel Not Directly Derived from SCAR

The following counsel is widely offered in modern pastoral writing on these questions. Each is compatible with the SCAR-derived guidelines above and often prudent, but each rests on cultural judgment or contemporary prudential inference rather than direct scriptural, patristic, or empirical warrant. Readers weighing these should weigh them accordingly, and should not attribute them to the SCAR analysis itself.

On the parent-adult child relationship:

- *“Transfer responsibility deliberately; do not create perpetual minors.”* Restates the command-to-counsel shift in the modern rhetorical register. The underlying shift is SCAR-grounded (§1.2, §3.1.2, §3.10); “perpetual minors” is a 20th-century diagnostic framing.
- *“Never withdraw love on account of disagreement.”* Restates “do not provoke to wrath” (Eph. 6:4) in the modern therapeutic register of “withdrawal of love.” The underlying prohibition is SCAR-grounded; “withdrawal of love” as a diagnostic category is not itself biblical language.
- *“Make provision now for aging; do not require adult children to invent the provision under duress later.”* Prudential extension of 2 Cor. 12:14 and 1 Tim. 5:8. Compatible with those texts but not itself commanded there.
- *“If you receive material provision, receive it with gratitude and reasonable deference; if you provide your own, do so without arrogance.”* General Christian ethic on receiving and giving. Not distinctively derived from SCAR on this particular topic.
- *“Do not turn a household template into a doctrinal shibboleth.”* The paper’s own synthesis judgment. Compatible with §1.8 and §3.11, but a modern rhetorical caution rather than a scriptural or patristic command.
- *“Restore the church’s role in courtship and marriage counsel where it has been lost.”* Prudential diagnosis paired with the Ignatius model. The Ignatius role itself is SCAR (§3.4); the “where it has been lost” diagnosis is modern.

On the marriage moment:

- *“Pray and examine before initiating any conversation about a match.”* General Christian counsel; not specifically SCAR-derived on this topic.
- *“Do not use the marriage arrangement as an instrument of family alliance or financial arrangement.”* A modern Western-egalitarian prohibition. Scripture and Antiquity accept alliance and financial dimensions of marriage as normal (Genesis 24 in-

volves both; ketubot and dowry practice presuppose both). What SCAR actually forbids is the *overriding* of consent, as the SCAR-only guideline above states. This blanket prohibition should be held loosely and applied to abuses, not to the presence of alliance or provision as such.

- “*Discern what parents alone cannot: whether you can love this person for a lifetime.*” Modern romantic-love framing. Biblical criteria for the covenant partner are shared faith (2 Cor. 6:14; 1 Cor. 7:39), godly character (Prov. 31; Ruth), and calling (1 Cor. 7:17, 20), as the SCAR-only bullet above states. “Love this person for a lifetime” as a decision-criterion is a 20th-century framing.
- “*Provide teaching, counsel, and structured accountability during courtship and betrothal.*” Prudential elaboration of the Ignatius model (*To Polycarp* 5:2); the specific mechanisms are modern.

5.5 Failure Modes Common to All Views

Each view has a central good — family, launched adulthood, priestly-releasing love, parental mediation — and each view can drift the same way: when that central good ceases to point to Christ and becomes a god in its own right. The failure is not merely *forgetting* Christ; it is *replacing* Him with the good the view was built around. A failure mode is not the view. The Prodigal parable diagnoses the failure modes without collapsing the doctrines that can drift into them. One naming convention governs throughout: the **Clutch** and the **Abandonment** are the *characteristic* drifts of 1b and 2b respectively — the named modes their own strongest advocates must guard against — but they are not exclusive to those views; a 1a household can drift into the Clutch and a 2a household into the Abandonment, which is why the paper elsewhere speaks of households of any view “drifting toward” either mode.

- **View 1a (Household Continuity, Prudential Covering) fails when the household becomes the treasure.** Covering hardens into control. A father’s will substitutes for God’s. Marriage is delayed indefinitely. Adult children are treated as perpetual minors. Household continuity becomes a mark of piety rather than a means to it.
- **View 1b (Continuous Doctrinal Authority) is prone to the Clutch.** In its failure mode the covering itself becomes the idol — safety-under-authority hardens into a pledge of *spiritual safety* (remain under the covering, therefore no harm) and the direct answerability to Christ, the searching of Scripture, and the Spirit’s own leading that the New Testament *did not subordinate* to any human office are quietly folded into the covering along with the

directive authority. Ordered-means-of- grace becomes an alibi for evasion on both sides: the covering is invoked to guarantee what only Christ can guarantee; the parent's ministering-under-God is imitated in the ministering only, not in the under-God. Advocates of 1b who name the Clutch honestly, and who insist that the covering is one *ordered means* rather than the source of safety, describe the discipline in a form that avoids this drift. Naming the failure mode is not naming the doctrine — the ordered household in Ephesians 5-6 *ministers under Christ*; it does not stand between the believer and Him.

- **View 2a (Prudential Launching) fails when independence becomes the treasure.** The “advisory” mode is asserted so strongly that honor thins into optional courtesy, counsel is treated as elective, household piety disintegrates without a positive replacement, and the launched adult drifts into whatever the ambient culture already wanted.
- **View 2b (Release with Prayer) is prone to the Abandonment.** In its failure mode the release itself becomes the idol — autonomy hardens into a pledge of *spiritual safety* (no coercion, therefore no harm) and the continuing love, prayer, honor, and door-open watchfulness that Luke 15's father *did not release* are quietly released along with the directive authority. Direct-answerability-to-Christ becomes an alibi for withdrawal on both sides: Christ's priority is invoked to justify what Christ has not authorized; the Father's own release-in- continuing-love is imitated in the release only, not in the continuing love. Advocates of 2b who name the Abandonment honestly, and who insist that release without continuing prayer, honor, and counsel is not the Prodigal father's shape, describe the discipline in a form that avoids this drift. Naming the failure mode is not naming the doctrine — the Prodigal father *released and kept praying*; he did not abandon.
- **The Twin Idolatries.** The **Clutch** (a drift-mode of 1b) and the **Abandonment** (a drift-mode of 2b) are inverted forms of the same refusal. In the vocabulary of §1.1.1, the Clutch is the *idolatry of sense (1)* — directive authority absolutized into a guarantor of spiritual safety, so that the covering itself becomes what saves. The Abandonment is the *amputation of senses (3) and (4)* — counsel and priestly intercession dropped along with the released directive authority, so that release means release from the whole parental office rather than only from its directive mode. The Clutch promises “*I am safe because I remain under my covering*”; the Abandonment promises “*I am safe because I have thrown off every covering.*” Both refuse the Father — one by clutching, one by fleeing. Both terminate honor at the point control ends. The pastoral

temptations of each look opposite; the underlying refusal is the same. Neither drift can produce the lifelong honor Scripture requires (Exod. 20:12; Matt. 15:4-6), and neither can imitate the Father's own posture in Luke 15. The Prodigal parable diagnoses both — and shows that faithful releasing and faithful covering share a common center in the Father's undying love.

- **The Arrangement Question fails when the arrangement itself becomes the treasure.** Parental mediation hardens into coercion. Family alliance or financial interest overrides genuine consent. The couple's own discernment is bypassed. Parents extend the arrangement office into ongoing management of the marriage after the wedding. The parental office, given by God to serve the covenant, becomes a claim of continuing ownership.

Canonical illustration: Joash and Jehoiada (2 Chron. 24). The scriptural case that names the deepest form of the Clutch failure mode *from the formed child's side* is Joash. Rescued as an infant from Athaliah's murder of the royal seed by his aunt Jehosheba and hidden in the temple by Jehoiada the priest, Joash is crowned at seven and "did that which was right in the sight of the LORD all the days of Jehoiada the priest" (2 Chron. 24:2). When Jehoiada dies at 130, the princes of Judah approach; Joash listens to them, forsakes the LORD, and has Jehoiada's own son Zechariah stoned to death in the court of the LORD's house (2 Chron. 24:15-22). The pattern is the exact inverse of the Rechabites of Jer. 35 (§4.1b): where the Rechabites kept the ancestral command faithfully across the generations, Joash's faith held only for the lifespan of the priestly-household scaffold that supported it, and collapsed the moment that scaffold was removed. The formation was strong; it was never *interiorized*. The text stands as Scripture's own diagnosis that formation-under-priestly-authority is not itself sufficient to produce a Christ-following adult — the *goal* of formation is a heart in which the covenant is inscribed (Deut. 6:6-9; Jer. 31:33; 2 Cor. 3:3), not compliance under a scaffold. Every view treated in this paper has to reckon with the Joash pattern on its own terms: 1a and 1b as the failure mode their central good is most vulnerable to, 2a and 2b as the reason mere release cannot itself secure the interiorization the release presupposes.

A second canonical illustration: Samuel's sons (1 Sam. 8:1-5). A companion case rounds out the Joash pattern from the parental side rather than the formed-child's side. Samuel — the paradigmatic priestly-prophetic figure of the transitional era, himself formed under Eli (whose parental failure toward his own sons is treated at §5.0.1) — appoints his own sons Joel and Abijah to be judges over Israel. "*And his sons walked not in his ways, but turned aside after lucre, and took bribes, and perverted judgment*" (1 Sam. 8:3). The elders of

Israel bring this failure to Samuel as the immediate occasion for their request for a king (1 Sam. 8:4-5). The narrative places the deepest priestly-prophetic formation of the era — Samuel's own — into the same pattern Joash instances: a form of household piety that does not, by the mere fact of its own faithfulness, guarantee the interiorization of that piety in the next generation. Scripture presents this without simple moral reduction of Samuel, and without excusing Joel and Abijah — precisely as it presents Eli without excusing Hophni and Phinehas. The datum every view has to carry: even the most faithful household formation is neither the cause nor the guarantee of the son's own heart before God. The Rechabites are the counter-witness that shows what faithful multigenerational formation *can* produce; Joash, Joel and Abijah, Hophni and Phinehas, and Adonijah (§5.0.1) are the canonical witnesses that show that it does not always.

The love-and-unity test — sharpened in §5.7 to include the questions of discipleship, witness, church participation, and cost — catches each failure mode early, if it is applied honestly.

Reality-Leg Notes on Household-Continuity Communities

The Reality-leg data on household-continuity practice is disproportionately shaped, in the North American conversation, by the twentieth-century movements treated at §4.1b and by their documented failures. That data is real and stays; it is not the whole picture, and it does not describe the largest and longest-running Christian communities that hold something like View 1a in practice.

Amish and conservative Mennonite (Old Order, Beachy Amish, Hutterite). Community documentation from Donald Kraybill, *The Riddle of Amish Culture* (Johns Hopkins, 2001) and *The Amish* (with Karen Johnson-Weiner and Steven Nolt, Johns Hopkins, 2013); John Hostetler, *Amish Society* (Johns Hopkins, 1993); and the Young Center for Anabaptist and Pietist Studies at Elizabethtown College tracks a household-continuity pattern with unusually high retention (Kraybill et al. 2013 report rates broadly in the 80-95% band, varying by affiliation; northern Indiana at ~95%; see §B.3.5 for detail), stable multigenerational households, apprenticeship-into-vocation, and locally-mediated marriage formation. The pattern is neither Gothard-style umbrella nor Nee-style delegated authority; it is straightforwardly the older Anabaptist reading of Haustafel and household-covenant piety worked into a community rule of life. Failure modes exist (shunning practices — *Meidung* — bear the main critical weight in the outside literature; the Amish themselves defend the practice as an ecclesial discipline distinct from parent-child cutoff), but the pattern's endurance and its generational retention constitute Reality-leg data that any serious treatment of View 1a has to reckon with.

Global South Christianity. The demographic center of world Christianity has shifted decisively to Africa, Asia, and Latin America. Philip Jenkins, *The Next Christendom: The Coming of Global Christianity* (Oxford UP, 2002/2011), documents the size and shape of the shift. Household patterns in most of these contexts — West African Christian households, East Asian Christian households, Latin American Catholic households — sit closer to View 1a’s multi-generational household continuity than to the North American launched-at-18 pattern, without ever having passed through the twentieth-century umbrella-doctrine controversies. Anthropological and pastoral literature (Andrew Walls, *The Missionary Movement in Christian History*, Orbis 1996; Lamin Sanneh, *Whose Religion Is Christianity?*, Eerdmans 2003) treats the shift and its household implications. The Reality-leg observation is straightforward: the majority-world Christian household today looks more like §4.1a than like §4.2a; comparable outcome studies on Christian Smith’s measures do not yet exist for these households (§B.3.4).

Bearing on the SCAR analysis. The Reality leg on View 1a is not exhausted by the twentieth-century North American umbrella-doctrine testimony (Recovering Grace and West 2024, treated at §4.1b Challenges); those describe a specific North American subculture running the harder 1b form of the teaching. The wider Reality-leg witness — Amish, Anabaptist, Hutterite, Global South, Orthodox Jewish continuities — attests, where measured, durable generational transmission (retention: §B.3.5); the launched American samples show lower retention on the instruments used there (§B.3.1-B.3.2), though populations, instruments, and denominators differ (§B.3.4). That does not decide the view question; other faithful views can point to their own Reality-leg witnesses — for 2a, the resilient-disciple cohort of Kinnaman and Matlock’s study (§B.3.2), young adults who retained Christian practice *through the launch*, and the vocational-transfer and missionary record of §1.4.6 and §4.3.5, which is a launched record; for 2b, the pastoral literature and Ruth Bell Graham’s first-person testimony gathered in §5.3’s Release-with-Prayer block and §5.4. It does mean that the case against View 1a cannot rest on selective sampling of one troubled subculture.

5.6 Pastoral Edge Cases and Exceptions

The four views and the Arrangement Question are formulated with an implied ordinary case: two believing biological parents, a household intact through the child’s minority, an adult child whose vocational, spiritual, and marital paths lie ahead. Real households present many cases that do not fit that frame. These are not failure modes — they are pastoral realities the ordinary-case frame does not describe. The paper cannot address each in detail; five are named here because

readers regularly ask.

Blended families. Where an adult unmarried child now lives under the household headship of a stepparent — or where the biological parents live in separate households, either or both remarried — the Haustafel's addressee-set and the fifth commandment's honor-object multiply. Scripture is not silent on step-relations (Ruth to Naomi is the paradigmatic case of loyalty across a non-biological seam) but does not systematize them. The practical shape: honor is owed to each biological parent regardless of remarriage; the stepparent's household authority during the child's minority tracks residence and household membership rather than biology; adult-child obligations to stepparents are pastoral and prudential rather than commanded in the categorical mode of Exod. 20:12. Where a stepparent has raised the child as one of the household's own, the honor commandment applies in substance, though the biblical vocabulary does not name that case directly.

Widowed and single parents. The Haustafel envisions two parents; the biblical world often did not have them. Widows are a recurrent category in Scripture (1 Tim. 5; Acts 6:1-6; Ruth) and receive their own specific pastoral attention. The adult unmarried child of a widowed parent bears an intensified form of the ordinary provision-and-care obligation (1 Tim. 5:4, 8), and the church's role thickens (1 Tim. 5:3-16 assumes the church acts where the biological family cannot). Where a parent has raised the child alone through no fault of their own, honor is undiminished; where the single-parent situation reflects the parent's own covenantal failure (a father who abandoned the household, a mother who left the covenant), honor is still owed, on the fifth commandment's own logic that it does not qualify honor by the parent's honorableness, though the shape of expressed honor may be more constrained than the ordinary case.

The parent's continuing need. The four views describe the seam between minority and adulthood as if the household's ordinary gravity ran one way — the child's dependency lessens, the parent's oversight releases. In many households this ordinary gravity is reversed. A widowed or single parent may need the unmarried adult child's presence, provision, or care before the child's own marriage has occurred. First Timothy 5:4 addresses precisely this case: "if any widow have children or nephews, let them learn first to shew piety at home, and to requite their parents: for that is good and acceptable before God." The apostle sets this obligation *before* the church's own duty of relief. Deuteronomy 27:16 and Ruth's care for Naomi (Ruth 2:2, 18) supply the Old Testament pattern; Jesus's own commission of John from the cross (John 19:26-27) elevates it into a christological act. The bearing on the four views is this: where a parent's genuine need runs before

marriage, the adult child's ordinary trajectory (whichever view describes it) is modified by the honor commandment's provision-clause — not suspended, but reshaped. Views 2a and 2b, in particular, must resist the drift by which "launched" becomes "unavailable"; Views 1a and 1b must resist the parallel drift by which the parent's need becomes a covering-justifying claim that would not otherwise be made. In all four views, the parent's need reorders the household's ordinary shape without changing the doctrine.

Persistent disability or dependency in the adult child. The Haustafel and the fifth commandment assume an adult child who at some point becomes practically capable of independent household formation. Not every adult child does. A child with profound intellectual or developmental disability, a child with chronic mental illness that prevents independent living, a child whose physical condition requires continuous care — these cases are what the four views most conspicuously do not address. Scripture supplies partial patterns rather than a doctrine: David's care for Mephibosheth (2 Sam. 9), the presence in the covenant community of those who "cannot recompense thee" (Luke 14:14), the church's inclusion of "the feeble" (1 Cor. 12:22, ἀσθενέστερα, *asthenestera*) as indispensable. The practical implication is that the leaving-seam that the ordinary case treats as biographical becomes, in these cases, eschatological: the seam that never arrives in this life is carried in the household of faith by the parents until they can no longer carry it, at which point either siblings, the extended covenant family, the local church, or specialized institutions of Christian mercy must receive what the biological parents can no longer bear. All four views recognize the obligation, but none of them shapes its practical form; the church's diaconal office and the covenant community's willingness to bear one another's burdens (Gal. 6:2) supply what the views alone cannot. The parent whose adult child is permanently dependent occupies a household shape the Haustafel does not describe and to which the ordinary seam-language does not apply; honor, provision, priestly intercession (sense (4) of §1.1.1), and the church's own care converge on this case without any of the four views being the frame in which the household lives.

Immigrant and culturally-displaced households. Where an immigrant Christian household holds an inherited household pattern (often closer to §4.1a) inside a host culture whose default is §4.2a, the adult child stands at a cross-pressure the ordinary case does not describe. Some accommodations are prudential and proper (learning the language of the host culture's pastoral counsel, negotiating with a spouse from a different background); some are not (adopting the host culture's default view because it is the default). The SCAR framework itself is culturally located — written in English, from North American

church traditions, mostly for households navigating English-speaking Christianity — and immigrant readers may find that their inherited streams (East Asian Christian household culture, African diaspora household culture, Latin American Catholic household culture) already carry answers that the American conversation is only beginning to recover. The framework's non-negotiables (honor, Christ-priority, no forbidding or compelling of marriage, adult consent, singleness not less than marriage) hold across cultures; the arrangement space in which the four views operate is where faithful cultural inheritance can supply what the American default cannot.

5.7 The Ultimate Test, Restated

Every arrangement — Views 1a, 1b, 2a, or 2b; whichever answer to the Arrangement Question; sons or daughters; symmetric or asymmetric — must pass two groups of questions.

The family test — the questions any warmly-affectionate household, Christian or not, might set for itself:

1. Does it **promote love** in the household? (John 13:34-35)
2. Does it **preserve unity** between parent and adult child? (John 17:20-23)
3. Does it **enable lifelong honor** of father and mother, with content? (Exod. 20:12; Mark 7:9-13; 1 Tim. 5:4)
4. Does it **keep the peace** of the household? (Rom. 12:18; 1 Pet. 3:8-9)

The discipleship test — the questions only a Christian household can honestly ask itself and answer:

5. Does it **form a disciple**, or merely a well-adjusted family member? (Matt. 28:19-20; Luke 14:26-33)
6. Does it produce **visible witness** — enough that outsiders ask what makes this household different? (Matt. 5:14-16; 1 Pet. 3:15)
7. Is the **church of Jesus Christ genuinely part of the discernment**, not merely officiating at the wedding? (Acts 15; 1 Cor. 5:1-13, 12:12-27; Ignatius, *To Polycarp* 5:2; §3.4)
8. Does it **leave Christ above every human bond, including this household's own — and is the household willing to bear the cost of doing so?** (Matt. 10:37; Luke 14:27-33; John 15:18-20; 2 Tim. 3:12)

The Matt. 10:37 question sits *here* rather than in the family test: “he that loveth father or mother more than me is not worthy of me” is a discipleship claim, not a family-relations metric, and its placement in the discipleship set is the point at which the two tests diverge. A

warmly-affectionate secular family can pass all four family questions — that is the diagnostic thought-experiment this section runs. Only a Christian household can pass all eight. Where an arrangement satisfies both groups, it is faithful — even where it differs sharply from another faithful family's arrangement. Where it satisfies the first four and cannot answer the second four, the household has become a good thing that has quietly displaced the Best Thing.

Worksheet

For household use in prayerful discernment. Take the specific arrangement in view — an adult child's continuing residence, a proposed launch, a suitor received, a call declined, a marriage arranged or a marriage entered without arrangement — and answer each question in a sentence or two, in writing, before the Lord. Do not answer in the abstract; answer for *this case*.

The family test.

1. **Love.** In what specific ways does this arrangement promote love between parent and adult child? Where is love strained?
2. **Unity.** Does this arrangement preserve unity, or does it proceed over an unresolved tension? Name the tension.
3. **Honor with content.** Does this arrangement enable honor that includes provision, consultation, reverence, and remembrance — or does it enable a thinner honor?
4. **Peace of the household.** Is the household at peace over this arrangement, or is the peace pretended? Who in the household still carries the disquiet?

The discipleship test.

5. **Formation of disciples.** Does this arrangement form disciples of Jesus Christ, or does it form well-adjusted family members who happen to attend church?
6. **Visible witness.** Would an outsider observing this household ask what accounts for what they see? Or would the household look like the ambient culture with slightly better manners?
7. **Church discernment.** Is the local church actually a participant in this discernment — with real weight, not merely ceremonial presence — or is the church being asked to bless a decision already made?
8. **Christ above every bond.** If this arrangement had to be surrendered tomorrow for the sake of Christ, would the household be willing? Is there any human bond in this arrangement that would resist being subordinated to Christ?

Reading the result. If the household can answer all eight honestly and

finds no fault, proceed with confidence. If one or two answers press, name the pressure; do not paper it over. If the first four are fine and the second four cannot be answered, ask whether the household is discipling itself out of Christian distinctness. The worksheet is not a scoring device; it is a way of making prayerful conversation concrete.

One qualifier — the mixed-household case. Where the household is mixed in the sense of §1.4.10 (unbelieving parents, or a parent whose command runs against Christ's), the family test may fail on Questions 1-4 through no fault of the arrangement itself. Christ Himself says households will divide over Him — "I came not to send peace, but a sword ... a man's foes shall be they of his own household" (Matt. 10:34-36, quoting Micah 7:6). Where the division is caused by fidelity to Christ rather than by the arrangement, the family-test failure indicts the *circumstance*, not the household; and Paul's own qualifier "if it be possible, as much as lieth in you" (Rom. 12:18, the very text of Q4) already names the limit. The worksheet is not a device for extorting peace from the disciple whom Christ has called to carry a cross the household refuses.

Chapter 6 — How to Use SCAR Before the Lord

This chapter is written for the reader who has walked through the four components, encountered the biblical postures of §5.0, seen the views set out in §5.3 (Views 1a, 1b, 2a, 2b, and the orthogonal Arrangement Question), and now sits with the question the paper cannot answer for anyone else: *What should my household do?*

The SCAR framework does not deliver its answer as a conclusion. It delivers the reader to prayerful discernment better equipped than before. This chapter suggests how.

6.1 What SCAR Is and Is Not

SCAR is a *discernment instrument*. It gathers what Scripture says, what Christ Himself modeled and taught, what the pre-Nicene church practiced, and what faithful Christian communities have practiced since. It does not produce a single answer for every case because Scripture itself does not produce a single answer for every case.

SCAR is not:

- A four-column decision matrix that spits out a verdict.
- A ranking scheme in which Scripture “beats” Christocentrism “beats” Antiquity “beats” Reality. The legs are ordered in role (as the TL;DR puts it), not ranked as competing votes.
- A way to avoid prayer.
- A substitute for the discernment of the local church, faithful counselors, and the household itself.

SCAR is:

- A way of ensuring the four sources God has actually given the church are all in the conversation, not just the source the reader’s tradition emphasizes.
- A way of noticing where the four converge (great confidence), where they leave tension (space for faithful diversity), and where an individual case must be prayed through with real humility.
- A discipline for reading Scripture with Christ at the center, the early church as company, and the lived practice of faithful believers as testimony.

6.2 Walking Your Case Through SCAR

The reader with a live question — *should my adult unmarried daughter move into her own apartment? or should we ask her to remain until*

marriage? or is this suitor whom she has met on her own to be honored, or reserved for family and church discernment? — can walk the case through the four components.

Scripture. What texts speak? Read them with your case in mind. Which are directly relevant? (In many cases: fewer than the tradition assumes.) Which are analogically relevant? Which of the “difficult texts” of §1.7 press on your case in ways you may not have wanted to hear?

Christocentrism. What did Christ Himself do? What did He teach? Which of His hard sayings press on your case? Does your inclination align with the pattern of Christ, or with a cultural template?

Antiquity. Did the pre-Nicene church face something like this? What did the fathers assume, teach, or practice? Where they were silent, what did their common practice imply? Where they spoke diversely, what were the boundaries within which their diversity sat?

Reality. Which faithful Christian communities today (or historically) have addressed this well? Not merely which communities agree with you — which communities have *fruit* that attests to the Spirit’s work. Which have failure modes you can see? What can you learn from both?

Then a final component the framework itself points to but does not name in its acronym: **the local church, the household of faith, and the Spirit.** Present the case for prayer and counsel to the elders you trust and to the household members most affected. Discernment is *ecclesial* and *familial*, not merely individual — especially in matters of household life.

6.3 Three Sub-Tools for the Scripture Leg

Within the Scripture walk, three sub-tools have proved useful in the wider evangelical hermeneutical literature. They are named here so the reader can use them explicitly.

6.3.1 Precept → Principle → Person of Truth

Dwight Cover (drawing on wider Reformed and evangelical hermeneutics) proposes a three-lens reading for any passage addressed to the household question:

- **Precept.** What does the text *command* or *forbid* explicitly? This is the plain sense — the “expressly set down” of Westminster Confession 1:6.

- **Principle.** Why does God care about this? What is the underlying good the precept is protecting or the underlying disorder the precept is guarding against? This is the “good and necessary consequence” of Westminster 1:6.
- **Person of Truth.** How does this passage point to Christ, and how does Christ Himself embody or fulfill the principle? Every precept and principle in Scripture is finally *about* someone — the Person who is Truth itself (John 14:6).

The three lenses answer three common misreadings. Reading only for Precept produces legalism where Scripture is silent and license where Scripture speaks in principle rather than command. Reading only for Principle produces sentimentality that dissolves specific obedience. Reading only for the Person of Truth produces piety detached from actual practice. All three together produce Christocentric obedience.

Worked example: 1 Corinthians 7:36-38. *Precept:* the passage addresses a decision-maker considering whether to give a virgin in marriage; there is a permissive verdict either way (give or keep, no sin). *Principle:* marriage and singleness are both to be received as callings, and the covenantal decision belongs to the responsible party (father, on one reading; couple, on another) discerning the good of the daughter and the honor of Christ. *Person of Truth:* the Father Himself is the archetype of the one who gives — He gave His Son (John 3:16), and He gives the Bride to the Son (Rev. 19:7-9). Any faithful reading of the passage must eventually stand before the Father who gives.

6.3.2 The Leaky-Bucket Test

Steve Wagner’s leaky-bucket metaphor (as summarized by Cover) names a common failure of theological argument on questions Scripture does not settle by a single silver bullet. Rather than one airtight proof, the case is built from several partial arguments — none individually decisive, all together substantial. A bucket with several small holes still carries water if the water is added faster than it leaks. A case built from several converging biblical, Christological, historical, and pastoral arguments still carries weight even when no single argument is a silver bullet.

Most of the household-question cases in Chapters 1-4 are leaky-bucket cases. Almost none of the faithful views can be settled by a single verse. All of them are held by faithful Christians on cumulative grounds. The reader is invited to notice, when weighing a case, whether the objection is to any single argument (which may be a leaky pail on both sides) or to the *convergence* of arguments across all four SCAR components (which is where discernment actually happens).

6.3.3 The Assumptive-Language Audit

Del Tackett's assumptive-language audit (via Cover) asks a diagnostic question: *what does my language on this topic assume about the reader's culture, defaults, and practices?* If a modern Christian reads Ruth 3 and assumes Naomi's counsel is manipulation because "no woman today would tell her daughter-in-law to lie at a man's feet on the threshing floor," the assumption is imported; the text carries no such judgment. If a reader assumes 1 Corinthians 7:36-38 must be about a couple rather than a father because "no father today would decide his adult daughter's marriage," the assumption is imported; a first-century reader had no such default.

The audit is applied by asking: *if I read this passage as if the modern practice did not exist — as if I had never seen a modern American courtship or a modern American launched adult child — what would I most naturally conclude?* Where the naive reading and the modern reading diverge sharply, the modern reading may be doing more assumption-work than exegesis. The audit does not settle the question, but it prevents the tacit smuggling of cultural defaults into what looks like exegesis.

6.4 The Three Biblical Postures as a Discernment Aid

Before deciding a governance question, ask which of the three postures of §5.0 the moment actually requires.

- Is this a **Release** moment? The adult child has spoken; the child is choosing; you have offered the covenantal word. The question is not what to do *to* them; it is whether you can keep loving *through* what you cannot approve. Samson's parents are your company.
- Is this an **Intercession** moment? The child is beyond your reach — ill, hardened, distant, in ruin. The question is not how to reassert control; it is whether you will bring them to Christ in prayer without ceasing. Jairus, the demoniac's father, and the Syrophenician woman are your company.
- Is this a **Dedication** moment? The child is being called to something you would not have chosen — a mission field, a vocation of service, a consecrated singleness, or simply a costly obedience. The question is not whether you can retain them; it is whether you can release them *to God*. Hannah, Mary, and Christ at Gethsemane are your company.

Many family conflicts are misread governance questions when they are actually posture questions. The governance question — *which of*

the faithful views do we hold? — cannot be well answered without first locating the moment among the three postures.

6.5 A Worked Example — Eli and Samson

The Eli-Samson contrast worked in §5.0.1 is not only a scriptural illustration; it is a worked SCAR example.

- **Scripture.** Judges 14:1-4 (Samson's parents overruled and compliant, with the providential note) and 1 Samuel 2:22-25; 3:11-14; 4:11-22 (Eli's failure to restrain).
- **Christocentrism.** Jesus at twelve (Luke 2:41-52) — subject but not only to parents — is the pattern of the honoring adult child. Jesus in Matthew 15:1-9 — rebuking traditions that nullify honor — is the pattern of authority that never becomes self-serving.
- **Antiquity.** The pre-Nicene fathers uniformly assumed active parental catechesis of children (Didache, Barnabas, Polycarp) and simultaneous adult direct-address by the church to adult believers (Justin, Athenagoras) — the difference by life stage that Eli refused to observe.
- **Reality.** The failure of parental voice through weakness (Eli) is one of the persistent failure modes across all household patterns; the difficulty of releasing under covenantal objection (Samson's parents) is the persistent discipline of Prudential Launching and the Prodigal-shaped release.

The worked example does not settle any live case. It shows the reader what walking a case through SCAR looks like when done carefully. Every live case will demand its own similar walk.

6.6 Where SCAR Runs Out and Prayer Begins

Every discernment instrument has a terminus. SCAR's terminus is the point at which the reader has faithfully gathered what Scripture, Christ, the early church, and faithful communities witness — and the question remains genuinely open. This is not a failure of the framework; it is the framework doing its work.

At this point the historic Christian answer is not more analysis. It is prayer. James wrote to Christians who did not know what to do:

If any of you lack wisdom, let him ask of God, that giveth to all men liberally, and upbraideth not; and it shall be given him. But let him ask in faith, nothing wavering. (Jas. 1:5-6)

And to the Philippians:

Be careful for nothing; but in every thing by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known unto God. And the peace of God, which passeth all understanding, shall keep your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus. (Phil. 4:6-7)

The framework hands the reader to prayer better equipped, not freer of the need for it. The peace promised in Philippians 4:7 is not the peace of certainty about the right household arrangement. It is the peace of God guarding hearts and minds *through Christ Jesus* while the practical answer is still being sought.

If the reader has walked SCAR faithfully and does not yet know what to do, the reader has arrived exactly where the framework is designed to leave a reader: in prayer, in the company of the local church, and under the Lordship of Christ whom no framework can substitute for.

Conclusion — Love and Unity in Christ

The Shared Ground

However a reader adopts and applies the faithful views, all Christian views on the parent-and-adult-child question presuppose a common ground. Naming it explicitly, before the final practical exhortations, is not a matter of picking a view. It is a matter of naming what every faithful reading of Scripture on this question presupposes.

- **Christ is the treasure.** “Yea doubtless, and I count all things but loss for the excellency of the knowledge of Christ Jesus my Lord: for whom I have suffered the loss of all things, and do count them but dung, that I may win Christ” (Phil. 3:8). No view presented in §5.3 disagrees. The household arrangement, however ordered, is subordinate to the treasure.
- **The Kingdom is the field of hidden treasure.** “Again, the kingdom of heaven is like unto treasure hid in a field; the which when a man hath found, he hideth, and for joy thereof goeth and selleth all that he hath, and buyeth that field” (Matt. 13:44). Every arrangement in §5.3 is legitimate only as it releases the household — parent, adult child, and the whole fabric of household life — for the kingdom’s sake.
- **The believer’s life is hid with Christ in God.** “If ye then be risen with Christ, seek those things which are above, where Christ sitteth on the right hand of God. Set your affection on things above, not on things on the earth. For ye are dead, and your life is hid with Christ in God. When Christ, who is our life, shall appear, then shall ye also appear with him in glory” (Col. 3:1-4). The parent-and-adult-child question is important and it is not ultimate. What is ultimate is Christ.

Every Christian view in §5.3 is a view of *how* to live these convictions in the household. No view in §5.3 is a substitute for them. Where a view begins to displace these convictions — where the household arrangement, of whatever style, becomes the treasure instead of the vessel of the treasure — it has ceased to be Christian, whatever its structural resemblance to a defensible view.

The convictions above are the *shared ground*. The views are different fields plowed on the same ground.

Love and Unity

The New Testament pattern is clear at its poles. Minor children under the parental roof obey and honor. Married adults form new households and cleave to their spouses. The middle case — the unmarried

adult son or daughter — is left, deliberately, to be worked out by faithful households under the Lordship of Christ, in the community of the church, according to the honest reading of the texts we have.

The Bible does not give one household template. It gives:

- One command that never expires: **honor thy father and thy mother.**
- One paradigmatic transition: **leaving unto cleaving** in marriage.
- One first allegiance: **Christ above every earthly bond.**
- One inviolable boundary: **no tradition may nullify honor.**
- One direction of provision: **parents for children, then children for parents** as the years turn.

Within those, the Bible permits a range of faithful arrangements. It does not permit any arrangement that fails the love-and-unity test.

This study has surveyed the faithful views (1a, 1b, 2a, 2b, and the orthogonal Arrangement Question). It ends not with a further survey but with a summons to four sets of readers — and to the church that shepherds them all.

To the unmarried daughter reading this. Your ultimate question is not *which household template your family follows*, and it is not *whether you will marry*. Your ultimate question is whether the God who calls Himself the husband of His people (Isa. 54:5; 2 Cor. 11:2; Rev. 19:7-9) is enough. He is. You are not incomplete for lack of a husband; you are already betrothed. Whether the LORD gives you an earthly marriage or not, you are the beloved of the Bridegroom now. Set your affections on Him first, and every other question — including whether to marry, whom to marry, and how to honor your parents through the process — falls into its place.

To the unmarried son reading this. Your task is not to *wait* for a wife; your task is to *become* the man Christ is calling you to be. Elisabeth Elliot's counsel to her generation of daughters runs to sons with equal force. Manhood in Scripture is *given under call* — Elisha at the plow, Peter at the nets, Timothy from Lois and Eunice's knee to Ephesus — and the call is Christ's before it is your father's, your mother's, or your future wife's. Honor your parents; take their counsel seriously; and where Christ is sending, go — do not let waiting itself become the calling. Do the next thing He has given you, today.

To the parent releasing an adult child. Your love outlasts your control. You have formed this child as well as you have been given grace to form. Now the task is not further formation by decree; it is intercession without restraint, and dedication to the LORD. Hannah lent Samuel to the LORD “as long as he liveth” — not for a season.

Mary released her Son to a cross her release did not prevent. Neither woman controlled the outcome; both are honored. Your adult son or daughter belongs first to Christ. Release him there, and keep releasing him there, in prayer, for as long as you draw breath.

To the parent whose adult child has walked away. The father in Luke 15 does not run when the son turns around; he runs when the son is “yet a great way off.” He was watching the whole time. That watching — Monica’s seventeen years of tears for Augustine, Samuel’s mourning until the LORD said *how long?*, the widow of Nain’s silent grief that Christ met before she could ask — is not a lesser faithfulness. It is the parental posture of release joined to intercession-without-restraint (§5.0.1-§5.0.2). Keep praying. Keep the door open. Do not make honor conditional on your child’s return; do not chase; do not relent on your household’s confession. Do the next thing the LORD has given you today, and trust the ending to Him.

To the church that shepherds all of these: equip them. Do not require of any family a household template Scripture does not require; do not permit a template Scripture forbids (§1.8). Marry your young who are called to marriage. Care for and deploy your unmarried. Honor your elders. Bring the marriages of your young under pastoral counsel and blessing — the assumption Ignatius could take for granted (§3.4). And teach the reader to walk his own case through Scripture, Christocentrism, Antiquity, and Reality before the Lord (Chapter 6).

“And he shall turn the heart of the fathers to the children, and the heart of the children to their fathers.” — Malachi 4:6.

Soli Deo Gloria.

Appendix A — Sources Consulted (Selected)

Scripture

King James Version, throughout.

Deuterocanonical / Second-Temple Sources

The paper cites two deuterocanonical books as *Second-Temple background* rather than as canonical Scripture-leg witnesses, consistent with Article 6 of the Thirty-Nine Articles and Westminster Confession 1.3, both of which distinguish the Apocrypha from the canonical books while permitting their use “for example of life and instruction of manners” (Article 6). Editions cited:

- *The Wisdom of Ben Sira* (Sirach 3:1-16, 3:12-16 quoted in §2.5 as Second-Temple background to Mark 7 korban). The quoted block follows the *KJV Apocrypha* (per the 2026-07-24 source verification); the *Revised Standard Version — Second Catholic Edition* (Ignatius Press, 2006) and the *Douay-Rheims* (DRA) are consulted for comparison where noted.
- *Tobit* (Tobit 4-11 summarized in §4.5 for the arrangement pattern; 6:11-13; 7:11-14; 8:6 wedding prayer; 10-11 return blessing). Same editions.

Pre-Nicene Sources

- *Didache* 4:9-11, quoted from J. B. Lightfoot, *The Apostolic Fathers* (1891)
- *Epistle of Barnabas* 19:5, quoted from Lightfoot (1891)
- Polycarp, *To the Philippians* 4:2, quoted from Lightfoot (1891)
- Ignatius, *To Polycarp* 5:1-2, quoted from Lightfoot (1891); the marriage-with-bishop sentence (5:2) quoted from ANF vol. 1 (Roberts and Donaldson, 1885)
- *Shepherd of Hermas*, Visions 1-2, quoted from the ANF vol. 2 translation (Roberts and Donaldson, 1885); Greek text and modern translation in Bart D. Ehrman, *The Apostolic Fathers* vol. 2, Loeb Classical Library 25 (Harvard, 2003); older Loeb edition Kirsopp Lake, 1912-13; commentary in Carolyn Osiek, *Shepherd of Hermas*, Hermeneia (Fortress, 1999).
- *First Epistle of Clement to the Corinthians* 21:6-8, same editions.
- Justin Martyr, *First Apology* 15, quoted from ANF vol. 1 (Roberts and Donaldson, 1885)
- Athenagoras, *Legatio pro Christianis* 33, quoted from ANF vol. 2 (Pratten, 1885)

- Clement of Alexandria, *Paedagogus* (esp. III.11) and *Stromata* III.12.79-90. English in ANF vol. 2 (Wilson, 1885). Critical Greek text and French translation in *Sources chrétiennes* 70, 108, 158 (Mondésert, Marrou, Matray, Van den Hoek). English of *Stromata* Book III with commentary in John Ferguson, *Clement of Alexandria: Stromateis Books One to Three*, Fathers of the Church 85 (CUA Press, 1991).
- Tertullian, *On the Veiling of Virgins* 1 and 11 (quoted from ANF vol. 4, Thelwall trans.); *Ad Uxorem* I.5-8 (summarized, not quoted)
- *Passio Perpetuae et Felicitatis*. English rendering after W. H. Shewring, *The Passion of SS. Perpetua and Felicity*, MM. (Sheed & Ward, 1931); critical Latin/Greek text in Thomas J. Heffernan, *The Passion of Perpetua and Felicity* (Oxford, 2012); earlier critical edition C. J. M. J. van Beek, *Passio Sanctarum Perpetuae et Felicitatis* (Nijmegen, 1936).
- Eusebius of Caesarea, *Historia Ecclesiastica* 6.2 (Origen's youth). Kirsopp Lake, LCL 265 (Harvard, 1932); English also in NPNF² vol. 1 (Schaff, 1890).
- Cyprian, *De Habitu Virginum* 3 and 22, quoted from ANF vol. 5 (Wallis, 1886); *Epistle* 4 (modern critical numbering; = ANF *Epistle* 61, "To Pomponius, Concerning Some Virgins") on the *virgines subintroductae*
- Methodius, *Symposium* (Banquet of the Ten Virgins)

Note on patristic editions. Where the paper quotes pre-Nicene sources in English, the rendering follows the Ante-Nicene Fathers translation (Roberts and Donaldson, eds., 1885-1887) unless a more recent scholarly translation is named at the quotation point (as with the Shewring rendering of the *Passio* in §3.7.1). Chapter and section divisions follow the standard critical editions.

Hebrew Bible Commentary (Rechabites, Jeremiah 35)

Cited in §4.1b's exegetical challenges for the counter-reading of the Rechabite oracle as a Jonadab-vow contrast-device rather than as a generalizable pattern for perpetual filial obedience:

- Holladay, William L. *Jeremiah 2: A Commentary on the Book of the Prophet Jeremiah, Chapters 26-52*. Hermeneia. Fortress, 1989. pp. 246-52.
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- Walker, Steve & Wendy. “Courtship for the Glory of God.” Sermon, February 10, 2024. <https://churchandfamilylife.com/resources/65de5dfe16b49bdd100b82cb>
- National Center for Family-Integrated Churches (NCFIC), general teaching.
- Botkin, Anna Sofia and Elizabeth. *So Much More: The Remarkable Influence of Visionary Daughters on the Kingdom of God* (2005), with the authors’ subsequent reflections.

Modern Sources — Views 2a and 2b (Launched at Adulthood) and Household-Formed / Kingdom-Directed Communities

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Modern Sources — The Arrangement Question (Parental Mediation of the Marriage Covenant)

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This appendix consolidates material that is *contextual* to the positions catalogued in Chapter 4 but not directly load-bearing on the SCAR analysis. §B.1 traces the modern origins of View 1b (the Continuous Authority / “Umbrella” Doctrine). §B.2 traces the modern origins of View 2 (Launched at Adulthood, in both its prudential (2a) and release-with-prayer (2b) forms). §B.3 surveys the empirical / sociological literature relevant to the “Reality” leg of the quadrilateral, particularly with respect to Views 2a and 2b, with methodological caveats.

B.1 Modern Origins of View 1b (Continuous Authority / “Umbrella” Doctrine)

A note before the history begins. This section traces the twentieth-century origins of *View 1b specifically* — the doctrine that adult unmarried believers require continuous covering by a defined human authority as a condition of spiritual protection or God’s blessing. It does *not* trace the origins of View 1a (Household Continuity / Prudential Covering), which has a genuine Reformed and Puritan

household-worship warrant treated in §B.1.7 below. Views 1a and 1b are frequently conflated, both by their critics and by some of their proponents. They should be distinguished. View 1a's classical warrant is the Puritan doctrine of family religion — the household as a "little church" — grounded in Deuteronomy 6:6-7, Psalm 78:5-8, Ephesians 6:4, and the pastoral literature of the Reformed household tradition. View 1b's warrants are the four modern strands surveyed below and are, whatever their intended continuity with older piety, distinct twentieth-century developments.

A further methodological word is owed. This section's history is *scandal-shaped* — Nee, the Shepherding Movement, Gothard, Vision Forum, Sproul Jr. — while §B.2 tells View 2's social history in a neutral register and treats outcomes only in §B.3. That asymmetry is not a rhetorical thumb on the scale; it is a fact about the material. The twentieth-century movements that formalized the umbrella / covering claim into a systematic requirement are the doctrine's carriers, and their record is largely what a reader will encounter if she searches. §B.1.6 explicitly disclaims the genetic fallacy — scandal in a movement does not by itself falsify a doctrine held by persons outside that movement. §B.1.7 then reads the older Puritan, Reformed, and Catholic primary sources on their own terms and finds that they in fact bound directive obedience at adulthood, which places 1b's claim of continuity with those older streams in contested territory. Readers who hold 1b on independent exegetical grounds should read the history as history and the exegesis on its merits.

The doctrine as such — with the umbrella / covering imagery, and the systematic claim that being outside a defined human authority exposes the believer to spiritual attack — is a twentieth-century development. It arises in four related but distinct strands, developed largely independently at first and later cross-pollinating.

B.1.1 Watchman Nee — *Spiritual Authority* (1948 lectures / 1972 English)

Watchman Nee (*Ní Tuòshēng*, 1903-1972) delivered the lectures collected as *Spiritual Authority* (originally *Quánbǐng yǔ Shùnfú*, "Authority and Submission") to Local Church workers on Kuling Mountain in 1948; the English translation was published in 1972 by Christian Fellowship Publishers (New York), which renders Nee's *dàibǎo quánbǐng* as "delegated authority" and "representative authority" (the rendering "deputy authority" belongs to the Living Stream Ministry literature). The book articulates three related claims that would become foundational for later covering theology, each quoted here from the 1972 translation. (a) Authority is God's fundamental way of ordering the universe: "All things are created through God's au-

thority and all physical laws of the universe are maintained by His authority ... Authority is a tremendous thing in the universe — nothing overshadows it” (p. 10). (b) God delegates authority through representative authorities — parents, husbands, elders, governments — through whom obedience to God is mediated: “To rebel against God’s representative authority is the same as to rebel against God” (p. 20; the domains are worked out at pp. 61-66 for governments and the home, p. 190 for elders). (c) Submission to the delegated authority *as such* is required, even where the delegated authority is unjust, on the pattern of David refusing to lift his hand against Saul (1 Sam. 24; 26; expounded at pp. 41-44): “Whether the one in authority is right or wrong does not concern us ... The obedient needs only to obey; the Lord will not hold us responsible for any mistaken obedience, rather will He hold the delegated authority responsible for his erroneous act” (p. 71). Nee’s own ecclesiology (the Little Flock / Local Church) makes the elder the ordinary representative authority for believers not otherwise under a father or husband.

Nee’s book has been the direct or indirect source for much of the subsequent covering literature; the Shepherding Movement leaders read and cited him, and Bill Gothard’s teaching shows strong structural parallels. Later critics (both Chinese-language and Western) have argued that Nee’s application of David-and-Saul as a general authority-submission principle overreads a narrative text; defenders reply that Nee’s exposition carries its own qualification apparatus, which fairness requires stating. Nee treats Acts 5:29 (“We must obey God rather than men”) as a genuine exception where “the delegated authority here had distinctly violated God’s command” (p. 74), and draws a formal distinction between *submission* and *obedience*: “Should the delegated authority issue an order clearly contradicting God’s command, he will be given submission but not obedience” (pp. 108-109). The book’s second half, moreover, is aimed at the authority-holder rather than the subordinate: “Those who seek to exercise authority should not be given authority” (p. 175); “The Lord does not come to be authority; He comes to serve” (p. 176). Critics reply in turn that the exception is confined to direct contradiction of God’s command — leaving the unjust-but-not-impious order, which is the practically common case, under the p. 71 rule — and that the twentieth-century applications (§§B.1.2-B.1.4) conserved Nee’s authority-structure while shedding his restraints on the authority-holder.

A living continuation of the Nee stream. The Living Stream Ministry (Anaheim, California; founded by Witness Lee, Nee’s principal co-worker, in 1974) keeps *Spiritual Authority* in print under the title *Authority and Submission* and continues to teach the deputy-authority doctrine through the network of “local churches” associated with the

Lee stream. As a systematic carrier of the 1b covering doctrine as such, this stream is (a) currently active in print and in teaching, (b) not implicated in the specific misconduct findings that attach to the American IBLP-Vision-Forum stream, (c) theologically contested on other grounds — the ground of contention is chiefly the local-churches ecclesiology and its associated christological formulations, not sexual or financial misconduct — and (d) importantly outside the American homeschool- movement genealogy that dominates §B.1.3-§B.1.4. Its inclusion in this appendix does two things: it is honest about where the deputy-authority doctrine's most sustained living continuation now lives, and it complicates any framing that assumes the doctrine is coextensive with the American movements. Readers who wish to evaluate 1b's most current systematic articulation in print, and who have found the American vehicles disqualified by the Reality- leg data catalogued in §§B.1.3-B.1.4, will find *Authority and Submission* to be its most direct current expression. The paper does not endorse the local-churches ecclesiology; it simply names where the doctrine's living systematic voice presently sits.

B.1.2 The Shepherding Movement (Fort Lauderdale, 1966-1989)

The Shepherding (or Discipleship) Movement began with the Holy Spirit Teaching Mission (HSTM, 1966), reorganized as Christian Growth Ministries (CGM) in 1972 (CGM had begun publishing *New Wine* magazine in 1969), and crystallized in 1974 when five charismatic teachers — Bob Mumford, Derek Prince, Charles Simpson, Don Basham, and Ern Baxter, known as the “Fort Lauderdale Five” — formally submitted to one another in a chain of “personal shepherds.” Their teaching held that every believer must be personally shepherded by another believer to whom he owed obedience; the shepherd in turn was shepherded by another; the chain of covering ran up through the Five themselves. Marriage, vocational, geographic, and financial decisions were routinely made under shepherd direction.

The movement was widely criticized in the mid-1970s by Pat Robertson, Jimmy Swaggart, and Kathryn Kuhlman, and was the subject of a formal “shepherding controversy” convened by the Assemblies of God and others in 1975. Derek Prince publicly withdrew and repented in 1983; Bob Mumford issued a formal apology in 1989-1990, “A Formal Repentance Statement to the Body of Christ” (published widely in charismatic periodicals; see *Ministries Today*, Jan/Feb 1990). The movement formally dissolved in the late 1980s. The specific practices repented of included the routine subordination of family and vocational decisions to the shepherd, and the pastoral use of the covering language to prevent members from leaving. (Sources: S. David

Moore, *The Shepherding Movement: Controversy and Charismatic Ecclesiology*, T&T Clark / Continuum, 2003; Jamie Buckingham, “The End of the Discipleship Era,” *Ministries Today*, Jan/Feb 1990; Robert Digitale, “Shepherding Movement: An Idea Whose Time Has Gone?” *Christianity Today*, 19 March 1990. On the Nee → Shepherding link: Allan Clare’s circulated review *A Little History: The Truth about the Shepherding Movement* (archived at archive.org); Christian Research Institute material on the Local Church controversy.)

B.1.3 Bill Gothard — the “Umbrella of Protection” (1961-2014)

Bill Gothard’s ministry began in 1961 as Campus Teams, was renamed the Institute in Basic Youth Conflicts (IBYC) in 1974, and again renamed the Institute in Basic Life Principles (IBLP) in 1989. The Basic Seminar reached an estimated 2.5 million attendees between the 1960s and the 2010s. Gothard’s “Umbrella of Protection” diagram — God over father, father over mother, parents over children — was the visual centerpiece of the teaching: living under one’s proper umbrella protects from spiritual attack; stepping out from under the umbrella (for example, an adult unmarried daughter moving into her own apartment) exposes the person to demonic influence.

Gothard’s Advanced Training Institute (ATI, homeschool arm, launched 1984) and the Character First! program extended the teaching into family and civic life. The Duggar family (of *19 Kids and Counting*) was the most publicly visible ATI household. In February-March 2014, Recovering Grace (recoveringgrace.org), an ex-IBLP watchdog site, compiled testimonies from more than thirty women alleging inappropriate conduct by Gothard over decades; the number reached at least 34 by 2015. Gothard resigned from IBLP in March 2014; the civil suit *Wilkinson et al. v. IBLP* filed October 20, 2015 in DuPage County, Illinois alleging sexual abuse, harassment, and cover-up was voluntarily dismissed on statute-of-limitations grounds in February 2018. The 2023 Amazon Prime documentary *Shiny Happy People: Duggar Family Secrets* brought renewed public attention. IBLP continues to operate. (Sources: Kathryn Joyce, *Quiverfull: Inside the Christian Patriarchy Movement*, Beacon Press, 2009; the *Recovering Grace* archive; “The Cult Next Door,” *Chicago Magazine*, July 2016; *Shiny Happy People: Duggar Family Secrets*, Amazon Prime, 2023.)

The “Chain of Counsel” doctrine — Gothard’s operational vocabulary for the marriage-formation window. Gothard’s *Basic Life Principles* seminar and the accompanying *Life Notebook* material name a specific operational form the covering claim takes at the seam between formation and marriage: the *chain of counsel*. In the *Life Notebook*’s “Friends” section, under the heading “Eight Qual-

ities Essential for Marriage,” the third essential quality is listed as **“Harmony with Authority,”** with the practical instruction to “establish chains of counsel” — a defined list of persons (family members, friends, associates, spiritually mature adults, teachers and spiritual leaders) to whom the believer is accountable for major decisions, with special weight given to parents. The specific catechetical script for a daughter handling an approach from a suitor — “Before I can say yes, we’ll need to check with my father. Can you stop over and meet him?” — and for the marriage question itself — “Before I could give you an answer on marriage, you would have to discuss it with my father” — appears in the same document. The paternal-mediation-of-courtship practice thus becomes not merely a household preference but a *marriage-formation precondition*: **“Harmony with Authority”** is listed as one of eight qualities essential for a happy marriage, and the recommended wording for a young adult asking forgiveness of the parent — *“I have come to realize that I was wrong in rejecting your authority and being ungrateful for all you have done; I am calling to ask, will you forgive me?”* — categorizes resistance to the parent’s authority as by-definition sin requiring restitution. This is the specific *operational* form the Nee deputy-authority doctrine takes in the American homeschool-movement setting: chain of counsel as social structure, harmony with authority as marriage precondition, paternal mediation of courtship as the operational script.

The Life Notebook material continues to circulate. A first-person report from within IBLP-attender family networks (2026, in the author’s possession) — the “Eight Qualities Essential for Marriage” material forwarded to the author by a church elder as current premarital counsel — indicates that the doctrine continues to circulate in materially unchanged form through the same seminar-attender-to-household channel Gothard’s ministry has always used. That the doctrine’s transmission has continued through informal-network sharing rather than through fresh systematic book publication is itself a data point about how covering theology has *always* moved (Gothard’s own model was seminar attendance → notebook → household application), and the mode persists.

B.1.4 Doug Phillips, Vision Forum, and Biblical Patriarchy (1998-2014)

Doug Phillips founded Vision Forum in 1998 as an outgrowth of Vision Forum Ministries (formally established 1998). Its published *Tenets of Biblical Patriarchy* (2007) systematized the covering doctrine into an explicit patriarchal ecclesiology: the father is priest and authority of his household; unmarried adult daughters remain under paternal authority “until given in marriage” to a husband who becomes their

new head; the notion of an independent unmarried adult daughter as a normative pattern is rejected. Vision Forum's *Return of the Daughters* documentary (2007) and the Botkin sisters' *So Much More* (2005) popularized the daughter-at-home ideal.

Phillips resigned from Vision Forum Ministries on October 30, 2013, following the disclosure of what he termed an "inappropriate relationship" with Lourdes Torres-Manteufel, a young woman his family had taken into their household. Vision Forum Ministries dissolved in November 2013. Torres-Manteufel filed a civil lawsuit against Phillips in Bexar County, Texas (April 15, 2014), alleging predatory grooming from age 15 and a sexually abusive relationship spanning years; the suit was settled in 2018. The National Center for Family-Integrated Churches (NCFIC), which had been closely associated with Phillips, continued under other leadership and articulated more moderate positions. Douglas Wilson's Moscow, Idaho ministry (Christ Church / Canon Press / *Blog and Mablog*) represents an ongoing, somewhat distinct expression of biblical-patriarchy teaching without Phillips's specific covering framework. (Sources: Julie Ingersoll, *Building God's Kingdom: Inside the World of Christian Reconstruction*, Oxford UP, 2015; *Torres-Manteufel v. Phillips*, Bexar County, TX, filed April 15, 2014. On successors: the NCFIC website (ncfic.org) and Douglas Wilson's *Blog & Mablog* (dougwils.com) provide the movement's own current articulations.)

Kristin Kobes Du Mez, *Jesus and John Wayne: How White Evangelicals Corrupted a Faith and Fractured a Nation* (Liveright, 2020), p. 294, situates the teaching within a broader post-1970s network in which "Doug Wilson, John Piper, Mark Driscoll, James Dobson, Doug Phillips, and John Eldredge all preached a mutually reinforcing vision of Christian masculinity — of patriarchy and submission, sex and power." Du Mez's synthesis is scholarly reception of the movement in its patriarchy-and-masculinity dimension. Readers weighing it as evidence against particular figures should note that the six named figures hold materially different positions on the specific question of the unmarried adult child: Phillips articulates the covering / Umbrella doctrine (§4.1b, B.1.4); Piper holds View 2a with a strong complementarian marriage theology; Dobson holds View 2a with family-systems accents; Wilson holds 1a-strong on the daily-life axis, paternal-mediation on the Arrangement Question, and a covenantal covering-transfer claim for unmarried daughters (§4.1b lists him among the current carriers on the daughters- component only, and *not* as an advocate of the systematic umbrella / covering doctrine, which he has publicly refused); Driscoll and Eldredge lie largely outside the adult-child debate as such. The network Du Mez names is real; collapsing it into a single position on this paper's question would be a category error.

B.1.5 R.C. Sproul Jr. — Family-Integrated Church Voice (deposed 2006)

Not one of the four movements above but part of the same pattern: R.C. Sproul Jr. was deposed from the ministry by the Westminster Presbytery of the Reformed Presbyterian Church General Assembly in 2006 for what the presbytery called “abuse of authority in an inexcusable manner.” He had been an influential voice in the family-integrated church movement. He was subsequently reinstated in a different denomination but faced further controversies in later years.

B.1.6 The “Recovery of Puritan and Catholic Teaching” Claim

Proponents of View 1b often present the doctrine as a *recovery* of older Reformed or Catholic household piety. On the paper’s reading of the primary sources, the claim does not hold in the form its proponents state it; readers who read the same sources differently should test the passages quoted below.

Puritan sources. William Gouge, *Of Domesticall Duties* (1622), articulates a robust doctrine of household order — husband over wife, parents over children, master over servants — grounded in the fifth commandment. But Gouge treats parental authority over children as *age-limited* in its directive form: the treatise puts the question directly at Treatise 5 §62 — “Quest. What if children be growne to yeeres, and not vnder their parents gouernment?” — and answers, “There may be some difference both in some parts of subiection, and also in the manner of subiection betwixt such children as remaine vnder their parents gouernment, and such as are freed from it: but yet so long as a childe hath a parent, of what age or estate so euer he be, he oweth an honour vnto his parent.” Directive subjection is tied to the “vnder gouernment” state; the honor duty continues past it. Marriage is the ordinary transition point at which the daughter passes from paternal to marital authority; there is no doctrine that a fatherless or launched adult daughter must be re-covered by an elder. Richard Baxter, *A Christian Directory* (1673), similarly treats the “government of children” as ending with adulthood and marriage; Baxter is emphatic that the honor commandment continues but treats marriage-promises made while “the child was at age” as adult acts that bind on their own account, rather than as acts requiring continuing parental consent for validity. The Westminster Larger Catechism (Q. 129-130) treats superiors and inferiors generally without positing an umbrella-of-protection doctrine of continuous covering. The Puritan household was ordered and pious; it was not umbrella-doctrinal in the twentieth-century sense.

Catholic sources. The Catechism of the Catholic Church (2214-2220,

citing the tradition) is explicit: “Obedience toward parents ceases with the emancipation of the children; not so respect, which is always owed to them” (CCC 2217, as quoted at §4.3.1). Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* II-II, q. 101, treats *pietas* (filial piety) as a lifelong virtue; but *obedientia* to parents is treated at II-II q. 104 as bounded by the natural termination of paternal power and by the higher law of God. Aquinas is specific at q. 104 a. 5: Paul’s “in all things” (Col. 3:20) is read as jurisdictionally scoped, and the article names the cases where the jurisdiction does not reach — “servants are not bound to obey their masters, nor children their parents, in the question of contracting marriage or of remaining in the state of virginity or the like” (Dominican trans.; Latin text in the Leonine edition via Corpus Thomisticum). The *doctor communis* of the Catholic tradition thus places the paper’s central topic — the adult child’s marriage decision — explicitly outside continuing paternal directive authority, while condemning *obedientia indiscreta* (undiscriminating obedience) as a vice rather than a virtue. The 1983 Code of Canon Law (canons 1058, 1071, 1083) requires the ability to marry as an adult without parental consent, and while parental blessing is strongly encouraged (canon 1071 § 1, 6°), it is not required for validity — a canonical position established at the Council of Trent (Session 24, *Tametsi* decree, Chapter I, 1563), which anathematized those who claimed that marriages contracted by children without parental consent are invalid. The Catholic tradition is emphatic on lifelong *honor* and on *vocational discernment* under ecclesial guidance; it does not teach an umbrella-of-protection doctrine of continuous covering by a defined human authority.

The four modern strands are therefore, whatever their intended continuity with older piety, a distinct twentieth-century doctrinal development. This does not by itself falsify the doctrine, which must be assessed on its own scriptural and theological claims (see §4.1b). It does mean the “recovery” framing overstates the historical warrant.

B.1.7 The Actual Reformed and Puritan Warrant — for View 1a, Not 1b

A separate and prior tradition does bear on View 1a, and it should not be lost inside the criticism of View 1b. The Reformed and Puritan tradition of household worship — of the Christian household as “a little church” — is a robust, textually-anchored, ecclesially-endorsed pattern of pious multigenerational household life that is compatible with View 1a but that is not the modern umbrella doctrine.

Matthew Henry, *A Church in the House: A Sermon Concerning Family-Religion* (London, preached 16 April 1704; printed for Tho. Parkhurst). Henry, the Presbyterian pastor at Chester and

author of the celebrated *Exposition of the Old and New Testament*, preached this sermon in London and printed it “at the Request of Some who Heard the Substance of it Preach’d.” The core exhortation is that “every house should be a little church” — that heads of households lead daily Scripture reading, catechesis, and prayer with the whole household present. Henry does not teach a covering doctrine, does not teach that an adult unmarried child requires continuous submission under an authority as a condition of God’s protection, and does not teach that departure from the paternal household is spiritually dangerous per se. He teaches that the household — as long as it persists as a household — is to be a worshiping unit. That is the Puritan warrant relevant to View 1a: not authority-continuation but worship-continuation.

Cotton Mather, *Cares about the Nurseries* (Boston, 1702).

Mather issued the work as two paired discourses: “The One, Offering Methods and Motives for Parents to Catechise their Children, while yet under the Tuition of their Parents. The Other, Offering Some Instructions for Children, How they may do well, when they come to years of doing for themselves.” The paired shape of the work — parent-facing and child-facing, “under the tuition of their parents” and “when they come to years of doing for themselves” — makes explicit what the older Reformed tradition assumed: that parental tuition has a natural terminus (the child’s years of “doing for themselves”), and that both stages have their proper piety. The Puritan formation of adult offspring is by pre-adult catechesis, not by post-adult continuous covering. Mather also wrote the better-known *A Family Well-Ordered* (1699), which similarly treats the reciprocal duties of parents and children within an assumed household life-cycle.

William Gouge and Richard Baxter (already treated in §B.1.6): Gouge’s *Of Domesticall Duties* (1622) and Baxter’s *A Christian Directory* (1673) round out the picture. Both treat parental authority over children as directive during the years of household formation and honor-only after adulthood or marriage. Neither posits a doctrine of continuous covering.

What this warrant supports and does not support.

The Reformed and Puritan household tradition supports:

- The household as a worshiping unit — daily Scripture, catechesis, prayer — for as long as the household persists.
- Deliberate, sustained parental catechesis of children through adolescence and into “years of doing for themselves” (Mather’s phrase; Deut. 6:6-7).
- Multigenerational household life as an honorable and biblically witnessed pattern.

- Marriage as *an* ordinary transition point at which household membership is renegotiated (life-cycle service into another household was another; see §B.2.1 for the historical qualification).
- Fathers as active *disciplers*, not merely disciplinarians (Eph. 6:4).

It does not support:

- The umbrella doctrine — that adult believers require continuous covering by a defined human authority as a condition of spiritual protection.
- The claim that departure from the paternal household prior to marriage is *per se* sinful or spiritually dangerous.
- The claim that adult unmarried offspring owe ongoing directive obedience of the kind proper to minor children.
- Any doctrine that would nullify the honor Christ commands (Matt. 15:4-6) by making household submission the means of that honor.

The Puritan warrant is real and it is different from the modern umbrella doctrine. Both critics and defenders of View 1a will read the tradition more clearly by keeping the two distinct.

B.1.8 Current Carriers and Adjacent Voices

Two research notes migrated from §4.1b, preserved in full: the search for currently active systematic carriers of the covering doctrine, and the Plymouth Brethren / dispensationalist picture.

A note on the current systematic carriers. In preparing this chapter the author searched, in print and online, for currently active systematic defenses of the covering doctrine in the same register as Nee, Gothard, or Phillips. The finding is fuller than “the doctrine now lives only in older texts,” and the paper records the fuller finding so the reader is not left to infer an absence that is not there. Four current carriers, each of a different type, sit in the field, with two adjacent observations about American mainstream-adjacent practitioners belonging in the honest inventory though they do not themselves function as carriers of the doctrine.

- *Exegetical, daughters-form, with a doctrinal-notoriety caveat.* William (Bill) Einwechter, a Reformed pastor and theologian, wrote the most direct scholarly-register exegetical defense of the daughters-form of the claim: “What About the Unmarried Daughter?” (originally circulated in *Patriarch* magazine and the Vision Forum orbit), arguing from Numbers 30 and the father-of-the-virgin reading of 1 Corinthians 7:36-38 that the unmarried adult daughter remains under paternal authority until marriage. The

caveat, which the paper names first in its name-the-asymmetry style: Einwechter is a theonomist whose 1999 essay defending the continuing judicial validity of the Deuteronomy 21 penalty for the incorrigible son drew wide criticism — a doctrinal notoriety, distinct from personal misconduct but a real reason readers of his marriage essay will weigh it accordingly. Both essays share the assumption of the Mosaic judicial law’s continuing magisterial reach; readers of the marriage essay can weigh it with that hermeneutic in view.

- *A living Nee stream, outside American evangelicalism.* Witness Lee’s Living Stream Ministry (Anaheim, California; founded 1974) continues to print and teach Nee’s *Spiritual Authority* as *Authority and Submission*. This is the deputy-authority doctrine’s most sustained current systematic voice in print. It sits outside the American homeschool-movement genealogy that §B.1.3-§B.1.4 catalogues; it is theologically contested on other grounds (chiefly its local-churches ecclesiology and associated christological formulations), not on the Reality-leg data that attaches to the American movements. Treated in §B.1.1.
- *The Gothard Life Notebook material, continuing through informal-network transmission.* The chain-of-counsel doctrine Gothard developed in the IBLP *Basic Life Principles* seminar and the accompanying *Life Notebook* material has never depended on bookstore-shelf distribution; it moves through the seminar-to-notebook-to-household channel Gothard’s ministry has always used. A first-person report from within IBLP-attender family networks (2026, in the author’s possession) — “Eight Qualities Essential for Marriage” and its associated catechetical scripts forwarded to the author as current pre-marital counsel — indicates that the material continues to circulate in materially unchanged form. Treated in §B.1.3.
- *A daughters-component partial carrier, inside a framework that refuses the full covering doctrine.* Douglas Wilson’s *Her Hand in Marriage: Biblical Courtship in the Modern World* (Canon Press, 1997) is the most rhetorically able current living defense of two specific components of the traditional claim: the father’s continuing jurisdiction over the daughter’s courtship (Exod. 22:16-17; Num. 30; the bride-price grammar) and the covering-transfer at marriage. On those two components it is stronger writing than any other current source. Wilson advances the argument, however, inside a framework that *explicitly rejects* the universal umbrella / covering mechanics of the Vision Forum articulation — he has publicly refused the daughters-at-home absolutism in print — and his position on sons is launch-shaped (*Future Men*, Canon Press, 1999). Wilson thus belongs in the honest inventory as a current carrier of the *daughters-component* of

1b, not as a systematic advocate of the whole covering doctrine. The paper cites *Her Hand in Marriage* on its exegetical merits in the Arrangement Question treatment (§5.3); its inclusion here is the same discipline applied to the carriers finding — engage the text and name the frame, rather than avoid the contested person. Wilson’s public controversies lie on grounds unrelated to the covering doctrine and are not Reality-leg data for it; the paper engages the text. Treated further at §B.1.4.

Two adjacent observations belong in the inventory though they are not themselves carriers of the covering doctrine:

- *The deliberate boundary case — American mainstream-adjacent voices who articulate a boundary against the full claim.* Voddie Baucham, Scott Brown, Jason Dohm, and Dwight Cover — practitioners who take the household-continuity pattern most seriously in the current American evangelical setting — are, on the daily-life axis, working in the 1a register (household as pattern and pastoral wisdom) rather than the 1b register (household as systematic doctrinal requirement). Baucham’s father-as-family-shepherd framework — building the household discipleship ethos of *Family Driven Faith* (2007) into a head-of-household formal structure in *Family Shepherds: Calling and Equipping Men to Lead Their Homes* (Crossway, 2011) — is the paradigm case. Baucham’s own critique of reducing fatherhood to material provision is direct: “Parenting, especially when it comes to fathers, has been reduced to a materialistic endeavor. A man with a job that takes him away from his wife and children and removes all possibility of spiritual influence now takes solace in the fact that he’s ‘working to give them what really matters’” (*Family Shepherds*, p. 75). The right ordering, in Baucham’s own framing, subordinates career to family identity: “Are you a doctor who has a wife on the side, or are you a husband and father who provides for his family through a job in the medical field?” (*Family Shepherds*, p. 96). The formulation is thus a household-shepherd doctrine rather than a covering doctrine: material provision matters but is not sufficient; spiritual shepherding of the household is the father’s core duty. The doctrinal under-frame is a three-jurisdictions sphere-sovereignty: “God designed the world with three distinct institutions — the family, the church, and the civil government — each with specific jurisdictions. The church can no more tell a family how to run its affairs than it can tell the state how to run theirs. Certainly, the church has a responsibility to teach, admonish, warn, and guide. However, it may not govern the other jurisdictions” (*Family Shepherds*, p. 176) — a Kuyperian sphere-separation that distinguishes 1a from 1b (which reads the church-elder covering as continuing

over the launched adult child). Baucham himself treats launch as the expected trajectory: his chapter sections “Preparing Your Marriage for the Empty Nest” and “Preparing Your Children for Marriage” (pp. 97-98) are consistent with a frame in which the family-shepherd’s authority is bounded at the household-formation seam rather than extended over the launched adult; and his use of the “adult children” category at p. 175 places them in the 1 Tim. 5:4 reverse-provision direction (adult children caring for aging parents), a role that presupposes their own independent household-formation. Cover’s Cop → Coach → Consultant chart (Christian Heritage Conference 2025 talk, “Dads, Prepare and Launch Sons as Men of God”; unpublished chart in author’s possession, discussed at §5.0.5) explicitly argues that parental discipline should decline to 0% by adulthood, targeting “shoulder-to-shoulder, man-to-man respect” and the adult child as “fellow-heir of the grace of life.” Brown and Dohm’s National Center for Family-Integrated Churches teaching draws the same boundary in family-integrated-church register. These voices are the doctrine’s current *deliberate boundary case*, practitioners of the household-continuity intuition who have positioned themselves in print against the full continuous-authority claim while running the outward shape.

- *Practice without doctrinal adjudication.* Steven and Teri Maxwell’s Titus2 material (books, blog, and family conferences over the 1990s-2020s) runs the father-mediated courtship and adult-children-at-home practices at full strength without articulating a position on the systematic doctrinal claim in either direction — practice literature without the doctrine’s adjudication. Their material is thus an honest data point about how the outward household-continuity shape can be run as devotional-practical piety detached from the doctrinal question, but it is not itself a carrier of the covering doctrine’s articulation.

The reader is thus not left to infer that the absence of a mainstream-bookstore systematic advocate means the position is unheld or unarticulated; it is held, and it is articulated in four current active carriers of different types — Einwechter’s exegetical essay defending the daughters-form, Living Stream Ministry’s continuation of Nee outside American evangelicalism, Gothard Life Notebook material circulating through IBLP-attender networks, and Wilson’s daughters-component argument inside a covering-doctrine-refusing frame. The mainstream American practitioners closest to the intuition either draw the boundary explicitly in print (Baucham, Cover, Brown, Dohm) or run the practice without adjudicating the doctrine (Maxwells).

Note on Plymouth Brethren and dispensationalist writers. These communities and voices are sometimes assumed to share 4.1b,

but the picture is more complex. The *Exclusive Brethren* lineage (Darby → J.B. Stoney → F.E. Raven → J.T. Taylor Sr. and Jr. → Hales, now organized as the Plymouth Brethren Christian Church) practices strict community and family separation from outsiders, including “withdrawing from” (a form of shunning) that can sever adult family relationships — a practice the community itself grounds in its reading of the separation texts (2 Tim. 2:19-22; 2 Cor. 6:14-17) and in Darby’s founding principle (*Separation from Evil God’s Principle of Unity*, 1834), as ecclesial obedience rather than family cutoff. Ngaire Thomas, raised in the Taylor-era Exclusive Brethren and now outside the community, describes the formation aim in her memoir *Behind Closed Doors* (Penguin NZ, 2004): “an independent spirit ... usually meant that a person had begun to think for themselves rather than obeying the M.O.G. [Man of God] — an undesirable trait that needed to be dealt with.” Craig Hoyle’s *Excommunicated* (HarperCollins NZ, 2023) documents the same pattern from another survivor’s perspective. The practical outcome — adult community members remaining under communal and paternal authority — resembles View 1b in outward shape, but the theological engine is *ecclesial-separation doctrine* rather than Nee’s *delegated-authority* teaching or Gothard’s *umbrella* teaching.

The *Open Brethren* (Anthony Norris Groves, Robert Chapman, George Müller, and their heirs) have no doctrinal position on adult unmarried children as such and in practice track the mainstream evangelical launched-at-adulthood pattern (§4.2a) with strong assembly involvement.

Dispensationalist writers proper. Modern American dispensationalism *originated* in the Brethren movement — Darby’s sevenfold division of biblical history and his pre-tribulational rapture teaching are its parent stock — but propagated across the American evangelical world well beyond the Brethren, through the Scofield Reference Bible (1909, revised 1917) and the Dallas Theological Seminary tradition (Lewis Sperry Chafer, John Walvoord, Charles Ryrie, J. Dwight Pentecost). These writers are not Brethren, and neither is the most prominent contemporary inheritor of the dispensational lineage, John MacArthur — pastor of Grace Community Church in Sun Valley, California, and founder of The Master’s Seminary, whose soteriology is Reformed and whose ecclesiology is independent and Baptist. He is a “leaky” dispensationalist in the classification the movement uses of itself, not a Brethren.

None of these writers press the umbrella doctrine, and where they engage the Ephesians 6:1 passage they tend to hold the age-limited reading. MacArthur’s *Ephesians* (Moody, 1986, at Eph. 6:1) reads it explicitly: “*Tekna* (children) is a general term for children and is not

limited to a specific age group. It refers to any child still living in the home and under parental guidance.” The present-tense imperative “demands a continuous obedience” — but continuous *within* the age-scope of “child still living in the home and under parental guidance.” That is substantially the status-bounded reading toward which the paper’s own lexical lean runs (§1.1.1, §1.2.1). The Scofield Reference Bible (1917 note at Eph. 6:1) is a bare cross-reference to Colossians 3:20 with no substantive treatment of scope. Ryrie’s *Basic Theology* (Moody, 1986/1999) and study-Bible notes do not thematize the age-limitation question. The silence itself is informative: the twentieth-century American dispensational tradition, wherever it engaged the passage, tended to hold the age-limited reading, and where it did not engage the question it did not press a continuous-authority claim.

B.2 Modern Origins of View 2 (Launched at Adulthood)

Views 2a and 2b share a common historical arc. Both are products of industrial and post-industrial reorganization of the household and of a series of twentieth-century developmental-psychology and pastoral frameworks. 2a and 2b diverge at the theological interpretation of those developments, not at the developments themselves.

B.2.1 The Pre-Industrial Household

The picture of a pre-industrial household as a stable unit in which unmarried adult sons and daughters uniformly remained under the paternal roof until marriage requires qualification, particularly for the Northwest European and Anglo-American stream from which the Reformed, Puritan, and evangelical traditions descend. The dominant household-historical scholarship since John Hajnal’s 1965 paper on European marriage patterns — extended by Peter Laslett and the Cambridge Group, and documented in exhaustive detail for England by Ann Kussmaul’s *Servants in Husbandry in Early Modern England* (Cambridge, 1981) and for colonial New England by Edmund S. Morgan’s *The Puritan Family* (1944; rev. Harper & Row, 1966) — describes a “Northwest European Marriage Pattern” (NWEMP) with three features material to the present question. First, mean age at first marriage in England and its colonies from at least the sixteenth century ran in the mid-to-late twenties for both sexes — much later than the Mediterranean or Slavic patterns. Second, between roughly ages fourteen and marriage, a substantial fraction of young people — Kussmaul’s estimate (ch. 1) for early modern England is that servants “constituted around 60 per cent of the population aged fifteen to twenty-four,” and the practice cut across social strata —

left the paternal household and lived within *another* household as servants in husbandry, apprentices, or domestic servants, under the discipline of the master and mistress of that household rather than of their biological parents. Third, this out-of-household residence was ordinarily terminated by marriage, at which point the young person established a new independent household rather than returning to the parental one.

Two theological implications follow, and both matter for the paper's downstream reasoning. The first is that the historic norm the Reformed and Puritan streams *actually* inherited and codified was not "unmarried children remain under the paternal roof until marriage" but something closer to "unmarried children are formed within a household — either the parental household or another household of the same covenanted community — under discipline, until marriage." Morgan documents that Puritan New England assumed and legally regulated the placement of unmarried teenagers into other households (see the Massachusetts Bay orders of 1668 requiring town selectmen to place "unruly" youth in service — reprinted in William H. Whitmore, ed., *The Colonial Laws of Massachusetts, Reprinted from the Edition of 1672*, Boston, 1889). The paternal household was one instance of a broader category — the ordered household under a head — and the practice of placing unmarried adults *outside* the parental home under another head's authority was ordinary, not exceptional. Second: the transfer point commonly appealed to in Chapter 4's Arrangement discussion (§4.6) — that departure from the parental household historically coincided with marriage — is true for one leg of the young adult population (those who remained on the farm or in the family trade until marriage) but not for the very large fraction who left the parental household as adolescents for service in another household. The pattern View 1a appeals to at §B.1.7 as "the historic norm" is more accurately described as *one* historic norm within a broader system in which household-of-formation and household-of-origin were routinely different.

None of this settles the exegetical or theological question. What it does is remove one implicit historical support from any view that frames "remaining in the paternal household until marriage" as *the* uniform pre-industrial pattern that the industrial and postindustrial world merely disrupted. The historic Anglo-American practice was already a mixed one, and the Reformed tradition regulated the mixture under a household-discipline framework rather than a paternal-only framework. The industrial and post-industrial disruption (§B.2.2) is real and is what View 2 responds to; but the pattern it disrupted was not the one View 1a often implicitly reconstructs. Sense (2) of authority in §1.1.1 — formative office — was routinely exercised in the historic pattern by a household head other than the biological

father; senses (3) and (4) — counsel and priestly office — remained with the biological parents; and sense (1) — directive authority in the moment — followed residence and covenant, not biology.

B.2.2 Industrialization, Urbanization, and the College Track

Nineteenth- and early twentieth-century industrialization moved productive work outside the household, opened wage-labor to unmarried young adults, and made independent housing economically feasible. The Servicemen's Readjustment Act (the GI Bill, June 22, 1944) subsidized college education and low-interest home loans for returning servicemen and reshaped the American household: by the mid-1950s an unprecedented share of American young adults left the paternal household in their late teens or early twenties, first for military service, then for college, then for independent housing in the emerging suburbs. The Federal Housing Administration (established 1934) and Veterans Administration mortgage programs, combined with postwar suburban tract construction (Levittown, 1947), made independent household formation an economic default rather than an economic exception. What had been a launching pattern tied to marriage became, for the first time in Western history, a launching pattern tied to age-of-majority.

B.2.3 Developmental Psychology — Erikson and Arnett

Erik Erikson's *Childhood and Society* (1950) proposed a life-cycle model in which adolescence and young adulthood are characterized by *identity vs. role confusion* — a stage in which the young person must construct an identity distinct from parents in order to enter adult intimacy and generativity. Erikson's model gave a developmental framing to what postwar suburbanization was already producing: an extended period between the end of parental authority and the formation of the new household, treated as a *necessary* stage rather than an incidental delay. The framework was elaborated by James Marcia's identity-status research in the 1960s-1970s and became standard in American developmental psychology.

Jeffrey Jensen Arnett's "Emerging Adulthood: A Theory of Development from the Late Teens Through the Twenties" (*American Psychologist* 55, May 2000; expanded in *Emerging Adulthood: The Winding Road from the Late Teens Through the Twenties*, Oxford UP, 2004, second ed. 2015) proposed that the period between roughly 18 and 29 has become a distinct developmental stage in industrialized societies, characterized by identity exploration, instability, self-focus, feeling in-between, and a sense of possibility. Arnett explicitly framed emerging adulthood as *not-yet-adulthood* — a period in which the person is

neither adolescent nor fully adult, and in which the developmental task is self-authorship. The framework was welcomed by some as descriptive; it has been critiqued (by Christian Smith and others, see B.3) as *prescriptive* of the very pattern it purports to describe.

B.2.4 Focus on the Family and the Evangelical Adaptation

Focus on the Family was founded by James Dobson in 1977. Dobson's early books (*Dare to Discipline*, 1970; *The Strong-Willed Child*, 1978) addressed the parenting of minor children; his later work (*Bringing Up Boys*, 2001; *Bringing Up Girls*, 2010) and Focus's ongoing radio and print counsel to parents of adult children addressed the launching question directly. Dobson's counsel warned against both extremes — hovering parents who cannot release their adult children, and disengaged parents who abandon them at eighteen — and articulated the position now catalogued as View 2a: directive authority ends at adulthood; honor, counsel, and moral obligation continue. Gary Chapman's *The Five Love Languages* (1992) and subsequent works on adult relationships extended similar counsel to the marriage and family sphere. The counsel typical of American parachurch youth ministries (Young Life, Cru / Campus Crusade, Youth for Christ) during the same decades reinforced the launch-at-18 pattern within an evangelical framework of continuing honor.

B.2.5 The Boomerang Generation and the Delayed Launch

Beginning in the 1990s and accelerating after the 2008 financial crisis, American young adults began returning to (or not leaving) the parental household in unprecedented numbers. Pew Research Center reported that in September 2020, for the first time since the Great Depression, a majority of U.S. adults aged 18-29 lived with their parents (Fry, Passel, and Cohn, "A Majority of Young Adults in the U.S. Live with Their Parents for the First Time Since the Great Depression," Pew Research Center, September 4, 2020). This economic shift has partially recomposed the launched-at-adulthood pattern — either through economic necessity or through a re-evaluation of the practice — without in itself resolving the theological question of what authority attaches to household residence.

B.2.6 Where 2a and 2b Diverge

The material and developmental history is common to both. 2a interprets the emerging pattern as a legitimate *shift of mode* — directive authority naturally ends when economic and vocational independence begin; honor, counsel, and moral obligation continue. 2b interprets

the emerging pattern as a *covenantal release* — the adult child answerable directly to Christ, the parent’s office becoming priestly (intercession, counsel, watchfulness) rather than directive. A third interpretation — the person as sole authority over his or her own life, residual parental claims elective — is the Abandonment drift (§5.5), not a faithful view. The theological divergence lies at exactly this point, not at the economic or developmental one.

B.2.7 The Secular Career-Track Parallel and Delayed Marriage

The pattern of delayed marriage paired with adult-woman frustration documented in §4.1a Challenges and (for the harder 1b / umbrella form) at §4.1b’s Reality-leg discussion (Recovering Grace and West 2024 at §4.1b; Kobes Du Mez 2020 at §B.1.4) has a striking secular parallel that shows the pattern is not peculiar to Christian patriarchy.

Since the 1970s, the US median age at first marriage has risen sharply. The US Census Bureau (Historical Marital Status Tables, Table MS-2, “Estimated Median Age at First Marriage, by Sex: 1890 to Present,” [census.gov/data/tables/time-series/demo/families/marital.html](https://www.census.gov/data/tables/time-series/demo/families/marital.html)) reports:

- 1970: men 23.2 years, women 20.8 years
- 2023: men 30.2 years, women 28.4 years

A rise of seven to eight years for both sexes in half a century. A parallel literature — journalistic, sociological, and memoir — has followed the trajectory of the women involved.

Sylvia Ann Hewlett’s founding text of the modern discussion, *Creating a Life: Professional Women and the Quest for Children* (Talk Miramax, 2002), reported that 33% of high-achieving career women aged 41-55 were childless, rising to 49% among “ultra-achievers” earning over \$100,000. The accompanying *Harvard Business Review* article, “Executive Women and the Myth of Having It All” (April 2002), crystallized the finding: “Nowadays, the rule of thumb seems to be that the more successful the woman, the less likely it is she will find a husband or bear a child.”

Lori Gottlieb’s much-discussed *Atlantic* essay “Marry Him! The Case for Settling for Mr. Good Enough” (March 2008) argued the regret side of the same trend from the inside: “My advice is this: Settle! ... Marriage ultimately isn’t about cosmic connection — it’s about how having a teammate, even if he’s not the love of your life, is better than not having one at all.” Her subsequent book *Marry Him* (Dutton, 2010) expanded the argument.

Kate Bolick’s *Spinster: Making a Life of One’s Own* (Crown, 2015) opens: “Whom to marry, and when will it happen — these two ques-

tions define every woman's existence, regardless of where she was raised or what religion she does or doesn't practice" (p. 1). Bolick's book alternates memoir and cultural history and treats prolonged singleness sympathetically.

Rebecca Traister's All the Single Ladies: Unmarried Women and the Rise of an Independent Nation (Simon & Schuster, 2016) provides the historical framing: for the entire history of the United States "the median age at first marriage for women had remained between twenty and twenty-two." Traister documents that in 2009 the proportion of American women who were married dropped below fifty percent for the first time.

What this comparative note establishes for the SCAR analysis.

The pattern of delayed marriage paired with adult-woman frustration — including the specific "old maid" fear that L.J. records at Recovering Grace (§4.1b Challenges) and that Gottlieb articulates in her own voice — appears in *both* the over-protective direction (§4.1a drifting into the Clutch, §4.1b's Clutch drift, §5.5) *and* the launched-and-adrift direction (§4.2a drifting toward autonomy; §4.2b drifting into the Abandonment, §5.5; and the career-first secular pattern reaching the same downstream outcome by a wholly different route). The two directions arrive at the same downstream outcome by opposite drifts of opposite views. Faithful 1a, 1b, 2a, and 2b all name and resist the drift that would produce the delayed-marriage-and-frustration cohort; the Reality-leg data records the shape of what happens where the drift is not resisted. This is a Reality-leg observation neither of the launched-at-adulthood views nor either of the household-continuity views can safely ignore: whichever way the launch is arranged, formation patterns in which marriage is deferred by default — rather than either pursued as a formative goal or set aside for a discerned calling (§4.3) — produce the same downstream cohort by different routes.

B.3 Empirical Studies on Launched Emerging Adults

The following empirical literature bears on the "Reality" leg of the SCAR quadrilateral, particularly with respect to Views 2a and 2b.

Methodological caveats. The studies below are sociological and psychological, not theological. They can describe *what happens* to young adults in various launching patterns; they cannot by themselves adjudicate *what should* happen. The empirical picture is also predominantly American, predominantly Protestant, and predominantly of the post-1980 cohorts; extrapolation to other cultural contexts is limited. The findings are cited here as one input to the SCAR "Reality" leg, not as conclusive. One symmetry note: the attrition and outcome

findings for launched cohorts (§§B.3.1-B.3.4) carry methodological limits of the same kind §B.3.5 flags for the household-continuity data — self-report instruments, cohort effects, the absence of comparison groups raised under the alternative patterns, and no counterfactual identification of the household variable itself. The caveats run in both directions, not only against the smaller literature.

B.3.1 Christian Smith and the National Study of Youth and Religion (NSYR)

The National Study of Youth and Religion, directed by Christian Smith (University of Notre Dame) with funding from the Lilly Endowment, followed a nationally representative cohort of American teenagers into emerging adulthood over more than a decade. Three books:

- *Soul Searching: The Religious and Spiritual Lives of American Teenagers* (with Melinda Lundquist Denton, Oxford UP, 2005). Study of American 13-17-year-olds. Introduced the term *Moralistic Therapeutic Deism* (MTD) as the functional lived theology of most American teenagers regardless of their nominal tradition: God exists and wants people to be good; the central goal of life is to be happy and feel good about oneself; God does not need to be particularly involved in life except when needed to resolve a problem; good people go to heaven when they die.
- *Souls in Transition: The Religious and Spiritual Lives of Emerging Adults* (with Patricia Snell, Oxford UP, 2009). Follow-up study of the same cohort at ages 18-23. Documented substantial religious attrition during the launch: emerging adults raised with strong parental religious formation retained faith at higher rates than those without, but even in the strongest formation groups, substantial minorities departed. The functional theology of the cohort remained MTD-shaped.
- *Lost in Transition: The Dark Side of Emerging Adulthood* (with Kari Christoffersen, Hilary Davidson, and Patricia Snell Herzog, Oxford UP, 2011). Documented five *problematic* domains in the emerging-adult cohort: confused moral reasoning, routine intoxication, materialistic life goals, regretted sexual experiences, and civic and political disengagement. Smith and colleagues were careful to distinguish these findings from a moral panic — most emerging adults are not in acute crisis — while arguing that the cultural apparatus supporting emerging adulthood is producing genuinely worse outcomes on these axes than earlier cohorts.

B.3.2 David Kinnaman and Barna Group

David Kinnaman, *You Lost Me: Why Young Christians Are Leaving Church ... and Rethinking Faith* (Baker Books, 2011), synthesized Barna Group studies of American church-raised young adults ages 18-29 and identified six broad reasons for disaffiliation (Kinnaman's own chapter labels): churches seem *overprotective* (ch. 5), *shallow* (ch. 6), *antiscience* (ch. 7), *repressive* — particularly on sexuality — (ch. 8), *exclusive* (ch. 9), and *doubtless* — meaning unwelcoming of honest doubt (ch. 10). Kinnaman's *Faith for Exiles* (with Mark Matlock, Baker Books, 2019) followed with a smaller but positive study of "resilient disciples" who retained Christian practice through the launch. Kinnaman and Matlock identify five co-equal practices; the third — "forge meaningful, intergenerational relationships" — is characterized as one of the defining features of the resilient-disciple group, whose cross-generational church-community ties are reported to be substantially deeper than those of the prodigal / nomad / habitual-churchgoer cohorts.

B.3.3 Jean Twenge — iGen and the Post-Smartphone Cohort

Jean Twenge, *iGen: Why Today's Super-Connected Kids Are Growing Up Less Rebellious, More Tolerant, Less Happy — and Completely Unprepared for Adulthood* (Atria, 2017), documented statistical shifts in the cohort born approximately 1995-2012: delayed independence markers (driver's license, dating, working, drinking, sexual initiation), increased screen use, and — most controversially — sharply increased rates of depression, anxiety, and suicidality correlated with the mass adoption of the smartphone around 2012. Twenge's causal claims (particularly the smartphone-mental-health link) have been contested in the literature; the descriptive claim that this cohort is markedly less independent at each life-stage than immediately preceding cohorts is broadly accepted. Twenge's *Generations* (Atria, 2023) extends the analysis across six generational cohorts.

B.3.4 What the Empirical Picture Does and Does Not Show

The empirical picture is *consistent with* the concern that the launched-at-adulthood pattern, particularly as it drifts toward the *Abandonment* (§5.5), produces measurable costs in religious retention, moral formation, and (per Twenge) mental health. It does not by itself show that any of the alternative views — 1a, 1b, or any answer to the Arrangement Question — produce demonstrably better outcomes on the same measures at scale, since comparable longitudinal studies of adult children raised under those patterns are lacking. Kinnaman's finding that multi-generational integrated community predicts resilience is

suggestive of View 1a (in either its covering or kingdom-directed accent). Christian Smith’s findings on the durability of parental religious formation are consistent with every faithful view’s insistence on the primacy of the household. The empirical literature supports the *diagnostic* seriousness of the challenges (§4.2a and §4.2b “Challenges” sections) without prescribing a particular alternative.

B.3.5 What Positive Data Exists for 1a-Shaped Communities

Because the surveyed longitudinal studies (Smith, Kinnaman, Twenge) were designed around mainstream-evangelical and general-population samples, they under-sample the communities where View 1a is the lived norm. What positive data exists is smaller-N, tradition-specific, and best treated as *suggestive* rather than probative. It is nonetheless part of the Reality leg and is owed to the reader.

A note on figures. Where specific percentages are quoted, they are drawn directly from the named primary reports (Kraybill et al. 2013 for Amish retention; the 2018 Cardus reports *From the Classroom to the Workplace* and *Involved and Engaged* for the homeschool figures). Earlier-wave figures (2011, 2014) and figures drawn from the parallel *social-ties-and-relationships* thematic report have not been individually pinpoint-verified for this draft; formal work should consult the specific report and wave. The concept-level claims — that household-continuity communities exist as a distinct measurable population, and that the studies of them are mixed rather than uniformly favorable — hold at the concept level independent of any particular figure. This scoping applies to §B.3.5 only; §§B.3.1–B.3.4 summarize well-known published theses of Smith, Kinnaman, and Twenge and do not carry the same caveat.

Old Order Anabaptist retention. Sociological studies of Old Order Amish and conservative Mennonite communities (Donald Kraybill, *The Riddle of Amish Culture*, rev. 2001; Kraybill, Johnson-Weiner, and Nolt, *The Amish*, Johns Hopkins, 2013, Chapter 9 “Retention and Defection”) report a broad band of adult-child retention rates — roughly 80-95 percent depending on affiliation and settlement, with Nolt and Meyers reporting a present northern Indiana rate of about 95 percent (up from 80 percent in the 1920s-30s) and the more liberal New Order defecting at ~40 percent while the traditional Andy Weaver group loses ~2.6 percent (Kraybill et al. 2013, p. 163 with notes at p. 439) — figures substantially above the retention rates reported in mainstream-evangelical longitudinal studies, though measures and denominators differ across studies (see pre-note above). These communities live a variant of View 1a in a strong form: unmarried adults ordinarily remain in or adjacent to the parental household and community; vocational formation is intra-community; marriage

arises within a bounded courting network. The retention finding does not by itself vindicate any particular exegesis, but it establishes that household-continuity communities can be measured and that their measurable outcomes on retention are not weaker than the mainstream alternative.

Christian homeschool graduates — a mixed record. The Cardus Education Survey (Ray Pennings et al., 2011, 2014, 2018) is one of the few large-N studies of formation outcomes by schooling type. Its record for religious homeschool graduates specifically — a subgroup with $n = 124$ in the 2018 U.S. wave, small enough that Cardus themselves flag chance-fluctuation risk — is genuinely mixed, and the paper reports it as such.

On the positive side, the 2018 CES thematic report *Involved and Engaged* finds that “the likelihood of donating to a religious congregation is higher among all religious school graduates, especially among Protestant school and religious homeschool graduates,” and that religious school graduates (homeschool and Protestant school alike) are “also more likely than public school graduates to donate money or goods to other types of religious organizations or causes as well.” Mission and social-service trip participation is also higher among religious homeschool graduates than public school graduates, though the homeschool effect there is largely accounted for by demographic and family background variables. Cardus’s evidence for higher *early-marriage* formation is best attested for evangelical Protestant Christian *school* graduates, not homeschool graduates specifically; the 2018 *Involved and Engaged* report does not present marriage-timing findings for the homeschool subsample.

On the countervailing side, *Involved and Engaged* also finds that “Protestant and religious homeschool graduates are less likely to report that they volunteer for a neighbourhood or civic organization,” that religious homeschool graduates report a lower average number of civic organizations, that they are “70 percent less likely” than public school graduates to volunteer for international issues or causes, and that once family-background controls are applied, total-volunteer-hour differences across school sectors are not statistically significant. The 2018 CES report *From the Classroom to the Workplace* found that respondents homeschooled for religious reasons had completed on average “just over one year less of schooling than public school graduates,” were “about four times more likely to leave schooling directly after graduating from high school,” were “over twice as likely to be unemployed” than public school graduates, and reported household income “about \$10,000 lower on average” than public school graduates; the odds of a religious homeschool graduate attaining an advanced degree were “about 60 percent less than an average public

school graduate.”

The honest summary is that religious homeschool graduates are strong on *religious-institutional* giving and mission-trip participation, roughly comparable to public school graduates on total volunteer hours once family background is controlled, and below public school graduates on secular civic volunteering, international-cause volunteering, years of education, advanced-degree attainment, employment, and household income. The picture is not “homeschool graduates do better” or “worse” as a totality; it is that homeschool formation ties a graduate more tightly to congregational and religious-cause life, and less tightly to secular civic and labor-market outcomes. Brian Ray’s surveys through the National Home Education Research Institute (NHERI) report patterns favorable to homeschooling; NHERI is a homeschool-advocacy-affiliated research shop, which the paper flags alongside the ordinary self-selection caveat (families who choose homeschooling differ from families who do not, so what is measured is outcomes for the population as such, not the counterfactual effect of the schooling choice itself; and homeschooling is here a proxy for the formation-intensive household, not a direct measure of adult household continuity). Overall the Cardus/NHERI record supports the claim that these communities produce measurable strengths in congregational and formation outcomes, alongside measurable deficits in secular civic and labor-market outcomes, without supporting an unqualified claim of educational or occupational advantage.

Catholic communities with strong household catechesis. Reports from the Center for Applied Research in the Apostolate (CARA, Georgetown) on Mass attendance and vocations across Catholic sub-populations consistently find that adult retention in the faith tracks the strength of household-of-origin practice more closely than most other single variables studied. This is consistent with (though not exclusive to) View 1a’s insistence on the household as the primary catechetical unit.

A note on first-person 1b goods testimony. In preparing this appendix the author searched for a substantial body of first-person testimony from adults raised under a systematic continuous-authority pattern (1b proper, in the Nee / Gothard / Phillips register rather than the moderate 1a register) who describe the experience as good — the sort of memoir literature that would parallel West 2024 or the Recovering Grace archive but in the affirmative direction. What surfaced was scattered — brief testimonies within apologetic literature for the position, comments sections, homeschool-network publications — rather than the book-length first-person accounts that would carry the same evidentiary weight as the critical memoirs. The paper records the search and its outcome so the asymmetry in the appendix’s

testimony citations is understood as a real feature of the available literature rather than a selection choice. That the critical memoirs are more substantial than the affirmative memoirs is itself Reality-leg data, but it is not by itself adjudication: memoirs are written by those with a story that demands writing, and the peaceful continuation of an ordinary household seldom produces one.

What the positive data does and does not do. Taken together, the Anabaptist, homeschool, and Catholic-catechetical evidence supports one modest claim: household-continuity communities (1a-shaped) produce measurable formation strengths that the mainstream-evangelical baseline does not consistently produce. The evidence does *not* isolate the distinctive claim of View 1b — that continuing directive authority as a *systematic requirement* is the operative variable — and the paper does not present it as if it did. Whether View 1b as such adds to or subtracts from 1a-shaped advantages is not answerable from the current empirical literature. Honest use of the Reality leg here requires the paper to report both the positive findings for 1a-shaped communities and the countervailing findings within the same body of studies, and to name the *absence* of a comparable finding for 1b as a distinct systematic claim.

Draft v2.16.0 — 2026-08-04 — Study Copy. This is a single-document edition of the SCAR analysis for study and review. If the direction is approved, the analysis will be split into full chapter files with research documents per the SCAR methodology.